

The Breathing 1%

#0: What is The Breathing 1%?

The Breathing 1% (TB1%) is based on the idea that *“Breathing is the compound interest of health and wellness.”* That if we improve by just 1% every day, those benefits will compound into extraordinary results.

It’s also based on the science of learning. It’s quick, bite-sized chunks of wisdom that are easy and fun to digest.

Lastly, like breathing, it’s about repetition and consistency. If you’ve followed my newsletter for a while, you’ll see many of the Thoughts repeated here (sometimes almost word-for-word).

That’s part of the learning process. You get new things from revisiting old ideas with a fresh mind. In fact, that’s where most of the learning happens: in re-learning.

The Format

The format used here—daily bite-sized emails with audio—is inspired by my absolute favorite teacher, Brian Johnson. In fact, the whole design of the Breath is Life Learning Center follows his teaching structure.

The way he teaches changed my life, so I know it works. I took it and applied it to breathing.

TB1% is also inspired by Josh Spector’s daily emails, which I love and always read.

Thanks for Joining

Thank you for joining me on this journey toward becoming the best possible versions of ourselves we can become.

If breath is life, then optimal breathing is optimal living. So here’s to breathing and living better, today.

#1: Why We Start with the Breath: The Ultimate Self-Improvement Tool

“You can borrow knowledge, but not action.” – James Clear

Action is the cornerstone of all improvement. Of course, we have to read and learn—but that only stores potential energy. Action converts that energy into something useful.

And breathing is the most basic form of taking action. **Breathing causes shifts in our mind and body that are genuinely useful in real-life situations.**

It’s no wonder all ancient traditions focused on the breath. Before the internet, before you could major in positive psychology, before life coaches and Harvard studies, there was the breath.

Breathing is the ultimate self-improvement tool.

#2: The Four Qualities of Breath We Want to Develop to Feel Better

“One of the essential techniques that I distill from this body of knowledge about pranayama is that the qualities of breath that you want to develop are to make it deeper, slower, quieter, and more regular.”

- Andrew Weil, MD, Breathing: The Master Key to Self Healing

These are the qualities we want to develop with The Breathing 1%.

Let’s make it our mantra wherever we find ourselves: deeper, slower, quieter, and more regular.

I love these qualities because they’re concrete. Instead of just “coming back to our breath,” we can come back to deeper, slower, quieter, and more regular.

It gives us something we can do, that actually does something:

“When your breathing is deeper, slower, quieter, and more regular, you are feeling better, in both mind and body. Your nervous system is functioning more smoothly, and all your organs are operating more harmoniously as a result.”

Sounds good to me 🙏

(#3) Why Breathing Seems Like a Panacea (maybe it is?)

“Your body has numerous major systems, including the endocrine (hormone), cardiovascular, immune, gastrointestinal, and nervous systems. If you want to use the mind-body connection to lower your stress, cool the fires, and improve your long-term health, **what’s the optimal point of entry into all these systems? It's the autonomic nervous system (ANS).**” (my emphasis)

- Rick Hanson, PhD, Buddha’s Brain

And what’s the optimal point of entry into the ANS? The breath.

As Deb Dana says, “Breath is a direct, easily accessible, and rapid way to shape the state of the nervous system.”

When we change the breath, we change the nervous system, and we change all the major systems of the body.

(#4) The #1 Breathing Fundamental

“Taken together, these results confirm that nasal stimulation represents the fundamental link between slow breathing techniques, brain and autonomic activities and psychological/behavioral outputs.” - Zaccaro et al. (2018)

(<https://www.thebreathingdiabetic.com/science-411s/zaccaro-et-al-2018>)

If you're reading this, you're probably aware of the importance of nasal breathing. But, you might not have known that a 2018 study concluded that **all the benefits of slow breathing—whether in our brains, nervous systems, or emotions—might be linked to the nose.**

That's a powerful statement.

We won't make our mantra any longer, but just remember that those deeper, slower, quieter, and more regular breaths should be taken through the nose most of the time :)

(#5) The True Definition of Success (a quote)

On weekends, I just send a memorable breathing quote. Enjoy!

“To know that even one life has breathed easier because you have lived. This is to have succeeded.”

- Ralph Waldo Emerson

(#6) The Power of Rest (a quote)

On weekends, I just send a memorable breathing quote. Enjoy!

“Breathing, like most forms of physical rest, improves as you practice. It takes a little time. But it’s a technique you’ll be able to do for the rest of your life, so it’s worthwhile getting good at it now.”

- Matthew Edlund, The Power of Rest

(#7) Breath is Life, Spirit, and a Divine Gift Bestowed Upon Us

“If you look up the word “spirit” in the dictionary, you will find that it comes from the Latin, spirare, meaning “to breathe.” The inbreath is inspiration; the outbreath expiration. From these come all the associations of spirit with the breath of life, vital energy, consciousness, the soul, often framed as divine gifts bestowed upon us, and therefore as aspect of the holy, the numinous, the ineffable. **In the deepest sense, the breath itself is the ultimate gift of spirit.**” (my emphasis)

- Jon Kabat-Zinn, Ph.D., Wherever You Go There You Are

Although it’s critical to look at the science of how breathing affects our body and mind, let’s not forget intangible aspects of it, too. That *“the breath itself is the ultimate gift of spirit.”*

Let’s use this divine gift that’s been bestowed upon us wisely. 🙏

(#8) How to Make Spiritual Progress

Yesterday, we learned from Jon Kabat-Zinn that breathing is *“the ultimate gift of spirit.”*

Today, let’s look at how Harvard-trained MD Andrew Weil explains the same idea in [*Breathing: The Master Key to Self Healing*](#):

“[B]reath is the animated, nonphysical aspect of your being. So that when you look in the direction of breath, when you focus your attention on your breath, you are really looking at your spiritual self.”

That statement is why Dr. Weil also says that, *“if you do nothing other than pay attention to your breath today, for a few seconds more than you did yesterday, you have increased your spiritual awareness. You have made spiritual progress.”*

Sounds good to me. Enjoy making a little spiritual progress, today 🙏

(#9) Relaxed & Alert: Why Slow Breathing Works

“Within a very short time, breathing at five breaths a minute will synchronize the electrical rhythms of the heart, lungs and brain, which is very beneficial and leads to a state in which we are both relaxed and alert. It's unusual to be both relaxed and alert at the same time, but Coherent Breathing creates this sweet spot.”

- Dr. Patricia Gerbarg, from Wake Up to Sleep

Here's an excellent description of why slow breathing (sometimes called Coherent or resonant breathing) works. It synchronizes the electrical rhythms of the heart, lungs, and brain, leaving us “relaxed and alert.” <— Sounds perfect to me 🙏

Give it a try: Breathe 6 seconds in and 6 seconds out (that's the rate Dr. Gerbarg is referring to here). Or 5 seconds in, 7 out (that's the one I like better), or any really rate and ratio that is comfortable to you between about 4 and 7 breaths a minute.

[You can use this app to make it easier.](#)

Here's to synchronizing our body's signals to feel relaxed and alert, with the simple power of the breath.

(#10) Get Instant Willpower (the only “quick fix”)

“You won’t find many quick fixes in this book, but there is one way to immediately boost willpower: Slow your breathing down to four to six breaths per minute [...] Slowing the breath down activates the prefrontal cortex and increases heart rate variability, which helps shift the brain and body from a state of stress to self-control mode. ... And because it only takes one to two minutes of breathing at this pace to boost your willpower reserve, it’s something you can do whenever you face a willpower challenge.”

- Kelly McGonigal, Ph.D., The Willpower Instinct

If we need more willpower, it doesn’t get any simpler than this. However, there’s a paradox here: *we need willpower to remember to slow down our breathing.*

That’s why we return to our mantra repeatedly (especially when we don’t need it) until it’s our default reaction in any situation: deeper, slower, quieter, and more regular = more willpower.

P.S. I share a personal story about this in the audio version. It’s too much detail to include here, but if you’re interested in how I apply this in real life while riding the bike with my daughter, give it a listen.

(#12) The Breath is a Mirror

“In this way, the breath is like a mirror that shows you the state you are in.”

- Wim Hof

(#14) How to Become a World-Class Breather

“World-class performers are less about complexity and more about optimizing simplicity...It’s about the fundamentals. But small, daily improvements on the fundamentals every day done with ridiculous consistency creates insane revolutions over time.”

- Robin Sharma, [Optimize Interview](#)

Since you’re reading this, I imagine you wouldn’t mind becoming a world-class breather. Fortunately, it’s actually pretty simple: *reduce the complexity and optimize the simplicity*.

Of course, you can still utilize a variety of advanced techniques. Kobe Bryant didn’t only practice shooting free throws, and Tom Brady doesn’t only practice taking snaps.

But it all starts with the fundamentals.

What is the best way to do that? Deeper, slower, quieter, and more regular → repeat (but only forever).

Let those benefits compound into “insane revolutions over time.”

(#15) Why All Breathwork Works: The Brain, Lungs, and Speed Dial

“Over thousands of years of evolution, fast and powerful pathways between the respiratory system and the brain have been established. If breathing stops, death occurs within minutes, and so the brain prioritizes messages from the lungs above all others.”

- Charley Morley, Wake Up to Sleep

This idea has been said in many ways, but this version resonates profoundly with me.

And it concisely summarizes why all breathwork works: *“the brain prioritizes messages from the lungs above all others.”*

Let’s be sure to send our brains positive signals, today.

P.S. It’s pretty easy, actually: deeper, slower, quieter, and more regular :)

(#16) Natural Resistance Breathing: Aquatic Exercise Strengthens Breathing Muscles

“The lungs are receiving a greater volume of blood as well, which, combined with the pressure that water exerts on the chest wall, makes them work harder to breathe—approximately 60% harder than on land. This means that aquatic exercise can strengthen the respiratory muscles and improve their efficiency.”

- Wallace J Nichols, Blue Mind
(I can't recommend this book enough.)

Resistance breathing has countless benefits, including better cardiovascular health, stronger respiratory muscles, less oxidative stress, and reduced inflammation.

But if you have no interest in buying a device for resistance breathing, here's a free alternative: aquatic exercise. You get the calming effects of the water while also strengthening your breathing muscles.

A natural and soothing win-win 🙏

(#17) Exercise Your Richer Inner Core (not your abs or diaphragm)

“More and more, I became convinced that our bodies are wired to benefit from exercising not only our muscles but our rich inner, human core — our beliefs, values, thoughts, and feelings.”

- Herbert Benson, MD, [Timeless Healing](#)

What better way to exercise and express those than a daily self-care ritual? I like 20-30 min of breathing & gratitude every morning, but anything you do to connect to your values, beliefs, and feelings will do.

Have fun exercising your most valuable inner core, today 🙏

(#18) New Science 411: The Famous 10-18% Nasal Breathing and Oxygenation Study

"We here show that arterial oxygenation is improved in healthy awake subjects during nasal breathing as compared with mouth breathing."

- [Lundberg et al. \(1996\)](#)

It's Friday, so [a new Science 411](#) is available now. **It's a must-read/listen if you're a breathing nerd.**

Here are the take-home messages:

- Nasal breathing **increased tissue oxygenation by ~10%** compared to mouth breathing in 6 of 8 healthy people.
- Adding nasal air to a ventilator **increased arterial oxygenation by ~18%** in 6 of 6 mechanically ventilated people.

[Read or listen to the new 411](#) to get all the details of this fascinating study. Enjoy!

(#19) Releasing Tensions

“Our breathing is designed to help us release any tensions that have become so much a part of us that we no longer sense their presence.” - Carla Melucci Ardito

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable breathing quote for you to enjoy. It's a productive form of mental rest :)

(#20) Quote

(#21) The Best (and most therapeutic) Form of Mouth Breathing

The best (and most therapeutic) form of mouth breathing is...

Laughter.

It's one of my new favorite "breathing exercises." 😊

Don't forget to give it a try today.

(#22) Breath is Medicine

“Medicine and medication both derive from an ancient Indo-Iranian root meaning something like ‘thoughtful action to establish order’; the same root gives us the words measure and meditate.”

- Andrew Weil, MD, Mind Over Meds

If “medicine” literally means something like “thoughtful action,” then mindful breathing is (in every sense of the word) medicine.

Let’s not forget to take our dose, today :)

P.S. Deeper, slower, quieter, more regular.

P.P.S. After this little etymology lesson, Dr. Weil goes on to say, “*How curious that ‘thoughtful action’ has become synonymous with the giving and taking of chemical substances.*” Curious, indeed 😏😏😏

(#23) Suffering vs Peace: Who's Breath Are You Focusing On?

The more you learn about breathing, the more you'll notice how poorly everyone else does it.

And it's natural to want to fix them.

But let's remember that trying to change others will lead to suffering.

Focusing on what you can control—your breath—will lead to peace.

(#24) How to Experience More Awe, Gratitude, & Joy

“University of North Carolina psychologists Barbara Frederickson, PhD, and Bethany Kok, PhD, demonstrated this beautifully when they asked 52 adults to track their positive emotions—awe, gratitude, joy—for 9 weeks. They found that the higher a subject’s HRV was at the beginning, the easier and more quickly he or she could experience positive feelings over the next 9 weeks.”

- Leah Lagos, Psy.D., [Heart Breath Mind](#)

Do you want to experience more awe, gratitude, and joy? (Who doesn’t?! 😄) Research suggests that having a higher resting HRV will let you.

And the best way to increase your baseline HRV? Dr. Lagos says, “*The standard rate that works for most individuals is to inhale for 4 seconds and exhale for 6 seconds with no pause in between.*”

Even just a few minutes of this will help you feel better. But, consistent practice [will increase baseline HRV](#), thus setting you up to experience more positive emotions all day, every day.

(#25) New Book 411: The Healing Power of the Breath

“Rather than write an exhaustive book with hundreds of breath practices, we have selected a few that are easy to teach, easy to learn, safe, rapidly effective, and useful in many different aspects of life.”

[The Healing Power of the Breath](#)

It's Friday, so a new Book 411 is now available. I'm super excited about this one; I think it's the most practical Book 411 to date.

You'll learn the 3 core breathing exercises they chose to meet their above criteria.

Also, the audio podcast version has a fun, heartfelt treat at the beginning. Enjoy!

P.S. This is my favorite overall breathing book simply because it's short, simple, and extremely practical with the guidelines and exercises. I hope the 411 inspires you to read the full thing :)

(#26) Offering Ourselves to the World

“Breathing involves a continual oscillation between exhaling and inhaling, offering ourselves to the world at one moment and drawing the world into ourselves at the next.” - David Abram

P.S. At the [Skill of Stress course](#) I recently attended, one of my favorite teachers, Emily Hightower, said something along the lines of (paraphrasing) “*Don’t take a breath; give an exhale.*” I think that’s a perfect complement to this quote 🙏

(#27) A Mysterious and Mystical Organ

"The lungs are a mysterious and even mystical organ. They are our connection to the atmosphere, the organ that extracts the life force we need to exist." - Michael J Stephen, MD

(#28) 3 Breaths Changed David Goggins' Entire Life

“When I was teetering on the brink, I was able to physically calm myself down with a few deep breaths, and that helped me see through the adrenaline rush. My heart rate was still elevated, and panic continued to creep in, but I’d regained enough of my composure to make a conscious, one-second decision to stay in the fight.”

- David Goggins, [Never Finished](#)

In his new book, [Never Finished](#), David Goggins says that when the first freezing wave hit him in Hell Week, it almost sent him home.

“I was a half-step from voluntarily pulling the plug on a dream that had the power to change the course of my entire life.”

Enter the power of the breath: *“In order to think clearly, I needed oxygen. I took a deep breath. And then another. ... I took another breath, as the next big wave swelled ... I was done showing weakness. I was finished with fear.”*

And as they say, the rest is history.

P.S. Of course, I’m cherry-picking here. But how crazy that even *the* David Goggins instinctually recognized to return to his breath in one of the most crucial decision points of his life...

P.P.S. I’m listening to the audio version (which is a must with his books), so the quotes are my best attempt at transcription based on how it’s narrated.

(#29) Thich Nhat Hanh on Finding the Best Practice for You

“Only by using your intelligence and putting the teachings into practice can they bring you happiness. Please base your practice on your own life and your own experiences, your successes and your failures.”*

- Thich Nhat Hanh, The Heart of the Buddha’s Teaching

There are about a billion breathing techniques and methods out there to choose from.

But how do we actually find the best practice for ourselves?

Although this passage is about applying the Buddha’s teachings, I think it applies perfectly here, too.

Of course, we have to learn from others. But no one recipe fits everyone. So, it’s ultimately up to us to base our practice on our own lives and experiences. And that’s what will ultimately bring us happiness 🙏

P.S. This wisdom also applies to basically every other area of our lives.

(#30) Our Lungs and the Possibilities of the World

“Our lungs developed to utilize oxygen and efficiently drive our metabolic reactions. We are aerobic creatures, and if the lungs are our most important organ, then oxygen is the most important gas in the atmosphere. [...] **With oxygen, the possibilities of the world opened up.**”

- Michael J Stephen, MD, Breath Taking

Just an elegant reminder of how vital our lungs and oxygen are—they literally open the world’s possibilities to us. So let’s get the most out of them today.

Deeper, slower, quieter, and more regular breathing will help us do just that. 🙏

(#31) Do This when Life Gets Complicated: Two Hours instead of One

“When life gets complicated, lean into these practices, as they’re how you get the creativity needed to untangle the complicated.”

- Steven Kotler, The Art of Impossible

In this passage, Kotler is discussing four practices for “sustained peak performance” (which he says are gratitude, mindfulness, exercise, and sleep).

But the concept really applies to anything we do for better health (like our breathing practice).

When life gets absurdly busy, we should lean into these practices, not remove them.

Gandhi comes to mind here: *“I have so much to accomplish today that I must meditate for two hours instead of one.”* ← Amen to that.

P.S. Launching this learning center has been crazy. I could read and breathe all day, every day, but it’s the formatting and logistics of everything that makes my head numb. Although modest by Gandhi’s standards, I followed this advice and increased my morning breathing practice by 5 minutes when the learning center launched. I must say, it’s good advice—and it works :)

(#35) Breathing Exercises Lower Inflammation and Change Gene Expression

“In those who practice breathing exercises, levels of inflammatory proteins in the blood are significantly lower, especially under certain types of stress. Mobilizing the power of the breath has also been shown to turn on anti-inflammatory genes and turn off pro-inflammatory ones, including genes that regulate energy metabolism, insulin secretion, and even the part of our DNA that controls longevity.”

- Michael J Stephen, MD, Breath Taking

That’s pretty remarkable. And from a practical perspective, the breathing exercises Dr. Stephen is referring to are those that induce the “relaxation response.”

So, let’s remember to breathe slowly, extend our exhales, and enjoy mobilizing the power of the breath to reduce inflammation and regulate energy metabolism today.

(#36) It Doesn't Have to Be Breathing (here's why most methods work)

Last time, we talked about using slow breathing to evoke the relaxation response. This does all sorts of good things, like lowering inflammation & stress hormones.

But, really, any method that evokes the relaxation response will work. Here's how Wayne Jonas, MD, brilliantly puts it in his book *How Healing Works*:

“Differences in the effects of various stress management approaches are minor compared to the general goal of inducing a relaxation response. For more than fifty years, Harvard's Professor Herbert Benson, author of *The Relaxation Response*, demonstrated that almost any type of relaxation inducer—prayer, meditation, rhythmic breathing, visualization, or biofeedback—can rapidly reverse the more than five hundred genes that are turned on by stress. In addition, those who regularly practice a relaxation method have better long-term health, recover faster from health challenges, and use fewer medical services.”

So pick one that resonates with you and enjoy harnessing the relaxation response for better long-term health and faster recovery 🧘

(#37) How to Easily Access Presence (with or w/o breathing)

“But learning new skills is also one of the best ways to enhance awareness of the present moment [...] New situations kill the mental clutter. In newness, we’re forced into presence and focus.”*

- Michael Easter, The Comfort Crisis

This is why our first time doing anything (breathing, meditation, surfing, yoga, etc.) is usually the most life-changing. In the novelty, we were forced to be present.

And although I’m a huge fan of consistency, the practical message here is that we can deliberately use newness to access a more present state of mind. This can help us periodically reinvigorate our spirit.

So how could you give this a try today? Maybe a new yoga class, a new breathing technique, or just listening to a new song from an artist you love?

(#38) Change Your Story: “The Mind Narrates what the Nervous System Knows”

“We live a story that originates in our on autonomic state, is sent through autonomic pathways from the body to the brain, and is then translated by the brain into the beliefs that guide our daily living. The mind narrates what the nervous system knows. Story follows state.”*

- Deb Dana, The Polyvagal Theory in Therapy

“The mind narrates what the nervous system knows.” <— 🧠

And the fastest way to access the nervous system? The breath.

As Dana also says, “*Breath is a direct, easily accessible, and rapid way to shape the state of the nervous system.*”

Change your breath → change your state → change your story.

(#39) Wim Hof Wisdom Bundle (bonus gifts)

I have a few end-of-the-year bonuses for you.

Instead of getting one Book 411, you're getting a Book 411 and four Science 411s on Wim Hof's method.

I'm calling it the Wim Hof Wisdom Bundle. Click the link to access all the wisdom (it's also available from the Member's Home Page).

Enjoy!

P.S. I will eventually have Wisdom Bundles for lots of topics—this is just the start...

(#40) A 30-Second Thought Experiment Bound to Improve Your Life

(it genuinely changed mine in 2022)

(1) Bring to mind someone you would die for—no hesitation, no questions asked.

(2) Now ask yourself: Would you live for this person? Would you start that one thing you know you should be doing? (Yes, that one.) Would you give up that one thing you know you shouldn't be doing? (Only you know which one.)

It's easy to die for someone. What's harder is really living for them.

P.S. This was inspired by a beautiful book titled *The Gift* by Dr. Edith Eger, a Holocaust survivor with an incredibly tragic yet deeply humbling and inspiring story.

(#41) A Breath of Unity

“Each new breath creates a unity of life as all people share the nourishment that the earth's atmosphere freely offers.”

- Barbara Fredrickson, Ph.D., Love 2.0

Extra: 23 One-Sentence Breathing Ideas for 2023

To start 2023 off right, here are 23 one-sentence breathing ideas for 2023.

Enjoy!

(#42) An Acid for Digesting Oxygen

"Oxygen is what we breathe in. CO₂ is what we internally produce in order to allow us to use that oxygen most efficiently." - David Bidler, Breathe to Perform

That's an awesome way to look at it.

While not technically accurate, we could say:

Your body produces stomach acids to digest food. It produces blood acids to digest oxygen.

(#43) Breathwalking in its Simplest Form

“Breathwalk at its very simplest means putting breathing patterns and walking together into a carefully and beautifully timed single, synchronized movement. It is walking harmonized with breathing.”

- Gurucharan Singh Khalsa, Ph.D., and Yogi Bajan, Ph.D., *Breathwalk*

Breathwalking is a great way to combine three ancient wellness techniques: walking, breathing, and meditation. I sometimes use it in the afternoons. But, I also find myself using it periodically when walking just about anywhere.

Here's a good one to get started:

- Inhale 8 steps, exhale 8 steps
- Do this for 3 min
- Walk normally for 2 min
- Repeat as needed

It's simple yet surprisingly powerful. Give it a shot and see how you feel.

(#50) The Long-Term Benefits of Breathing Exercises: Normalize Cortisol and Be Calmer

“The long-term effects of a daily breathing practice, just like those of a daily exercise routine, are even more pronounced. Preliminary studies have found that regularly practicing breathing exercises normalizes your level of cortisol, the ‘stress hormone.’ As a regular practice, breathing can recondition your body to a state of greater calm, helping it bounce back from stress more quickly and perhaps reducing reactivity in the face of challenges...you can use daily breathing exercises to prepare your nervous system to be resilient in the face of stressful events.”*

- Emma Sepällä, Ph.D., [*The Happiness Track*](#)

That is all 🙌

P.S. We’ve made it 50 days of improving by 1% every day 🍦🍦🍦

* I listened to this book on Audible, so the quote is my best guess based on the narrator’s pace and pauses.

(#51) Reading Can Produce Healing

“Bibliotherapy is based on the assumption that the simple act of reading can produce healing of various health conditions, including depression. The definition of bibliotherapy has broadened over the years to include using any type of reading material that is uplifting or emotionally sustaining.”

Herbert Benson, MD, [Relaxation Revolution](#)

As someone obsessed with reading, this might be my new favorite word :)

However, I always preach that our reading should lead to action. That knowing is not enough...we must do something.

But maybe just reading is, in fact, healing. As Dr. Benson goes on to say, one study found that “Therapeutic reading ranked toward the top of the interventions, along with CBT and supportive-expressive groups, as a highly effective method of decreasing depressive symptoms.”

I hope these 1%'s work as bibliotherapy for you 🙏

(#52) Better Sleep and Higher Vagal Tone

“Taken together, our results suggest that slow-paced breathing performed before sleeping may enhance restorative processes at the cardiovascular level during sleep.”

- [Laborde et al. \(2019\), Journal of Clinical Medicine](#)

This excellent study ([see the Science 411 for more](#)) found that 15 min of slow breathing (6 breaths/min) before sleep for 30 days led to:

- Significantly better subjective sleep quality
- Significantly higher nighttime vagal tone (via HF-HRV)
- Higher (but not significant) morning vagal tone

Not bad for just 15 minutes a night 🙌

To be honest, I’ve never been able to commit 15 minutes before bed to breathing. But, I always do at least 5-10, and I find it to be good enough to fall asleep faster.

(#53) Join the Relaxation Revolution

It's Friday, so a new Book 411 is available.

This week, we have the Relaxation Revolution. It's an awesome look at the relaxation response and the power of our minds (using visualization) to heal and optimize our bodies.

Although the best artists, athletes, and performers all use visualization, I've never been able to fully commit to it—probably because of all the woo-woo connotations around it. But, the 1 Life-Changing Idea on “remembered wellness” got me doing it consistently for over a month now. I love it. I hope you do, too.

Have a great weekend.

In good breath,
Nick

(#54) Creating Disease-Resistant Genes

“Looking down the generations, those of us who practice breathing exercises today may well pass on more disease-resistant genes to our descendants tomorrow.”

Michael J Stephen, MD, [Breath Taking](#)

P.S. Dr. Stephen was using research on the Relaxation Response for this great quote. Learn more about it in the latest Book 411 on [Relaxation Revolution](#), released yesterday.

(#55) Expressing Our Inner Feelings

“The quality of our breath expresses our inner feelings.”

- TKV Desikachar

P.S. I found that one on [this great page of quotes](#).

(#56) Harmonize the Butterflies in Your Stomach

“It's all right to have butterflies in your stomach. Just get them to fly in formation.” - Dr. Rob Gilbert

Controlling your breathing is one way to help synchronize them.

(#57) Sent Out Survey

(#58) What Steve Jobs Can Teach Us about Teaching

Have you heard the famous line that goes something like this: “Steve Jobs didn’t even let his kids use iPads!”

People use that as an argument against using iPads.

I don’t see it that way.

I see it as motivation to create something I’m proud of, something I’d love my daughter to use, not something I’d have to hide from her.

So here’s to using our lives to create things we’re proud to teach and share with our kids, one breath at a time.

(#59) What We Can Say About Slow Breathing Techniques

In *Relaxation Revolution*, Dr. Benson says that he was excited about the genetic findings of the relaxation response. Some of the changes appeared beneficial for cancer.

But, he had to stay grounded:

“I could not yet tell any cancer patients, including Cameron, “There is a new, established treatment for your cancer.”

I could say, however, “There is new research that represents a promising first step toward a new cancer therapy. And, at the very least, this approach is safe and could make you feel better.””

It’s that last sentence that’s crucial. It’s exactly what we can say about slow breathing for just about any condition: “At the very least, this approach is safe and could make you feel better.”

Sounds good enough to me.

(#60) Important New 2023 Nature Publication on Breathing

“Research on breathwork could be likened to that of meditation, which received an unprecedented surge in scientific exploration two decades ago. We may be at a similar cusp with breathwork and anticipate considerable growth in the field.”

- Nature Scientific Reports (2023)

Although I dislike the word “breathwork” for some reason, this may be the most important paper published on breathing to date.

Here are a few key takeaways, but definitely check out the new Science 411 released today to get all the details.

Breathwork is as effective as standard treatments like cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT), meditation, mindfulness, and acceptance of emotions for reducing stress, anxiety, and depression.

Breathwork is as effective as physical activity for reducing anxiety and depression symptoms.

Whether breathwork is self-learned remotely, taught 1-on-1, or taught to a group doesn’t impact the above results.

Have a great weekend!

In good breath,

Nick

P.S. I recommend the audio version of this one because I add a lot of context, which is too much for written form. For example, that second bullet point above could be used disingenuously to drive clicks. Yes, it is very powerful, but we just want to be realistic about what it means.

(#61) Resurrected from the Grave

“Many ancient practices and rituals have been rejected by modern science, only to be resurrected from the grave by that same science!”

Herbert Benson, MD, [Relaxation Revolution](#)

P.S. This was inspired by the new Science 411 shared yesterday. Let's not forget that, although science is powerful, breathing exercises have something far more powerful behind them: thousands of years of practice.

(#62) On Presence

“If something is going to happen to me, I want to be there.”

- Albert Camus

P.S. The 1 Life-Changing Idea from The Mindful Day complements this perfectly.

(#63) Flipping Perspectives for Long-Term Benefits

“[J]ust as repeated activation of the fight-or-flight response can lead to sustained problems in the body and its mechanics, so too can repeated activation of the relaxation response reverse those trends and mend the internal wear and tear brought on by stress.”

Herbert Benson, MD, *Timeless Healing*

It's easy to see how chronic stress can add up to all sorts of health problems.

But let's not forget that the opposite is also true.

P.S. I'll be releasing a Book 411 on *Timeless Healing* on Friday.

(#64) Growing Grass or Pulling Weeds?

“When I was working for the St. Louis Rams, I asked the head groundskeeper, Scott Parker, how I could get rid of the weeds in my yard at home. With great confidence, he replied, ‘Grow more grass.’ Growing more grass chokes out the weeds.”

- Relentless Solution Focus

This is one of the coolest shifts in mindset that we can apply to any problem.

Any time we’re in a challenging situation, let’s ask: “Am I growing grass or pulling weeds?”

(#65) All Life Sciences are Breath Sciences

If [breath is life](#), then all life sciences are, in some way, breath sciences.

- Heart science is in some way breath science.
- Brain science is in some way breath science.
- Physiology is in some way breath science.
- Psychology is in some way breath science.
- & on and on

If you study life, you study breath :)

P.S. Thank you (!!) all so much for the survey responses last week. You can see the results [here](#). Based on the responses, the only major change I am making for now is to add a short monthly audio wrap-up. Check out the notes in the survey results because many of you had amazing ideas about quotes and making TB1% more different from my weekly newsletter. I don't have a perfect solution yet, but my mind will be churning, so thank you!

P.P.S. I may have cried at some of the nice words you left :)

(#66) What Does All of this Mean in Real Life?

“So what does this mean for us? We can use our breath whenever we experience a stressful event. [...] It's the most accessible tool you have, and it's invisible. You can practice breathing for well-being no matter where you are without anyone noticing.”*

- Emma Seppälä, The Happiness Track

That's a perfect description of what all this breathing education means in real life. And we can use it anytime, anywhere, without anyone even noticing.

Of course, breathing isn't everything, but it's the most accessible tool we have.

Let's use it wisely 🙏

(#67) Timeless Healing

“Believe in something good if you can. Or even better, believe in something better than anything you can fathom. Because for us mortals, this is very profound medicine.”

- Herbert Benson, MD, Timeless Healing

It's Friday, so a new Book 411 has just been released: Timeless Healing: The Power and Biology of Belief.

As the subtitle suggests, this one is mainly about the power of our minds and belief.

Here's a quote to keep in the back of your mind as you read or listen:

“By controlling your breathing, you can use a voluntary mechanical behavior to make a profound change on your state of mind.”

- Emma Seppälä, PhD

Enjoy!

In good breath,
Nick

(#68) Induce a Chosen State of Mind

“In other words, by changing the breath pattern one can induce a chosen state of mind.”
- Swami Niranjanananda Saraswati

P.S. This quote pairs nicely with our new Book 411 on Timeless Healing.

(#69) Where Happiness Lies

“Happiness lies in your own heart. You only need to practice mindful breathing for a few seconds, and you'll be happy right away.”

- Thich Nhat Hanh

(#70) How to Live a Meaningful Life: Be a Lobster

“For the lobster, stress literally leads to growth—if the lobster did not feel stressed in the small shell, it would not know to get a bigger one and be able to continue growing. Stress provides you with the same opportunity to grow. If you don’t experience stress, you don’t move forward, you don’t challenge yourself, and you don’t get the opportunity to live a fulfilling, meaningful life.”

- Inna Khazan, Ph.D., [Biofeedback and Mindfulness in Everyday Life](#)

We’ve been talking a lot about reducing stress lately. But let’s not forget that, in many cases, stress is necessary for growth and a “fulfilling, meaningful life.”

Stress—> Breathe—> Recover—> Grow—> Repeat Forever 💪

(#71) Thoracic Curve and Lung Function

“Our thoracic curve affects lung function. When the thoracic curve become more pronounced (think hunchback), the lungs’ ability to expand decreases. Excessive thoracic curvature weakens respiratory muscles and restricts your ability to take a full, deep breath.”

- Pete Egoscue, [Pain Free](#)

We all know posture is important, but reading (and re-reading) this passage was a much-needed reminder to make my posture more of a priority—if only for my lungs’ sake.

I hope it sparks something for you, too 🙏

(#72) It's Not the Highs, It's Who You Become

"It's not the highs along the way that matter. It's who you become."

- Daniel Goleman & Richard Davidson, [Altered Traits](#)

That's a perfect rule of thumb for any contemplative practice (like breathing). Improving biomarkers of health and wellness is meaningful, but it's who you become that matters most.

(#73) Reconciling Acceptance with Growth

“‘Each of you is perfect the way you are,’ Zen master Suzuki Roshi told his students, adding, ‘and you can use a little improvement’—neatly reconciling acceptance with growth.”

- Daniel Goleman & Richard Davidson, [Altered Traits](#)

That’s an ideal way to reconcile acceptance with growth. And a perfect philosophy for why we do these 1%’s every day.

We are perfect just how we are. But we could use a little improvement :)

(#77) The Easiest Way to Immediately Improve Your Breathing

“The inhalation should be extremely soft and continuous, whether sitting down or lying down. If you are walking or standing, you should be relaxed. What is forbidden is noise.”

- [The Primordial Breath, Volume 1](#)

The easiest thing you can do to instantly improve your breathing anytime, anywhere, is just make it quiet. “What is forbidden is noise.”

P.S. Remember our mantra way back from the [2nd edition](#) of TB1%? Deeper, slower, **quieter**, and more regular.

(#78) Follow this Advice Today (and for the rest of our lives)

“So look for those little ways in the flow of life to feel a bit more relaxed, protected, strong, and at ease...and a little more grateful, glad, and successful...and a little more cared about and caring, and a little more loved and loving. One breath at a time, one synapse at a time, you can gradually develop an increasingly unshakable core inside yourself. The more often and deeply you do this, the greater the results.”

That’s perfect advice for us to follow today, tomorrow, and for the rest of our lives 🙏

(#79) The Making of the Present Moment

“Your experience of the present moment is based on the activity of your nervous system at that moment.”

- Rick Hanson, Ph.D., Neurodharma

And since, as Deb Dana tells us, **“Breath is a direct, easily accessible, and rapid way to shape the state of the nervous system,”** we might say:

Your experience of the present moment is based on your breathing at that moment.

P.S. A fun related quote: “In truth we are always present. We only imagine ourselves to be in one place or another.” - Howard Cohn

(#80) Science Offers Only Glimpses

“This highlights a weakness in what otherwise might seem quite impressive findings on the yogis: these data points are but glimpses of the altered traits that intensive, prolonged meditation produces. We do not want to reduce this quality of being to what we happen to be able to measure.”

- Daniel Goleman & Richard Davidson, *Altered Traits*

I obviously love reading science, but the more I learn and practice breathing, the more this resonates with me.

So let's value scientific findings while simultaneously remembering that it's only a glimpse of the benefits based on **“what we happen to be able to measure.”**

(#81) The Breath-Love Connection

It's Friday, so [a new Book 411 is available](#). This week, we have Love 2.0 by Barbara Fredrickson. I think you're gonna enjoy it.

Here's a passage from Thought #4 that captures the essence of the [Book 411](#):

...But perhaps a big part of this all comes back to love. We've now learned that breathing is self-love; it increases our vagal tone and allows us to experience more love-love (more positivity resonance). Experiencing more love, then, will reshape our lives for the better, triggering an upward spiral that lifts us to become the best versions of ourselves we can become.

Have a great weekend!

In good breath,
Nick

(#82) The Stream of Thinking

“I am as confident as I am of anything that, in myself, the stream of thinking is only a careless name for the stream of my breathing.” - William James

P.S. I removed a lot of extra words from this one to make it easier to read.

(#83) Wandering Walks Outdoors

“We should take wandering outdoor walks, so that the mind might be nourished and refreshed by the open air and deep breathing.” - Seneca

(#84) Power of Slow Breathing: Meditation, Yoga, and the Healing Touch of Prayer

Here's a memorable passage from *Breath* where James Nestor offers an eloquent summary of the benefits of slow breathing:

"In many ways, this resonant breathing offered the same benefits as meditation for people who didn't want to meditate. Or yoga for people who didn't like to get off the couch. It offered the healing touch of prayer for people who weren't religious."

P.S. Note that the essential words are "in many ways"; not "in all ways." Breathing isn't a one-to-one replacement for these other powerful health practices. But, it is a nice "all-in-one" option that covers many bases 🙏

(#85) Voluntary vs. Physiological Slow Breathing: Pick Which Suits You Best

Voluntary Slow Breathing: Using an app (or counting) to deliberately breathe slowly at a set pace (like five breaths a minute).

Physiological Slow Breathing: Using mindfulness or a relaxation technique (like yoga nidra) to naturally slow your breathing.

Of course, they have slightly different benefits, but either will be an effective way to improve your health & wellness, so pick the one that suits you best 🙏

(#86) A Simple Way to Fall Back to Sleep

“Counting is handled by the same area of the brain that’s responsible for worrying. It’s difficult to do both at the same time, so counting is exceptionally effective at crowding out stress, calming a busy brain, and enhancing focus.” - Leah Lagos, Psy.D., Heart Breath Mind

It’s hard to count and worry at the same time. So, when we wake up and our minds start worrying, breath counting is particularly useful for falling back to sleep.

Here’s how to use it: silently count each exhale you take. Count up to 10, and then restart at one until you fall asleep.

Simple and highly effective.

(#87) How Long Should You Practice Each Day?

"I think the amount of time that you spend on this work is not that important. ...[W]hat is important here is the regularity of doing this work. You want to do this every day without fail because you are attempting to change rhythms in your nervous system, and it's the constancy of the input, it's the regularity of the input, that is going to produce these changes over time."

- Andrew Weil, MD, Breathing: The Master Key to Self Healing

We can use science to find a reasonable daily dose (which is about 10 min for slow breathing).

But an even better approach is what Dr. Weil says here: Focus on consistency. We're trying to rewire our nervous systems, and *"it's the regularity of the input that is going to produce these changes over time."* 🙏

P.S. This reminds me of a quote from Eddie Stern in One Simple Thing: *"Any practice, whether spiritual, physical, or artistic, only begins to pay off when it is done with regularity and sincerity."*

(#88) New Sci411: Breathing Improves Cognition

It's Friday, so a new Science 411 was just released.

This is an amazing, recently-published study on breathing and executive function.

It found that 15-min of slow breathing:

- Improved attention control
- Improved working memory
- Increased cognitive flexibility

Take-home: slow breathing helps you plan, monitor, and execute your goals.

I hope you enjoy the Science 411!

In good breath,
Nick

(#89) Respiration is Reciprocation

“To breathe is to absorb ourselves in what surrounds us, to take in little bits of life, understand them, and give pieces of ourselves back out. Respiration is, at its core, reciprocation.” – James Nestor, *Breath*

(#90) A Universal Goal

“A universal goal in meditation of every kind comes down to sustaining attention in a chosen way or to a given target, such as the breath.” – Daniel Goleman & Richard Davidson

P.S. And if you haven’t checked out the latest Science 411 yet, we also learned that a breathing practice itself can help us sustain our attention on a given target.

(#91) Breath of Life Influences Everything

“Chronic overbreathing leads to loss of health, poor fitness, and compromised performance and also contributes to many ailments including anxiety, asthma, fatigue, insomnia, heart problems, and even obesity. It may seem strange that such a disparate range of complaints can be caused by or worsened by overbreathing, but the breath of life influences literally every aspect of our health.” – Patrick McKeown, The Oxygen Advantage

And fortunately, this is also why better breathing can help with so many issues: “the breath of life influences literally every aspect of our health.”

(#92) Why We Should Practice Abdominal Nose Breathing

“However, when we breathe through the nostrils and into the abdomen, not only do we breathe less frequently, but our exhalations are prolonged. What this means is that abdominal nose breathing not only makes more oxygen available to our bodies in a more efficient manner, but it also stimulates the sympathetic nervous system less frequently.”

- The Tibetan Yoga of Breath

That is all :)

(#93) Building Tremendous Breath Energy

“Having breath energy in a body is like having water in a river: the same water can both topple a boat and carry a boat. The breath energy can both build and destroy a body. When there are deep waters, unusually large ships can be carried. When tremendous breath energy is accumulated, unusual life can be maintained.”

- The Primordial Breath, Volume II

Here's to building “tremendous breath energy” so we can sustain unusually optimal lives 🙏

(#94) Breathing for Focus

“Noradrenaline is also released, though in different amounts, during times of intense focus, curiosity, or passion, promoting the growth of new connections in the brain. Researchers...found that slow, controlled, deep breathing helps the brain nail the noradrenaline “sweet spot,” heightening attention and getting people laser focused.” - Leah Lagos, Psy.D., [Heart Breath Mind](#)

Next time we need focus, let's breathe slowly and deeply to hit our “noradrenaline sweet spot.” Anecdotal, I've found it only takes a few breaths to reset and regain focus. It's simple and highly effective 🙏

P.S. This pairs nicely with the latest Science 411 on how slow breathing improves executive function.

(#95) Breath: The New Science of a Lost Art

“That’s what these researchers discovered. The missing pillar in health is breath. It all starts there.” - James Nestor, *Breath*

It’s Friday, so a new Book 411 is available.

I’m super excited (and even a bit nervous) about this one: *Breath* by James Nestor.

I’m excited because it’s such a good book. But nervous because there’s no way to cover all its wisdom in a short 411.

In any case, I’ve done my best to collect what I believe to be the most essential big concepts. I hope you enjoy it!

In good breath,

Nick

(#96) A Promising Cost-Effective Technique

“Slow-paced breathing appears a promising cost-effective technique to improve subjective sleep quality and cardiovascular function during sleep in young healthy individuals.”

— [Journal of Clinical Medicine \(2019\)](#)

P.S. We have [a Science 411 on this paper here.](#)

(#97) Not Genetics, Diet, or Daily Exercise

“They gathered two decades of data from 5,200 subjects, crunched the numbers, and discovered that the greatest indicator of life span wasn’t genetics, diet, or the amount of daily exercise, as many had suspected. It was lung capacity.”

— James Nestor

P.S. Check out Thought #2 in [our new Book 411 on Breath](#) for more on lung capacity.

(#98) A Fun Fact About the Upper Airways

I recently read in this older paper that “the upper respiratory tract is able to warm and saturate inspired air so that in climates as cold as minus 100°C [-148°F] air entering the alveoli has attained body temperature and is saturated with water vapor.”

My brain can’t fully grasp how remarkable that is over such a short distance...

Our airways are incredible.

(#99) Getting from Point A to B

*“This is the deepest paradox in all of meditation: we want to get somewhere—we wouldn’t have taken up the practice if we didn’t—but **the way to get there is just to be fully here. The way to get from point A to point B is really to be at A.**”*

- Larry Rosenberg, [*Breath by Breath*](#)

And the way to really be at A? [The breath.](#)

(#100) 100 Inspiring Breathing Quotes

To celebrate 100 days of The Breathing 1%, here are 100 Inspiring Breathing Quotes you can flip through at your leisure.

You can view them on the web or download them as a PDF here:

(#101) Just the Start

“Mindful Breathing is a useful practice in its own right. It allows us to take some time out from our busy daily routines, and often creates a restful state that allows us to recharge our batteries and find some inner peace. However, I’d like you to think of it as a versatile training tool to help you engage fully in every meaningful task in your life.”

We might use our breathing practice to find inner peace, recharge, or build resiliency in a controlled environment. But that’s just the start.

Its ultimate goal: “to help you engage fully in every meaningful task in your life.” ← let’s do that



(#102) Yogic Breathing Vagal Stimulation

It's Friday, so we have [a new Science 411 available](#). The paper this week is: **Vagal Mediation of Low-Frequency Heart Rate Variability During Slow Yogic Breathing**

This was super neat and important.

Here is the 1 Big Takeaway:

By separately blocking the parasympathetic and sympathetic nervous systems during slow breathing, this study conclusively found that observed increases in HRV during slow breathing are primarily due to increased vagal activity.

And here's a graphical representation of the key findings:

(#103) We Don't Need Qualifications

“The breath is something that is readily available to us simply because we are human beings. We do not need anything else to qualify. How marvelous!”

- Anyen Rinpoche & Allison Choying Zangmo, [The Tibetan Yoga of Breath](#)

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable breathing quote for you to enjoy—it's a productive form of mental rest :)

(#104) What's Best for You is Good for Everyone

“This is perhaps the biggest revelation of the awakened brain: that it's in our innate nature to build a better world. That what's good for everyone is also what's best for each one of us.”

- Lisa Miller, Ph.D., The Awakened Brain

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy.

(#105) Try it, and See What Happens

“So, at the beginning, you might want to stay with the breath, or use it as an anchor to bring you back when you are carried away. Try it for a few years and see what happens.”

- Jon Kabat-Zinn, [Wherever You Go There You Are](#)

In our world of instant gratification, “Try it for a few years and see what happens,” not only makes me laugh, but is also the best advice ever. Count me in. I know you are, too.

(#106) Why Breathing Heals

“This research clearly shows that working with the breath balances the two components of the autonomic nervous system by enhancing parasympathetic nervous activity (enabling body and mind to relax) and decreasing sympathetic nervous activity (which causes the body to feel anxious or overly alert). It also improves respiratory and cardiovascular function, decreases the negative effects of stress and the production of stress hormones, and improves physical and mental health.”

- Anyen Rinpoche & Allison Choying Zangmo, [The Tibetan Yoga of Breath](#)

When combined, all those improvements lead to healing and health.

P.S. This one is now up near the top of my list of mind-blowing quotes about the healing power of breathing.

(#107) Breath Pauses, the Nervous System, and 4-7-8

“Vagal activity is enhanced during the postinspiratory period and inhibited during the postexpiratory period.”

When I read this unassuming sentence in the Discussion of our most recent [Science 411 paper](#), it was actually quite eye-opening for me.

It means:

Inhalations: Sympathetic

Inhale-Holds: *Parasympathetic*

Exhalations: Parasympathetic

Exhale-Holds: *Sympathetic* (I had never actually thought deeply about this one and always thought this was parasympathetic)

Putting these together, we see why deeply relaxing breaths usually focus on inhale-holds and prolonged exhalations.

Let’s look at the most common example, 4-7-8 breathing. With this breath, 4 seconds are spent in sympathetic and 15 parasympathetic.

No wonder Dr. Weil says, “This breathing exercise is a natural tranquilizer for the nervous system.”

(#108) 3 Quotes from Bruce Lee on Methods

I think these apply perfectly to breathing (or any contemplative practice):

“Any technique, however worthy and desirable, becomes a disease when the mind is obsessed with it.”

“The individual is of first importance, not the system. Remember that man created method and not that method created man, and do not strain yourself in twisting into someone’s preconceived pattern, which unquestionably would be appropriate for him, but not necessarily for you.”

“The more complicated and restricted the method, the lesser the opportunity for the expression of one’s original sense of freedom.”

(#109) Less is More

“If you reduce your breathing and properly regulate the amount of air you take in, you will teach your body to breathe more efficiently, and you will become healthier.”

Patrick McKeown, The Oxygen Advantage

Our new Book 411 release today is The Oxygen Advantage.

Serendipitously, March 12th will be my 5-year anniversary of starting OA teacher training. And although I’m more of a “Mixed Breathing Artist” nowadays, the OA program is still the most comprehensive and science-backed technique that I’ve discovered. (And Patrick is still one of the nicest people I’ve ever met.)

I hope you enjoy getting the key concepts in the Book 411!

In good breath,
Nick

(#110) The Oldest, Single-Most Efficient Intervention

“Controlled respiration is one of the oldest and certainly the single, most efficient acute intervention for the mitigation and treatment of excessive stress. Any clinician treating patients who manifest excessive stress syndromes should consider controlled respiration as a potentially suitable intervention for virtually all patients.”

Everly and Lating (2019)

https://link.springer.com/chapter/10.1007/978-1-4939-9098-6_15

(#111) The Finest Gift of Nature

“Breath is the finest gift of nature. Be grateful for this wonderful gift.” — Amit Ray

(#112) Breathing and Emotions

To add to the mind-blowing quote we saw on Saturday, here are a couple more [I stumbled upon](#) that had my mind spinning:

“Throughout this article we have demonstrated that emotions can affect respiration and respiration can also influence emotions, yet this well-established relationship is not utilized in conventional treatments. Breathing and meditation techniques are simple, easy, and cost effective yet they are not widely used as treatments.”

“We propose that these breathing techniques could be used as first-line and supplemental treatments for stress, anxiety, depression, and some emotional disorders.”

P.S. I changed the order of these sentences to make them flow more logically.

(#113) Applying the Lung's Elegant Structure to All Aspects of Our Lives

"While the heart has dense striated muscle, and the brain its conglomerated networks of communicating neurons, the lung is a thin, graceful structure of interconnecting fibrous tissue that is beautifully held together with a foamy substance that lubricates its functions in a quiet and effortless manner. It is an organ of elegance, not brute strength."

- Michael J Stephen, [Breath Taking](#)

Our most important organ is designed to be graceful and flexible, not rigid and strong. To be of elegance, not strength.

Something for us to consider in all aspects of our lives...

(#114) Deep Breathing = Deep Keel

“Developing inner resources is like deepening the keel of a sailboat so that you're more able to deal with the worldly winds—gain and loss, pleasure and pain, praise and blame, fame and slander—without getting tipped over into the reactive mode. Or at least you can recover more quickly.”

- Rick Hanson, Ph.D., [Neurodharma](#)

Although Dr. Hanson is talking about inner resources in general, this is a perfect analogy for why improving HRV via slow deep breathing is so helpful: *it's like deepening the keel of your physiological sailboat.*

You will still be hit by life's storms, but you'll remain steadier and recover quicker.

We could say that *deep breathing = deep keel.*

(#115) My New Seated Breathing Posture

“Sattva is a Sanskrit word meaning “hero,” a spiritual hero who works for the benefit of others. Because it is less physically demanding than full lotus posture, most of us will be able to sit in Sattva posture if we work at it over time.”

When I read that there’s a posture signifying “a spiritual hero who works for the benefit of others,” there was no way I wasn’t making this my new breathing position.

Here’s how Anyen and Allison say it’s done:

“Sattva posture is done differently for males and females, but both can begin by sitting cross-legged on the floor. Elevating the hips so that they rest above the knees makes the posture easier to hold, so we need to sit on a pillow or cushion. For males, the left leg is tucked in closer to the body and the left foot placed on the inner right thigh, while the right leg rests in the front. For females it is the opposite: the left leg rests in the front and the right leg is tucked, with the right foot resting on the inner left thigh. This posture is similar to a half lotus posture, except that one leg rests in front of the body for balance.”

And here’s a picture from the book. It’s probably copyright infringement to share this, but as a spiritual hero working for the benefit of others, I think they’ll let it slide 😊:



Sattva posture and placement of the back of the hands on the crease of the thigh. The placement of the vajra fists on the crease of the thigh, and the male sattva posture are demonstrated.

P.S. I know several of you are yoga teachers. And as much as I love learning, if this translation of Sattva (or the posture) is incorrect, please don’t tell me...I’m way too excited about the idea of embodying spiritual heroism while I breathe 😊 😊

(#116) New Sci 411

(#117) Becoming More Alive

“Waking up is becoming more alive. The aliveness that's available to all of you is already here in this moment. It's life in the form of breathing.” – Larry Rosenberg

(#118) A Source of Support

“The breath is not only a source of support for the physical body; it is also a support for mental, emotional, and spiritual well-being.” - Anyen Rinpoche & Allison Zangmo, *The Tibetan Yoga of Breath*

(#119) Diverse Tactics for Human Potential

“The integration of a wide variety of perspectives is necessary for a more complete understanding of the full depths of human potential, as too much focus on a single perspective runs the risk of giving a distorted view of human nature. As Maslow said, ‘I suppose it is tempting, if the only tool you have is a hammer, to treat everything as if it were a nail.’” - Scott Barry Kaufman, Ph.D., [Transcend](#)

Here’s an excellent reminder that we need a wide range of methods—with breathing and life in general—if we are to become the best version of ourselves.

If all we have are hammers, everything will look like a nail.

P.S. This happened to me recently: I was beating a problem with my “breathing hammer” that didn’t need breathing at all—it needed me to change something in my diet. Which reminded me of this passage :)

(#120) Teaching Philosophy from Abraham Maslow

“Maslow viewed the role of the teacher, therapist, and parent as horticulturists, whose task is to ‘enable people to become healthy and effective in their own style.’ To Maslow, this meant that ‘we try to make a rose into a good rose, rather than seek to change roses into lilies. . . . It necessitates a pleasure in the self-actualization of a person who may be quite different from yourself. It even implies an ultimate respect and acknowledgement of the sacredness and uniqueness of each kind of person.’”

- Scott Barry Kaufman, Ph.D., [*Transcend*](#)

I absolutely love this. **“We try to make a rose into a good rose, rather than seek to change roses into lilies.”** 🙌🙌🙌

Ancient meditation teachers did this too. They didn’t have a preset plan. They looked at the temperament of each student and matched them to a practice accordingly.

How might you apply this philosophy in your life, or in your role as a teacher or parent?

(#121) Slow Breathing, HRV and Mental Health

“Additionally, recent neurocardiology studies have revealed that the heart is capable of secreting feel-good chemicals like dopamine, oxytocin, and norepinephrine, all of which help to counteract feelings of depression. ... the notion that the heart can produce these neurochemicals is exciting on many levels. This suggests that strengthening the heart through HRV-strengthening practices could possibly yield mild antidepressive effects.”

- Leah Lagos, Psy.D., [*Heart Breath Mind*](#)

By strengthening the heart, we may improve its ability to release feel-good chemicals like dopamine and oxytocin. This may be one more reason [slow breathing is so helpful](#) for mental health.

(#122) How to Be Confident

“This is a key point. If we want to do anything with confidence—speak, paint, make love, play tennis, or socialize—then we have to do the work. We have to practice the necessary skills over and over, until they come naturally. ...

This insight gives us the first “right rule” of the confidence game: RULE 1: The actions of confidence come first; the feelings of confidence come later.”

- Russ Harris, [*The Confidence Gap*](#)

Just an awesome reminder that actions come before feelings.

We can apply this to all aspects of our lives, but for our breathing, we might make the following “right rule:” The practice of breathing comes first; the confidence you’ll be able to use your breathing for self-regulation in any situation comes later.

Related Quote: “Another point most of us fail to see: action comes before the courage to act. Action spawns courage, not the other way around. Action also generates motivation. Instead of waiting for inspiration to strike, action implores you to keep going.” – Marie Forleo, Everything is Figureoutable

(#123) The Tibetan Yoga of Breath

“Each time a gust of wind blows over the ocean, ripples and waves cause movement and agitation on the water’s surface. However, when the air is calm, so is the water. It is just so with the mind. The more often we breathe, the more agitated the energy of body and mind becomes. By breathing less frequently, we begin to achieve elemental harmony.”

Anyen Rinpoche and Allison Zangmo, [*The Tibetan Yoga of Breath*](#)

It’s Friday, so we have a new 411. This week, we have [*The Tibetan Yoga of Breath*](#).

It’s filled with inspiring wisdom on the power of the breath. If you need a daily reminder to practice, there’s surely a quote or two in this one that will motivate you.

I hope you enjoy the 411 🙏

In good breath,
Nick

(#124) Ability to Live and Value Your Life

“The practices of breathing and working with your body are about re-empowering you. They’re about connecting you with your own mind, your own body, your own will and your ability to live and to value your life.” — Daniel Libby, Ph.D.

(#125) When to Practice

“Practice should not be separated from living, and living at all times should be one's practice.” – [Chan master Sheng Yen](#)

P.S. I found this quote in Three Steps to Awakening, which I then searched to find the above-linked site.

P.P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote as a productive form of mental rest.

(#126) Endlessly Ending. Endlessly Renewed

“One of the most remarkable facts of existence is under our noses all of the time. This is the Now of the present moment: endlessly ending, and endlessly renewed. Radically transient, yet always enduring.” – Rick Hanson, Ph.D., Neurodharma

“Endlessly ending, and endlessly renewed. Radically transient, yet always ending.” Just like each breath.

I suppose this is why humanity has always regarded breathing as our gateway to presence; because it is presence :)

(#127) How to Practice Breath Awareness (perfectly)

Yesterday, we learned that breath is presence. So how do you use this info? Here's the simplest practice you can do anytime, anywhere. Use it once or twice today and notice how it shifts your mind and body for the better:

“At this very moment, whether you know it or not, each breath happens right here and right now. Little by little the question becomes, Are you intimate with this breath just as it is? Intimate, meaning not separate but fully experiencing whatever you experience as the breath fills up the lungs and empties in this particular posture at this time in this place.

When the mind gets caught up in its productions, can you return to the body and the breathing? Wherever you feel those breath sensations at any moment, your practice is perfect.” – Larry Rosenberg, [*Three Steps to Awakening*](#)

(#128) Changing the Present Moment

“Your experience of the present moment is based on the activity of your nervous system at that moment.” – Rick Hanson, Ph.D., [Neurodharma](#)

I share this quote a lot because it’s succinct yet insanely powerful.

It means that when we can change our breath (which changes our nervous system), we change our experience of the present moment.

Make sure you use this amazing gift at least once today 🙏

(#129) Self-Explanation vs. Self-Expression

One of the best ways to learn a concept is through ***self-explanation***—explaining a concept in your own words using analogies that make sense in your life.

But for breathing, one of the best ways to learn a concept is through ***self-expression***—expressing a concept through repeated practice so that it makes sense in your life and your routine.

What method or concept have you learned recently that you can try expressing?

(#130) The “Embreathment” Illusion

“This new way of inducing a respiratory bodily illusion, called “embreathment,” revealed that breathing is almost as important as visual appearance for inducing body ownership and more important than any other cue for body agency.” - [The “embreathment” illusion highlights the role of breathing in corporeal awareness](#)

The “embreathment” illusion <-- if that’s not the coolest thing you’ve seen in a science paper, I don’t know what is :)

This excellent paper used a neat virtual reality experiment to highlight the importance of breathing for our sense of embodiment.

It was amazing, so I hope [you enjoy the 411](#) (and all my speculation about what these results might mean...)

In good breath,
Nick

(#131) Turn to Breath Like a Good Friend

“Wherever you go, the breath is with you, providing an anchor. At moments that are right for you, you can turn to it just as you might turn to a good friend, to help you stay alert and cut down on the mind's habitual, unnecessary thinking that often squanders so much energy.” – Larry Rosenberg

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable breathing quote for you to enjoy. It's a productive form of mental rest :)

(#132) It's Surprising More People Don't Know This

“Our breathing can help us in capturing our moments. It's surprising that more people don't know about this. After all, the breath is always here, right under our noses.” – Jon Kabat-Zinn, Ph.D.

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable breathing quote for you to enjoy. It's a productive form of mental rest :)

(#133) Doing Lungwork

Here's a neat stat: To perform their vital functions and keep us alive, [it's estimated](#) that the lungs themselves use about 5% of total body oxygen consumption.

So, even if we don't do breathing exercises, we're always doing lungwork :)

(#134) Let Emotions Go Cold

“Please remember that emotions will always pass. Even if you do not meditate, everything changes and shifts—but often an emotion remains ‘hot’ as it moves along. In dharma language, the critical question to ask is whether the emotions go out hot or cold. **In the light of awareness, emotions go out ‘cold.’** Like a defanged snake, a noise is made but the bite is not poisonous.” – Larry Rosenberg, Three Steps to Awakening

Here’s another way to look at the benefits of breathing, meditation, or any other contemplative practice you might do for emotional regulation.

Emotions will pass either way, but our practice helps them go cold.

(#135) The Force Applied is Minute

“In the Art of War, which I used to introduce this book, Sun Tzu offers up a second approach one can use in an unfair fight: *“The force applied is minute but the results enormous.”* Don’t struggle against a brick wall. Find a way to apply the minimum amount of force with the maximum amount of impact.”* – Amishi P. Jha, Ph.D., [Peak Mind](#)

Having a consistent breathing practice is the minimum amount of force we can apply to get the maximum amount of impact on our physical and mental wellness.

Don’t struggle against a brick wall. Instead, put your back against it to straighten your spine and take a few nice slow, deep breaths :)

* I’m listening to this book and haven’t gotten the print or Kindle versions yet, so this is my best attempt at transcription.

(#136) Almost Instantaneously

“Our breathing pattern can have an enormous effect on our psycho-physical state. This means that changing the way we breathe can literally change the way we feel, almost instantaneously. Want to be relaxed? Breathe like you already are.” – Charlie Morley, [Waking Up to Sleep](#)

I’ve shared passages like this probably a dozen times now. But it never gets old to me.

It’s the most powerful part of breathing: we can almost instantaneously *change how we feel*.

(#137) Three Steps to Awakening

“The next step is crucial: you give relaxed, careful attention to respiration and to the obvious, often neglected fact that each one of us is breathing. In other words, you are alive! Did you know that?” – Larry Rosenberg, [*Three Steps to Awakening*](#)

It's Friday, so a new 411 is available. This week, we have *Three Steps to Awakening*, our second book from Larry Rosenberg.

It's an excellent book with many gems on the power of breath awareness.

What You'll Learn:

1. The Power of Breath Awareness ('a joyful abiding in the here and now')
2. How to Practice Breath Awareness
3. Life is the Real Practice
4. The Proof is in the Pudding (plus some 'ouch' teaching)

1 Life-Changing Idea

The Best Advice on Methods (plus long beards)

[Click here to read or listen to the 411.](#)

In good breath,
Nick

P.S. You are alive...did you know that?

(#138) Great Adventures Await You

“But great adventures await you if you give yourself a little time to string moments of awareness together, breath by breath, moment to moment.” – Jon Kabat-Zinn

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable breathing quote for you to enjoy. It's a productive form of mental rest :)

(#139) The Wonders and Benefits that Each Breath Offers

“May your adventures be truly great for as long as you take another breath. And may you live long as you seek to discover the wonders and the benefits that each breath has to offer in this, the journey of life.” – Rev. Duffy Peet

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable breathing quote for you to enjoy. It’s a productive form of mental rest :)

P.P.S. I found this excellent quote through a rather odd series of events related to the Jon Kabat-Zinn quote I shared yesterday. But since it’s from a Reverend, perhaps it was divine intervention :)

(#140) Cleaning Windows

I was cleaning windows at my house the other day. I started on the inside. No matter how clean I got it, it still looked dirty until I cleaned the outside too.

It was a reminder for me that no matter how much inner work I do with my breathing practice, I still have to keep the environment around me clean too.

Maybe it will mean something for you

(#141) Happy World Breathing Day

Although every day is World Breathing Day, let's use this "official" one as a reminder to show gratitude for the fact that we're alive and breathing, in whatever way is right for you.

For me, it's reading my current favorite quote on breathing:

"And beyond improving stress resilience, breath practices can restore your sense of being genuinely who you are, of knowing what you feel, of recognizing what others feel, and of being able to experience deep and meaningful connections with people, with your values, and with all that is." — Richard Brown, MD, and Patricia Gerbarg, MD

And starting my morning breathing session by silently reciting the last sentence of this passage:

"Oxygen, in fact, is the most valuable resource to our species. ... Consider the last time you thought to yourself while taking a breath, 'This is great! I have an abundance of the most valuable resource known to our species, and I don't even have to work that hard to get it!'"

P.S. World Breathing Day also happens to be my birthday. Perhaps, like the quote I found on Sunday, this is another case of divine intervention 😂 But, more than likely, it's just coincidence :)

(#142) Storing Your Breath for Later

You can store the power of your slow breathing practice for the rest of your day, week, month, and year through increased vagal tone. It's kind of like the bank account of slow breathing.

In this way, slow breathing is one of the best investments you can make. It gives you an immediate return of a calmer and more focused mind plus long-term interest in the form of increased vagal tone, increasing your capacity to love, improving resiliency, and leading to an overall healthier life.

(#143) A Force-Multiplier for Any Practice

“We need a force multiplier, like a power-up in a video game. The attentional force multiplier you need to acquire is your capacity to be meta-aware, to notice.

To notice when we are not focused or too focused.

To notice when we are mentally elsewhere and not in the here and now.

To notice what is happening around us and within us.

Noticing is what unlocks our capacity to intervene in these pervasive attentional problems.

It’s simple: To know if you’re getting grabbed by something and need to intervene, you have to be watching. - Amishi P. Jha, Ph.D., [*Peak Mind*](#)

Whether we use breathing, yoga, meditation, or any other contemplative practice, we need to know when we need to actually use that tool. This is where meta-awareness comes in.

By helping us notice what we’re noticing, it becomes a “force multiplier” for any practice.

(#144) Voluntary Control of Respiration Patterns

“Any clinician treating patients who manifest excessive stress syndromes should consider controlled respiration as a potentially suitable intervention for virtually all patients.” - Everly and Lating (2019)

It's Friday, so a new Science 411 was just released. Today, we have an awesome one, Voluntary Control of Respiration Patterns, a book chapter in *A Clinical Guide to the Treatment of the Human Stress Response*.

It was a quick and easy overview of the benefits of diaphragmatic breathing from a clinical perspective. The quote above sums it up perfectly.

I hope you enjoy this super practical 411.

[Click Here to Read/Listen to the New 411](#)

In good breath,
Nick

Course Announcement

New Course: Breathing for Better Mental and Emotional Health

Hey, it's me for the second time today :)

I'm teaching a new 4-week course called Breathing for Better Mental and Emotional Health. Much of it is inspired by Learning Center Material.

It's going to take place in May during Mental Health Awareness Month. It costs \$400, but if you'd like to join, you get 75% off as a Learning Center Member, making it just \$100 for the entire 4 weeks. [You can learn all the details here.](#)

Coupon Code: LEARNINGCENTER75

Expires: May 6, 2023 (the course starts May 7)

As a member, you can also share this 75% coupon with a few friends and family as you see fit.

I hope to see some of you there!

All the best,
Nick

(#145) If Breath Influences Body and Mind...

“[I]f breath influences both the body and the mind, not only physical, mental, and emotional states are reflected in the pattern of breath, but through breathing we can also influence our physical, psychological, and spiritual well-being” – Patel (1993)

P.S. I found this quote in [this chapter](#).

(#146) The Majority Said, “The Breathing”

“When we surveyed several hundred patients who had been out of the stress reduction program for a number of years and asked them what the single most important thing they got out of the program was, the majority said, ‘The breathing.’” – Jon Kabat-Zinn, Ph.D.

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable breathing quote for you to enjoy 🙏

(#147) You Cannot Fail at This

“In fact, in this way of looking at things, there is truly no place else to go, so efforts to get anywhere else are ill conceived. They are bound to lead to frustration and failure. On the other hand, you cannot fail to be where you already are. So you cannot ‘fail’ in your meditation practice if you are willing to be with things as they are.” - Jon Kabat-Zinn, Ph.D., [*Full Catastrophe Living*](#)

This is so good: *“you cannot fail to be where you already are.”*

Meaning, you cannot fail at being with the breath.

(#148) Anything You Set Out to Do

“Working memory is where you hold a goal in mind so you can move toward it. By goal...I mean the micro-intentions and deliberate aim of having a desired outcome for each and every task you engage in—all the decisions, planning, thinking, actions, and behaviors you do over the course of a day: anything you set out to do.”

Based on this description, working memory is pretty influential. It plays a role in “anything you set out to do.”

But I’m sharing this because a 2022 study [we recently reviewed](#) found that—you guessed it—slow breathing significantly improves working memory.

Putting it together: By improving working memory, slow breathing can help you with anything you set out to do 🙌

(#149) Can You Use this Truism?

“Of course, it is a truism that none of us can live without breathing. But can you make use of this truism, so that it helps your contemplative life?” - Larry Rosenberg, [*Three Steps to Awakening*](#)

Just a question for you today: *How might you use this truism to help your life?*

(#150) Using Neem Karoli's Advice in Our Breathing/Contemplative Path

"If someone was following a given inner path, Neem Karoli always encouraged it. From his perspective the main point was that you do your practice—not try to find the 'very best.'

Whenever Neem Karoli was asked about which path was best, his answer was 'Sub ek!'—Hindi for 'They are all one.' Everyone has different preferences, needs, and the like. Just choose one and plunge in.

In that view contemplative paths are more or less the same, a doorway beyond ordinary experience." - Daniel Goleman & Richard Davidson, [*Altered Traits*](#)

Amen to that 🙏

Don't try to find "the best" breathing practice, or yoga practice, or meditation technique. Just find the one that resonates with you now (accepting it will change with time) and plunge in.

(#151) Peak Mind

“[I]f you come away from this book with anything, I want it to be a clear sense of how important this is. We’re busy. We’re time-pressured. We are always under the gun. But twelve more minutes of work is simply not going to catch you up as much as sitting quietly, and on purpose, with your breath.” – Amishi P. Jha, Ph.D., [Peak Mind](#)

I’ll repeat: *“But twelve more minutes of work is simply not going to catch you up as much as sitting quietly, and on purpose, with your breath.”* 🙏

It’s Friday, so a new Book 411 was just released. This week we have ***Peak Mind: Find Your Focus, Own Your Attention, Invest 12 Minutes a Day***. This was such a good book and full of practical wisdom.

Her ideas that we cover in Thought #4 and the 1 Life-Changing Idea on “pre-silience” are so good...

[Click here to read the 411 on Peak Mind.](#)

Enjoy your weekend!

In good breath,
Nick

P.S. Thanks to friend and mentor P.H. for suggesting this book to me 🙏

(#152) Our Bodies are Joined with the Planet

“Our very bodies are joined with the planet in a continual rhythmic exchange as matter and energy flow back and forth between our bodies and what we call ‘the environment.’ One way this exchange of matter and energy happens is through breathing.” – Jon Kabat-Zinn, Ph.D.

(#153) Nose More Important than Vagus Nerve?

“The emerging scenario strongly suggests that the effects of SNB [slow nasal breathing], beyond the relative contribution of vagal stimulation, are mainly ascribable to olfactory epithelium stimulation.” – Zaccaro et al. (2022), Neural Correlates of Non-ordinary States of Consciousness in Pranayama Practitioners: The Role of Slow Nasal Breathing

P.S. Let that sink in a little...pretty mind-blowing. This is just a little teaser for the paper I'm reading now (not quite finished) and will be releasing a 411 on this coming Friday. The article is challenging to read, but it may significantly contribute to our understanding of why slow breathing is so beneficial...we'll see once I get through it all...

(#154) You're More Alive (and live longer)

"You're more alive when body and breath are permeated with the energy of awareness." – Larry Rosenberg, [*Three Steps to Awakening*](#)

Remember, we are only present about 50% of the time (see the [1 life-changing idea here](#)). When we bring awareness to more moments by bringing awareness to our breath, we not only become more alive, but also live longer because we're actually present for the life we're living 🙏

P.S. It's much easier said than done...

(#155) More Human, Not Superhuman

“It’s very intuitive: If we breathe better...we can deliver more oxygen to our muscles and organs, including the heart and brain, and thus heighten our physical capacity. All we’re really doing is assisting the body in working the way it was meant to work in the first place.” –

Patrick McKeown, [*The Oxygen Advantage*](#)

That’s such a great reminder that breathing (and other mind-body practices like meditation and yoga) are not hacks to boost our health and performance to superhuman levels.

They’re simply **“assisting the body in working the way it was meant to work in the first place,”** which may feel superhuman at times...

(#156) Upward Spirals in Your Life

“In fact, science documents that positive emotions can set off upward spirals in your life, self-sustaining trajectories of growth that lift you up to become a better version of yourself.” – Barbara Fredrickson, Ph.D., [Love 2.0](#)

This is the real power of slow breathing. By using your practice to regularly elicit positive emotional states—*a hallmark feature of slow breathing*—you set off upward spirals that “lift you up to become a better version of yourself.” 🙌

(#157) It Actually Worked Perfectly

I was so tired this past Saturday night that I fell asleep twice during my nighttime.

Then, right when it finished, and I was about to fall asleep for good, I thought, “Oh s***, there was a huge package in front of the neighbor’s door!” I knew they were out of town, so I didn’t want to leave it out overnight.

I got up, got dressed, and as I was walking out the door, I remember thinking “Well, that breathing practice was useless now.”

Then, as I was carrying the heavy box back across the street to my house—*being a good neighbor*—it hit me that the practice had actually worked perfectly.

Try looking for an inconspicuous way in which your contemplative practice shows up to help you be a better person today 🙏

(#158) Nasal Breathing vs. Vagal Stimulation

It's Friday, so we have [a new 411 available](#). As promised on Sunday, it's on a 2022 paper exploring the differences between vagal stimulation by itself and vagal & nasal stimulation together during slow breathing. *It was an amazing paper to read.*

Here was my 1 Big Takeaway from it:

Slow nasal breathing has significantly different effects on the brain than slow mouth breathing, which results in less physical and psychological tension, less anxiety, more joy, and a relaxed yet fully aware altered state of consciousness. Nasal stimulation should be considered alongside vagal stimulation as a primary mechanism behind the benefits of slow breathing.

[I hope you enjoy the full 411!](#)

All the best,
Nick

(#159) Thought, Emotion, and Behavior

“Messages from the respiratory system have rapid, powerful effects on major brain centers involved in thought, emotion, and behavior.” - Patricia Gerbarg, MD, and Dr. Richard Brown, MD

(#160) Thinking is Entangled with Respiration

“Thanks to the regulation of breathing patterns, patterns in our thinking are not just affected, but revealed, together with their entanglement with respiration.” - Marco Bernini

(#161) Turbulence & Contemplative Practices

When you're flying and hit turbulence, you're told to put on your seatbelt.

It's reactive.

It's similar to when turbulence hits in our lives. We react and start eating healthy or exercising more.

But the regular use of contemplative practices like breathing and meditation are proactive.

They help you avoid turbulence altogether. Or when you can't, they're like your seatbelt, keeping you fastened in so you can make it through the bumpy ride.

(#162) Air Candy

Gratitude turns an ordinary breath into air candy.

(#163) Voice as Meditation

“In the beginning was the voice. Voice is sounding breath, the audible sign of life.” – Otto Jespersen

Treating voice as breath—so obvious, yet I hadn’t thought about it until reading this in *Breath Taking*—is another way to bring mindfulness into your day.

When you’re listening to music or to a person speak, notice that they’re doing a “breathing exercise,” allowing you to hear the audible sound of life 🙏

(#164) Why Dr. Weil Recommend Breathing to Everyone

“I recommend breath work to almost all patients that I see because, in my experience, stress is a primary cause (or an aggravating cause) of most cases of illness. And even if people have diseases that clearly have organic physical causes, relaxation can nonetheless benefit them and help their body’s healing system work better.” – Andrew Weil, MD, *Breathing: The Master Key to Self Healing*

This is a perfect description of why slow breathing exercises work for basically anyone. Regardless of your condition (even if you don't have any), relaxation is still valuable in our modern stress-filled world.

(#165) Full Catastrophe Living

“Right in the simple old breath...lies a completely overlooked source of power to transform our lives. All we need to do to make use of it is to deepen our attentional skills and our patience.” – Jon Kabat-Zinn, Ph.D., [*Full Catastrophe Living*](#)

It's Friday, so a new 411 has been released. This week it is *Full Catastrophe Living*.

Jon Kabat-Zinn has an incredible knack for articulating how mindfulness of breathing can transform our lives. The book is full of quote gems and inspiration to notice our breath more regularly and embrace this “full catastrophe” we call life.

[I hope you enjoy the 411!](#)

In good breath,
Nick

P.S. Just a reminder that (if you're not already sick of learning from me 😊) my new 4-week course on [breathing for better mental & emotional health](#) starts on Sunday, May 7th. You can sign up for just \$100 as a learning center member using the coupon code: LEARNINGCENTER75. Sign-up closes at 11:59 p.m. Eastern on May 6th. I look forward to seeing a few of you there!

(#166) The Heart of All Life

“In addition, the mental component of breath is a sense of rhythmic expansion and contraction. And I think that connects us to every other living thing because all living organisms breathe. So that same rhythm is at the center of the heart of all life.” – Andrew Weil, MD

(#167) The Paradox of a Lifetime

“Paradoxically, it takes time to become what we already are.” – Rick Hanson, Ph.D.

(#168) Which is Better to Have?

“Is there a separation between body and mind, and if so which is it better to have?” — Woody Allen

That’s a fun, hypothetical question to consider. Sometimes a bit of humor is the best way to highlight the irrationality of an argument :)

(#169) Water & Breath

“Petr Janata...is a cognitive neuroscientist and expert on music in the brain. He theorizes that the low frequency of the sound of water, coupled with its rhythmic nature, is similar to the frequency and rhythm of human breath. ...‘If I ask you to close your eyes and turn on a recording of the ocean, I can change your mood immediately.’” – Wallace Nichols, *Blue Mind* (inset quote from Petr Janata)

Here’s a simple way to boost the benefits of any contemplative practice you do: add the sound of water. For example, sit outside near a body of water, or just use headphones with some relaxing ocean or river sounds (here are a few tracks [on Spotify I find peaceful](#)).

Since the frequency and rhythm of water are “similar to the frequency and rhythm of human breath,” it seems like a perfect complement :)

(#170) The Only Thing We Can Master

“The only thing that we can control and master is our own spiritual path.” - [Anyen Rinpoche & Allison Choying Zangmo](#)

Sometimes I think, “If I could only talk to this person, I could help them.” Or, “If only people would stop watching the news so much, we’d all be a lot nicer to each other.”

But this quote is a nice reminder that the only thing we can control & master is **our own path**. And it doesn’t just apply to spirituality; it applies to business, sports, and all areas of life.

And the best place to start? Mastering our own breath :)

(#171) How to Approach Practice

If you studied basketball in great detail, you'd probably find a lot of health benefits.

If you studied tennis in great detail, you'd probably find a lot of health benefits.

If you studied surfing in great detail, you'd probably find a lot of health benefits.

Likewise:

If you study slow breathing in great detail, you'll find a lot of health benefits.

If you study mindfulness in great detail, you'll find a lot of health benefits.

If you study yoga in great detail, you'll find a lot of health benefits.

The difference?

People choose sports based on joy and pleasure but often choose a contemplative path just for the science and outcomes.

Let's do our best to balance both, but with an emphasis on joy. If we focus on joy, the benefits will take care of themselves.

Let's instead adopt a sports mindset to our contemplative practice, choosing the ones that bring us the most joy. Let others study the benefits while we simply enjoy the activity for the sake of the activity itself.

(#172) Slow Breathing May Reduce Risk of Alzheimer's

“As far as we can tell from the published literature and ClinicalTrials.gov searches, this study provides the first evidence of a behavioral intervention that reduces A β levels (measured with plasma, CSF or PET) compared to a randomized control group.” – Nature Sci Rep (2023)

This week's 411 is on a newly-published study (rightfully) getting a lot of attention. Perhaps not enough attention.

It found that 20-40 minutes of daily slow breathing reduced amyloid- β levels, a key biomarker for the risk of Alzheimer's disease.

Pretty remarkable stuff.

I hope you enjoy the 411 and the slightly modified format to make it easier to follow!

Have a great weekend,
Nick

(#173) Childlike Mental Flexibility, Adultlike Purpose

“The breathing will seamlessly bring you back to the natural mental and emotional flexibility you had as a child, but with the direction and purpose you have as an adult.”

– Richard Brown, MD, and Patricia Gerbarg, MD

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable breathing quote for you to enjoy. It’s a productive form of mental rest :)

(#174) Our Highest Form of Love

“Attention, both its receptive and concentrative forms, is not only a precious brain resource—it’s a currency, one of our most valuable currencies. The people in our lives notice what, where, and who we spend it on. Attention, in a lot of ways, is our highest form of love.” – Amishi Jha, Ph.D.

P.S. The best way to improve our attention and, thus, love? Breath awareness 😊

(#175) One Sentence on Gratitude & Breathing

Slow breathing is to breathing exercises what gratitude is to journaling.

(#176) The Curation Meditation

Here's a way to make meditation fun: Instead of focusing on one object, try to "curate your thoughts." Watch them all go by and see if you can find any good ones. Your mind thinks; you just listen for the fun and exciting stuff.

We can call it The Curation Meditation :)

P.S. In my newsletter on [February 7, 2022](#), I shared that I use this approach sometimes when I can't sleep. I still do. In fact, I used it last night, which inspired me to reshare it here :)

(#177) The Breathing Pole Vaulter

“Listening to them, one image that came to mind was that of the polevaulter. At first, the athlete needs a pole to propel him or herself to a great height. At a certain point, the athlete has to release the pole and just jump.” – Larry Rosenberg, Three Steps to Awakening

This is an excellent analogy for any breath-focused contemplative practice (breathwork, meditation, yoga, etc.)

The breath is like the pole, boosting us to a great height where we can “let go” and discover our full potential.

(#178) Breathing, Brandy, and Wine: An Analogy

“That’s a very interesting clue as to the meaning of spirit, and I think that it’s possible to look at breath in relation to body in the same way that we could look at Brandy in relation to wine. That breath represents the concentrated, distilled essence of being. And that it is nonphysical, it is invisible, it does not have substance, but it’s where the power is.” – Andrew Weil, MD, *Breathing: The Master Key to Self Healing*

That’s so good: **“That breath represents the concentrated, distilled essence of being.”**

And that’s one reason why Dr. Weil says, **“if you do nothing other than pay attention to your breath today, for a few seconds more than you did yesterday, you have increased your spiritual awareness. You have made spiritual progress.”**

Here’s to making a little spiritual progress, today 🙏

(#179) Altered Traits

“As practice continues and breathing becomes progressively slower, the body adjusts its physiological set point for its respiratory rate accordingly. That’s a good thing. While chronic rapid breathing signifies ongoing anxiety, a slower breath rate indicates reduced autonomic activity, better mood, and salutary health.” - Daniel Goleman, Ph.D., and Richard Davidson, Ph.D., *Altered Traits*

It's Friday, so we have a new 411 available. This week it's on *Altered Traits: Science Reveals How Meditation Changes Your Mind, Brain, and Body*

It was an excellent, objective overview of meditation research, with many practical wisdom gems spread throughout.

I hope you enjoy the 411!

Have a great weekend,
Nick

(#180) A Shadow of Happiness

“We are what we think, all that we are arises with our thoughts, with our thoughts we make the world. Speak or act with a pure mind, and happiness will follow you as your shadow, unshakable.” – Buddha

(#181) Focusing on Others

“Sharing another person’s feelings of distress need not be a downer. As Dr. Aaron Beck...has said, when you focus on someone else’s suffering, you forget your own troubles.” - Daniel Goleman, Ph.D. & Richard Davidson, Ph.D.

(#182) Ongoing Awareness

“Our breathing has the added virtue of being a very convenient process to support ongoing awareness in our daily lives. As long as we are alive, it is always with us. We can’t leave home without it.” – Jon Kabat-Zinn, Ph.D., [*Full Catastrophe Living*](#)

Let’s make sure we check in on this “very convenient process” of breathing periodically today.

Not for the breath’s sake, but to support ongoing awareness, which will allow us to actually experience more of the life we’re living 🙏

(#183) A Natural Antioxidant

[A 2017 study](#) had type-1 diabetics breathe extra oxygen.

- Blood pressure and arterial stiffness increased, *indicating a rise in oxidative stress.*

Then, they had them breathe extra oxygen again, but this time while breathing slowly at 6 breaths a minute.

- Slow breathing *offset the harmful effects* of extra oxygen on blood pressure and arterial stiffness.

Leading to this hypothesis: **“...our results lead to the hypothesis that slow breathing may exert some antioxidant effect, possibly via parasympathetic stimulation.”**

Pretty neat.

(#184) Laughing Monks: A Story to Contemplate

“For example, when Varela put on an EEG cap, which uses electrodes to measure electrical activity in the brain, monks from the Institute of Buddhist Dialectics in Dharamsala laughed and said, ‘How could we be measuring anything to do with the mind by putting a cap on the head? The mind is here!’—pointing to their hearts.”

– Clifford Saron, Ph.D., [*The Healing Power of Meditation*](#)

Reading that story (and its implicit meaning) a few times is like a meditation in itself :)

(#185) One of My New Favorite Words

“People talk a lot about resilience. What you’ll learn in this book is really about what I call “pre-silience.” Resilience means bouncing back from adversity. But what we want is to train our minds so that we maintain our capacities even as we are experiencing challenge.” –

Amishi Jha, Ph.D., [*Peak Mind*](#)

How’s “pre-silience” for the best word & concept ever?

“[I]t means that you can be in a difficult situation, fully, and know that you have the cognitive resources to get through it.”

That’s precisely what we’re building in the Learning Center with our consistent study and practice :)

(#186) Amplifying Benefits: Mindfulness + Slow Breathing

“In the acute phase, we also show for the first time that meditation elicits a reduction in oxygen saturation, not compensated by an increase in ventilation and by a sympathetic activation, suggesting an acute resetting of chemoreceptor sensitivity and a hypometabolic state.” – Bernardi et al. (2017)

It's Friday, so a new 411 is available: Acute fall and long-term rise in oxygen saturation in response to meditation.

Hundreds (maybe thousands) of studies have been performed on slow breathing.

From my understanding, the most significant adverse effect that's ever been discovered from this research is that people tend to hyperventilate when they're first learning (the slow breathing rate is challenging, so they overcompensate by breathing more).

This study (unknowingly) discovered a way to lessen this effect: Combine slow breathing with mantra-based mindfulness. This tends to reduce breathing volume while still getting the HRV benefits of slow breathing.

Read or listen to the full 411 for more.

In good breath,
Nick

(#187) Rhythm of the Mind

“Gandhi used to walk for miles every day repeating it to himself until the rhythm of the mantram and his footsteps began to stabilize the rhythm of his breathing, which is closely connected with the rhythm of the mind.”

– [Eknath Easwaran](#)

P.S. Speaking of mantras, don't forget to check out the [new Science 411 released yesterday](#) which discussed how we can use mantras with our slow breathing practice to get the best of both worlds 🙏

(#188) Be Devoted

“Be devoted to the breath and renounce everything else.” – Eugene Cash

P.S. Not all the time, of course, but for short dedicated periods :)

(#189) Toward Our Better Nature

“As we see it, the most compelling impacts of meditation are not better health or sharper business performance but, rather, a further reach toward our better nature.” - Daniel Goleman, Ph.D. & Richard Davidson, Ph.D., [*Altered Traits*](#)

I think this is true of any contemplative practice: meditation, breathing, yoga, or even just reading.

So here's to choosing our favorite one, and inching closer toward our better nature, today 🙏

(#190) The Tip (or nose) of the Iceberg

“The nose you see on your face comprises approximately 30 percent of its volume. It is the tip of the iceberg, so to speak, with the remaining 70 percent of the nasal cavity set deep within the skull.” – Patrick McKeown, *The Oxygen Advantage*

Just some neat numbers today to remind us of how amazing our bodies are 🙏

(#191) Loud Breathing in Yoga: Beyond Respiratory Physiology?

In [*The Joy of Movement*](#), Kelly McGonigal has a fascinating passage about how loud breathing during yoga might be a critical component of social bonding and group flow:

“Studies show that yoga, like dancing, can create social bonds. ... The breath becomes the beat that drives the flow of poses, and the sound of the group inhaling and exhaling in unison provides a satisfying sensory feedback.”

Now, I’m clearly a big fan of quiet breathing. Traditional yoga practices are too. But perhaps loud breathing goes beyond respiratory physiology, helping promote social and emotional connections?

It’s an interesting idea to contemplate...

P.S. [HHPF recently shared](#) a news article about brains syncing during group activities, which inspired me to revisit this passage from Kelly McGonigal. It seems like matching breaths would be the absolute best way to sync peoples brain waves :)

(#192) Breathing vs. Intention

“Under normal circumstances, these conditions are considered damaging and would require medical care. (//) But something else happens when we practice these techniques willingly, when we consciously push our bodies into these states for a few minutes, or hours, a day. In some cases, they can radically transform lives.” – James Nestor, *Breath*

If more stressful breathing techniques, like breath holds and fast breathing, occur spontaneously, they have some pretty terrible effects.

But if they’re done consciously, **“they can radically transform lives.”**

A question we might contemplate: How much of this is the power of the breath, and how much is the power of intention?

(#193) The Healing Power of Meditation

“What if learning how to inhabit silence and stillness and awareness—especially when you do so with kindness, with patience, and with self-compassion—is itself healing?” – Jon Kabat-Zinn, Ph.D., *The Healing Power of Meditation*

It’s Friday, so we have a new 411 available: *The Healing Power of Meditation*. Each chapter was written by a different expert, making it really fun to read.

The 411 dives into the basics of meditation, plus topics like **telomerase, gray matter, adaptive functioning, and emotional health**.

If nothing else, I can’t recommend enough the 1 Life-Changing Idea, which provides the perfect “outro” to any practice you do 🙏

[Click here to read/listen to the 411.](#)

Have a great weekend,
Nick

(#194) The Hardest Thing in the World

“The hardest thing in the world is to simplify your life because everything is pulling you to be more and more complex.” - Yvon Chouinard

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy & contemplate :)

(#195) Gaining Mind Mastery

“So what makes breathing so effective? It’s very difficult to talk your way out of strong emotions like stress, anxiety, or anger...But with breathing techniques, it is possible to gain some mastery over your mind.” - Harvard Business Review, [Research: Why Breathing Is So Effective at Reducing Stress](#)

(#196) What Emotions (and breathing) Show Us

“Emotions show us where to direct our attention. Rather than obscure the path, they can clarify and sharpen it.’ (//) In other words, emotions tell us about what matters to us.” – Erika Rosenberg, Ph.D., *The Healing Power of Meditation*

That’s an amazing way to reframe emotions. Rather than being something that needs to be “suppressed” or “changed,” let’s view them as guideposts, showing us what really matters to us 🙌

P.S. Because of the breath-emotion link, being mindful of subtle changes in our breath can also show us what matters to us.

<https://breathlearning.com/science-411s/jerath-et-al-2015/>

(#197) Neuroplasticity & the Gratitude Breath

“Every time you take in the good, you build a little bit of neural structure. Doing this a few times a day—for months and even years—will gradually change your brain, and how you feel and act, in far-reaching ways.” – Rick Hanson, Ph.D., *Buddha’s Brain*

Here’s a simple way to take in the good—that is, practice gratitude—a few times a day to change your brain: Take a couple of breaths and think to yourself, **“This is great! I have an abundance of the most valuable resource known to our species, and I don’t even have to work that hard to get it!”**

P.S. I start every breathing practice like this. Sometimes it feels too strained, and I don’t notice much of anything. But sometimes, it profoundly shifts my mindset, and each breath is that much better.

(#198) Become More Fortunate

“The most fortunate are those who have a wonderful capacity to appreciate again and again, freshly and naively, the basic goods of life, with awe, pleasure, wonder and even ecstasy.” – Abraham Maslow

Yesterday, we learned a simple 1-2 breath gratitude practice. What better way to appreciate again and again, freshly and naively, this most basic good of life—the breath—than with that easy practice?

So here's to using it to become a little more fortunate, today 🙏

P.S. So you don't have to click around, here's the practice again: Take a couple of breaths and think to yourself, **“This is great! I have an abundance of the most valuable resource known to our species, and I don't even have to work that hard to get it!”**

(#199) The Real-Life Power of Contemplative Practice

“We will be doing this so that rather than destroying us or robbing us of our power and our hope, the storms of life will strengthen us as they teach us about living, growing, and healing in a world of flux, change, and sometimes great pain.” – Jon Kabat-Zinn, *Full Catastrophe Living*

Of course, there are many powerful nervous system and brain changes going on, but this is the true real-world power of contemplative practices involving breathing. They teach us to accept (and even value) all of life's storms.

And paradoxically, it's this acceptance of things as they are that actually begins the process of living, growing, and healing 🙏

(#200) How Nasal Breathing Counteracts Gravity

“In this work, we have demonstrated that nasal breathing counteracts the effects of gravity on pulmonary blood flow in the upright position by redistribution of blood to the nondependent lung regions.” – Sánchez Crespo et al. (2010)

It's Friday, so a new 411 was just released.

In this one, you'll learn:

How nasal breathing redistributes blood flow (up to 24%) in the lungs to counteract gravity

How nitric oxide (NO) is the essential component of this blood flow redistribution

How nasal NO may have been an evolutionary adaption allowing us to walk upright

I hope you enjoy the 411.

Enjoy your weekend,

Nick

(#201) Since Earliest History...

“Since earliest history, virtually every major psychospiritual system seeking to comprehend human nature has viewed breath as a crucial link between the material world, the human body, the psyche, and the spirit.” — Stanislav & Christina Grof

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy & contemplate.

(#202) All Persons Going to Sleep Should Think

“All persons going to sleep should think, not of their business, not of their riches or poverty, their pains or their pleasures, but, of what are of infinitely greater importance to them, their lungs; their best friends, that have kept them alive through the day.” — George Catlin

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy & contemplate.

(#203) Why We Use the Breath for Attention

“...we use the breath for a couple of important reasons: It anchors us in the body. It allows us to experience the body sensations that are unfolding in real time as we breathe, in the here and now. This helps us more easily catch when our minds have wandered away from these sensations to thoughts about the past or future. And finally, our breath is always with us. It’s the most natural built-in target for our attention that we can always return to.” – Amishi Jha, *Peak Mind*

Make sure you take advantage of this a few times today :)

(#204) Flip the Script

“When we create conditions that are ideal for deep rest—feeling safe, engaging in a mind-body practice, or being in nature—our breathing will often change naturally as the body adjusts. Today, we flip that. We start with the breath. When we practice the kind of breathing our body wants to do in a deep rest state, we signal to the body that it’s okay to rest. It’s okay to let go.” – Elissa Epel, Ph.D., *The Stress Prescription*

This is the true power of practice. Rather than wait for deep rest to change our breathing, we can flip the script and consciously change it to create the conditions for deep rest.

Make sure to take advantage of this wonderful gift :)

(#205) Seeing More Joy

Doing a deliberate slow nasal breathing practice first thing every morning is like putting on joy contacts to start your day.

(#206) Enhancing Life Outside of Practice

“We expand our inner presence and relaxation...and, over time, we find more and more of that inner expansion and relaxation in daily life. The same is true of doing deep meditation (more inner silence in life), yoga postures (more flexibility in life) and other yoga practices on a daily basis. It all ends up enhancing our life outside the practices. This is the real benefit of doing yoga practices, and the primary reason for doing them.” – Yogani, *Spinal Breathing Pranayama*

This is true for any contemplative or relaxation practice we do. It's not about escaping life. It's about enhancing our life outside of practice (which is, of course, where most of life is lived).

(#207) The Stress Prescription

“It’s quite amazing: we can control our breath, which means we can control the state of our autonomic nervous system and even our state of consciousness. By altering our breath, we also influence our emotional state, pushing us toward calm, joy, and equanimity.” – Elissa Epel, Ph.D., *The Stress Prescription* (<https://www.thebreathingdiabetic.com/book-411s/the-stress-prescription>) (<https://breathlearning.com/book-411s/the-stress-prescription>)

It is quite amazing, huh? 😊

It’s Friday, so we have a new 411 available. This week, it’s The Stress Prescription. I absolutely loved the scientific yet practical guidance in this book.

Here’s what we cover in the 411:

4 Thoughts:

1. Accepting & Embracing Uncertainty
2. Baseline Stress, Vagal Tone, and Morning Breathing
3. Your Body Loves Acute Stress (plus the challenge mindset)
4. The Power of Nature, Water, and Breathing

1 Life-Changing Idea

Flip the Script and Bring the Retreat to You

[Click Here to Read/Listen](#)

Have a good weekend,
Nick

(#208) Right in the Simple Old Breath

“Right in the simple old breath...lies a completely overlooked source of power to transform our lives. All we need to do to make use of it is to deepen our attentional skills and our patience.” – Jon Kabat-Zinn

(#209) Reflection & Action

“Reflection and action must never be undertaken independently.” - Paulo Freire

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy & contemplate.

P.P.S. I found this quote [here](#).

(#210) A Different Perspective on the Attention Crisis

Discussing social media, emails, and “phone pings” in general:

“I want to make one thing crystal clear: there is nothing wrong with your attention. In fact, it’s working so well, and so on cue, that computer programs can predict how it will respond. We’re in a crisis because our attention works so well. It’s doing exactly what it was designed to do: respond powerfully to certain stimuli.” – Amishi Jha, Ph.D., [*Peak Mind*](#)

That’s a life-changing perspective shift.

And luckily, it doesn’t mean we’re hopeless.

Dr. Jha discovered one tool that allows us to use our attention how we want (instead of how algorithms wish to): Mindfulness.

(#211) Reaching Blissful States

Discussing advanced yogis that reach crazy states during meditation:

“Their remarkable meditation skills bespeak what’s technically known as a “state by trait interaction,” suggesting the brain changes that underlie the trait also give rise to special abilities that activate during meditative states.” – Daniel Goleman, Ph.D. & Richard Davidson, Ph.D., [Altered Traits](#)

These findings mean: the longer you practice, the more your brain changes, and the more likely you are to be *physiologically capable* of having profound meditations. They’re a “state by trait” effect, and they’re available to all of us—we just have to keep practicing 🙏

P.S. I think this happens with anything: surfing, running, yoga, skiing, reading, etc.

(#212) Common to All Contemplative Traditions

“The first and most fundamental practice of meditation is to allow the mind to settle into a state of “calm abiding,” where it will find peace and stability and can rest in a state of nondistractedness. When you first begin to meditate, you may use a support: for example, looking at an object or an image of Buddha, or Christ if you are a Christian practitioner; using a mantra or chant; or lightly, mindfully watching the breath, which is common to all spiritual traditions.” – Sogyal Rinpoche, [*The Healing Power of Meditation*](#)

To settle the mind and find peace & stability, all contemplative traditions agree on breathing.

We could meditate on the power of that statement for a lifetime 🙏

(#213) Engaging in Meaningful Tasks

Discussing mindful breathing:

“I’d like you to think of it as a versatile training tool to help you engage fully in every meaningful task in your life.” – Russ Harris, [*The Confidence Gap*](#)

Thus, we practice mindful breathing to learn how to focus and be present. It’s a training tool.

Then, in real life, we let go of breathing, but use that same skill to engage fully in life:

“...instead of shining the spotlight on your breath, shine it on the task that you are doing. Engage fully in the experience and let your thoughts come and go like passing cars.”

(#214) Breathing and Brain Health

“To our knowledge, our study is the first report demonstrating the impact of a mind–body approach such as yogic breathing to modulate CSF dynamics” – Nature Sci Rep (2022)

It's Friday, so we have a new Science 411 available, and it's a super neat one.

This study found that slow, deep, yogic breathing increased cerebrospinal fluid (CSF) flow toward the brain by 16-28%.

Check out the full 411 for other findings and why they're so crucial to brain health.

[Click Here to Read/Listen to the 411](#)

Enjoy the weekend,
Nick

(#215) Far too Important

“Life is far too important a thing to ever talk seriously about.” - Oscar Wilde

P.S. On weekend, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy & contemplate.

P.P.S. I found this one on Insight Timer.

(#216) Every Dimension of Your Life

“By developing the simple profound practice of mindful breathing, you have a lifeline that ties you to every dimension of your life—to your body, to your emotions, to the thoughts racing through your head, to whatever connection you have to the world around you and to the enormity of the universe.” – Al Lee and Don Campbell

(#217) From Which Your Life Flows

“[G]o into yourself and see how deep the place is from which your life flows.” - Rainer Maria Rilke

Whether we're doing a 10-minute meditation, a 100-mile run, or just taking 1 conscious breath, this is what all contemplative and physical activities have in common.

We're simply going into ourselves to see how deep the place is from which our life flows.

(#218) Your Body Loves Acute Stress

“Your body loves acute stress. This process of peak and recovery—of sympathetic nervous system action followed by parasympathetic nervous system action, triggering cell cleanup and repair—is wonderful for us. In fact, we need it.” – Elissa Epel, Ph.D., [The Stress Prescription](#)

The damaging effects of *chronic stress* often make us forget the incredible benefits of *acute stress*. In fact, it’s not even just beneficial: **“we need it.”**

Here are a few ways to get it:

- Physical exercise (always the best option)
- Heat
- Cold
- Breath holds
- Short-term conscious hyperventilation

Pick one that resonates with you and enjoy harnessing the power of good stress in your life 🙏

(#219) One of the Most Profound Aspects

One of the most profound aspects of breathing is that, depending on our disposition, we can treat it like exercise, like diet, like prayer, or like all of them.

And the best part: No approach is right or wrong.

(#220) The Idea Behind Breath Training

“The idea behind breath training is that proper breathing affects so many other physical parameters: rib position, neck extension, the shape of the spine, even the position of our feet on the ground. The way in which we breathe reflects how we interact with the world.” –

Peter Attia, MD, *Outlive*

“The way in which we breathe reflects how we interact with the world.” <-- Although he was talking about physical movement & stability, this is true any way you analyze it 🤔

And, in my opinion, it's the primary reason for all breath training: to change how we interact with the world.

(#221) Spinal Breathing Pranayama

“The spinal nerve, which we are stimulating, is the central highway in the nervous system. By enlivening the spinal nerve with the combination of attention moving up and down, and the restraint of breath, we are stimulating the entire nervous system in a way that is both energizing and relaxing on a very deep level.” – Yogani, *Spinal Breathing Pranayama*

<https://breathlearning.com/book-411s/spinal-breathing-pranayama/>

It's Friday, so a new 411 has just been released. This week, it's on Spinal Breathing Pranayama, a book I randomly found and decided to read for fun. However, it was so simple and so clearly written that I decided to make a 411 on it too.

Also, although Yogani has written many books, his bio says: **“He wishes to remain anonymous, preserving a quiet life in practices.”** So, I immediately loved him, lol.

I hope you enjoy it!

[Click Here to Read/Listen to the Book 411](#)

All the best,
Nick

(#222) It's Rarely Mysterious Techniques

"It's rarely a mysterious technique that drives us to the top, but rather a profound mastery of what may well be a basic skill set." - Josh Waitzkin

(#223) Not Just Figuratively, But Literally

“The air I inhale enters my body and becomes part of me. The air I exhale moves into someone else and becomes part of her. Just by looking at how the air moves, we realize we are all connected to one another, not just figuratively, but also literally.” – Haemin Sunim

P.S. It’s wild because this is so obvious, but something about how Haemin said it made it “click,” and it blew my mind.

(#224) Living to 93

I finished reading *Outlive* over the weekend. It's really good. But it's also insane all the things Dr. Attia does to try to live longer (he had a couple more passages on breathing I'll share soon).

And although I'm a nerd and love stuff like that, I kept coming back to a conversation I had with a neighbor down the street.

She recently turned 93, and she's one of the warmest and most welcoming people I've met.

She was out working in her yard the other day, and I asked her something like, **"What's the secret to living so long and staying so healthy?"**

Her response: **"Don't think about it."**

(#225) Set the Tone

“We each have our unique starting baseline—the level of stress arousal that we usually hover around through any typical day. ... Regardless of where we start from, the lower we can get our baseline stress arousal, the better—it means we’ll be much more able to tolerate the peaks of stressful events.” – Elissa Epel, Ph.D., [*The Stress Prescription*](#)

Do you know why the first sentence of a paragraph is the most important? Or why first impressions matter so much?

They set the tone for everything to come.

Similarly, starting your day with slow breathing (or your favorite contemplative practice) sets the tone of your day by lowering your baseline stress levels: **“it means we’ll be much more able to tolerate the peaks of stressful events.”**

(#226) As the Breath Goes, the Nervous System Follows

Peter Attia, MD, discussing techniques he uses for his emotional health in *Outlive*:

“Another technique I have grown very fond of is slow, deep breathing: four seconds to inhale, six seconds to exhale. Repeat. As the breath goes, the nervous system follows.”

But you all already knew this.

The main reason I’m sharing it is to highlight how breathing spans genres. Whether it’s rigorous science or deep spirituality, it all comes back to the same basics: Four seconds in, six seconds out, repeat. The breath leads, the nervous system follows.

(#227) Whole-Life Breathing

When we regularly do any kind of contemplative practice that slows down our breathing, it increases our vagal tone.

But “higher vagal tone” is just a number. What’s better is looking at what it means for our whole life.

And I’ve never read a better description of that than in Love 2.0, where Barbara Fredrickson, Ph.D., describes people with higher vagal tone:

“Physically, they regulate their internal bodily processes more efficiently, like their glucose levels and inflammation. Mentally, they’re better able to regulate their attention and emotions, even their behavior. Socially, they’re especially skillful in navigating interpersonal interactions and in forging positive connections with others.”

Sounds good to me. Perhaps we should call slow breathing “whole-life breathing” instead :)

(#228) Brain Oscillations, Cognition, and Nasal Breathing

“A key implication of our data is that the nasal route of respiration offers an entry point to limbic brain areas for modulating cognitive function.” – [Zelano et al. \(2016\)](#)

It's Friday, so a new Science 411 was just released.

This one is on a foundational study on the power of the nose, finding that nasal breathing **synchronizes oscillations across several brain areas and enhances cognition.**

I hope you enjoy it!

[Click here to read/listen to the 411.](#)

In good breath,
Nick

(#229) A Plethora of Everyday Struggles

“Taking control of the breath — consciously thinking about the unconscious respiratory mechanism — is the first step to improving a plethora of everyday struggles and habits.” - Grant Johnson

(#230) Attention is the “Ultimate Creative Act”

“The choice we make of how we dispose our consciousness is the ultimate creative act: it renders the world what it is.” – Iain McGilchrist

P.S. When I read that quote, this one immediately popped into my head. They’re fun to contemplate together: **“To know that the mind is the root of everything is to realize that we are ultimately responsible for both our own happiness and our own suffering. It is in our hands.”** - Sogyal Rinpoche

(#231) Two Ways to Keep Your Practice Interesting

- 1) Switch up your routine or exercises every 15-30 days to continuously create novelty.
- 2) Cultivate mindfulness so the same old boring exercises continuously create novelty.

P.S. There's no right or wrong, and you can do both at the same time :)

(#232) A Few Years Ago

“The practice of mindful breathing may be very simple, but the effect can be great. Focusing on our in-breath, we release the past, we release the future, we release our projects. We ride on that breath with all our being. Our mind comes back to our body, and we are truly there, alive, in the present moment. We are home.” - Thich Nhat Hanh, *Peace is Every Breath*

A few years ago, I would’ve thought this passage was cheesy.

But after years of practice, I’ve come to appreciate these types of changes in my daily life more than any of the physiological or neurological health benefits of my breathing practice.

It’s a nice reminder that sometimes unexpected outcomes are better than the ones you were actually hoping for 🙏

(#233) Breathing Less is Not the Same

“To be clear, breathing less is not the same as breathing slowly. [...] The key to optimum breathing, and all the health, endurance, and longevity benefits that come with it, is to practice fewer inhales and exhales in a smaller volume. To breathe, but to breathe less.” – James Nestor, [Breath](#)

Slow breathing is powerful by itself. But to get the most benefits, we should also *breathe less air* during the practice.

Here is a simple way to do just that:

Pick an emotionally meaningful word (“peace,” “love,” etc.)
Focus on and silently repeat that word to yourself while inhaling or exhaling (or both) during your slow breathing practice.

[Research shows](#) that adding in this simple act of mindfulness tends to reduce breathing volume



(#234) How to Build a Stronger Mind

In Peak Mind, Dr. Jha describes a “mindfulness push-up” as the following:

You shine your attention on your breath.

Your mind wanders, and you notice it.

You redirect your mind to your breath.

“This is what we might call the ‘push-up’ of a mindfulness breathing exercise.”

I love this analogy because it conveys the most crucial aspect of mindfulness: Just like repeated physical push-ups make our muscles stronger, the more times this cycle happens during meditation, the more “mind push-ups” you do, and the stronger your mind gets.

(#235) Humor & The Things You Can See

“To be happy, it’s not necessary to expend great effort so we get somewhere else.

Instead, relax into the present moment while finding humor in your life.

With humor, life becomes light and leisurely.

And laughter always brings people to experience openness and joy.” – Haemin Sunim, [*The Things You Can See Only When You Slow Down*](#)

It’s Friday, so a new Book 411 has just been released, this week on *The Things You Can See Only When You Slow Down*.

That above quote comes from my favorite thought from this one.

Here’s what we cover:

4 Thoughts

The Power of Awareness

Effort Leads to Effortlessness

Breathing Must Be Practiced

The Power of Humor & Joy

1 Life-Changing Idea

Breath is Connection, Literally & Figuratively

It’s one of the shortest 411s to date. I hope you enjoy it!

[Click Here to Read or Listen](#)

In good breath,

Nick

(#236) Answering Life's Questions

“One could also say that our human existence can be made meaningful ‘to the very last breath’; as long as we have breath, as long as we are still conscious, we are each responsible for answering life’s questions.” – Viktor Frankl

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy & contemplate.

(#237) The Soul of the Visible Landscape

“The air, we might say, is the soul of the visible landscape, the secret realm from which all things draw their nourishment.” - David Abram

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy & contemplate.

(#238) Life's Storms

Trees don't brace themselves when a storm is coming. They simply grow their roots strong enough to always be prepared for whatever nature throws at them ([pre-silience 101](#) style).

Slow, mindful breathing is our roots. We do it daily so we're planted in the ground when life's storms inevitably hit us.

P.S. Sometimes, storms are so strong they uproot a tree entirely. This happens in life too. The difference is we have the capability to consciously replant ourselves.

(#239) Always Come Back to Practice

“Experiences are a by-product of our practice. We always favor our practice over the experiences.” – Yogani, Spinal Breathing Pranayama

This was one of my favorite ideas from this book.

When we have a great experience: we feel joy, we get a clear mind, we experience insightful breakthroughs, we feel just a sense of peace, whatever it might be, we don't really get too caught up in them. We simply remember that it was the practice that got us there:

“The practice of spinal breathing is what produces the results. Let's always keep that in mind whenever we feel tempted to chase after the sirens of experience. Just easily come back to the simple procedure of spinal breathing, and all will be progressing fine.”

P.S. Of course, this applies to any contemplative practice: slow breathing, meditation, yoga, running, walking, and on and on.

(#240) 2.5 Complementary Practices

Here's why I think **mindful slow breathing** is the perfect combination of practices:

- Slow breathing alters brain oscillations to support mindfulness.
- Mindfulness alters biochemistry to support slow breathing.

Combined, they give you two of the most validated mind-body exercises in one simple practice.

P.S. But for even more benefits, add another component: Humor. Laugh at yourself occasionally—perhaps even during your practice—and watch the benefits soar 😊

(#241) Efficacy vs. Effectiveness (and the “you method”)

“Efficacy tests how well the intervention works under perfect conditions and adherence (i.e., if one does everything exactly as prescribed). Effectiveness tests how well the intervention works under real-world conditions, in real people.” – Peter Attia, MD, *Outlive*

This passage pops into my mind often since reading it.

It’s an excellent reminder that, regardless of which practices you do for your health and wellness, the most important thing to do is find an effective way to incorporate them into your life. A “you method” that works under the real-world conditions of your day-to-day living 🙏

(#242) Mindful Breath Awareness Improves Cognition

“It is intriguing that a mental exercise that “merely” entails the voluntary focus on a simple object, such as the sensation of one’s own breath, combined with a non-reactive and accepting awareness of concurrently arising mental phenomena, can have far-reaching effects on cognitive functions.” – Schöne et al. (2018)

<https://breathlearning.com/science-411s/schone-et-al-2018/>

It’s Friday, so a new 411 is available. This week, it’s on a paper published in Nature Scientific Reports titled *“Mindful breath awareness meditation facilitates efficiency gains in brain networks: A steady-state visually evoked potentials study.”*

This study is significant because it analyzed mindful breath awareness by itself (whereas most mindfulness papers examine multicomponent interventions like MBSR or MBCT).

Pretty remarkably, they found that the brief (but consistent) practice of just mindful breath awareness improves our attention, our ability to resist distractions, and the efficiency of neural networks responsible for these processes 🙌

[Click Here to Read/Listen](#)

Enjoy your weekend,
Nick

(#243) Why Mind Training Makes Practical Sense

“Given that the world we see through our mind’s eye is limited, if we can train our mind and choose wisely where to focus, then we will be able to experience the world corresponding to the state of our mind.” – Haemin Sunim

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate.

(#244) Like a Wave from the Ocean

“You didn’t come into this world. You came out of it, like a wave from the ocean. You are not a stranger here.” – Alan Watts

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate.

(#245) The Audience Effect

[The Audience Effect](#) says that our behavior changes when we believe someone else is watching us.

I believe this concept actually applies particularly well to mindfulness.

We might even say that mindfulness creates an everlasting audience effect of one. And it always influences behavior in the best direction because it's the most important audience of all: You.

(#246) Meta-Awareness, Push-Ups, and Breathing

Using your breath to change your state of mind is actually pretty straightforward.

The real challenge is using your mind to remember to use your breath to change your state of mind.

That requires meta-awareness, and it's a skill we build every time we do one of those "mindfulness push-ups" we talked about last week:

You shine your attention on your breath.

Your mind wanders, and you notice it. <-- Building meta-awareness

You redirect your mind to your breath.

This is another crucial reason mindfulness complements any breathing practice: it helps you use your mind to recognize when you need your breathing.

(#247) Pain Perception and Acceptance vs. Suppression

“A number of studies have compared the effects of two contrasting anticipatory attitudes—acceptance and suppression—on pain perception. ... Psychologists have generally found that, compared to suppression, acceptance reduces the unpleasantness of pain without reducing the pain itself. For this reason, it is a more effective coping skill.” - Matt Fitzgerald, [How Bad Do You Want It?](#)

Got any pain you're dealing with in your life? (Of course you do, you're human 😊).

Instead of trying to suppress it, try accepting it. As Fitzgerald says, **“it is a more effective coping skill.”**

P.S. Metaphorically, perhaps this is why contemplative practices are so helpful for dealing with life's pains. In one way or another, these practices all teach an attitude of acceptance, which may help to reduce **“the unpleasantness of pain without reducing the pain itself.”** 🙏

(#248) Broader Stability Style

“The larger point is that someone's breathing style gives us insight into their broader stability strategy, the set of patterns that they have evolved over the years to help them get by in the physical world. All of us have these strategies and 95% of the time...they work fine. But once you add different stressors...those strategies, those instinctive physical reactions, can create problems. And if our respiration is also taxed, those other problems will be magnified.”* – Peter Attia, MD, *Outlive*

Although Dr. Attia is discussing the role of breathing for physical stability, isn't it amazing that this idea is equally applicable to mental, emotional, and spiritual stability too?

The breath provides steadiness in all of life.

*I listened to the Audible version of this one and haven't gotten the e-book yet, so this is my best attempt at transcribing the passage.

(#249) Peace is Every Breath

“Mindful breathing is your seatbelt in everyday life—it keeps you safe here in the present moment.” – Thich Nhat Hanh, *Peace is Every Breath*

<https://breathlearning.com/book-411s/peace-is-every-breath/>

It's Friday, so a new 411 is available. This week it's on *Peace is Every Breath* by Thich Nhat Hanh. The above quote is from an excellent analogy discussed in Thought #3.

Here's everything we cover:

4 Thoughts:

Peace is Every Breath: The Power of Mindful Breathing

Belly Breathing, Treetops, and Life's Storms

Your Seatbelt in Everyday Life

How to Deal with Anger: A Burning House and Your Emotions

1 Life-Changing Idea

Joy is a Habit (and mindful breathing gets us there)

And since it's Thich Nhat Hanh, you'll also find several poetic and insightful quote gems.

Click Here to Read or Listen

<https://breathlearning.com/book-411s/peace-is-every-breath/>

Have a great weekend,

Nick

(#250) Pieces of Rubber

“Mind is everything. Muscle - pieces of rubber. All that I am, I am because of my mind.” - Paavo Nurmi

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate.

(#251) Like a Source Metronome

“[C]onsider your breathing like a metronome, consistently and rhythmically connecting you to your own source and providing you with a regular mechanism for recentering yourself.” – George Mumford

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate.

(#252) The Answers to the Most Pressing Questions

“An athlete gets herself into trouble when, instead of listening to her body and its intuitions, she begins to worry about what her competitors are doing and tries to “outwork” them. The answers to the most pressing questions that athletes face in their day-to-day quest for improvement (“Should I push? Should I back off?”) lie within them.” – Matt Fitzgerald, *How Bad Do You Want It?*

I believe this idea applies to all of life, not just athletics: Nine times out of ten, the answers to the most pressing questions we face in our quest for continuous improvement lie within us.

(#253) Hearing Your Heart Voice

Yesterday, we said the answers to life's most pressing questions lie within us.

That sounds neat & insightful, but how do we actually access that innate wisdom?

You guessed it: Breathing 😊 (or any contemplative practice...meditation, yoga, walking, etc.).

But for it to really work, we must be consistent. As Light Watkins says in his new book *Travel Light*:

"To get access to your heart voice, you have to become a daily meditator. No days off. No holidays, birthdays, or weekends away from meditation."

That sounds like a deserving challenge to me. So here's to using our practice to access our heart voice and answer life's most pressing questions 🙏

(#254) Being Here but Letting Go

I recently read a story about a triathlete who let go of winning. Instead, she simply experienced gratitude for the ability to participate in triathlons. Paradoxically, she then went on to become a world champion.

It reminded me of this gem from Larry Rosenberg, which is more relevant to us:

“This is the deepest paradox in all of meditation: we want to get somewhere—we wouldn’t have taken up the practice if we didn’t—but the way to get there is just to be fully here. The way to get from point A to point B is really to be at A.”

It’s an excellent reminder that presence and gratitude will help us in any domain of life 🙏

(#255) Breath as Metaphor

“If we can learn to allow the breath to unfold naturally without tampering with it, then in time we may be able to do that with other aspects of our experience: we might learn to let the feelings be, let the mind be.” – Larry Rosenberg, *Breath by Breath*

When I practice breath awareness, this passage often comes to mind. It’s an excellent reminder that we can use breathing as a metaphor for all aspects of life.

Namely: If we can let the breath unfold naturally, perhaps we can let go of our desire to control other aspects of life, too...

(#256) Respiratory Feedback in the Generation of Emotion

“To our knowledge, this is the first demonstration that the alteration of respiration is sufficient to induce emotion.” - Respiratory Feedback in the Generation of Emotion

<https://breathlearning.com/science-411s/philippot-et-al-2002/>

It's Friday, so a new 411 is now available.

This groundbreaking study (21 years ago) was the first to discover that breathing in specific patterns can elicit specific emotions.

Here's an example: To elicit joy, they told participants to **“Breathe and exhale slowly and deeply through the nose; your breathing is very regular and your ribcage relaxed.”** And sure enough, it worked.

The way they figured out these breathing patterns was pretty neat, so I hope you enjoy the 411.

[Click Here to Read/Listen](#)

Have a great weekend,
Nick

P.S. If you want to learn more about breathing & emotions, consider signing up for my upcoming 4-week course, [Breathing for Better Mental & Emotional Health](#). You get it for only \$100 as a Learning Center member. (Enter coupon code BLLC_MEMBER if it isn't automatically applied.)

(#257) To Treasure Breath

“To treasure breath is like loving your face and your eyes. It has never been unattainable.” –
[The Primordial Breath Volume 1](#)

(#258) The Real Teacher

“It is life that is the real teacher. Practice should open us to a fuller life, not cut us off from it altogether.” - Larry Rosenberg

(#259) Tuning Your Breath Guitar

Guitar players change the tune of their guitar to give a song the feel they want.

We can use our breath to change the tune of our mind to give it the feel we want.

Want to enjoy calmer and more joy-filled thoughts?

Tune your mind with some slow nasal breathing.

Want to experience more agitation?

Tune it with some fast upper-chest breathing.

So here's to using our breath each morning to get our minds in tune with how we want to feel that day 🙏

(#260) Tuning Your Breath Guitar Part 2

Yesterday, we said we could use our breath to tune our minds for the type of thoughts we want. Let's extend that analogy a little further today.

Some musicians re-tune their guitars by ear. Some use an electronic tuner. It just depends on their circumstance and personal preference.

Similarly, we can change our breath by feeling. Or we can use an electronic tuner (like a breathing app), depending on our circumstances and preferences.

Either way, in most cases, it's the act of changing the breath that is generally more important than exactly how we do it.

(#261) Jimi Hendrix and Breath Awareness

I bet when Jimi Hendrix, Eric Clapton, or John Mayer picked up their guitars, it changed their whole demeanor. Just holding it, without playing or tuning it, likely put them in a different state.

That's what breath awareness is like.

Sure, we can breathe in specific ways to tune our minds for certain thoughts (which we've discussed the past two days). But just noticing your breath immediately transforms you, like a musician holding their instrument.

So make sure you "pick up" your breathing several times today 😊

(#262) Picture a Trampoline Tipped Sideways

Here's a trick the staff psychologist for British Rowing offered in the 2003 World Championships to help the rowers focus on the process instead of the outcome. It seems like it would be a helpful visualization in all of life:

"The rowers were instructed to picture a trampoline at the finish line, tipped onto its side so that any thought of theirs that jumped ahead to the outcome would bounce back to the present moment. They bought into it and it worked." – Matt Fitzgerald, *The Comeback Quotient*

(#263) Life is the Endurance Event

“Psychologists use the term coping to refer to a person’s behavioral, emotional, and cognitive responses to discomfort and stress. ... (//) In endurance sports, successful coping is any behavior, emotion, thought, or combination thereof that yields better performance.” – Matt Fitzgerald, How Bad Do You Want It?

<https://breathlearning.com/book-411s/how-bad-do-you-want-it/>

It’s Friday, so a new 411 is available. This week it’s on *How Bad Do You Want It?*

If we consider life one big endurance event, this is one of the best books ever written for coping with being alive. We can simply take the tools endurance athletes use to persist and apply them to life (specifically to our contemplative practice).

Here are the ideas we cover in the 411:

4 Thoughts

1. Perceived Effort and the Psychobiological Model
2. Coping Mechanisms for Life (they are uniquely yours)
3. What Do You Expect? Mindfulness and the Audience Effect
4. The Workaround Effect and Setbacks as Blessings

1 Life-Changing Idea

1. Letting Go and the Self-Belief Paradox

I hope you enjoy it!

[Click Here to Read/Listen to the 411.](#)

Have a good weekend,
Nick

(#264) No Longer Lost in Them

“When you are stressed out, be aware of your stress.
When you are irritated, be aware of your irritation.
When you are angry, be aware of your anger.
As soon as you become aware of these feelings
you are no longer lost in them.” – Haemin Sunim

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate.

(#265) Imposter Syndrome

“Everyone living at the edge of their comfort zone has impostor syndrome. If you don't have impostor syndrome, go further.” – Light Watkins

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#266) How to Respond Mindfully (instead of reacting mindlessly)

“Probably the best place to start is with your breathing. If you can manage to bring your attention to your breathing for even the briefest of moments, it will set the stage for facing that moment and the next one with greater clarity.” – Jon Kabat-Zinn, Ph.D., *Full Catastrophe Living*

To respond more mindfully to stressful events (rather than reacting habitually), we start by noticing our breathing, which brings us back to the present and sets the stage for facing the event with greater clarity.

If you feel so inspired, give it a try today 🙌

(#267) We Won't Be Perfect

Yesterday, we learned from Jon Kabat-Zinn that if we stop to notice our breathing, it allows us to respond mindfully (rather than react mindlessly) to stressful situations.

<https://breathlearning.com/the-breathing-1/number-266/>

But this doesn't mean we'll be perfect.

Kabat-Zinn also tells us:

"Choosing to go the route of the stress response rather than the stress reaction obviously does not mean that you will never react automatically by feeling threatened or fearful or angry, or that you will never do anything silly or self-destructive. What it does mean is that more of the time you might be more aware of those feelings and impulses as they are arising ... [A]wareness reduces arousal at the time by situating things in a larger perspective, or it helps you to recover from it more quickly afterward."



(#268) Even if You Took a Perfect Breath

Even if you took the most perfect breath ever taken, you'd still have to take another one to stay alive. Then another. And another. In this way, breathing is the perfect metaphor for all our accomplishments in life.

No matter how great we do anything, it doesn't exonerate us from continuing to do the work. But viewed as a metaphor, breath awareness and breathing exercises can teach us to enjoy these ongoing cycles of life.

(#269) That's How Gratitude Works

"That's how gratitude works, transforming not reality itself but how reality is seen." – Matt Fitzgerald, *The Comeback Quotient*

If you've ever finished a mindful, slow breathing practice (or any contemplative practice) and noticed that everything around you seems more peaceful and beautiful, this is why.

These practices naturally cultivate gratitude, which doesn't change reality, but how reality is seen.

(#270) Mindful Breath Awareness Improves Brain Dynamics

“In sum, we show that a relatively short period of mindfulness practice...with relatively short daily practice times...significantly changes brain dynamics related to the internal monitoring of response conflicts and related errors.” – Pozuelos et al. (2019)

<https://breathlearning.com/science-411s/pozuelos-et-al-2019/>

It's Friday, so a new Science 411 is now available.

Using cognitive tests and EEG, this study found that practicing mindful breath awareness for 17 minutes, five days a week, for three weeks **improved impulse control and brain dynamics** related to the metacognitive processes of conflict and error monitoring.

“These findings contribute to clarifying the mechanisms through which mindfulness meditation practice promotes positive outcomes.” 🙌🙌🙌

[Click Here to Read or Listen to the 411](#)

Have a great weekend,
Nick

(#271) Balancing Speedy Energy

REMINDER: There's only one more day to sign up for the 4-week Breathing for Better Mental and Emotional Health Course. You get it for just \$100 as a Learning Center Member. Enroll using this link. (If the discount isn't automatically applied for some reason, use this code at checkout: BLLC_MEMBER)

"We need to understand when we're speedy, feel the speedy energy, and work with our breath to rebalance it. If we do this, one day we will find the balance in our energy." - Tsoknyi Rinpoche

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate.

(#272) To Become the Person You Want to Be

“To become the person you want to be, you must fully acknowledge the person you are.” –
Matt Fitzgerald

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate.

(#273) Calm Energy, Fast Mind and Body

“We will learn how to slow down the feeling world but also realize that the body and the mind don't need to slow down. Then we can walk fast but be calm. We can think fast and very creatively, but our energy remains calm. This is the goal.” - Tsoknyi Rinpoche, *Why We Meditate*

And what does Tsoknyi Rinpoche suggest we do to learn this? Slow belly breathing, of course



Give it a try today.

(#274) First Impressions

“You never get a second chance to make a first impression.” – Will Rogers

Each morning when we wake up, we meet a new day. Make a good first impression by doing your contemplative practice first thing. The day will like you and treat you kinder.

P.S. And be sure to aim for consistency: each day you meet is different, and today doesn't remember yesterday's introduction.

(#275) Why Breathing Right Before Meditation

I've read in several places that breathing exercises are traditionally used right before meditation. (Of course, I believe breathing exercises *are* a form of meditation, but I digress... 😊)

In any case, here's an excellent modern explanation of why that might be the case:

“Relaxation is the basic competency in meditation that enables all the others. Mind training without relaxation is like a tree without strong roots—it is not sustainable. The skillful trainee establishes relaxation first and then builds on top of it.” - Chade-Meng Tan, Joy On Demand
<https://www.amazon.com/Joy-on-Demand-Chade-Meng-Tan-audiobook/dp/B01COR0MV8/>

Now breathing before meditation makes perfect sense: What better way to establish relaxation before meditation than some deliberate slow breathing exercises?

(#276) Just Keep Going

Here's an excellent passage from [Tsoknye Rinpoche](#) on how to deal with the ups and downs of our contemplative practice:

“Remember that meditation experiences keep rising and falling, like our moods or the stock market. Sometimes we feel clear, light, and elated, like we're making rapid progress. Other times we feel sluggish or agitated, like we're not getting anywhere, like anything but meditation would be better. Just keep going without getting too caught up in our shifting experiences. *It doesn't really matter what our changing experiences are, so long as we keep practicing and developing these habits.*”



(#277) Joy On Demand

“Some believe you need a lot of money to experience joy, while others believe you can only find happiness if you give up everything and live in a hut in the woods. You might think you need to meditate for many years to access joy, but as you will see..., you can begin to experience benefits in one breath.” – Chade-Meng Tan, [*Joy On Demand*](#)

It's Friday, so a new 411 is available. This week, it's on *Joy On Demand*.

This was a great book on joy, mindfulness, and “one mindful breath.” Two ideas derived from it (Thought 4 and the 1 Life-Changing Idea below) have helped to significantly improve my daily enjoyment.

Here's what we cover:

4 Thoughts

How to Access Joy on Demand: One Mindful Breath

Adding Gentleness & Intensity for More Joy

Inclining the Mind Toward Joy (and the power of morning practice)

Slow Breathing is to Mindfulness what Smiling is to Facial Expressions

1 Life-Changing Idea

Take One Breath, Ten Times

[Click Here to Read or Listen](#)

Have a great weekend,

Nick

(#278) By Changing Breath Patterns...

“By changing patterns of breathing we can change our emotional states, how we think, and how we interact with the world.” – Dr. Patricia Gerbarg

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate.

(#279) To Live is to Die

“To live is to die, to be awake is to sleep, to be young is to be old, for the one thing flows into the other.” – Heraclitus

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#280) Mindful Breathing Preserves Focus After Multitasking

I'm not sure if this finding is remarkable or potentially dangerous (lol). But it's too neat not to share 😊

"For instance, research at Stanford University found that if you are focused on an important project and then stop to answer a text or email, and end up browsing the web, when you finally return to your important project your focus has dimmed. It takes you some time to ramp up your concentration to the previous level. Unless you did ten minutes of mindfulness of your breath a couple of times that day—then you have little or no loss of concentration after 'multitasking.'" – Daniel Goleman, Ph.D., *Why We Meditate*

(#281) Two (plus one) Ways to Keep Your Practice Interesting

In TB1% number 231, I provided two ways to keep your practice interesting. Let's add a third today:

- 1) Switch up your routine or exercises every 15-30 days to continuously create novelty.
- 2) Cultivate mindfulness so the same old boring exercises continuously create novelty.

3) Cultivate gratitude

As Chade-Meng Tan says, **"Gratefulness brings into proper perspective how precious each joyful experience actually is."** 🙌🙌🙌

Use one (or all three) as needed 🙏

(#282) Physical Body Dependent on the Flow of Breath

“The flow of breath, then, is constantly helping to shape the pattern of energy flow that underlies and sustains the physical body. If we can grasp the significance of this, if we can understand the crucial way in which the energizing effects of the breath support the metabolic processes of different parts of the body, we can begin to understand how the physical aspects and activities of our body are created by and dependent on the process of breathing.” – Science of Breath

Just an excellently-worded reminder that breathing sustains the body. If we grasp this significance, we begin to understand why breathing is so powerful and why anyone focused on health and wellness eventually discovers the breath.

P.S. Science of Breath won the most votes, so it will be the next Book 411. Thank you all for voting! I’m about 1/3 way through the book, and it’s incredible...I don’t know how I haven’t read this before 🤖

(#283) A Heuristic for Slow Breathing & Memory

“The degree of slowness is directly proportional to the intensity of memory; the degree of speed is directly proportional to the intensity of forgetting.” - Milan Kundera

That’s a simple & elegant heuristic for understanding how slow breathing helps cognitive function: Slowness intensifies memory; fastness intensifies forgetting.

P.S. Kundera isn’t talking about breathing per se, but life in general. He calls those relationships “existential mathematics,” which is probably the coolest idea ever 😊

(#284) Yoga Breathing, Meditation, and Longevity

“By inducing stress resilience, breath work enables us to rapidly and compassionately relieve many forms of suffering.” – Brown and Gerbarg (2009)

<https://breathlearning.com/science-411s/brown-and-gerbarg-2009/>

It's Friday, so a new Science 411 has just been released. This week, we have an excellent paper titled *“Yoga Breathing, Meditation, and Longevity”* (there was no way I couldn't read that, lol).

It was a narrative review packed with lots of ancient wisdom and modern science to back it up.

My take-home: Yogic breathing and meditation are complementary practices that may enhance longevity by improving nervous system health and stress resiliency, boosting emotional health, enhancing brain health, and reducing suffering associated with disasters.

I hope you enjoy the 411.

Click Here to Read or Listen

<https://breathlearning.com/science-411s/brown-and-gerbarg-2009/>

Have a great weekend,
Nick

P.S. I'll be sending out a poll for voting on the next Science 411 later today.

(#285) Deep, Even, and Steady Diaphragmatic Breathing

“All techniques aimed at providing relaxation of the body, nerves, and mind will be ineffective unless chest breathing is replaced by deep, even, and steady diaphragmatic breathing.” – Swami Rama

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#286) How to Reach a High Mountaintop

“If we want to reach a high mountaintop, we just have to keep steadily walking—our mood at any particular moment is not so important.” – Daniel Goleman and Tsoknyi Rinpoche, *Why We Meditate*

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#287) How the Inuit Measure the Strength of an Emotion

“It was here that I learned about a valuable Inuit tradition. If you are so angry that you can hardly control your feelings, you are asked to leave your home and to walk in a straight line through the landscape outside until your anger has left you. You then mark the point at which your anger is released with a stick in the snow. In this way, the length, or the strength, of one's rage is measured.” – Erling Kagge, *Walking: One Step at a Time*

I just loved this and thought you might, too.

But...it also made me wonder if we could make a similar heuristic measurement with breathing. Perhaps when we feel a strong emotion, we sit and breathe slowly and measure how long it takes to dissipate...

(#288) A Smile of Enlightenment

“The moment you wake up, right away, you can smile. That’s a smile of enlightenment. You are aware that a new day is beginning, that life is offering you twenty-four brand-new hours to live, and that that’s the most precious of gifts.” – Thich Nhat Hanh, *Peace is Every Breath*

I began doing this after reading the book, and it’s genuinely life-changing (even if it’s a rather weird smile because I’m still wearing my tape, lol).

Try it tomorrow morning (or anytime, really) and see how you feel 🙏

(#289) You Can Learn a Lot About a Person

The breath is full of information. You can learn a lot about a person by simply watching them breathe. And when you first learn this, it's easy to make yourself feel good by assessing people's physical and emotional state by just watching their breathing.

But the real power is in remembering this applies to yourself, too. Remembering that you can assess yourself, your emotional state, and any underlying tension you might be holding on to by watching yourself breathe.

The breath is full of information, and you can learn a lot about yourself by being mindful of it



(#290) Step One in Making a Comeback

In *The Comeback Quotient*, Matt Fitzgerald says the first step in any comeback is to accept reality as it is (he calls it becoming an “ultrarealist”).

And to cultivate an attitude of ultrarealism, he suggests...you guessed it..mindfulness:

“There’s a reason I started off with Kate Courtney’s story about using meditation to get better at facing reality. The first known proponent of ultrarealism (to use my term) just so happens to be the same person who popularized mindfulness meditation.”

And that person was, of course, the Buddha.

So, if you’re staging a comeback of any kind, step one is to accept where you’re currently at. And an excellent way to do that? Mindfulness meditation.

(#291) Science of Breath: A Practical Guide

“There is no such thing as an involuntary system if the student learns to regulate the motion of the lungs. For by doing so, a vast portion of that system is brought under his voluntary control.” – Swami Rama, *Science of Breath*

It's Friday, so a new Book 411 is now available. This week, we have our first one chosen from your voting: Science of Breath: A Practical Guide.

If you're a nerd, it's one of the best, most straightforward books written about the science of breathing. I'm ashamed it's taken me this long to read it...

Here's what we cover in the 411:

4 Thoughts

Why Breathing? Energy, the Pranic Body, and Yogic Philosophy

“All Systems Are Voluntary”: Where Yogic Philosophy Meets Modern Science

Picture a Cylinder, and the Mechanics of Optimal Breathing

Nostril Cycles & a Natural (but Sad) Neti Pot

1 Life-Changing Idea

Who You Are and Who You Become

I hope you enjoy it!

[Click Here to Read or Listen](#)

All the best,
Nick

(#292) Or Even a Lifetime

“Hence it is that one can spend decades, or even a lifetime, delving into the subtleties and implications of the process of breathing.” – Science of Breath

P.S. That’s my goal in life :)

P.P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#293) Walking and Inner Silence

“All my walks have been different, but looking back I see one common denominator: inner silence. Walking and silence belong together. Silence is as abstract as walking is concrete.” – Erling Kagge

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#294) Experiencing Wholeness: Why We Practice

“Through ongoing practice, we can come to live in a more integrated way from day to day and from moment to moment, in touch with our own wholeness and connectedness and aware of our interconnectedness with others, with the larger world in which we find ourselves, and with life itself. **Feeling whole, even for brief moments, nourishes us on a deep level.**” (my emphasis) - Jon Kabat-Zinn, Ph.D, Full Catastrophe Living

That’s why we practice: it brings us wholeness, which, even if only for brief moments, “nourishes us on a deep level.” 🙏

(#295) An All-Natural Neti Pot

Did you know there's a natural way to flush your nose with warm salt water? It's through crying.

Tears go through a duct that drains into the nose, which is why people often need a tissue when they're upset.

Rudolph Ballentine, MD, even says, **"To capitalize on this fact, the nasal wash should be done with water that is of the same composition as tears. It should be exactly that salty, and it should be at body temperature."**

That's so neat.

So, next time you need a cry, let it out. Your breathing will thank you 😊

(#296) The Well-Being Equation

$$\text{well-being} = \frac{(\text{Glow})^2}{(\text{Pain}_{\text{body}} + \text{Pain}_{\text{mental}})}$$

That eloquent equation was created by philosopher Arne Næss (I found it in this book).

In the equation, glow refers to passion or fervor; crucially, it is squared. This means a slight increase in glow will drown out increases in physical and mental pain. I love that.

It's a nice reminder that, instead of always focusing on what's bad, sometimes it's better to simply create more good.

(#297) Discovering Your Internal Silence

“I believe it's possible for everyone to discover this silence within themselves. It is there all the time, even when we are surrounded by constant noise. Deep down in the ocean, below the waves and ripples, you can find your internal silence.” – Erling Kagge, *Silence in the Age of Noise*

One way to find that silence is to breathe deep down into your belly, below the restlessness of your noisy mind. There, you'll discover your internal silence, ever-present and always accessible.

(#298) Laughter as Medicine: One of My New Favorite Reviews

“These analyses demonstrated the potential therapeutic role of laughter-inducing interventions as a complementary strategy to improve everyone’s well-being and highlight the need for further research aiming to improve our collective sense of humor.” – Kramer and Leitao (2023)

<https://breathlearning.com/science-411s/kramer-and-leitao-2023/>

(How’s that for the best quote in a science paper ever?)

It’s Friday, so a new 411 is available. This is the paper you voted for, and it’s one of my new favorite reviews...so thank you!

Take-home: This 2023 meta-analysis analyzed 8 studies and found that spontaneous laughter reduced cortisol by over 31.9%, making it a potentially powerful tool for improving wellness.

In the 411, I also provide 3 ways to apply this knowledge using Spotify, funny videos, and Instagram.

[Click Here to Read or Listen](#)

Have a great weekend,
Nick

(#299) Then Joy Arises Naturally

“Relaxing the breath, breathe in. Relaxing the breath, breathe out. Then joy arises naturally.” -
Bhante Henepola Gunaratana

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy 🙏

(#300) Silence Can Be Anywhere

“You don't need a course in silence or relaxation to be able simply to pause. Silence can be anywhere, anytime—it's just in front of your nose.” – Erling Kagge

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy :)

(#301) An Island for Yourself

Yesterday, I shared this brilliant quote from Erling Kagge:

“You don't need a course in silence or relaxation to be able simply to pause. Silence can be anywhere, anytime—it's just in front of your nose.”

That's amazing by itself, but it got even better. Kagge went on to say, **“Sure, we are all part of the same continent, but the potential wealth of being an island for yourself is something you carry around with you all the time.”**

“An island for yourself” <-- That's so good 🙌

So, here's to using our breath to create our own island of silence, today.

(#302) Universal Nature of All Beings

“Moreover, breathing is not exclusive. Living beings differ in appearance and behavior. They eat various kinds of food. They sleep in many types of beds. But all living beings breathe. ... When we focus on the breath, we become mindful of the universal nature of all beings.” –

Bhante Gunaratana, The 4 Foundations of Mindfulness

Just a thoughtful reminder that breathing unites all living beings, so when we focus on it, it can help us appreciate this connection 🙏🙏🙏

(#303) Never Follow a Leader Who Doesn't Limp

““I stopped saying, ‘Why me?’ and started saying, ‘Why not me?’” Saul told me as he continued to run. “Do you know the saying, ‘Never follow a leader who doesn’t limp?’ That’s how I see myself now. What happened to me allows me to touch people in a way I never could before.”” – Matt Fitzgerald, The Comeback Quotient

Saul Raisin is a cyclist who suffered a traumatic brain injury during a race. Although his comeback to cycling failed, he became a beacon of hope to other TBI sufferers.

I often think about Saul’s story (this passage in particular). It’s an excellent reminder that the flaws and shortcomings we sometimes try to hide are usually what make others appreciate us most 🙏

(#304) Becoming Mindful of Losing Mindfulness

“Always remember: becoming mindful of losing our mindfulness is mindfulness.” – Bhante Gunaratana, The 4 Foundations of Mindfulness

That’s such a good quote. And remember that it doesn’t just apply to our formal practice. It applies to spending time with family and friends, working, or any other time we realize we’re not actually experiencing what we’re doing.

Realizing we’ve lost our mindfulness is mindfulness 🙏

(#305) The Comeback Quotient

“My greatest hopes for this book are (1) that it is read by athletes and nonathletes alike and (2) that every reader is able to apply the inspiration and learning they glean from it to their own life, whether it be in a sport, a relationship, a job, a health crisis, or any other circumstance where a comeback is called for.” – Matt Fitzgerald, The Comeback Quotient

It's Friday, so a new 411 is available, this time on The Comeback Quotient.

I must say that he accomplished both of the above hopes with this book. It was a nice blend of sports, ancient philosophy, and modern science that can be applied anywhere.

Here's what we cover in the 411:

4 Thoughts

Becoming an Ultra Realist: The Foundation of Staging a Comeback

Step One: Accept the Situation (the Buddha & mindfulness)

Step Two: Embrace the Situation (locus of control & gratitude)

Step Three: Address the Situation (the what, the why, the how)

1 Life-Changing Idea

Never Follow a Leader Who Doesn't Limp

I hope you love it!

[Click Here to Read or Listen](#)

Enjoy the weekend,
Nick

(#306) The Roots of Suffering

“The roots of suffering are within us. And the method for eliminating suffering is within us as well.” – Bhante Gunaratana

(#307) The Most Interesting Kind of Silence

“The silence around us may contain a lot, but the most interesting kind of silence is the one that lies within. A silence which each of us must create.” – Erling Kagge

(#308) Sometimes It's the Simplest Reason

“Research at Harvard and elsewhere finds that the more our mind wanders, the worse we feel. ... On the other hand, the Davidson group has found that being able to bring our attention to what's going on in and around us in the present predicts a stronger sense of well-being.” – Daniel Goleman, Ph.D., *Why We Meditate*

There's a lot of incredible science on the benefits of mindfulness. But sometimes, it's the simplest reason that is most meaningful: The more our minds wander, the worse we feel. The less they wander, the better we feel.

(#309) The Answer to Life's Mysteries

“For thousands of years, individuals who lived in close quarters with no one but themselves around—monks on mountaintops, hermits, sailors, shepherds and explorers on their voyage home—have been convinced that the answer to life’s mysteries can be found in silence. That is the point. You sail out across the sea, but it’s when you make your return that you may discover what you have been seeking is in fact inside yourself.” – Erling Kagge, *Silence*

Those last two sentences are so good. We must sail across the sea first. It’s the only way to know with certainty that what we have been seeking is within.

(#310) Helping in Inexplicable Ways

“This is a common experience for those coming to meditation and meditation practices. They begin practice looking for stress reduction, or to increase their brain size, or to bring some other tangible benefit to their life. But they start to realize that these practices do much more, that they enrich their lives in inexplicable ways and help them in ways that they didn’t even know they needed to be helped.” – Sara Lazar, Ph.D., *The Healing Power of Meditation*

This is precisely what happened to me (and many people I talk with) with breathing and mindfulness.

We start out hoping for a tangible, sciencey-sounding health benefit.

But we stick around for the inexplicable ones we can’t even articulate.

(#311) 3 Simple Lessons

The best morning breathing exercise is a good night's sleep.

The best healing breathing exercise is a good dose of laughter.

And the best time of day for breathing exercises is always right now.

(#312) Effect of Breathing Exercises on Oxidative Stress

“Breathing exercises can improve the main biological indicators of OS [oxidative stress] toward the direction of antioxidation and improve the OS state by increasing the levels of antioxidants and reducing those of oxidative markers.” – Li et al. (2023)

<https://breathlearning.com/science-411s/li-et-al-2023/>

It's Friday, so a new 411 is available. This is obviously a sad day for me, since it's the last 411 in the foreseeable future, but I hope you enjoy it nonetheless 🙏

Here's the takeaway: This meta-analysis examined 10 studies and found that breathing exercises of all kinds significantly reduce biomarkers of oxidative stress while increasing the body's antioxidant capacity.

[Click Here to Read or Listen](#)

You'll get two more TB1%'s on Saturday and Sunday...I'll try to end it with some good quotes :)

Have a great weekend,
Nick

(#313) The Definition of Success

“To know that even one life has breathed easier because you have lived. This is to have succeeded.” - Ralph Waldo Emerson

P.S. I sent this one back in TB1% number 5, but it seems relevant today. Although the Learning Center failed financially, based on the number of emails you all have sent (many of which made me cry, [natural neti pot style](#)), I think it succeeded by this definition 🙏

(#314) So, What Will You Do with Them?

“Now that you have learned the core breathing practices, they are yours forever. No one can take them from you. They will never run out, run down, or expire. They belong to you. So, what will you do with them?” – Richard Brown and Patricia Gerbarg, *The Healing Power of the Breath*

Today is the last TB1% for the foreseeable future.

I'll still be doing courses, workshops, and coaching, so I hope to see you again sometime soon. And if you have diabetes or know someone who does, be sure to sign up to become a free beta tester for The Breathing App for Diabetes.

Thank you again, from the bottom of my heart, for your support and encouragement.

With love and gratitude,
Nick

The Learning Center is Open Again

I'm excited to announce that the Learning Center is now open again. I loved and missed it too much. I'm going back to work full-time, which will allow me to do all my breathing work simply for the love it again :)

2 New Things

Workshops: All my workshops will now be in the Learning Center as part of the membership.

Three are currently available:

Philosophy of Breath (new version specifically for the Learning Center)

How to Get Started with Breathwork

Breathing for Better Brain Health

I will add a new one every quarter (the next one will be April 1).

Breath Practices: Although I hate my voice and suggest you use an app, lol, I have uploaded recordings of what I feel are the core practices associated with the material in the Learning Center.

1 Change

I'm going to release new Book and Science 411s every other week (two each month) to make it more manageable. They will be released on Sundays instead of Fridays (so I can make last-minute changes over the weekend 😊)

A New Book 411 on My Favorite Book Ever

To kick things off, we have a new Book 411 on what is probably my favorite book ever written: The Well-Lived Life. The 411 cannot do it justice, but I hope you find it incredibly inspiring, nonetheless.

In good breath,

Nick

P.S. If you're receiving this, it means you're a lifetime member, and the Learning Center material is yours forever at no further charge.

(#315) Jigsaw Puzzle (one of my new favorite passages)

“I like thinking of us as puzzle pieces because it gives us each space to be unique. We’re not supposed to be shaped this way or that; we’re supposed to be shaped precisely as we are, because that way we can fit together. It isn’t anyone’s job to judge the shape of anyone else’s piece, and in the same way, it isn’t useful to try to make ourselves more or less like anyone else or to worry if they judge our shape. Instead, it’s up to each of us to align with our own soul and help others do the same. Seeing things this way helps us understand that each of us is essential.” – Gladys McGarey, MD

I love this so much—it’s one of my new favorite passages 🙏

(#316) Let Things Flow Naturally Forward

“Life is a series of natural and spontaneous changes. Don’t resist them; that only creates sorrow. Let reality be reality. Let things flow naturally forward in whatever way they like.” – Lao Tzu

Paradoxically, controlling our breathing is a way to let things flow naturally.

The conscious act of slowing our breath down trains our nervous systems and minds to be more adaptable. This greater flexibility means we can better handle natural and spontaneous changes as they occur 🙏

The Breathing 1%: Practice mindful, slow breathing in the morning to be more adaptable and open to change throughout the day.

(#317) How to (almost) Not Suffer from Pain

In The Mindfulness Solution, Ronald Siegel, Psy.D., presents a conceptual equation for suffering:

Suffering = Pain x Resistance

Here's what this symbolic relationship means:

If our resistance is zero, we won't suffer.

If our resistance is high, we'll suffer a lot.

Of course, it's impossible to have zero resistance (if you're a normal human like me, lol). But this is a nice (and immediately applicable) reminder that most of our suffering comes from resisting our pain rather than accepting it.

So, today's 1%: When physical or psychological pain pops up, practice mindful acceptance to reduce resistance and lessen suffering.

(#318) Bound to Have Wonderful Outcomes

“As I’m fond of saying, small tweaks lead to big changes, and a little attention goes a long way. A few minutes of slow breathing is a small tweak—perhaps just one percent of our day—and that little bit of attention to the very thing that sustains our life is bound to have wonderful outcomes.” – Eddie Stern, *Healing Through Breathing*

That is so good. I have nothing helpful to add :)

So, today’s 1%: Slow down and put a little attention on the very thing that sustains life—our breath. It’s “bound to have wonderful outcomes.”

(#319) Changing Identity from Air to You

“At this very moment billions of oxygen atoms are changing identity from being ‘the air’ to being ‘you.’” – Ronald Siegel, Psy.D.

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate.

(#320) And if I Am in a Hurry?

“A disciple asks a Zen master: ‘How long does it take to be able to experience Awakening?’ ‘Maybe 20 years,’ answers the master. ‘And if I am in a hurry?’ asks the disciple again. ‘In that case, it is 50 years,’ concludes the master.” – Steven Laureys, MD

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate.

P.P.S. I shared this one in the newsletter a while back. But it’s so good that it’s worth revisiting regularly :)

(#321) We Are All Creators

In The Creative Act, Rick Rubin says: “Through the ordinary state of being, we’re already creators in the most profound way, creating our experience of reality and composing the world we perceive.” < -- That’s so good.

But...I think we could take it a level deeper and say we’re all creators because we’re all breathing. We literally construct our body and mind with each breath we take. That means the way we breathe profoundly influences how we live and our experience of reality.

So, today’s 1% is to remember that you are an artist, your “creative act” is the life you’re composing, and your breath is the driving force of that ultimate creation.

(#322) Dramatic Shifts to Our State of Mind and Nervous System

“When we begin to take up breathing practices, we temporarily make an involuntary, life-sustaining function voluntary, and in that can make dramatic shifts to our state of mind and the state of our nervous system.” – Eddie Stern, *Healing Through Breathing*

Breathing is the only involuntary, life-sustaining function we can freely control. It also happens to be the most essential for living, so consciously changing it can make dramatic shifts in our well-being.

So, today's 1%: Let's harness this power by taking a few moments to voluntarily control our breath to elicit meaningful “shifts to our state of mind and the state of our nervous system.”

(#323) How Mindfulness Helps in Being Better People

“When we pay close attention to our experience, we notice that harmful behavior creates waves of disturbance in the mind. It's difficult to have a peaceful meditation session after a long day of lying and stealing...So through mindfulness, we make healthier, wiser decisions because we're more sensitive to the subtle effects of those decisions.” – Ronald Siegel, Psy.D., The Mindfulness Solution

I love this (and it reminds me of TB1% number 245 on the audience effect).

Today's 1% is to use this quote as a reminder and motivator to practice mindfulness so that we can “make healthier, wiser decisions because we're more sensitive to the subtle effects of those decisions.” 🙏

(#324) We Don't Need to Hurry

"It may sound paradoxical, but however tight our schedule, however many things clamor to be done, we don't need to hurry. If we can keep our mind calm and go about our business with undivided attention, we will not only accomplish more but we'll do a better job and find ourselves more patient, more at peace." – Eknath Easwaran, Take Your Time
<https://amzn.to/49R6rNg>

This is a message all contemplative practices teach, but one that is incredibly challenging to follow (I know I rarely live this way).

So, today's 1% is to simply remember that no matter how busy we are, we don't need to hurry. We need only to return to our breath, cultivate a calm mind, and "go about our business with undivided attention."

(#325) The Pace You Set

“The pace you set first thing in the morning is likely to stay with you through the day. If you get up early and set a calm, unhurried pace, it is much easier to resist getting speeded up later on as the pressures of the day close in on you. ... It puts your activities into a more peaceful perspective that will stay with you all day.” – Eknath Easwaran, Take Your Time
<https://amzn.to/49R6rNg>

Each morning, we meet a new day. We can make a good first impression by starting calm and unhurried using our favorite contemplative practice.

So, today's 1% is to remember that morning practice starts your day off calmly and joyously. That peaceful perspective “will stay with you all day.” 🙏

(#326) A Great Zen Master Was Once Asked

“A great Zen master renowned for his wisdom was once asked, ‘What’s the most remarkable thing you’ve learned in all of your years of meditation and study?’ He answered, ‘The most remarkable thing is that we’re all going to die but we live each day as though it weren’t so.’”

– Ronald Siegel, Psy.D.

(#327) Slow Breathing for Cardiovascular and Emotional Health

A new Science 411 was just released in the Learning Center on a 2024 study published in Mindfulness: The Effect of Slow-Paced Breathing on Cardiovascular and Emotion Functions: A Meta-Analysis and Systematic Review.

There were no earth-shattering findings, but it was still a fun paper to read. Here's my quick summary:

This 2024 meta-analysis found that slow-paced breathing, at least in the short term, has positive effects on the cardiovascular system, and these physiological changes are associated with a modest reduction in negative emotions.

You can read the entire 411 in less than 3 minutes or listen to the podcast version (which is 12 minutes) here:

I hope you enjoy it!

In good breath,
Nick

(#328) Any Framework, Method, or Label

“Any framework, method, or label
you impose on yourself
is just as likely to be a limitation
as an opening.” – Rick Rubin

P.S. Just a great quote to contemplate today since I sent a new 411 yesterday.

(#329) Good Impatience and Good Patience

“Exceptional people are impatient with limits others place on them...But exceptional people show enormous patience when they’re working at a process they believe will make them better...Just because the results aren’t immediate, they don’t give up. They persist.” – Dr. Bob Rotella, *How Champions Think*

That’s so good, and it’s today’s 1%: Let’s be a little more impatient with the limits others place on us but more patient with the things we do (like our contemplative practice) to make ourselves better.

(#330) Watering Your Seeds of Happiness

“So, I planted in myself a number of seeds of happiness. I know that this is very important because if I do not have enough happiness within myself, I shall not be able to help other people, other living beings. So that is why every day to practice in order to water the seed of your happiness, of your joy, is very important.” – Thich Nhat Hanh, The Art of Mindful Living Talk

Today's 1%: Make sure you're taking time to water the seeds of your own happiness and joy. Without it, you will not be able to help anyone else.

(#331) An Insightful Analogy for Slowing Down

“If life were always pleasant, it wouldn’t matter so much if our minds were speeding out of control. But life has a way of presenting us with speed bumps. If you hit a speed bump at seventy miles per hour, you are going to be in the hospital. When life puts up speed bumps, we have to be able to slow down to get over them without injury.” – Eknath Easwaran, Take Your Time, <https://amzn.to/49R6rNg>

This insightful analogy perfectly illustrates the benefit of slowing down, and it’s today’s 1%. Let’s remember that life will always throw us speed bumps—that’s just part of being alive. Taking time to slow down our minds each day will help us overcome them without injury 🙏

(#332) A To-Be List

“So often we sleepwalk through our lives...There are those who approach the opportunities of each day like crossing items off a to-do list instead of truly engaging and participating with all of themselves.” – Rick Rubin, *The Creative Act*

I make a to-do list every day (and I love crossing off each item).

But this passage made me think: Why not make a “to-be” list instead? Instead of focusing on doing things, why don’t I focus on experiencing them?

So, as of Wednesday, the top of my list says “To-Be List.” It’s a subtle reminder to cultivate awareness instead of sleepwalking through my day.

Today’s 1%: If you feel so inspired, consider turning your to-do list into a to-be list 😊

(#333) How to Achieve Your Goal in Any Walk of Life

“If you have trained your mind to give complete attention to one thing at a time, you can achieve your goal in any walk of life. Whether it is science or the arts or sports or a profession, concentration is a basic requirement in every field. And complete concentration is genius.” – Eknath Easwaran

P.S. On weekends, I just share a shorter insightful quote for you to contemplate and enjoy 🙏

(#334) It's Better Not to Arrive

I recommend listening to Thich Nhat Hanh speak this passage here. He makes himself laugh, which made me laugh out loud, too. <https://youtu.be/JIEqlqzkt4?t=3361>

“Life is a walk, and you should be able to enjoy each step you make. If you keep thinking of arriving, of the destination, you should remember that the final destination is not so rightful. It's your own funeral. [*begins laughing*] So why arrive? [*crowd starts laughing*] Why arrive? It's better not to arrive. Therefore, you should go into the direction of life.” – Thich Nhat Hanh

P.S. On weekends, I just share a shorter insightful quote for you to contemplate and enjoy 🙏

(#335) A Humorous Interpretation

“The next time you find yourself doing something embarrassing, I encourage you to try to think about how it could be seen as funny. What about your mistake is humorous? What was surprising, silly, or just plain ridiculous? How would someone on the outside see it, and why might they laugh? You'll be surprised by how often a humorous interpretation is available if you only go looking for it.” – Gladys McGarey, MD, *The Well-Lived Life*

This mental exercise has been genuinely life-changing for me, especially since I do a lot of embarrassing things :)

Today's 1%: The next time you're faced with embarrassment (or if you ruminate on one event often), try finding a humorous angle. It can be truly transformative for dealing with these moments.

(#336) So We Notes to Keep Track

After Gandhi spoke eloquently for over 2 hours without preparation, reporters asked his secretary Desai:

“How is it that he is able to speak so well for such a long time without any preparation, without any prompting, without even any notes?” ...

Desai replied, ‘What Gandhi thinks, what he feels, what he says, and what he does are all the same. He does not need notes.’

Then he added smiling: ‘You and I, we think one thing, feel another, say a third, and do a fourth, so we need notes and files to keep track.’” – Eknath Easwaran, Gandhi The Man

That last part always makes me laugh inside (because it’s so accurate).

Today’s 1%: Let’s use this as a reminder to put down our literal and metaphorical notes about who we’re “supposed” to be and instead think, speak, and act from our hearts 🙏

(#337) Are You Getting Too Old?

“Understanding this opens us to a new possibility—one we may not have considered before...What if, instead of chasing youth and lost time, we could embrace the aging process, making space for our lives to get better and better as they go along?

...

When seen from this perspective, growing older is no longer about compensating for lost or weakened capacities but rather about getting closer to embracing who we are meant to be. Each year that goes by connects us more to our purpose.” – Gladys McGarey, MD, 103 years old

Today’s 1%: Let’s use this wisdom as a beautiful reminder that growing older is not about trying to compensate to stay younger. It’s about “getting closer to embracing who we are meant to be. Each year that goes by connects us more to our purpose.”

(#338) We Don't Have a Good Control Group

In his book, Dr. Siegel shares how, even with years of mindfulness practice, he still experiences moments of tension, especially when running late. His children playfully tease him: 'Dad — don't you teach people how to live in the moment?'

Then he says:

"Now that my daughters are old enough to understand the scientific method, I'm able to point out that we don't have a good control group. We don't know with certainty how distressed I'd be by everyday problems without mindfulness practice."

That's profound and worth contemplating in our own lives...

Today's 1%: The next time we're not as calm or concentrated as we think we "should" be, let's remember that there's no way of knowing how much worse off we would've been without our practice 🙏

(#339) Happiness that's Independent of Fickle Fortunes

“Modern scientific research is lining up nicely with ancient wisdom to point the way to a rich and meaningful life. It is reinforcing what mindfulness practice has long revealed: savoring our experience, appreciating and embracing our place in the amazing ever-changing world, sensing our interconnection with other people, animals, and the rest of nature, and engaging our talents fully for the good of all fosters a kind of happiness that isn't dependent on fickle fortunes.” – Ronald Siegel, Psy.D.

Today's 1%: Let's use this as a reminder that, over time, the qualities of mind our contemplative practices cultivate offer “a kind of happiness that isn't dependent on fickle fortunes.”

I hope you experience a touch of that contentment over the weekend 🙏

(#340) The Three Ways to Ultimate Success

“There are three ways to ultimate success:

The first way is to be kind.

The second way is to be kind.

The third way is to be kind.” – Fred Rogers

P.S. On weekends, I just share a quick insightful quote for you to contemplate and enjoy 🙏

(#341) The Creative Act by Rick Rubin – New Book 411

“The universe is only as large as our perception of it. When we cultivate our awareness, we are expanding the universe.” – Rick Rubin

I just released a new Book 411 on The Creative Act by Rick Rubin. This short book is a must-read for anyone interested in creating a meaningful life—which is, of course, you 😊

At the very least, I hope you’ll check out Thought #3 on Inner Harmony and the 1 Life-Changing Idea on Japanese pottery.

I hope you enjoy reading or listening,
Nick

(#342) A Deep Connection to Our Inner Life

“We can form an intimate relationship with our breath, our nervous system, and thus understand on a deep level the way our mind works. Ultimately, this is not about simply breathing; it is about finding a deep connection to our inner life.” – Eddie Stern, *Healing Through Breathing*

That’s so good (and basically sums up most of the Breath Learning Center).

Today’s 1%: Let’s remember that breathing isn’t just breathing. It’s “about finding a deep connection to our inner life” so we can understand how our bodies and minds work.

(#343) A Thread Throughout Our Day

“Eventually, we are trying to extend the influence of morning meditation until it becomes like a thread running through the day. Then there is a continuous connection between meditation and daily living. The timeless values on which we are meditating begin to transform every word and action.” – Eknath Easwaran, Conquest of Mind

Today’s 1% is to use this as a reminder of the power of our breath. When we meditate on the breath (or do breathing exercises), then there is always “a continuous connection between meditation and daily living.” It’s up to us to draw upon it throughout our day.

P.S. In addition, reading these daily messages attentively serves as a short wisdom meditation. I hope each one becomes a thread through your day, providing timeless values that will help align your words and actions with the person you want to be 🙏

(#344) He Refused to Walk with a Companion

Annabel Streets (<https://amzn.to/3xarpIV>) speaking about the eighteenth-century German philosopher Immanuel Kant:

“Obsessed with notions of health, he was fascinated by his breathing. In fact, Kant developed a technique of breathing solely through his nose—250 years before scientists recognized the role of nasal breathing for good health. Kant was so determined to breathe only through his nose that he refused to walk with a companion, fearful that conversation might inadvertently make him inhale through his mouth. Kant lived to just short of his eightieth birthday, a phenomenal age in 1804.”

Of course, the benefits of social walking probably far outweigh the benefits of nasal breathing. But as an introvert, I love this 😂

So, today’s 1% is simple: Enjoy a nice walk. Nasal breathing is mandatory. Companions are optional.

(#345) What the Seed Contributes

“A seed does not contribute much materially to the plant it grows into; the material comes from the soil, sunlight, water, and air. What the seed contributes is information. It has the same DNA as every other living entity, but when its genes begin to be expressed, it pulls from the environment what is needed to make a plant of just a particular kind.” – Eknath Easwaran, The Dhammapada s

Our morning contemplative practice and these daily emails are like seeds. They don't contribute much materially, but they provide critical information. By planting seeds of wisdom, joy, love, and humor each morning, they allow us to naturally pull from our surroundings what is needed for these qualities to grow in our lives.

(#346) The Buddha Gained Nothing Through Meditation

“Someone once asked the Buddha skeptically, ‘What have you gained through meditation?’ The Buddha replied, ‘Nothing at all.’

‘Then, Blessed One, what good is it?’

‘Let me tell you what I lost through meditation: sickness, anger, depression, insecurity, the burden of old age, the fear of death. That is the good of meditation...’” – Eknath Easwaran

This is one of the biggest paradoxes of breathing and meditation practices. While we often focus on what we’ll get, the things we lose are usually the most important.

So, if you feel so inspired, today’s 1% is to consider the things you have lost from your practice that have made it worthwhile.

P.S. For me that includes losing a lot of self-judgment (but not all, lol), caring how others view me, regret about past mistakes, stressing over doing things perfectly, and—most of all—I’ve lost a lot of seriousness about myself.

(#347) The Great Lesson from the True Mystics

“The great lesson from the true mystics...is that the sacred is in the ordinary, that it is to be found in one’s daily life, in one’s neighbors, friends, and family, in one’s back yard.” – Abraham Maslow

P.S. On weekends, I just share a quick insightful quote for you to contemplate and enjoy 🙏

(#348) It Can Benefit Every Person We Encounter

“Breathing, the common, everyday act of inhaling and exhaling a breath, has the ability to be something that benefits not just me or you, it can benefit every person we encounter.” – Rev. Duffy Peet

P.S. On weekends, I just share a short, insightful quote for you to contemplate and enjoy. But for slightly more context on this one, he was referring to how a breath practice can help us develop qualities like patience, loving-kindness, and compassion, which then benefits everyone we meet 🙏

(#349) New Workshop: Breathing & Visualization for Healing

“In all the meditative traditions of the world, visualizations and imagery are used to invoke particular qualities of mind and heart.” – Jon Kabat-Zinn, Ph.D.

I just released a new workshop in the Learning Center titled Breathing and Visualization for Healing.

Overview: This workshop explores how slow breathing and mental imagery can be combined to promote healing and provides several exercises for putting this wisdom into practice.

Run Time: 55 min 48 sec

Formats: Video, Downloadable Audio, and a PDF of the presentation

[Click here to watch or listen.](#)

I hope you enjoy it!

Have a great week,
Nick

(#350) Your Peace is Disturbed, Not Theirs

“When you allow yourself to dislike someone, your peace is disturbed - not their peace of mind but your own. Tragically, we are bound to those people we dislike and shackled to those whom we hate....If we want sound health and unshakable security, we have to learn to be loving and calm under all circumstances. We have to learn to be as concerned about the welfare of those who dislike us as we are for those who like us.” – Eknath Easwaran, Take Your Time (<https://amzn.to/49r3PVS>)

I’ve read (but quickly forgotten 😅) passages like this many times. However, this one resonated with me deeply; maybe it will for you, too :)

So, today’s 1%: Remember that when “you allow yourself to dislike someone, your peace is disturbed,” not theirs.

(#351) Before We Unmute on Zoom...

“Speak only if it improves upon the silence.” – Gandhi

Ha! That’s a perfect way to apply ancient wisdom to modern times 😊

I’ve also heard it put this way: “Before speaking, consider whether it is an improvement upon silence.” That’s wise advice for Zoom...or any occasion.

So, today’s 1%: “Before speaking, consider whether it is an improvement upon silence.”

(#352) Science Talk for “Breath is Life”

I’m reading an excellent new paper...if the Learning Center had a science mascot, this paper would be it :)

In the subsection on mitochondria, they casually say:

“We must continuously breathe precisely to bring oxygen to mitochondria to fuel oxidative phosphorylation, to charge our mitochondria, which sustain cellular life, brain activity, and consciousness.”

Translation: Breath is life.

So, today’s 1%: Occasionally take a mindful breath, remembering that each one sustains “cellular life, brain activity, and consciousness.”

P.S. Thanks to Taylor at Symmetry for sending me this one while it was in preprints and to HHPF for posting it right when it was published 🙏

(#353) My New Favorite Two Words

In Awe: The New Science of Everyday Wonder..., Dacher Keltner says:

“What most commonly led people around the world to feel awe? Nature? Spiritual practice? Listening to music? In fact, it was other people’s courage, kindness, strength, or overcoming. Around the world, we are most likely to feel awe when moved by moral beauty.”

Moral beauty. Seeing those two words side-by-side invokes a little awe in me.

He goes on to say that moral beauty is “exceptional virtue, character, and ability...marked by a purity and goodness of intention and action.”

That sounds like a perfect North Star for becoming a better person.

Here’s to using our breath and contemplative practice so that we might develop more courage, kindness, and strength on our path to moral beauty.

(#354) From Our First Breath to Our Last

“From our first breath to our last, awe moves us to deepen our relations with the wonders of life and to marvel at the vast mysteries that are part of our fleeting time here, guided by this most human of emotions.” – Dacher Keltner

P.S. On weekends, I just share a short, insightful quote for you to contemplate and enjoy 🙏

(#355) Cost-Effective Interventions for Metabolic Disease

“Stress-reduction techniques may serve as cost-effective interventions for preventing and treating metabolic disease.” – Jurgens et al. (2023), Brain, Behavior, & Immunity

I just released a new Science 411 on this paper. Their results suggested that stress-lowering exercises (like slow breathing) may reduce inflammation and, consequently, improve metabolic function.

[Click Here to Read/Listen](#)

Read Time: 2 min 37 sec

Listen Time: 11 min 0 sec

If you're a coach, implementing these findings in your practice is straightforward; all you need is a Google Form. Check out the 1 Practical Application section to see how.

I hope you enjoy the 411!

In good breath,
Nick

(#356) Health Nuts

“Health nuts are going to feel stupid someday, lying in hospitals dying of nothing.” - Redd Foxx

P.S. Since we missed our usual Sunday quote yesterday, here’s a funny (and quite insightful) one to enjoy and contemplate today 🙏

(#357) Just One Person

“Pressure is contagious, but so is good will. Just one person slowing down, one person not putting others under pressure, helps everyone else to relax too.” – Eknath Easwaran, Take Your Time

When we practice slowing down, it helps everyone else feel at ease, too. It just takes one person, so let’s use this as inspiration to be that person today 🙏

P.S. If you are naturally tense like me, this additional passage from Easwaran is helpful: “To paraphrase the Buddha, we learn to do this by doing it. We learn to slow down by trying to slow down.”

(#358) No Hedonic Adaptation to This

“You might have thought that when we more often experience awe in the wonders of life, those wonders lose their power. This is known as the law of hedonic adaptation, that certain pleasures...diminish with their increased occurrence. Not so with awe. The more we practice awe, the richer it gets.” – Dacher Keltner, *Awe: The New Science of Everyday Wonder*

“The more we practice awe, the richer it gets.” That’s a beautiful idea and explains why daily practices like breathing or meditation, time in nature, or reading timeless wisdom never lose their potency. Each one brings awe, connecting us closer to our true selves; there is no hedonic adaptation to that.

(#359) Happy World Breathing Day

“The fact is that when we focus on the breath, we are focusing on the life force. Life begins with our first breath and will end after our last. To contemplate breathing is to contemplate life itself.” – Larry Rosenberg

Of course, every day is World Breathing Day 😊. And although I usually don't like made-up holidays (lol), in this case, I'll use it as an excuse to offer a breath-inspired wish for you, borrowed from Rev. Duffy Peet:

“May your adventures be truly great for as long as you take another breath. And may you live long as you seek to discover the wonders and the benefits that each breath has to offer in this, the journey of life.”

Enjoy your day!

(#360) Strive Earnestly

In The Dhammapada, Eknath Easwaran tells us the Buddha's last words were:

"Then I exhort you, brothers: remember, all things that come into being must pass away. Strive earnestly!"

The idea of striving earnestly actually appears several times throughout the book.

This surprised me because we often think of the "contemplative life" as letting go of striving. But the Buddha himself urged us to strive—to strive toward becoming our true selves, to strive toward being good.

So, today's 1% is to remember that striving earnestly for the right things is okay.

(#361) We Have Forgotten the Intangible

“Life is spontaneous and it is unpredictable, it is magical. I think that we have struggled so hard with the tangible that we have forgotten the intangible.” - Diane Frolov and Andrew Schneider

P.S. On weekends, I just share a short and insightful quote for you to enjoy and contemplate



(#362) The Beginning of a Happier Life

“The unselfish effort to bring cheer to others will be the beginning of a happier life for ourselves.” - Helen Keller

P.S. On weekends, I just share a short and insightful quote for you to enjoy and contemplate



(#363) A To-Be List, Part II

“Don’t do any task in order to get it over with. Resolve to do each job in a relaxed way, with all your attention. Enjoy and be one with your work.” – Thich Nhat Hanh

One month ago, we used Rick Rubin’s wisdom (<https://breathlearning.com/the-breathing-1/number-332/>) to create a “to-be list.” This passage from Thich Nhat Hanh is exactly what I had in mind.

So, if this idea still inspires you, consider making a to-be list for all your tasks and resolving “to do each job in a relaxed way, with all your attention. Enjoy and be one with your work.”

P.S. I’m still practicing this every day. I’ll confess that I often slip back into “just get it done” mode :) But I’m striving earnestly, and each time I remember to fully enjoy each task, it truly makes things more fulfilling.

(#364) How to End Any Quarrel

“People forget that their lives will end soon. For those who remember, quarrels come to an end.” – The Buddha

That’s a simple way to end almost any disagreement we might be dealing with: Remember, our lives will be over soon. From that zoomed-out (and 100% accurate) perspective, it’s easier to let go of disputes and direct our energy toward things that truly matter.

(#365) The Longer the Beard...

“Years ago, a wonderful Hindu teacher, Swami Chinmayananda, who taught me the Vedanta, said, ‘The longer the beard, the bigger the fake.’ And he, himself, had a beard that almost touched the floor!”

Ha! This always makes me laugh. It was part of a discussion about testing things for yourself rather than blindly trusting teachers.

Aside from the chuckle, it also made me think of how, in today’s society, our version of “long beards” is having credentials touching the floor: Master Instructor, Ph.D., MD, Psy.D., D.O., and so on :)

So, today’s 1% is remembering that, whether it’s a long beard or scholarly credentials, we should learn from the wise but ultimately test everything in our own lives. Keep what works, discard what doesn’t.

Enjoy your day,

Nick Heath, Ph.D., Advanced OA Instructor, Level 1 Pranayama Instructor (😂😂😂)

(#366) Breaking Out of Our Eggshell

“Our everyday life, the Buddha is suggesting, is lived within an eggshell. We have no more idea of what life is really like than a chicken has before it hatches. Excitement and depression, fortune and misfortune, pleasure and pain, are storms in a tiny, private, shell-bound realm which we take to be the whole of existence.” – Eknath Easwaran, The Dhammapada

This is part of the power of our breathing and contemplative practice. Each session, however tiny, helps crack our shells a little more...perhaps one day, we'll break out of them entirely 😊

(#367) You Can't Learn Too Much Theory

"There's no need to fear learning too much theory. It won't undermine the pure expression of your voice. If you don't let it. ... Learning provides more ways to reliably convey your ideas. From our enlarged menu, we can still choose the simplest, most elegant option." – Rick Rubin, The Creative Act

I'm biased (I did create the "Learning" Center, after all 😊), but I love this perspective. It's an excellent reminder that we needn't fear learning more about things we're interested in. Learning gives us an enlarged menu...but "we can still choose the simplest, most elegant option."

So, today's 1% is to enjoy learning way too much about the things you love. "It won't undermine the pure expression of your voice. If you don't let it."

(#368) When We Forget about the Body

“Interestingly enough, it is just when we forget about the body that it functions at its best.” –
Eknath Easwaran

P.S. On weekends, I just share a short and insightful quote for you to enjoy and contemplate



(#369) Healing Through Breathing – New Book 411

“Ultimately, this is not about simply breathing; it is about finding a deep connection to our inner life.” – Eddie Stern, Healing Through Breathing

I just released our next Book 411, this time on Healing Through Breathing by Eddie Stern.

This one is special for 3 reasons:

The book is incredible and one of my new favorites

Eddie is a close friend of mine

This is the first 411 on a book by an author who is also a Learning Center member (in Eddie's defense, I signed him up...he didn't do it willingly 😂😂😂)

The 411 is filled with actionable insights and wisdom, so I hope you enjoy it!

[Click Here to Read or Listen to the New 411](#)

Have a great week ahead,

Nick

(#370) Here is a Test to Find...

“Here is the test to find whether your mission on Earth is finished: if you’re alive, it isn’t.” -
Richard Bach

P.S. Since we missed our usual Sunday quote yesterday, here’s an insightful one to enjoy and
contemplate today 🙏

(#371) A Passage on the Power of the Breath

If you ever need a reminder of the power of breathing from a science perspective, this is it:

“The parasympathetic and sympathetic systems are tonically active, with efferent pathways extending from the brainstem and hypothalamus to all major peripheral organs and afferent nerves from the lungs, airways, and heart, projecting to the brainstem and to the hypothalamus and higher order neural regions. **Because of this anatomical connectivity, changes in breathing rate are quickly signaled to the brain**, allowing the brain to interpret that the body is in a relaxed, calm state, and safe state.” – Crosswell et al. (2024)

So, today's 1% is to make sure you take advantage of this anatomical connectivity to put yourself into a relaxed and calm state today 🙏

(#372) Teaching at a Free University

“All of us maintain a free university of our own, where we teach by what we are.” – Eknath Easwaran

As a parent, this quote (and its surrounding passage) basically slapped me in the face 😊

But even if you’re not a parent or a teacher, this is an excellent reminder that each of us is always teaching “by what we are.”

So, today’s 1% is to ask ourselves if we’re being the kind of teachers we’d like to learn from? Then, use this awareness to help us inch closer to who we’d like to be 🙏

P.S. For those interested, here’s the full passage: “If just one person in the family does this, a home becomes heaven. Even an office can become heaven! Putting others first is an infectious example that affects everybody around. In Berkeley in the sixties, an institution sprang up called the Free University. All of us maintain a free university of our own, where we teach by what we are. Especially where children are concerned, the home is a seven-day-a-week school of education for living.”

(#373) Taking in the Good, Drop by Drop

“Every time you take in the good, you build a little bit of neural structure. Doing this a few times a day—for months and even years—will gradually change your brain, and how you feel and act, in far-reaching ways.” – Rick Hanson, Ph.D.

This is a powerful reminder that our brains literally change when we consciously choose to “take in the good,” whatever that means to you. It might be laughing, observing nature, petting your dog, or noticing your child’s joy; these all actively shape and change our brains in “far-reaching ways.”

As the Buddha said, “Let no one think lightly of good and say to himself, ‘Joy will not come to me.’ Little by little a person becomes good, as a pot is filled by drops of water.”

(#374) Two Light-Hearted and Wise Zen Stories

To start the weekend with a smile on our faces and wisdom to contemplate:

I

“One Zen student said, ‘My teacher is the best. He can go days without eating.’

The second said, ‘My teacher has so much self-control, he can go days without sleeping.’

The third said, ‘My teacher is so wise that he eats when he’s hungry and sleeps when he’s tired.’”

II

“A Zen monk said, ‘Before I began to practice, mountains were mountains, and rivers were rivers. During many years of practice, mountains stopped being mountains and rivers stopped being rivers. Now as I understand things properly, mountains are mountains, and rivers are rivers.’”

(#375) If It's Raining and You Have an Umbrella

"If it's raining and you have an umbrella, use it. Don't endure unpleasant circumstances that can be changed by action." - David Reynolds

P.S. On weekends, I just share a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#376) Better to Follow This

“It helps to realize that it’s better to follow the universe than those around you.” – Rick Rubin

P.S. On weekends, I just share a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#377) “A Lens Through Which We See the World”

“How do emotions guide our actions?”

The first is this: emotions transform how we perceive the world...Each emotion is a lens through which we see the world.” – Dacher Keltner, Awe

“Each emotion is a lens through which we see the world.” This unintentionally explains the power of the breath perfectly.

By giving us direct access to our emotions, breathing exercises put a new lens on life, providing more clarity, focus, and joy.

But remember: These lenses get dirty throughout the day, so it's crucial to renew them every morning to set the tone for what's ahead 🙏

(#378) Our Job as Human Beings

“As human beings, our job in life is to help people realize how rare and valuable each one of us really is, that each of us has something that no one else has—or ever will have—something inside that is unique for all time. It’s our job to encourage each other to discover that uniqueness and to provide ways of developing its expression.” – Fred Rogers

That’s incredibly inspiring not just for teachers, coaches, and parents, but for all human beings.

And remember, the most promising way to help someone else discover their uniqueness and develop its expression is to first do it for ourselves 🙏

(#379) How to Give Your Heart and Lungs a Vacation

“In other words, patience is not only a mental virtue; it is an asset even for physical health. I’m sure you are aware of the way your heart races when you get impatient. Perhaps you have noticed, too, that your breathing becomes faster and more shallow. Doesn’t it seem reasonable that if you can strengthen your patience to such a degree that other people’s behavior never upsets you, your heart, lungs, and nervous system will be on vacation?” – Eknath Easwaran, Original Goodness

That does seem reasonable to me :)

Here’s to cultivating a little more patience so that we may give our hearts, lungs, and nervous systems a vacation every day 🙏

P.S. Reflecting on this insightful (and commonsensical) passage inspired me to write this: “Wisdom is words that you don’t need a reference for.” I didn’t need any scientific evidence to know that that passage was true. To me, that’s wisdom.

(#380) Why Worry Goes with Hurry

“Worry goes with hurry because people in a hurry don’t have time to think clearly and make clear decisions, so they are always worried about results. ... If you slow down enough to think clearly and act wisely, you have no need to worry because you know you are doing your best.”

– Eknath Easwaran, Take Your Time

To follow up on yesterday’s message on patience, here’s a gem on worrying and hurrying.

And notice that Easwaran didn’t say that if we slow down and practice patience, we’ll make the perfect decision or that it will always work out.

We just won’t have to worry because we’ll know we’re doing our best. There’s not much more we can ask for 🙏

(#381) How to Generate Hope Molecules

“Hope can begin in your muscles. Every time you take a single step, you contract over two hundred myokine-releasing muscles. The very same muscles that propel your body forward also send proteins to your brain that stimulate the neurochemistry of resilience. ... Any movement that involves muscular contraction—which is to say, all movement—releases beneficial myokines.” Kelly McGonigal, Ph.D., *The Joy of Movement*

This reminded me of the famous quip attributed to Hippocrates: “If you are in a bad mood, go for a walk. If you are still in a bad mood, go for another walk.” It sounds like modern neuroscience approves.

So, if you need to cultivate aspiration today, go for a walk (or do any movement you like) to generate some hope-inducing myokines and “stimulate the neurochemistry of resilience” 🙏

(#382) The Heaven, the Earth, and I

“The heaven, the earth and I share one breath, but each manages it individually.” – Lao-Tzu (as quoted in The Primordial Breath Volume I)

P.S. On weekends, I just share a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#383) Deep Rest – New Science 411

“In conclusion, contemplative practices are a powerful tool for enhancing health. Routinely practicing a contemplative technique may reduce harmful stress-related threat arousal, promote cellular-level healing and restoration, and ultimately promote positive mental and physical health.” – Crosswell et al. (2024)

That sounds good to me 🙌

This is from an excellent paper—Deep Rest: An Integrative Model of How Contemplative Practices Combat Stress and Enhance the Body’s Restorative Capacity—which I just released a Science 411 on.

This paper is unique because it doesn’t favor one approach; instead, it offers a unifying framework for understanding the benefits of all contemplative practices (slow breathing even plays a starring role).

If there were a “science mascot” for everything we study in the Learning Center, this paper would be it 😊

You can click here to read (~2 min 49 sec) or listen to the podcast version (12 min 19 sec)
<https://breathlearning.com/science-411s/crosswell-et-al-2024/>

In good breath,
Nick

(#384) Something Greater Often Emerges

“What we perceive as limitations have the potential to become strengths greater than what we had when we were ‘normal’ or unbroken...when something breaks, something greater often emerges from the cracks.” – Nnedi Okorafor

P.S. Since we missed our normal Sunday quote with the release of our latest Science 411, here’s an insightful one to enjoy and contemplate.

P.P.S. Gratitude to Gretchen Rubin for sharing this one 🙏

(#385) Creating an Awakened Brain

“Each of us is endowed with a natural capacity to perceive a greater reality and consciously connect to the life force that moves in, through, and around us. ... The awakened brain is the neural circuitry that allows us to see the world more fully and thus enhance our individual, societal, and global well-being.” – Lisa Miller, Ph.D., *The Awakened Brain*

That’s so good. And what better way to “connect to the life force that moves in, through, and around us” than through our breath?

So, let us take this as inspiration to use our breath and contemplative practices to awaken our brains so that we may access “the neural circuitry that allows us to see the world more fully and thus enhance our individual, societal, and global well-being.” 🙏

(#386) How to Get Even with Someone

“I confess to having been baffled for decades by that phrase ‘getting even.’ If you really want to get even with someone, be more forgiving; kindness exchanged for unkindness comes out even. What people call getting even is only getting odd.” – Eknath Easwaran, Original Goodness

“Kindness exchanged for unkindness comes out even.” That’s the most obvious yet surprising and life-changing observation I’ve encountered in a while.

So, when someone wrongs us, let’s remember that “What people call getting even is only getting odd.” The true way to get even is to do the opposite.

(#387) How to Get Oxygen Through Your Ears

“Moving to music even leads athletes to consume less oxygen as they exert themselves, as if the song itself supplies some of the energy they need.” – Kelly McGonigal, The Joy of Movement

This quote was part of a larger discussion, including many gems, like this one about people with diabetes: “Music redefined what their hearts were capable of.”

And this one about athletes: “Findings like this led the authors of a scientific review...to conclude that music is a legal performance-enhancing drug.”

So, the next time we need a little extra energy, let’s put on some music and let it supply supplemental oxygen through our ears 🎧

P.S. Although the type of music you choose may be different, I believe this applies while working, too 🙏

(#388) Calibrating Toward Greatness

“The objective is not to learn to mimic greatness, but to calibrate our internal meter for greatness. So we can better make the thousands of choices that might ultimately lead to our own great work.” – Rick Rubin

This is an inspiring point of view. We don't study passages from great people and teachers to try to mimic them perfectly. Instead, we do it to calibrate our internal meters so that we might ultimately create our own great work, in our own unique way, in our own unique set of life circumstances 🙏

(#389) The Purpose of the Human Brain

“The entire purpose of the human brain is to produce movement. Movement is the only way we have of interacting with the world.” – Daniel Wolpert, Ph.D.

P.S. On weekends I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate.

P.P.S. And for this one, the most fundamental of movement the brain produces for connecting with the world is the movement of air, our breathing :)

(#390) Play Like Yourself

“Sometimes you have to play a long time to be able to play like yourself.” – Miles Davis

P.S. On weekends I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

P.P.S. When I saw that one, it immediately reminded me of this gem from Buddha’s Brain:

“Paradoxically, it takes time to become what we already are.” – Rick Hanson, Ph.D.

(#391) The Most Valuable Real Estate in the World

“In my first book, *The Accidental Creative*, I recounted a meeting in which a friend asked a strange and unexpected question: ‘What do you think is the most valuable land in the world?’

Several people threw out guesses, such as Manhattan, the oil fields of the Middle East, and the gold mines of South Africa, before our friend indicated that we were way off track. He paused for a moment, and said, ‘You’re all wrong. The most valuable land in the world is the graveyard. In the graveyard are buried all of the unwritten novels, never-launched businesses, unreconciled relationships, and all of the other things that people thought, ‘I’ll get around to that tomorrow.’ One day, however, their tomorrows ran out.’” – Todd Henry, *Die Empty*

(#392) Breathed by the Atmosphere

“We are literally being breathed by the atmosphere all through the day, all through our lives. To acknowledge that we are being breathed all through our lives is an interesting prospect ... It’s reflective of a much larger principle in our lives, and that is the ability or willingness to let go of control, to accept the unknown, and allow nature to hold us. In that trust, in that acceptance, there can be found great peace and relaxation that we are ok.” – Eddie Stern, Healing Through Breathing

That’s so good. And although idyllic, it’s also immediately practical, reminding us that we are intricately connected to the world’s ecosystem. In this knowing, we can find “great peace and relaxation that we are ok.” 🙏

(#393) The Essence of Education

“As far as I’m concerned, this is the essence of education: to facilitate a person’s learning, to help that person become more in tune with his or her own resources so that he or she can use whatever is offered more fully.” – Fred Rogers

That’s a beautiful mindset to adopt in our teaching, parenting, advising, and general living.

And let’s remember the wisdom from Eknath Easwaran that “All of us maintain a free university of our own, where we teach by what we are.” This means the best way to actually help others become better in tune with their own resources is to first do it for ourselves 🙏

(#394) This is an Unalterable Law

“For hatred can never put an end to hatred; love alone can. This is an unalterable law.” – The Buddha, Translation by Eknath Easwaran

This reminds me of our TB1% on getting even: Meeting unkindness with kindness, meeting hatred with love; this is how we ‘get even’ with someone. “This is an unalterable law.”

P.S. One way to embody this wisdom is through loving-kindness meditation. We have a guided session on the practice page in the Learning Center. Colleen Loehr, MD, said, “The Breath Learning Center includes the best loving-kindness meditation I’ve ever heard.” Although I hate listening to my voice, I truly grateful for these kind words, and I hope others will find it beneficial, too.

P.P.S. I started practicing loving-kindness every day since reading A Well-Lived Life. Dr. Gladys (103 years old!) made an incredibly potent argument for the power of love, motivating me to incorporate this practice into my routine. I can’t recommend it enough.

(#395) The Most Empirically Supported Way

“The most empirically supported way that contemplative practices confer their psychological and physiological benefits is by lowering threat arousal through shifting the autonomic nervous system to parasympathetic dominance via slowed and/or regulated breathing.” Crosswell et al. (2024), *Psychological Reviews*

Of course, contemplative practices go beyond breathing. They draw upon physical, mental, and spiritual components to uniquely benefit each person who practices.

But, this is a powerful scientific statement to contemplate: “The most empirically supported way that contemplative practices confer their psychological and physiological benefits is...via slowed and/or regulated breathing.”

It reminds us that because breath is both our spirit—the essence of our being—and our direct connection to the nervous system, it plays a key role (intentionally or unintentionally) in all contemplative practice.

(#396) Better to Strive in This than Succeed in That

“It is better to strive in one’s own genuine truth than to succeed in the truth of another. Nothing is ever lost in following one’s own genuine truth.” - Bhagavad Gita

P.S. On weekends I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#397) Take Your Time – New Book 411 Now Available

“Everyone seems to be trying to fit more and more into the same fixed twenty-four hours. That is the paradox: we hurry faster and faster only to find we have less and less time.” – Eknath Easwaran

A new Book 411 was just released in the Learning Center on *Take Your Time: The Wisdom of Slowing Down* by Eknath Easwaran. (<https://breathlearning.com/book-411s/take-your-time/>)

This book was incredible, and Easwaran quickly became one of my favorite authors and teachers.

The 411 includes inspiring wisdom and practical ways to slow down, allowing us to cultivate more patience, peace, and attention so we can accomplish more than we ever have before.

I hope you enjoy it!

Click here to read or listen. (<https://breathlearning.com/book-411s/take-your-time/>)

In good breath,
Nick

P.S. I was hopped up on coffee when I recorded the audio version, which, somewhat paradoxically, was a way for me to embody my excitement about how good this book is 😂

(#398) The Best Gift We Can Give to Others

“The only thing we have to bring to community is ourselves, so the contemplative process of recovering our true selves in solitude is never selfish. It is ultimately the best gift we can give to others.” – Parker Palmer

P.S. Since we missed our usual Sunday quote yesterday, here’s a great one to enjoy and contemplate today 🙏

P.P.S. I found this in *Die Empty* by Todd Henry. I hadn’t heard of Parker Palmer, but this quote is certainly one of my new favorites.

(#399) A Tangible Reframe of 'Follow Your Passion'

“‘Passion’ has its roots in the Latin word pati, which means ‘to suffer or endure.’ Therefore, at the root of passion is suffering. ... Instead of asking ‘What would bring me enjoyment?’ which is how many people think about following their passion, we should instead ask ‘What work am I willing to suffer for today?’” – Todd Henry, *Die Empty*

“What work am I willing to suffer for today?” That’s a tangible way to reframe “follow your passion.”

Henry went on:

“Great work requires suffering for something beyond yourself. It’s created when you bend your life around a mission and spend yourself on something you deem worthy of your best effort.”

That’s so good. If it resonates with you like it did me, I hope it can help you “follow your passion” a little more this week 🙏

(#400) Breathing, Vital Energy, and Longevity

Here is an excellent, practical description of the breath-mind-longevity relationship worth contemplating:

“All creatures consume vital energy. In the ancient Hindu tradition, it is said that we come into life with a given supply of this energy, enough to power a certain number of breathing cycles. Our natural human life span, according to this view, is allotted not in calendar years but in the number of breaths we take. ...

If this theory is true, it may help to explain why these ancient sages claim a close connection between mental states and longevity. Our breathing rhythm, the measure of how fast our reserves of vital energy are being consumed, is regulated in part by our state of mind. Security, compassion, patience, forgiveness – all these are accompanied, if you observe closely, by a relatively slow breathing rhythm and heart rate. Positive states of mind like these conserve energy and lengthen the life span, leaving a reserve of resilience and resistance for facing challenges.” – Eknath Easwaran, Original Goodness

(#401) Universally Accessible, Scalable, and Cost-Free

“Breathing practices, when used in isolation, have the advantage of being universally accessible, scalable, and cost-free. They are not limited by access to healthcare services nor burdened by side effects and put potential treatment tools in the hands of the individual.” – Bentley et al. (2023), Brain Sciences

And if that’s not enough, they went on to say: “Breathing also uniquely engages in a reciprocal relationship with stress and anxiety, whereby stress and anxiety can both affect and be affected by altered respiratory patterns.”

These three sentences beautifully capture the power of the breath. Let’s use them as a reminder of the power we have with conscious breath control, and as inspiration to use that power a little bit each day to positively affect our stress and anxiety levels 🙏

(#402) A Natural Period When the Mind Grows Calm

“In the natural rhythms of life, there is a period in the junctions between night and day, in the ebb and flow between activity and rest, when the mind grows calm. If you set aside a period of quiet time early in the morning, it puts your activities into a more peaceful perspective that will stay with you all day.” – Eknath Easwaran, Take Your Time

That last sentence is powerful and has proven true in my life. But even if you're not a morning person, this can be an excellent reminder to look for the time of day when your mind naturally grows calm. Then, use that time to put everything else into a more peaceful perspective 🙏

P.S. An easy way to generate this peaceful perspective is with slow breathing, of course :)

(#403) The Ballad of Your Breathing

“When you blow a whistle or a bubble or a horn,
it is followed by an echo or a pop or a song.

Listen.

For this is the ballad of your own breathing.”

– Rebecca Kai Dotlich, *The Knowing Book*

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#404) Solid Material Wrapped Around Breath

“The body is solid material wrapped around the breath.” – Ida Rolf

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#405) Enjoying Who We Are

“In my early days of practice I hoped that it would give me a whole new personality. I’ve discovered that instead mindfulness practice has actually helped me enjoy the one I have while giving me effective tools to work with life’s inevitable challenges—tools without which I’m afraid I’d really be in bad shape.” – Ronald Siegel, Psy.D., *The Mindfulness Solution*

Here’s a nice reminder that breathing, mindfulness, yoga—any contemplative practice, really—are not necessarily about changing who we are. Instead, they allow us to enjoy who we are while, fortunately, giving us ways to work with and grow through life’s challenges. 🙏

P.S. This idea brings to mind this excellent (and humorous) quote from Zen master Suzuki Roshi: “Each of you is perfect the way you are ... and you can use a little improvement.”

(#406) Smell the Flowers; Blow Out the Candles

“Just as emotions like worry and fear can trigger the body’s stress response, what we experience physically in the body can affect our emotions. Because of this, we can often begin to quiet our worries and calm the symptoms of anxiety simply by controlling one critical body function: breathing.” – Jennifer Tucker, *Breath as Prayer* <https://amzn.to/3Kox15r>

This is a simple yet powerful reminder of just how effective the breath is for dealing with stress and anxiety.

And Tucker provides simple instructions to get started: “Smell the flowers; blow out the candles.” Breathe in through your nose, into your abdomen, as if smelling flowers. Then, exhale through pursed lips as if blowing out candles.

Use it as needed today 🙏

(#407) Then Tomorrow Has to Be Good

I've read lots of (and spent a lot of time on) methods and "hacks" to make tomorrow good, like limiting screen time at night, getting sun at the right time, meal timing, making my room colder, slow breathing before sleep, and on and on. They all seem to help in some capacity.

But here's another approach that is not science-based, yet probably works best of all:

"If you live today completely in love—hating no one, hurting no one, serving all—then tomorrow has to be good, whatever comes." – Eknath Easwaran

So, my new goal is to use my breath and wisdom practices to live that sentence daily (even if only for a few minutes at a time—baby steps, lol). I hope you'll join me 🙏

(#408) Specific Breath Pace May Not Matter

“Our analysis further suggests that, provided fast-only practices are avoided, specific breath pace may not matter, as effectiveness was not associated with pace when fast-only practices were excluded.” – Bentley et al. (2023)

This was one of the (many) neat results in the study published by the Health and Human Performance Foundation.

One practical thing it suggests is that slow breathing techniques reduce stress and anxiety regardless of the precise pace used. This gives us the freedom to choose a slow pace that suits us best— with or without pauses, equal ratio or extended exhales—and still be confident in its effectiveness.

This is a perfect example of how we can apply modern science to help us maximize effectiveness while maintaining personal autonomy 🙏

(#409) The Wise Shape Their Lives

“As irrigators guide water to their fields, as archers aim arrows, as carpenters carve wood, the wise shape their lives.” – The Buddha

I believe this is what we achieve through mindful breathing and reading timeless wisdom and modern science. But for our approach, I think pottery provides an even better analogy:

Slow breathing calms the mind and nervous system, much like adding water to clay to make it malleable.

Reading timeless wisdom and science allows us to shape our lives into what we want.
Real-life practice hardens this shaping into our very being.

Here's to shaping a few beautiful pieces, today 🙏

(#410) Foster a Calm Spirit

“If you would foster a calm spirit, first regulate your breathing; for when that is under control, the heart will be at peace.” — Kariba Ekken

(#411) Practical Breathing Guidelines – New Science 411

“This knowledge can and should provide a sense of freedom for individual practitioners and program developers alike in tailoring programs to meet their needs for stress reduction effectiveness.” – Bentley et al. (2023) <https://breathlearning.com/science-411s/bentley-et-al-2023/>

A new Science 411 was just released in the Learning Center, which accomplishes precisely what that sentence says. Because of its thoroughness and practicality, I think this may be the most important breath-focused study to date.

It’s so important that I will make this Science 411 free for everyone tomorrow.

Thanks to the Health and Human Performance Foundation for the enormous amount of time you spent to do this research and publish the paper 🙏

I hope you enjoy the new 411!

Click here to read or listen. <https://breathlearning.com/science-411s/bentley-et-al-2023/>

In good breath,
Nick

P.S. One caveat: I am super biased because I love HHPF. I used to volunteer for them, and before all this mindfulness and timeless wisdom made me soft (😂😂😂), I rucked 100 miles to raise support for them. (<https://black-sand-yoga.com/learn-1/2020/6/7/walking-100-miles-a-story-of-how-chronic-disease-makes-us-stronger>)

(#412) No Coincidence

“That oxygen, life, and lungs all came into our world in relatively close succession is no coincidence. Only with oxygen and some means of extracting it are all things possible—thinking, moving, eating, speaking, and loving. Life and the breath are synonymous.” –Michael J. Stephen, MD

P.S. Just an excellent quote (that becomes more insightful the more times I read it) to enjoy and contemplate to start the week 🙏

(#413) Warm-Up Exercise for Your Mind

“The purpose of warm-up exercises is to keep the body supple so that you do not strain a muscle. If you go out to run when your body is stiff, every muscle will complain... Similarly, if you try to work with difficult people - including yourself - when your mind is stiff, you are bound to get tense. Your patience may snap; your digestive organs may go on strike. ... Meditation is warm-up exercise for the mind, so that you can jog through the rest of the day without getting agitated or spraining your patience.” – Eknath Easwaran, Conquest of Mind

That’s an excellent analogy and reminder to warm up our minds with breathing and/or meditation each morning. It doesn’t 100% guarantee we won’t pull an emotional muscle, but it does lower our chances 😊

(#414) Where Much of Our Pain Comes From

“Some pain and illness is unavoidable, and some can be prevented with thought and care. A remarkable amount of pain and illness, however, is actually caused by our attempts to get rid of it. Like the psychological difficulties we’ve been discussing, a lot of physical disorders result unwittingly from our efforts to avoid unpleasant experience... Stress—our reaction to things we don’t like—is at the heart of all of these problems.” - Ronald Siegel, Psy.D., The Mindfulness Solution <https://amzn.to/3Wdg7hr>

That’s a humbling reminder that, because pain is part of life, we often cause ourselves more pain by thinking we shouldn’t have pain. (That’s a philosophical tongue twister, lol.)

One helpful tool: Mindfulness, which allows us to observe physical or psychological pain more clearly and break this stress cycle 🙏

(#415) Five Minutes

“The lack of significant association between effectiveness and session durations ≥ 5 min indicates that any session duration beyond 5 min can be effective...simply engaging in a breathing practice provides benefits, with sessions as short as 5 min yielding comparable benefits to longer sessions.” – Bentley et al. (2023) (<https://breathlearning.com/science-411s/bentley-et-al-2023/>)

This was the most surprising yet welcome result of this excellent paper: We only need five minutes of breath practice to see significant improvements in stress and anxiety.

Of course, longer sessions can have different psychological and physiological effects. But if our only goal is stress reduction (or we are just short on time), we can feel reasonably confident that even five minutes will make a meaningful difference in our day 🙏

(#416) Meditation as Important as Medicine

“Training the mind to stay steady brings another precious benefit: it protects us from the physiological impact of negative emotions and stress.

There is plenty of evidence today to suggest that destructive mental states like anger, depression, anxiety, and resentment have a serious impact on physical health. The medical sciences have made tremendous strides in the past century, yet I have no doubt that meditation will prove as important as medicine in keeping the body well.” – Eknath Easwaran, Original Goodness

Considering that this book was first published in 1989, we can now confirm that Easwaran’s prediction was well-founded. (Some doctors even “prescribe” meditation for stress nowadays 😊)

So, let’s use this passage as a reminder that training the mind (through practices like meditation and breathing) may be as important as medicine in protecting “us from the physiological impact of negative emotions and stress.” 🙏

(#417) How to Not Die

“If you don’t want to die, don’t be born.” — Larry Rosenberg

P.S. On weekends, I just send an insightful (and—like today—sometimes lighthearted 😊) quote for you to enjoy and contemplate.

(#418) It's What You Do in Life That's Important

“All people, no matter who they are, they all wish they had appreciated life more. It's what you do in life that's important, not how much time you have or what you wish you'd done.” – David Bowie

P.S. On weekends, I just send an insightful quote for you to enjoy and contemplate.

P.P.S. Thanks to Eddie Stern for sharing this one 🙏

(#419) A Contest of Wisdom in Ancient Greece

“There was a contest of wisdom one time in ancient Greece to find who could write down a sentence which would somehow always be true. The sentence that won the competition was ‘This too will pass.’” - John O’Donohue, *Walking in Wonder*

I don’t know if there was actually a contest of wisdom (it seems a bit paradoxical, lol). But this passage is a nice way to deliver the insight of this cliché but timeless statement. Good or bad, mundane or exciting, they all will pass.

P.S. This could also probably be the one sentence that is always true of any mindfulness program 😊

(#420) Slow Breathing a Type of Positive Stress

“Slow breathing is, in fact, a type of positive stress in and of itself, because you are making an autonomic function of your body intentional...sometimes, as you might notice, your nervous system might resist a little to the changes you are suggesting, because it is not used to being told what to do.” – Eddie Stern, Healing Through Breathing

I’ve never heard of slow breathing being a positive stressor, but I love this concept, and its explanation makes perfect sense.

So, the next time we teach slow breathing or rediscover it for ourselves, let’s remember that we’re taking control of an automatic function: “When you take over, there can be some internal tension.” However, as Eddie also says, that tension “will melt away with time, practice, patience, and a gentle approach to slow breathing.” 🙏

(#421) A Poor Host for Disease

“...this is one of the grandest secrets of health.

Research evidence today suggests that emotional immunity to negative states of mind may well be linked to physical immunity, even resistance to disease. A person who is even minded, who doesn't get shaken if people speak ill of him or excited when they praise her to the skies – such a person, I submit, is a poor host for disease.” – Eknath Easwaran, Original Goodness

How good is that? Of course, it doesn't mean we'll never get sick or that all our ailments will suddenly go away. But, if we can learn to be even minded—to not get shaken by life's rough patches nor too excited by its upswings—we can at least become “a poor host for disease.” 🙏

(#422) Blessings in Disguise

“Collectively, these examples prove that setbacks resulting in the loss of physical capacity, be it temporary or permanent, present an opportunity to make compensatory physical gains through the workaround effect and to become mentally fitter. Major injuries, minor injuries, sickness, starting over after time away from training, getting older—these hated setbacks and others are all potential blessings in disguise.” – Matt Fitzgerald, How Bad Do You Want It?
(<https://breathlearning.com/book-411s/how-bad-do-you-want-it/>)

Do you have any setbacks you’re facing, mental or physical? (If you’re a normal human like me, I’m guessing the answer is yes 😊)

Here’s a great reminder from endurance sports expert Matt Fitzgerald that these are “an opportunity to make compensatory physical gains...and to become mentally fitter.” All the setbacks we hate are potential blessings in disguise 🙏

(#423) We Have a Short Exposure

“We should never forget that death is waiting for us. A man in Connemara said one time to a friend of mine, Beidh muid sínte siar, a dúirt sé, cúig mhilliúin bliain déag faoin chré— we’ll be lying down in the earth for about fifteen million years, and we have a short exposure. I feel that when you recognize that death is on its way, it is a great liberation, because it means that you can in some way feel the call to live everything that is within you.” – John O’Donohue, *Walking in Wonder*

This is a wonderful reminder that we only have a short exposure to life. When we keep this reality close to heart, “it is a great liberation, because it means that you can in some way feel the call to live everything that is within you.” 🙏

(#424) May the Relief of This Rinse Your Soul

“Like the joy of the sea coming home to shore,
May the relief of laughter rinse through your
soul.” – John O’Donohue, For Equilibrium

P.S. On weekends, I just share a memorable quote to enjoy and contemplate (and in this case, practice every chance you get 😊)

(#425) The Mindfulness Solution – New Book 411

“So through mindfulness, we make healthier, wiser decisions (and minimize the pain of doing the opposite) because we’re more sensitive to the subtle effects of those decisions.”

We have a new Book 411 available: The Mindfulness Solution by Ronald Siegel, Psy.D. This was a great book on mindfulness and meditation, which also happened to have one of the most insightful quotes on breathing I’ve come across (see below). I hope you enjoy the 411!

[Click here to read or listen.](#)

In good breath,
Nick

P.S. Here’s the breath quote: “At this very moment billions of oxygen atoms are changing identity from being ‘the air’ to being ‘you.’”

And here was another insight gem from it: “We usually try to feel better by decreasing the intensity of painful experiences; in mindfulness practice, we work instead to increase our capacity to bear them.”

(#426) Wherever You Find Yourself

“The breath accompanies you the full length of life’s road: you learn about the body, feelings, mental formations, the mind itself, and, finally, the lawfulness of impermanence and emptiness of a substantial self.” – Larry Rosenberg, *Three Steps to Awakening*

This is a wonderful reminder of the far-reaching utility of the breath. No matter what you’re currently interested in—the body, emotions, the mind, the self—the breath can be a metaphor or direct tool for studying it. As you change, the breath changes with you.

As Rosenberg reminds us: “Wherever you find yourself, the breath is present.” This applies both literally and symbolically 🙏

(#427) A Different Kind of Conservation

“Today, when we talk of conservation, the assumption is that we’re talking about trying to save sea turtles, old buildings, endangered ecosystems, electricity, and so on. But we don’t think enough about a more internal conservation, conserving our attention for what matters, conserving our engagement for what’s important, conserving our acuity for decisions that make a positive difference. If you don’t know what you want to save, you can’t know how to save it.”
– Wallace J Nichols, Blue Mind

That’s so powerful, and it’s exactly what time around water and nature (Blue Mind) and breathing and meditation help us with: “conserving our attention for what matters, conserving our engagement for what’s important, conserving our acuity for decisions that make a positive difference.”

So, here’s to cultivating more inner conservation, today 🙏

(#428) Carving an Internal Canyon

“Rather, I think the power of breathwork to change the function of the nervous system can be compared to the way water cuts a canyon through rock. It’s the constant stimulus, the constant pressure, that produces huge changes, so that what appears to be a very gentle force produces very large results.” – Andrew Weil, MD, *Breathing: The Master Key to Self Healing*

This is one of the best analogies for understanding the power of breathing (slow breathing, in particular). One session is nice and will help us feel better. But it’s the constant pressure that generates meaningful change, “so that what appears to be a very gentle force produces very large results.” 🙌

Here’s to cutting through a little bit of our internal rock, today.

(#429) A Small Evolutionary Step

Our brains evolved to help us survive, which often backfires in today's world. For example, Steven Kotler says our brains notice about eight bad things for every one good thing we take in 🤖

Although disheartening, there is another side we often forget: practices also evolved to offset these unfavorable habits. As Ronald Siegel, Psy.D., tells us:

“Mindfulness is one of these practices. It developed through thousands of years of cultural evolution as an antidote to the natural habits of our hearts and minds that make life much more difficult than it needs to be.”

So, every time we practice mindfulness today, becoming aware and accepting of the moment, we are taking a small evolutionary step toward a more resilient and grateful society 🙏

(#430) Sound of Breath

“Petr Janata...is a cognitive neuroscientist and expert on music in the brain. He theorizes that the low frequency of the sound of water, coupled with its rhythmic nature, is similar to the frequency and rhythm of human breath. Sound, Janata contends, ‘affects our brain and influences our emotions. If I ask you to close your eyes and turn on a recording of the ocean, I can change your mood immediately.’” – Wallace J Nichols, Blue Mind

One way to take advantage of this is to listen to the sound of water during your breathing or meditation practice. It’s a simple & effective way to combine your actual breath with the sound of water, which is “similar to the frequency and rhythm of human breath.” 🌊

P.S. I’ve been doing this every morning since reading this book—almost two years now—and love it. It’s a peaceful way to bring nature indoors 😊

(#431) Much of Our Well-Being or Misery

“As long as our basic needs are met, much of our well-being or misery has more to do with how we interpret our situation than with the situation itself.” – Ronald Siegel, Psy.D.

P.S. On weekends, I just share a memorable quote to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#432) A Drop in the Ocean

“A drop in the ocean partakes of the greatness of its parent, although it is unconscious of it. But it is dried up as soon as it enters upon an existence independent of the ocean. . . .” –
Gandhi

P.S. On weekends, I just share a memorable quote to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#433) Making One's Life a Meditation

“Making one’s life into a meditation is different from using meditation to escape from life.” – Mark Epstein, MD, Advice Not Given

Of course, I’m not opposed to using meditation to escape from life—it’s better than many of the other options out there 😊

But I believe this is the ultimate goal: to allow our practice and the wisdom we read here every day to seep into our consciousness so that our entire life is an embodiment of our practice.

Here’s to inching toward that a little more, today 🙏

(#434) Flowers and Puzzle Pieces

“When a flower doesn’t bloom, you fix the environment in which it grows, not the flower.” - Alexander Den Heijer

I love this, and it reminds me of wisdom we shared from 103-year-old Gladys McGarey, MD, in TB1% #315 (<https://breathlearning.com/the-breathing-1/number-315/>):

“I like thinking of us as puzzle pieces because it gives us each space to be unique. We’re not supposed to be shaped this way or that; we’re supposed to be shaped precisely as we are, because that way we can fit together.”

If a puzzle piece isn’t fitting somewhere, we don’t try to change it; we simply keep looking for where it fits. Likewise, we don’t fix the flower; we fix its environment.

We’d be wise to apply this to ourselves more often... 😊

(#435) Homestead in the Most Remote of Woods

“For healing, what is required is much more sweeping: not only changes in lifestyle but changes in thought-style. You can eat a perfectly balanced diet, sleep at night on the lullaby of a waterbed, and homestead in the most remote of woods, but if your thoughts do not obey you, you will still be subject to stress.” – Eknath Easwaran, Original Goodness
(<https://amzn.to/3zhaRA1>)

That last sentence is so good. And although I don’t think we can ever have all our thoughts “obey us,” I do think we can slowly change our thought-style to be more in line with the people we want to become through breathing, meditation, and these short readings.

Here’s to inching a little closer to that ideal, today 🙏

(#436) There, I have Pacified Your Mind

This passage comes from Advice Not Given (<https://amzn.to/4bgVept>). It's a Zen story about Bodhidharma, who brought Buddhism to China, and Huike, who was intent on learning from him:

"The heart of the story is as follows:

Huike says to Bodhidharma, when finally given a chance to speak to him directly, 'My mind is anxious. Please pacify it.'

To which Bodhidharma replies, 'Bring me your mind, and I will pacify it.'

Huike says, 'Although I've sought it, I cannot find it.'

Bodhidharma then says, 'There, I have pacified your mind.'"

(#437) It Has No Counterpart in English

“In an ancient language from India called Pali, there's a term, ‘mudita,’ which seems like the opposite of envy, because it means ‘to delight in the good fortunes or the accomplishments of others.’ (Interestingly, it has no counterpart in English.)” – Paul Jarvis, Company of One

Mudita. What a neat word and idea. From my experience, this is something that we naturally cultivate through breathing and contemplative practice. We become so comfortable with who we are that we unconsciously take delight in the fortunes of others (I’m sure all the brain and nervous system changes contribute to this, too 😊).

So, here’s to a little less envy and a little more mudita, today 🙏

(#438) There is an Old Saying

“There is an old saying: ‘People will blame you if you say too much; they will blame you if you say too little; they will blame you if you say just enough.’” – The Buddha

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#439) The Unconscious? Mystery? Love and Light?

“Concentration is a channel into something we do not have exact words for. The unconscious? Mystery? The imagination? Love and light? It is tempting to turn whatever it is into something more concrete than we can actually apprehend.” – Mark Epstein, MD

(#440) Finding Humor in It

“The next time you find yourself doing something embarrassing, I encourage you to try to think about how it could be seen as funny. What about your mistake is humorous? What was surprising, silly, or just plain ridiculous? How would someone on the outside see it, and why might they laugh? You’ll be surprised by how often a humorous interpretation is available if you only go looking for it.” – Gladys McGarey, MD, *The Well-Lived Life*

I’ve shared this practice before. But since I use it literally every day, I often think, “I should reshare that one.” So, here we are 😊

And here is a more succinct way of putting it, attributed to writer and cartoonist Frank A. Clark: “I think the next best thing to solving a problem is finding some humor in it.” Amen to that.

(#441) Emulating Positive Attributes

“We need to rekindle our ability to emulate the positive attributes of those we admire in others, and apply those same attributes to our life and work. When we are conscious of the qualities we want to emulate, they become points of traction to help us coordinate our daily activities...” – Todd Henry, *Die Empty*

Given my obsession with learning from others, it’s likely not a surprise to you that I love this :
) However, it was the following paragraph that made it concrete and life-changing:

“However, this is more challenging than simply plucking desirable qualities out of thin air. You want to choose attributes to emulate that will help you become more of who you are, not more of who they are. ... The goal is to recognize the things you admire about others so that you can tap into those qualities, and so begin to tap into your own ethic.”



(#442) Respiratory Therapy for the Treatment of Anxiety – New Science 411

“This indicates that respiratory interventions may offer a promising anxiety intervention approach in psychiatric and non-psychiatric samples who do not have access to, are unwilling to engage in, or have not experienced symptom alleviation from other gold-standard interventions. Moreover, respiratory interventions are highly disseminable and can easily be incorporated into primary care settings, and/or administered remotely.” – Leyro et al. (2021)

A new Science 411 on this great paper, ***Respiratory therapy for the treatment of anxiety: meta-analytic review and regression***, was just released in the Learning Center.

Click here to read or listen to the 411. (<https://breathlearning.com/science-411s/leyro-et-al-2021/>)

I hope you enjoy it!

In good breath,
Nick

(#443) What Makes Our Heart Sing

“Each of us came here to do something. And as I see it, true health has nothing to do with diagnosing a disease or prolonging life just for the sake of it; it’s about finding out who we are, paying attention to how we’re called to grow and change, and listening to what makes our heart sing.” – Gladys McGarey, MD (103 years old), *The Well-Lived Life*

I may be biased 😊, but I believe there are no better tools for “listening to what makes our heart sing” than slow breathing and meditation. By cultivating a calm body and clear mind, they help us discover who we are and, quite literally, help us pay attention to how we’re called to grow.

So here’s to doing a little more of that, today 🙏

P.S. I’d also add walking—or any exercise you enjoy—to that list, too.

(#444) Still Another Trick, the Rascal!

Here is Eknath Easwaran discussing mind wandering during meditation:
(<https://amzn.to/3xTa2gh>)

“But when the door has opened, when the mind has jumped in its sports car and sped away, when you find yourself in a dress shop or a bookstore or at the beach, act promptly. Go up and tap the mind gently on the shoulder. It will probably cringe and say, ‘You’re furious with me, aren’t you?’

Still another trick, the rascal! It actually wants you to become angry and start scolding, because then it won’t have to return to the passage.”

That’s amazing. The mind “actually wants you to become angry and start scolding, because then it won’t have to return” to whatever you’re concentrating on. This applies not only to meditation, but to any kind of focus: at work, with family and friends, etc.

Let’s not let the mind win 😊

(#445) Only These Difficulties are Unconquerable

“Real difficulties can be overcome; it is only the imaginary ones that are unconquerable.” – Theodore N. Vail

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#446) Widening Our Circle and the Foundation of Inner Security

“Our task must be to free ourselves from this prison by widening our circle of compassion to embrace all living creatures and the whole of nature in its beauty. Nobody is able to achieve this completely, but the striving for such an achievement is in itself a part of the liberation and a foundation for inner security.” – Albert Einstein

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#447) As Concentration Increases

“As concentration increases, the mind and body relax. Thoughts diminish, emotional pressures weaken, and a kind of calm takes over. The mind gradually comes under some degree of control and settles down.” - Mark Epstein, MD, *Advice Not Given* (<https://amzn.to/4eQABDr>)

That’s a wonderful (and somewhat paradoxical) reminder that when we *exert cognitive effort* to concentrate on something—our breath, a mantra, movement, and so on—the opposite occurs: “thoughts diminish, emotional pressures weaken, and a kind of calm takes over.”

Seems worth the “effort” to me 😊

(#448) Some Rules Are Meant to Be Broken: 'You are still carrying her'

Here's a Buddhist story (I found in *Advice Not Given*) of two monks crossing a river:

"The two men come upon a young woman who is having trouble getting to the opposite shore. One of the monks, despite his vows to never touch a woman, picks her up and deposits her on the other side of the water. As they continue on their way, the other monk, the one who has kept his vows and not touched her, can't stop chastising his overly benevolent friend.

'How could you do that?' he asks. 'You know touching a woman is against our vows. And you were *holding* her.'

'I put her down long ago,' replies the first monk. 'You are still carrying her.'"

(#449) The Five L's

I came across an interview where Dr. Gladys McGarey, author of probably my favorite book, *The Well-Lived Life* (<https://breathlearning.com/book-411s/the-well-lived-life/>), was asked: "What's your life philosophy?"

Her response:

"I've come up with the Five Ls. The first two are 'life' and 'love', and one can't exist without the other. The third is laughter. Laughter without love is cold and cruel. Laughter with love is joy and happiness. The fourth is Labour – labour without love is drudgery. Labour with love is bliss – it's why painters paint, why singers sing. The fifth 'L' is Listening. Listening without love is empty sound. With love, it's understanding."

The Five Ls: Life, Love, Laughter, Labour, and Listening <--That's so good. Let's pick our favorite (I'm going with laughter) to focus on today 🙏

(#450) Breathing in Is a Spiritual Practice

“With mindfulness, you breathe in, and there you are, well established in the here and the now. Breathing in, touching your full aliveness, is a spiritual practice. Every one of us is capable of breathing in mindfully. I breathe in, and I know I am breathing in—that’s the practice of mindful breathing.” – Thich Nhat Hanh, *Peace is Every Breath* (<https://breathlearning.com/book-411s/peace-is-every-breath/>)

“Breathing in, touching your full aliveness, is a spiritual practice.” That’s so good. It reminded me of something similar that Rick Rubin shared:

“Taken more spiritually, inspiration means to breathe life into. An ancient interpretation defines it as the immediate influence of the divine.”

So, this is just our reminder that at any moment, we can experience the “immediate influence of the divine” by practicing mindfulness of breathing 🙏

(#451) Flourishing Under Stress

“But as stress researchers realize, full health is more than just the absence of disease. It means a dynamic harmony of body and mind which allows us to live at our full physical, emotional, and spiritual potential. ... Instead of trying simply to survive stress, we should aim at flourishing under it, making use of anything life brings.” – Eknath Easwaran, Original Goodness

And the best way to flourish under stress? It’s to shift our perspective from a “threat response” to a “challenge response.” When we view strenuous events as challenging rather than stressful, “bodily responses may actually be enhanced.” And happily, this is precisely what breathing and meditation train our minds to do, gradually shifting our perspective so we may flourish under stress 🙏

(#452) All Life Needs to Move

“All life needs to move. Life itself is always in movement, so aligning with our life force means that we must always look for the flow within us.” – Gladys McGarey, MD

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

P.P.S. I might be biased, but what better way to look for the flow within us than with conscious breathing.

(#453) Better Friends with Everybody

“Joyfulness keeps the heart and face young. A good laugh makes us better friends with ourselves and everybody around us.” – Orison Swett Marden

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#454) What “Mindfulness” Means

“First used in an English translation of a Buddhist text in 1881 at the height of the British colonization of South Asia, the term ‘mindfulness’ came into general acceptance in the Western world thereafter. But the term is a Western invention. The original word in the language of the Buddha’s time was sati. Sati means remembering. Right Mindfulness—or Right Sati—means remembering to keep an eye on oneself.” – Mark Epstein, MD, *Advice Not Given* (<https://amzn.to/3LlpzbN>)

“Remembering to keep an eye on oneself.” That’s a beautiful (and super practical) definition of mindfulness.

So here’s to using our breath and daily reading as a way of doing just that, so we can continually inch toward our unique version of a well-lived life 🙏

(#455) You Become More and More You

“The film director David Lynch formulated it most compellingly when he told me ‘The thing about meditation is, you become more and more you.’ So you should not have the slightest concern about meditating in ways that suit you and are to your liking.” - Steven Laureys, MD, The No-Nonsense Meditation Book (<https://amzn.to/48GsLsL>)

That’s worth repeating: “‘The thing about meditation is, you become more and more you.’ So you should not have the slightest concern about meditating in ways that suit you and are to your liking.” That applies perfectly to breathing exercises, too.

With that in mind, we might ask, ‘How could I tailor my breathing or meditation practice to better suit my unique self?’ Remember: it’s about becoming more of who we are, not more of someone else.

(#456) Urgent Diligence

“Brilliant work is forged by those who consistently approach their days with urgency and diligence. Urgency means leveraging your finite resources (focus, assets, time, energy) in a meaningful and productive way. Diligence means sharpening your skills and conducting your work in a manner that you won’t regret later. When you adopt the mind-set of urgent diligence, you’ll pour all of who you are into your days, and subsequently you’ll find that the unique value you bring to the world comes more clearly into focus.” – Todd Henry, *Die Empty*
(<https://amzn.to/3zISQuH>)

Here’s to crafting urgent diligence through our daily breathing and/or meditation practice, which simultaneously reminds us of our impermanence (cultivating urgency) while honing our ability to focus our minds (nurturing diligence) so we can forge the brilliant work of living a well-lived life



Extra Email: Original Goodness – New Book 411

“When all hostility, all resentment, all greed and fear and insecurity are erased from your mind, the state that remains is pure joy. When we become established in that state, we live in joy always. ... There, the mystics of all religions agree, we uncover our original goodness.” – Eknath Easwaran, Original Goodness

A new Book 411 one is now available for you on Original Goodness: A Commentary on the Beatitudes

Although I’m nowhere near the state of consciousness described above (and maybe never will be 😊), this book was filled with practical and inspiring wisdom on how to live better. Some of it even related directly back to our breathing rate (see Thought #4).

I hope you enjoy the 411!

[Click here to read or listen.](#)

In good breath,
Nick

(#457) Mental Mountain Slopes

“There is a beautiful description of mental inclination in some ancient texts. They compare it to mountain slopes. When the ground is sloped in a certain way, water flows effortlessly according to the direction of inclination. Similarly, when the mind is inclined in a certain way, thoughts and emotions happen effortlessly according to the nature of its inclination. If the mind is inclined toward joy, for example, then joyful thoughts and feelings tend to occur effortlessly.” - Chade-Meng Tan, Joy On Demand

I love this metaphor, and it is one of the best results of breathing and meditation practices (and these daily emails): We slowly change the slopes of our minds toward things that bring us closer to our true nature 🙏

(#458) Embracing (and highlighting) Imperfections

“In Japanese pottery, there’s an artful form of repair called kintsugi. When a piece of ceramic pottery breaks, rather than trying to restore it to its original condition, the artisan accentuates the fault by using gold to fill the crack. This beautifully draws attention to where the work was broken, creating a golden vein. Instead of the flaw diminishing the work, it becomes a focal point, an area of both physical and aesthetic strength. The scar also tells the story of the piece, chronicling its past experience.

We can apply this same technique to ourselves and embrace our imperfections. Whatever insecurities we have can be reframed as a guiding force in our creativity. They only become a hindrance when they prevent our ability to share what’s closest to our heart.” – Rick Rubin, *The Creative Act*



(#459) Mastering the Art of Living

“If you can laugh it off when things go against you while still giving your very best, you are mastering the art of living.” – Eknath Easwaran

P.S. On weekends, I just share a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#460) Are We There Yet?

“It's a mistake to think too much about the goal and to ask too often about it. I was happy on those hikes with my parents. ... Happy until the moment when I started asking how much farther it was.” – Erling Kagge

P.S. On weekends, I just share a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#461) Patience Means Slow Deep Breathing

“Patience means slow, deep breathing; impatience means poor lungs and irregular breathing. ... When you are patient, all the vital processes work smoothly.” – Eknath Easwaran, Passage Meditation (<https://amzn.to/4feNsQj>)

That sounds like a good enough reason to practice patience to me 😊 But let’s not forget that it’s a two-way street. When we practice slow, deep breathing, we create conditions that support being calmer and more patient, which will help us live better in the chaos of life.

(#462) Paradise Is Here or Nowhere

“Happiness does not depend so much upon our being favorably environed as upon the slope of our mind.

It is not enough to extract happiness from ideal conditions; any one can do that. But it is the self-mastered, the self-poised soul who can get happiness out of the most inhospitable surroundings. ‘Paradise is here or nowhere. You must take your joy with you or you will never find it.’” - Orison Swett Marden, *The Joys of Living* (<https://amzn.to/3zS8Wck>)

This reminded me of the famous quote, “The only Zen you find at the top of a mountain is the Zen you bring there.”

It’s a great reminder of why we use breathing, reading, and meditation to train our minds: so we can bring our own Zen and contentment everywhere we go 🙏

(#463) Shaping Our Brain Activity

“We can shape our brain activity and habitual states of stress arousal by changing the signals the brain is getting from the body. We can engineer a bodily experience that sends “corrective” signals to the brain, which shapes interoceptive cues, which in turn shapes how we feel right now. In other words, if we increase all the cues and conditions that tell our body we are safe, we are comfortable, there is nothing to do right now but relax, that’s a strong formula to start with.”
– Elissa Epel, Ph.D., The Stress Prescription

This is where the power of voluntary slow breathing comes in. It cues the brain that we are safe and have nothing to do but relax. This reduces threat arousal, allowing for peace and deep rest.

Make sure you take advantage of this wonderful gift 🙏

(#464) Let Go of the Banana

“They say that in India there is a particularly clever way of catching monkeys. As the story goes, hunters will cut a hole in a coconut that is just big enough for a monkey to put its hand through. Then they will drill two smaller holes in the other end, pass a wire through, and secure the coconut to the base of a tree. Then they slip a banana inside the coconut through the hole and hide. The monkey comes down, puts his hand in, and takes hold of the banana. The hole is cleverly crafted so that the open hand can go in but the fist cannot get out. All the monkey has to do to be free is to let go of the banana. But it seems most monkeys don’t let go.” – Jon Kabat-Zinn, Full Catastrophe Living (<https://amzn.to/3Si8yDz>)

Today’s 1%: Got any metaphorical bananas you need to let go of?

(#465) Born a Twin

“Happiness was born a twin, and only he who seeks another’s good, another’s welfare, another’s happiness, can find his own.” - Orison Swett Marden, *The Joys of Living* (published in 1913)

How good is that for some old-school wisdom for living better? This might be the most practical (and believable) path to happiness I’ve come across 😊

(#466) In Every Cell of Your Body

“Your mind is in every cell of your body.” – Candace Pert

P.S. On Weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#467) Just as We Were Born to Breathe Air

“Just as our bodies are born to breathe air, we are born to love. That’s why although it’s good to address our fear, it’s even better to focus on our love. Any effort we put toward love—truly, any effort at all—will self-perpetuate, bringing joy, health, and well-being into our lives.” – Gladys McGarey, MD (103 years old)

P.S. On Weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

P.P.S. Check out Thought #3 in our latest 411 on Original Goodness for more wisdom on this topic.

(#468) You Are on the Other Side

Here's a fun (and illuminating) story to start the week:

"One day a young Buddhist on his journey home came to the banks of a wide river. Staring hopelessly at the great obstacle in front of him, he pondered for hours on just how to cross such a wide barrier. Just as he was about to give up his pursuit to continue his journey he saw a great teacher on the other side of the river.

The young Buddhist yells over to the teacher, 'Oh wise one, can you tell me how to get to the other side of this river?'

The teacher ponders for a moment looks up and down the river and yells back, 'My son, you are on the other side!'"

(#469) A Purposeful, Generous, and Grateful Life

“Life is movement, and our breath keeps us going every minute of the day until we die, without us having to do anything about it. To bring awareness to that, and to begin to harness that power of movement towards understanding who we are, why we are here, and what we should be doing to live a purposeful, generous, grateful life, is all part of the practice of pranayama.” – Eddie Stern, Healing Through Breathing

How good is that? And it is also precisely what we’re doing in the Learning Center: Bringing awareness to the life-giving gift of breathing so we can direct it toward “understanding who we are, why we are here, and what we should be doing to live a purposeful, generous, grateful life.”

Consider taking a moment to reflect on just that, today 🙏

(#470) Maybe Death Is That Way Too

Here is an enlightening perspective shift on dying that's worth contemplating:

"If you could interview a baby in the womb, a baby that was about to be born, and the baby asked you what is going to happen to it and you said, 'You are going to go through a very dark channel. You are going to be pushed out. You are going to arrive into a vacant world of open air and light. The cord that connects you to your mother is going to be cut. You are going to be on your own forevermore, and regardless of how close you come to another, you will never belong in the way you have been able to belong here.' The baby would have no choice but to conclude that it was going to die! Maybe death is that way too." – John O'Donohue, *Walking in Wonder*

(#471) It's Not During Meditation

“Surprisingly, it is not during meditation that you make progress in meditation; it is during the rest of the day. What you do in meditation is get the power, install the dynamo; the actual work is done after you open your eyes, get up, and go out into the world.” Eknath Easwaran, Passage Meditation (<https://amzn.to/3A5eiKy>)

What an amazing reminder that, ultimately, the way we make progress in meditation (or breathing) is by bringing the results into the world. It's in how we carry that calm, attentive, and perhaps even joyful state into our everyday activities that truly matters.

And, most importantly, it's in how we remember to laugh at ourselves when we completely miss that target (this happens to me a lot 😂), as this is also a sign of progress 🙏

(#472) A “Subtle Fluid” that Washes the Brain (it’s not glymphatic or CSF related)

“There seems to be a subtle fluid from humor and fun which penetrates the entire being, bathes all the mental faculties, and washes out the brain-ash and debris from exhausted cerebrum and muscles.” – Orison Swett Marden, The Joys of Living (<https://amzn.to/4cdeDYO>)

This is just our reminder to enjoy some humor and fun this weekend to wash out “the brain-ash and debris” from our minds and muscles so we can refresh all our cognitive faculties 🙏

(#473) Controls Its Own Excitability

“The brain, by regulating breathing, controls its own excitability.” – Journal of Physiology (1988)
(<https://physoc.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/epdf/10.1113/jphysiol.1988.sp016961>)

P.S. On Weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#474) Your Mind Knows Only Some Things

“Your mind knows only some things. Your inner voice, your instinct, knows everything.” - Henry Winkler

P.S. On Weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate.

P.P.S. I couldn't pass up an opportunity to share a quote from The Fonz 😎

(#475) Preparation for the Entire Day to Come

“The most universal practice for tapping into the Life Force is really a number of practices — mediation, prayer, reading, journal writing, exercise—that make up the morning rituals that so many people swear by. Rather than preparing you for a single event, like a game, a play, or a public address, the rituals prepare you for the entire day to come.

Every time you ‘practice’ these activities—all of them or a select few—you are making the ‘choice’ to apply the Life Force to your own growth.” – Barry Michels and Phil Stutz, *Coming Alive*

How good is that? (Except that they left off breathing, ha!)

Here’s to using our practices and these daily readings to prepare for the whole day to come while applying the Life Force for our own growth 🙏

(#476) Beautiful Monsters

“Beautiful monsters are like ice. Their nature is like water. We don’t have to destroy the ice but melt it, free it into its natural state of flow. ... So the question becomes, how to melt the ice? The warmth of our kindness toward our beautiful monsters, in the form of nonjudging—this allows the ice to start melting.” - Daniel Goleman & Tsoknyi Rinpoche, *Why We Meditate*

Do you have any “beautiful monsters” you’re dealing with? Those emotional patterns that make life more difficult than it should be, that you wish would just go away? (Of course you do if you’re human 😊)

Here’s a great reminder that warmth and nonjudging acceptance—things we naturally develop through breathing and meditation—can melt them.

Remember: We’re not trying to eliminate them; instead, we’re changing their form into something that flows 🙏

(#477) What We See

“Do you know the old proverb, ‘You are what you eat’? We can ring a variation on it by saying, ‘You see what you are.’ ... Vision depends on a complex internal process, one element of which is desire. What motivates us receives our attention, and whatever has our attention is what we see.” - Eknath Easwaran, *Passage Meditation*

“What motivates us receives our attention, and whatever has our attention is what we see.”
How good is that?

It’s a perfect reminder that when we’re motivated by nourishing qualities—like learning, love, movement, kindness, and humor—that’s exactly what we’ll find in the world.

And it’s precisely why we renew our motivation and attention with our practice and these daily messages: so we can see the world anew each day.

(#478) Caught, Not Taught

“‘Attitudes are caught, not taught.’ That’s a wise Quaker saying.” – Fred Rogers, You Are Special

What a wonderful reminder that, sometimes, the best way to “teach” something is simply through how we live, not by any wise lessons we orchestrate. This is especially true for parenting :)

And it’s a perfect reminder to try our best to take the unrushed, peaceful state we gain from breathing, reading, and meditation out into our everyday lives so we can help others “catch” some of these benefits 🙏

(#479) Soul Wealth

“It is not the possession of money that constitutes wealth, that gives the highest satisfaction and awakens the consciousness of noble achievement, or that gives the assurance that we are fulfilling our mission...Only soul wealth, generous disinterestedness, the love that seeks not its own, and hands that help and hearts that sympathize constitute true riches and fill the possessor with the joy of one who knows that he or she is fulfilling the real purpose of life.” – Orison Swett Marden, *The Joys of Living*

Here's to using our breathing, reading, meditation, and movement to build a little more soul wealth so we can be filled with the joy of knowing we are fulfilling our real purpose in life 🙏

(#480) The Tether Between Us All

“Breath is the beginning, the end, and the tether between us all...It’s the wiring between all living organisms that proves we’re not separated or disconnected, but rather that we are being routed through the same network.” – Finnian Kelly

P.S. On weekends, I just share a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

Extra Email for New Science 411

Alternate Nostril Breathing – New Science 411

“This technique provides high level evidence for positive outcomes for the autonomic nervous and cardiopulmonary systems. There is also high level of evidence regarding improvement in cognitive functioning with regular practice of alternate nostril breathing.” – Ghiya (2017)

We have a new Science 411 available in the Learning Center on: Alternate Nostril Breathing: A Systematic Review of Clinical Trials.

This was a great little overview of ANB, highlighting its benefits for autonomic, cardiovascular, and cognitive functions. I hope you enjoy it!

[Click here to read or listen to it.](#)

Enjoy your weekend,
Nick

(#481) Oxygen for the Lungs and Soul

“Plants give us oxygen for the lungs and for the soul.” - Linda Solegato

P.S. On weekends, I just share a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

P.P.S. My wife got a new plant for her home office, which has made her very happy, and it reminded me of this quote I saw in a DailyGood email.

(#482) Resonance Walking

“Intriguingly, though, he has found a sweet spot where the rhythm of our footsteps synchronizes with our heart rate. In Greene's experiments the biggest boost in blood flow happened when the heart rate and step rate synchronized at around 120 beats and steps per minute. Walking in sync with the heart rate seems to provide a steady and predictable increase in blood flow to the brain, which, Greene speculates, might contribute to the feel-good factor that comes from a good, brisk walk.” – Caroline Williams, *Move: How the New Science of Body Movement Can Set Your Mind Free* (<https://amzn.to/4fJBbmX>)

Like resonance breathing, the exact number may be less important than simply making the effort to walk in sync. Either way, what a cool concept, and what great motivation to take a brisk walk to harmonize our heartbeats and steps to increase brain blood flow 🧠

(#483) Descending in Consciousness

“We must do what we can to make the body a good ally. We must give it what it needs: adequate sleep every night, wholesome, nourishing food in reasonable quantities, and lots of vigorous movement. Without a balance between physical activity and meditation, for instance, we may become irritable or restless. Exercise—jogging, swimming, climbing, hard work, and so forth for young people, and walking for just about everybody—can help to solve some of the problems that come as you descend in consciousness.” - Eknath Easwaran, *Passage Meditation*

Yesterday, we discussed “resonance walking”—walking at a brisk but manageable pace of about 120 steps/min. Today, we learn why it’s relevant on our contemplative path: Vigorous movement “can help solve some of the problems that come as you descend in consciousness.” The more we move, the easier it is to sit still.

(#484) Walk Slowly, Too

“One thing that works in our favor here is that, whenever you’re moving under your own steam at a pace that feels easy, the activity in the prefrontal cortex gets temporarily turned down...Reducing this filter allows access to a broader set of options—ideas that you might not otherwise consider.” – Caroline Williams, *Move: How the New Science of Body Movement Can Set Your Mind Free* (<https://amzn.to/4fJBbmX>)

We’ve mentioned the benefits of brisk walking for brain blood flow and meditation, but walking at a slow and comfortable pace has its advantages, too—the primary one being creativity.

So, the next time we’re feeling stuck, we can take a pleasant stroll, let our minds wander, and, as Williams tells us, we can “come back with a shiny new idea. It really is that simple.”

(#485) A Thousand Little Stones

“For ages, happiness has been represented as a huge precious stone, impossible to find, which people seek for hopelessly. It is not so; happiness is a mosaic, composed of a thousand little stones, which separately and of themselves have little value, but which united with art form a graceful design.” - Delphine de Girardin, 19th-century French writer and poet (1804–1855)

Here’s to arranging our thousand little stones—all the seemingly unrelated things we love that make us, us—into a mosaic that creates a well-lived life we enjoy. Breathing, reading, and meditation may only be a few of yours, but I’m grateful you share them with me 🙏

(#486) “Please Don’t Eat Sugar”

As a parent and teacher, this is my favorite Gandhi story...the reason why has nothing to do with sugar 😊

“During the thirties a woman came to Sevagram asking Gandhi to get her little boy to stop eating sugar; it was doing him harm. Gandhi gave a cryptic reply: ‘Please come back next week.’

The woman left puzzled but returned a week later, dutifully following the Mahatma’s instructions.

‘Please don’t eat sugar,’ Gandhi told the young fellow when he saw him. ‘It is not good for you.’ Then he joked with the boy for a while, gave him a hug, and sent him on his way.

But the mother, unable to contain her curiosity, lingered behind to ask, ‘Bapu, why didn’t you say this last week when we came? Why did you make us come back again?’

Gandhi smiled. ‘Last week,’ he said to her, ‘I too was eating sugar.’” – from Gandhi The Man

(#487) There Isn't a Cost

“There isn't a cost to staying open to possibility.” – Ellen Langer, Ph.D.

P.S. On weekends, I just share a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#488) Increase Brain Power

“You can increase your brain power three to fivefold simply by laughing and having fun before working on a problem.” – Doug Hall

P.S. On weekends, I just share a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate.

P.P.S. Although he’s just making a point and not being literal with the 3-5 fold increase, I’d wager it’s actually more 😊

(#489) Naturally Include Our Own

“To live simply is to live gently, keeping in mind always the needs of the planet, other creatures, and the generations to come. In doing this we lose nothing, because the interests of the whole naturally include our own.” – Eknath Easwaran, Original Goodness

“The interests of the whole naturally include our own.” Since reading that, I’ve thought of it every morning before my breath practice. I can’t put my finger on why it’s so potent (and I certainly don’t live up to it enough...baby steps 😊), but something about remembering that we are, in fact, part of the whole is both reassuring and humbling. I hope it resonates with you in some way, too.

P.S. Speaking of generations to come, I forgot to share that our daughter Marielle started kindergarten last week! We are proud parents over here:

(#490) Changing Our Soundtrack

“According to Damasio, the unconscious messages coming from the body provide not only the basis for the self but also a kind of undercurrent to our consciousness that sets the mood for everything else that happens. These “background feelings,” as he calls them, act a bit like the soundtrack of a film: they have the power to make us feel happy, sad, hopeful or on edge, for reasons that we can't quite put our finger on.” – Caroline Williams, *Move*

The idea of “background feelings” subtly shaping the overall mood of our lives is perfectly reflected in practices like breathing, meditation, and even reading these daily messages. These rituals seem to influence our physiology in ways that change our “life’s soundtrack,” helping us feel happy and hopeful “for reasons that we can’t quite put our finger on.” 🙏

(#491) Tuning Our Guitar

“Another important point is to remain balanced, not too tight and not too loose. If we’re too tight, we’ll lose our calmness and relaxation. If we’re too loose, we’ll stray into distraction. It’s like tuning a guitar. For the best sound it should be tuned just right—not too tight and not too loose.” – Daniel Goleman and Tsoknyi Rinpoche, *Why We Meditate*

Yesterday, we talked about changing our life’s soundtrack. Today, we learn how to get the sound just right. It begins by looking at where we’re being too tight (for me, this is how strict I am with our daughter’s nighttime routine) and where we’re being too loose (for me, this is working too much in the evenings). Then, working to find more balance.

Remember, for the best sound, our lives need to be tuned just right 🎵

(#492) How to Stop Burning Our Toast

“Thus, I was not surprised when a journalist who was interviewing me asked me if mindfulness is just a fad. My response was, “If every day you make toast and burn it in the process and someone shows you that all you need to do is change the dial on your toaster, would you go back to burning your toast after a while?” Once we learn to do something that helps, it’s not a fad; it becomes a way of life.” – Ellen Langer, Ph.D., *The Mindful Body*

That’s an excellent analogy, and it works perfectly for everything we practice: breathing, mindfulness, meditation, and so on. These practices simply help us stop burning our metaphorical toast 😊 Once we learn how much they help, they become a way of life.

(#493) As Good as Crunches

“Break into a full belly laugh and you hit two pillars of stress control in one go. A recent study found that laughing really hard provides a better core workout than crunches. Or, if your friends aren’t that funny, it might be worth considering laughter yoga, which uses breathing exercises and other movements to work the same muscles that are used in a real belly laugh.” – Caroline Williams, Move*

We already know that laughter significantly reduces cortisol, but here we learn it might be as effective—or even better—than crunches for our core. Let’s use that as our friendly reminder to laugh this weekend to support both our physical and mental health 😊

*I transcribed this passage from the Audible version, so it could have slight errors in punctuation.

P.S. I haven’t gotten the text version of this one yet (I do that after listening), so I don’t know if she provides a reference for this passage. A quick Google tells me that this might be the study she’s referring to: <https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/abs/10.1080/00222895.2013.844091>

(#494) Body, Mind, and Soul

“For centuries people have integrated breathwork into spiritual practices like meditation and mindfulness, connecting the breath to not just the body but also to the mind and soul, making breathwork not just a physical experience but a spiritual one as well.” – Jennifer Tucker

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#495) Skipping Happily Away with the Fairies

“If you are already breathing at a normal rate, slowing it down further still can change your state of mind to the point where you tune out from reality and skip happily away with the fairies.” – Caroline Williams

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote (and in this case, one that made me laugh) for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#496) A Refreshing Perspective on Rest

“One important point, and a key difference between rest and sleep, is that rest doesn’t necessarily need to involve being physically still. Hiking up a hill can count as rest if it gives you a mental break in the moment and a feeling of satisfied exhaustion afterwards. ... rest can be as active as you like, as long as it takes your mind off your woes for a while and leaves you feeling relaxed and restored.” – Caroline Williams, *Move*

Incorporating rest into our day is critical to our health and well-being. But here we’re offered a refreshing perspective: rest doesn’t necessarily mean “being still.” Of course, the usual suspects like breathing, meditation, and reading all qualify. But movement—even rather vigorous movement—also works, provided it takes our minds off our woes.

Let’s pick our favorite and enjoy the benefits of true rest 🙏

(#497) Leaving Before the Final Act

“Most people use the tools to address a particular problem, and when the problem is solved they forget about the tool. They’ve used the tool to climb out of whatever hole they’re in, they experience the relief of being free from what’s been bothering them, and then they go on with their life.

They’re missing something. Abandoning the use of tools once your problem is solved is like leaving the theater before the final act...If you keep using them, you ascend to another state — another world, filled with limitless potential.” – Barry Michels and Phil Stutz, *Coming Alive*

Have you got any “final acts” you’ve been missing? (Guilty here.) Let’s use this as motivation to keep using our tools long after we need them so we can “ascend to another state filled with limitless potential.” 🙌

(#498) Majoring in the Minor

“That’s when I learned that people have a habit of looking for the next big thing when they haven’t spent any time mastering the simple thing in front of them....A lot of you are missing the forest for the trees. You’re majoring in the minor. You’re getting in the weeds.” – Arnold Schwarzenegger

That’s so good, and it raises the question: Got any areas of your contemplative journey where you’re “majoring in the minor?” (Don’t we all 😊). Let’s use this as a reminder to master the simple tools in front of us—things like slow breathing, meditation, and mindfulness—before we go looking for the next big thing.

(#499) One-Tenth of One Percent

“But if you do something today that improves your performance by one-tenth of 1 percent...

And then you do it again tomorrow.

And then again the next day.

We’re talking compound interest—just think where you’ll be a year from now!” – Greg Harden,
Stay Sane in an Insane World

We make these small improvements every time we sit down to breathe, or meditate, or even read these short messages. And every time we breathe through our nose instead of our mouth; or choose a kind response over a hurtful one. Remember, these positive choices accumulate like compound interest. Just think of where we’ll be a year from now...

P.S. “Stay Sane in an Insane World”...how’s that for the best book title ever 😂

(#500) Remarkably, It's Possible to...

“Remarkably, it’s possible to use your breath to train your body to react more healthily to stress, both in the moment and over the longer term, by virtue of the way that it changes the level of activity along the vagus nerve. Over time, practicing slow breathing can change your baseline level of stress reactivity to a point where you freak out less often and recover more quickly when you do.” – Caroline Williams, Move

Most of us know this by now, but it’s always good to be reminded that slow breathing can help us “freak out less often and recover more quickly” when we do 😊. Let’s use this as motivation to practice daily and enjoy those benefits.

P.S. I bought this book spontaneously, primarily by looking at the cover (and a quick read of the description), lol. I had no clue it had a whole chapter on breathing. In any case, it’s a phenomenal book, and I loved the chapter on breathing...it was full of wisdom and quote gems like this. Will be sharing more soon.

(#501) Regardless of How We Get There

“Regardless of how we get there, either through meditation or more directly by paying attention to novelty and questioning assumptions, to be mindful is to be in the present, noticing all the wonders that we didn’t realize were right in front of us.” — Ellen Langer, Ph.D. (The “Mother of Mindfulness”)

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#502) Carried by the Surprise

“I would love to live like a river flows, carried by the surprise of its own unfolding.” – John O’Donohue

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#503) Purely for the Joy of It

“We have to keep having fun throughout our lives—it’s so important to do things purely for the joy of it.”

– Gladys McGarey, MD

Dr. Gladys shared this wisdom when talking about how much fun she has riding the new tricycle she got for her 102nd (!) birthday! Ha! That’s so awesome and inspiring, and it’s a wonderful reminder to do something purely for the joy of it today (and every day).

(#504) A Significant Boost to Mental Health

“The study volunteers only counted their breath for a couple of minutes at a time, which suggests that taking just a short break to do the same—no cushion or chanting necessary, you don’t even need to close your eyes or let on that you’re doing it—could be a great way to get out of your head and calmly reconnect with the rest of your body. Over time a regular check-in using breath as a shortcut to the body could add up to a significant boost to mental health.” – Caroline Williams, Move

Here, Williams highlights a study showing that breath counting synchronized breathing to brain waves in areas involved in interoception. Since interoception (or tuning into how our body is feeling) is critical to managing emotions, this underscores the power of this simple practice for mental health.

Give it a try anytime you need to calm your mind and reconnect with your body.

(#505) Our One Great Creative Masterpiece

“What we make of our life—the sum total of thoughts, emotions, words, and actions that fill the brief interval between birth and death—is our one great creative masterpiece. The beauty and significance of a life well lived consists not in the works we leave behind, or in what history has to say about us. It comes from the quality of conscious experience that infuses our every waking moment, and from the impact we have on others.” – The Mind Illuminated

And how can we most effectively deepen “the quality of conscious experience that infuses our every waking moment”? Breathing, meditation, and mindfulness, of course 😊. Through consistent practice, these tools allow us to purposefully shape and refine this one great creative masterpiece that is our life.

(#506) A Fast Track to Alternate State of Mind

“Whatever rate you breathe at, whether you focus on the breath for alertness, slow it down a bit for relaxation, or a lot to reach an altered state of consciousness, only nasal breathing allows your brainwaves to synchronize with the breath, offering a fast track to an alternative state of mind.” – Caroline Williams, *Move*

Just a great reminder that, except for a few specific techniques, most of the benefits of breathing start with the nose. So, anytime you want to shift your state of mind—whether it’s finding relaxation over stress, or focus over distraction—remember, it begins with nasal breathing. As Williams also notes: “Breath-linked mind control only works if you breathe through your nose.”



(#507) A Menu of Mind-Body Benefits

“The real power of breathing comes from the way that we can also control the rate and depth of our breathing rate and choose from a menu of body–mind benefits...we can use it to calm down, focus and think about what to do next. With a little practice we can also use breath control techniques to escape from reality for a while, taking a well-earned break from both body and mind. Or we can make like a monk and admire the rhythmic work of the pre-Böt-C from a mental and emotional distance. All are easy to do and can make a significant difference to how you think and feel—for solid physiological reasons.” Caroline Williams, *Move*

How good is this? Here’s to using this ability of breath control wisely so we can get what our bodies need from the “menu of mind-body benefits” that it offers 🙏

(#508) Take Control Over the Direction of Our Lives

“Mindfulness allows us to recognize our options, choose our responses wisely, and take control over the direction of our lives. It also gives us the power to change our past conditioning and become the person we want to be.” – The Mind Illuminated

P.S. On weekends, I like to keep it short with a memorable quote for you to reflect on 🙏

(#509) One of the Purest Forms of Joy

“A lot of things in daily life boil down to wonder. It is one of the purest forms of joy I can imagine.” – Erling Kagge

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and reflect on 🙏

(#510) These are the Signs of Progress

“I look for changes in character and conduct. How selfless can you be? Can you restrain your senses when necessary? Can you go against your self-will when it benefits those around you? How long is your span of attention? These are the signs of progress in meditation.” – Eknath Easwaran, Passage Meditation

Of course, there are many different signs of progress in meditation (and breathing and mindfulness), but these made me happy 😊 They offer a simple yet powerful way to assess whether these practices are truly changing our lives.

(#511) How to Overcome Obstacles to Daily Practice

“Diligence helps start you on your way, but the real solution to these obstacles is learning to enjoy your practice...Too often, people approach meditation as though they were taking medicine—it tastes bad, but they grin and bear it because it’s supposed to be good for them. Instead, make meditation into a pleasurable activity. If you’re at ease and happy, you will be more successful than if you’re tense and straining...Once you taste the joy and pleasure of practice, procrastination and resistance vanish. You’ll look forward to your time on the cushion and guard it as something precious.” – The Mind Illuminated

With that in mind, we might ask, ‘How could I tailor my practice to bring me more joy?’
Remember: We’re not supposed to grin and bear it; we’re supposed to enjoy it 🧘

Lesson: In our next 30-second lesson, you’ll learn how to overcome obstacles and make your practice something you look forward to each day.

(#512) High Vagal Tone and Stress

“High vagal tone has been linked to better working memory and ability to focus, emotional stability and reduced risk of anxiety and depression. People with high HRV also have a better ability to control blood sugar levels and are better able to suppress inflammation. This isn’t because they have a lower stress response in general—it’s because with higher vagal tone they are better able to turn it off again afterwards.” – Caroline Williams, Move

This passage is an excellent reminder that building higher vagal tone (through practices like slow breathing and loving-kindness) won’t mean we will “never get stressed”—that’s not our goal. Instead, what it means is that we’ll be able to quickly “turn it off again afterwards” and get back to living. To bounce back like this, we need a flexible nervous system, which is exactly what breathing and meditation cultivate.

Lesson: In tomorrow’s 30-second lesson, you’ll learn the real reason why building higher vagal tone helps us thrive.

(#513) The Pain Cycle

“So this is how the chronic back pain cycle works. Our initial pain causes worried thoughts, these thoughts create anxiety, and this anxiety causes muscles to tighten. Tight muscles cause increased pain, and increased pain triggers even more dire worried thoughts. Once the cycle sets in, other emotions, such as frustration and anger, get into the act.” – Ronald Siegel, Psy.D., *The Mindfulness Solution*

Although referring to back pain, this cycle applies to basically any type of physical or mental discomfort. Pain causes worried thoughts, those thoughts generate anxiety, and anxiety triggers physical tension that amplifies the pain. This increases anxious thoughts, and the cycle repeats.

A solution? Mindfulness. By helping us accept and observe the pain less judgmentally, mindfulness interrupts the cycle. Then, resistance and suffering decrease, allowing us to regain control of our lives 🙏

The Pain Cycle: In tomorrow’s 30-second lesson, we’ll discover how mindfulness can help break the cycle of pain and bring relief.

Although Siegel is referring to back pain, this cycle applies to nearly any type of pain—whether physical or mental. Pain triggers worried thoughts, those thoughts generate anxiety, and anxiety creates physical tension that amplifies the pain. The pain intensifies, and the cycle repeats, feeding on itself.

So how do we break free? The answer is mindfulness. By allowing us to observe and accept the pain without judgment, mindfulness interrupts the cycle. As our resistance softens, so does our suffering, and we can start to regain control over our experience.

How to Deal with Anger

“I have learnt through bitter experience the one supreme lesson to conserve my anger, and as heat conserved is transmuted into energy, even so our anger controlled can be transmuted into a power which can move the world.” – Gandhi

Here’s a powerful reminder that anger isn’t in itself bad. We don’t need to repress it or chastise ourselves for feeling it. Instead, the most effective response is to control our anger and transform it into power.

So, the next time we feel angry (which will likely happen sooner than later 😊), let's use mindfulness to ask how we might convert that anger into something useful and productive, rather than letting it control us.

Meditation and mindfulness practices create space, awareness, and time to choose our responses to emotional states. However, one of the most challenging to deal with is anger. While there are many practices we could potentially draw on, this quote from Gandhi captures the most effective approach: transform your anger into a controlled power, which can then move the world.

Given that Gandhi slept like 4-5 hours a night, worked nonstop, led a 240-mile march when he was 61, and was 78

(#514) Relish in the Journey

“Don’t forget, however, that the path is as important as the goal. The Stages outlined in this book may bring you to a state of peace and Insight, but they are also an exciting journey of discovery into the nature of the mind. Relish in this beautiful and sometimes challenging journey. The goal isn’t just getting to a calm, quiet pool, but learning about the makeup of the water itself as it goes from choppy to still, from cloudy to crystal-clear.” – The Mind Illuminated

That’s a perfect reminder to enjoy the path we’re on, not just the destination. It echoes this wisdom from Dr. Gladys McGarey: “What’s most important is to realize that searching for your juice is nearly as important as finding it. The search itself is life reaching for life.”

Both remind us to do our best to enjoy every moment of the journey 🙏

Relish in the Journey: In tomorrow’s 30-second inspirational message, we’ll draw upon the wisdom of a 103-year-old MD and a neuroscientist-turned-meditation teacher to remind ourselves to enjoy the path we’re on.

(#515) Your Soul is Alive

“If the sight of the blue skies fills you with joy, if a blade of grass has the power to move you, rejoice, for your soul is alive.” – Eleonora Duse

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and reflect on 🙏

P.P.S. This one could certainly fall into mindfulness 101 😊

(#516) We Can Do More than Change the Body

“If mind and body are one, we can do more than change the body by changing the mind; we can change the mind by changing the body.” – Ellen Langer, Ph.D.

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and reflect on 🙏

P.P.S. And what is the fastest way to use the body to change the mind? The breath (see this groundbreaking study—published 22 years ago—for more).

(<https://breathlearning.com/science-411s/philippot-et-al-2002/>)

(#517) Sometimes It's a Simple Observation

"Sometimes the most important finding in a scientific study is a simple observation, free of any hypothesis or pitting of theoretical perspectives against one another. And this was true in our daily diary research: people experience awe two to three times a week. That's once every couple of days. They did so in finding the extraordinary in the ordinary." – Dacher Keltner, Awe

Our mission for today (and every day), if we so choose to accept it, is to use mindfulness to find "the extraordinary in the ordinary" so we can experience and benefit from a little more awe in our lives 🙏

P.S. This also brings to mind what Abraham Maslow told us back in TB1% #347 (<https://breathlearning.com/the-breathing-1/number-347/>): "The great lesson...is that the sacred is in the ordinary, that it is to be found in one's daily life, in one's neighbors, friends, and family, in one's back yard." 🙌

"Sometimes the most important finding in a scientific study is a simple observation, free of any hypothesis or pitting of theoretical perspectives against one another. And this was true in our daily diary research: people experience awe two to three times a week. That's once every couple of days. They did so in finding the extraordinary in the ordinary: a friend's generosity to a homeless person in the streets; the scent of a flower; looking at a leafy tree's play of light and shadow on a sidewalk; hearing a song that transported them back to a first love; bingeing Game of Thrones with friends.

Everyday awe.

"Great thinkers, from Walt Whitman to Rachel Carson to Zen master Shunryu Suzuki, remind us to become aware of how much of life can bring us awe. It is a deep conviction in many Indigenous philosophies from around the world that so much of the life that surrounds us is sacred. Our findings suggest that these great minds and cultures were onto something: the wonders of life are so often nearby." – Dacher Keltner, Awe

(#518) Taking Your Brainwaves in Hand

“There is also an ever-increasing pile of scientific research that demonstrates that, when you control your breath, what you are actually doing is taking your brainwaves in hand and tethering the rate of their fluctuations to your breathing rate.” – Caroline Williams, Move

We often focus on the breath-nervous system connection, but let’s not forget that the breath-brain relationship may be even more profound. So, the next time you choose to deliberately control your breathing, remember that you’re not just calming yourself—you’re actually “taking your brainwaves in hand” and syncing them to your breathing. Pretty remarkable for something so simple 🙌

(#519) A Great Analogy for Focused Attention

“For example, when you’re carrying a full cup of hot tea through a crowded room, you want to sustain your attention on the cup while remaining aware of everything else around you. That way you can avoid a collision. Similarly, keep your primary focus on the breath and simply allow all other sensations and mental events in your peripheral awareness to just be there. Let them come, let them be, let them go.” – The Mind Illuminated

What a tangible metaphor for holding attention on the breath—especially once I switched it from tea to coffee 😊. Just as we carefully carry a cup through a crowded room, our focus on the breath requires a balance of focused attention and peripheral awareness.

So, here’s to carrying our breath (or any object of attention) like a hot cup of coffee in the busy room of our minds 🙏

(#520) A High-Resolution Analogy You Can Use Today

“Think about a digital photograph. The vividness and clarity of the image depend on the number of pixels. Likewise, the vividness and clarity of the meditation object depend on the number of perceiving moments of attention whose content is the meditation object.” – The Mind Illuminated

Although this passage is focused on meditation, the idea translates perfectly to life as a whole. The more “perceiving moments of attention” we bring to what’s happening (aka mindfulness), the more pixels we add to the image of our lives, and the clearer and more vivid they become



(#521) Seeing Possibilities (plus the best psychology)

“A good axiom in life is to try to see the possibilities in a situation. Often in a situation, it is the walls we see, it is the door where the key has been thrown away that we see, and we never see the windows of possibilities and the places where thoughts and feelings can grow.” – John O’Donohue, *Walking in Wonder*

Here’s a perfect practice in mindful living to try today (and every day): in any challenging situation, look for the possibilities instead of focusing on the walls. It’s definitely not always easy, but that’s what makes it so rewarding 🙌

P.S. This reminded me of Dr. Ellen Langer, often called the “Mother of Mindfulness.” She believes that mindful living and possibility are so connected she actually refers to her work as “The Psychology of Possibility.” How awesome is that?

(#522) There is No Path

“Traveler, there is no path. The path is made by walking.” – Antonio Machado

P.S. On weekends, I just share a memorable quote for you to enjoy and reflect on 🙏

(#523) Simple Tasks with a Clear Intention

“Repeating simple tasks with a clear intention can reprogram unconscious mental processes. This can completely transform who you are as a person.” – The Mind Illuminated

P.S. On weekends, I just share a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#524) A Walk to Remember

“In experiments when people walked with a high-energy, bouncing gait they were able to remember more happy words from a list of emotionally charged words, while those who were asked to walk slowly and with little bounce remembered more of the negative ones, even when they weren’t aware that they were doing a “depressed”-or “happy”-style gait.” – Caroline Williams, Move

That makes sense intuitively, but how cool to see it supported by some research? And while you probably won’t catch me bouncing down the sidewalk anytime soon 😊, it’s great motivation to put a little more pep in our step so we can potentially remember (or at least notice) more of the positive than the negative.

(#525) When Emotional Reactions Win

“But what if our emotions and past conditioning are so powerful in the moment that we can’t change how we feel and act? That’s all right. As long as we stay mindful enough, we give our unconscious processes new information, and we will be more successful in the future. With repeated effort, we will become less reactive, maybe without even realizing it. Even if we lose mindfulness completely in the heat of the moment, we can still use it afterward to reflect on what happened, our reactions, and their impact on ourself and others.” – The Mind Illuminated

How’s that for a gentle (but honest) reminder that—even when we slip up in the heat of the moment—all is not lost? By holding even a little bit of mindfulness, or by reflecting mindfully afterward, we can still train our minds to react more skillfully in the future 🙏

(#526) Where the Winds are Coming From

In meteorology, we name winds based on where they're coming from, not where they're going: a "north wind" means it's blowing from the north. This allows us to quickly understand the wind's qualities (for example, a north wind would generally bring cooler temperatures, at least in the northern hemisphere).

Similarly, in our daily living, we should focus on where our actions and practices are coming from—our intention—rather than where they're going.

We can extend the analogy and define four cardinal directions—Love, Wisdom, Purpose, and Joy—and ask:

Where is my action stemming from?

Am I cultivating love?

Connecting with my purpose?

Acquiring wisdom?

Experiencing joy?

This perspective reminds us that, while we can't always control where our actions will lead, we can control our intentions, which is a perfect embodiment of the art of mindful living 🧘

(#527) Walk and Breathe

“Efficient breathing allows our bodies to be properly oxygenated, enabling us to walk farther without feeling exhausted. Many of us don’t breathe properly as we exercise, gulping rapidly at air through our mouths rather than matching our (full, nasal) inhalations to our stride. When we walk to the rhythm of our breath—or even breathe to the rhythm of our feet—we slow and lengthen our breathing. In combination with good posture, paced rhythmic breathing means that demanding mountain ascents and lengthy treks feel less tiring.” – Annabel Streets, 52 Ways to Walk

Even if we’re not going on any mountain ascents or lengthy treks anytime soon, this is a great reminder of the power of breathwalking to make any stroll feel easier and less tiring 🙌

(#528) The Weight on Our Shoulders

“As my grandmother used to tell me, ‘The Lord will never put on your shoulders even one pound more than you can bear. But,’ she would always add, ‘you will never have to carry one pound less, either.’ Otherwise we would not grow.” – Eknath Easwaran, Conquest of Mind

How good is that wisdom from his grandmother? It’s a humbling reminder that we’re capable of handling whatever problems we’re dealing with. In fact, they’re precisely what’s needed in order for us to grow 🙏

(#529) Usual Everyday Routine

“Zen is not some kind of excitement, but concentration on our usual everyday routine.” –
Shunryu Suzuki

P.S. On weekends, I just share a memorable quote for you to enjoy 🙏

(#530) A Fountain of Goodness

“Dig deep within yourself, for there is a fountain of goodness ever ready to flow if you will keep digging.” – Marcus Aurelius

P.S. On weekends, I just share a memorable quote for you to reflect on 🙏

(#531) Self-Inquiry, Self-Transformation, and Self-Realization

According to Richard Rosen, pranayama is a means of:

- “Self-inquiry, since by looking at how we breathe, we begin to understand something about who we are.
- Self-transformation, since as the yogis say, breath and consciousness are two sides of the same coin, when we change the breath in pranayama, we inevitably change who we are.
- Self-realization, when our small breath becomes one with, and reveals itself identical to, the Great Breath.”

That’s so good. I’d say that this applies to not only pranayama, but any conscious breath practice performed over a lifetime 🙏

(#532) Subtle Power of a Quiet Mind

“Flowing water provides a helpful analogy. Compare the wide, tranquil, glasslike smoothness of the Ganges to a narrow, roaring mountain stream. Even though the total kinetic energy of the Ganges is far greater, the narrow stream appears more powerful. This is because the constricted, cluttered streambed produces a disordered, turbulent flow, whereas the Ganges has an orderly, smooth flow through a broad and unobstructed channel. The greater energy of the Ganges has carved a larger channel for itself, clearing obstructions and making the flow of energy far more organized.” – The Mind Illuminated

Here’s a great analogy illustrating the subtle power of a quiet mind. It may not look as forceful from the outside, but underneath, it holds far greater power.

(#533) Ultimate Goal of Training the Mind

“We can learn to say to life, ‘It doesn’t matter what you bring today. If you bring something pleasant, I will flourish; if you bring something unpleasant, I will still flourish.’ Once we have tasted the freedom of juggling at will with our personal preferences, we can face whatever comes to us calmly and courageously, knowing we have the flexibility to weather any storm gracefully. This is living in freedom, the ultimate goal of training the mind.” – Eknath Easwaran, Conquest of Mind

How good is that? It’s precisely why we use breathing and mindfulness to increase the adaptability of our bodies and minds. So we can say to life, “It doesn’t matter what you bring today. If you bring something pleasant, I will flourish; if you bring something unpleasant, I will still flourish.” Amen to that 🙏

(#534) Get the Very Best of Our Minds

“There is now enough robust science to show that **mastering the simple movements needed to control the rate, depth and route by which you get air into your body** can become a handy tool to steer thoughts and feelings in useful ways. Mastering this range of bodily movements can allow us to dial into the workings of the brain and the rest of the body, change the settings of both and get the very best out of the mind.” – Caroline Williams, Move

How’s that for a potent reminder of the power of the breath? By mastering the simple movements needed for breathing, we can get the very best from of our minds 🙌

P.S. And although there are many ways to master our breathing, two of the simplest and most transformative shifts Williams mentions are nasal breathing and slow breathing.

(#535) How to (counterintuitively) Move Forward

My new favorite quote

“Like skaters, we move forward by actually moving from side to side.” – Richard Rohr, *Falling Upward*

I’ve never loved a quote more in my life 😊

It reminds me of how we live, moving back and forth between:

Timeless Wisdom < --- > Modern Science

Breathing < --- > Meditation

Success < --- > Failure

Science Papers < --- > Spiritual Books

One Method < --- > Another Method

Seriousness < --- > Humor

And on and on and on.

All these seemingly sideways movements are, counterintuitively, gliding us forward.

So here’s to skating our way toward our True Nature a little more each and every day 🙏

(#536) Let All Else Fall Away

“Each moment of doing your best is a success. Let all else fall away.” – John Yates, Ph.D., and Matthew Immergut, Ph.D.

P.S. On weekends, I just share a memorable quote for you to enjoy and reflect on 🙏

(#537) Slow Circles of Nature

“Everything that slows us down and forces patience, everything that sets us back into the slow circles of nature, is a help.” – May Sarton (DailyGood 27 September 2024)

P.S. On weekends, I just send a noteworthy quote for you to enjoy.

P.P.S. This quote was actually about gardening, but it works beautifully for slow breathing and mindfulness, too 😊

[New Book 411] Move: How the New Science of Body Movement...

“Whether you want to learn better, slow brain aging, spark new ideas or just feel more in control of your mental health, there is almost nothing that moving more can’t help you to achieve. Body movements can serve as a short-cut to changing the ways we think and feel.”

We have a new Book 411 available on: Move: How the New Science of Body Movement Can Set Your Mind Free.

I loved this book, and, as I’ve mentioned before, the chapter on breathing was amazing.

The Book 411 covers my 5 favorite ideas from the book, plus a stack of memorable quotes. I hope you love it!

Click here to read or listen.

All the best,

Nick

<https://breathlearning.com/book-411s/move/>

(#538) The Grand Gesture

“Though the artist may have a number of goals and motivations, there is only one intention. This is the grand gesture of the work.

It is not an exercise of thought, a goal to be set, or a means of commodification. It is a truth that lives inside you. Through your living it, that truth becomes embedded in the work. If the work doesn't represent who you are and what you're living, how can it hold an energetic charge?” – Rick Rubin, *The Creative Act*

How good is that? And I'd argue that this is the whole point of breathing, meditation, and mindfulness practices: We are discovering truths that live inside of us and finding ways to express them, not just in our work, but in how we live our daily lives in general 🙏

(#539) Unique Powers of Self-Regulation

“Even if you’ve never given it a moment’s thought, breath control is instinctively recognizable as not only a human-only skill but also as one that is intimately linked to our unique powers of mental and emotional self-regulation.” – Caroline Williams, Move

Although that quote doesn’t flow quite as smoothly as some of her others, it highlights a powerful message: We all intuitively know that breath control is linked to our ability to self-regulate mentally and emotionally. The challenge (and opportunity) is remembering to use it 😊

(#540) It Will Happen, and to You!

“It is not that suffering or failure might happen, or that it will only happen to you if you are bad (which is what religious people often think), or that it will happen to the unfortunate, or to a few in other places, or that you can somehow by cleverness or righteousness avoid it. No, it will happen, and to you!” – Richard Rohr, *Falling Upward*

An enlightening reminder: No matter how many breathing exercises we do, how active we stay, if we sleep perfectly, eat a flawless diet, and follow every other wellness protocol on the planet, life will still challenge us. We will still face illness, loss, and failure. We cannot avoid it by cleverness, science, or any other means.

But—and this is a big but—once we realize this and give up the idea of being “perfect,” then life becomes even more beautiful and meaningful nonetheless 🙏

(#541) It, Too, is a Form of Meditation

“Sometimes new students say, ‘I seem to spend a lot of time just doing the ‘Preparation for Practice’-is that a problem?’ When I ask how the rest of their meditation went afterward, that usually answers the question...The preparation also helps establish a consistent practice, free from resistance and the deliberate wasting of time. And it doesn’t matter how long you spend on the preparation, because it, too, is a form of meditation.” – The Mind Illuminated

Just a wonderful reminder that the time we spend setting up for our practice—setting an intention, doing some warm-up movement, or anything else that helps us settle down—is part of the experience. Same with the time spent reflecting or resting afterward, too. So, let’s enjoy the process and remember that how we enter and exit the practice is an integral part of the ritual



(#542) An Intriguing Situation

“This is an intriguing situation when we stop to think about it, for if it is true that breath influences both body and mind, then the rhythm and the rate of the breath would reflect not only one’s physical condition, but would also help to create it.” – Science of Breath

Here’s another powerful reminder that, although breathing reflects our current state, it also shapes it:

Fast, shallow breathing reflects being anxious...but it can also cause anxiety.
Slow, deep breathing reflects being calm...but it can also create relaxation.

This is the truly remarkable power of breath control. When used sensibly and safely, it can help us “create the physical condition” we’re after 🙏

(#543) Humor and Humility

“Simply by maintaining a sense of humor and humility, we can teach the mind not to get upset even when a real trial comes.” – Eknath Easwaran

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#544) The Natural State of a Unified Mind

“Joy seems to be the ‘natural’ state of a unified mind, and the more unified a mind is, the more joyful it is. Joy is also the ‘glue’ that helps keep a mind unified.” – John Yates, Ph.D., and Matthew Immergut, Ph.D.

P.S. On weekends, I just send a short, memorable quote for you to enjoy 🙏

(#545) Don't Should on Yourself

“And when we speak of healing with the voice, we are talking about...learning the depths of our own personal voice: not to imitate my voice, not to imitate your voice, and not to say my voice “should” be anything. How many of us should on ourselves all the time? The ecology of the breath and the voice and the body is engaging in each of ourselves as we were individual stars, or planets. Not trying to compare ourselves to anyone else, but to realize what is the most ecological way that we vibrate, resonate, empower ourselves with a sound life.” – Don Campbell, *Healing Yourself with Your Own Voice*

This is both funny and deeply profound. So, let's do our best not to “should on ourselves” and instead find our own unique way to use our breath, voice, and body to live a sound life 🙏

(#546) A “Prescription” for Today (and every day)

“A well-known physician who has made a specialty of nerve diseases, not getting satisfactory results from the prescription of drugs, tried the experiment of inducing his patients to smile under all circumstances—to compel themselves to laugh whether they felt like it or not. ‘Keep the corners of your mouth turned up,’ is his prescription for those suffering from melancholia. It works like a charm.” - Orison Swett Marden, *The Joys of Living* (<https://amzn.to/4eFBrCM>)

I’m not sure if there was a doctor who really did this. And I’m not a fan of faking emotions. But, I can wholeheartedly get behind the idea of a “prescription to smile and laugh” 😊

Instead of forcing it, however, we can use mindfulness to bring natural smiles and laughter into our day—recognizing just how small our problems are in the long run, and remembering not to take things too seriously.

(#547) The Schedule of the Soul

“We move toward understimulation if we are on the schedule of soul. Life has stimulated us enough, and now we have to process it and integrate it, however unconsciously. ... Much of life starts becoming highly symbolic and “connecting,” and little things become significant metaphors for everything else.” – Richard Rohr, *Falling Upward*

“We move toward understimulation if we are on the schedule of the soul.” How inspiring is that? I think we’d all be wise to—at least occasionally—pause and remember that “life has stimulated us enough.” Then, take time to connect with the schedule of our soul in our own unique ways 🙏

(#548) The Father of Medicine (and breath)

“In addition to contemplating many other anatomical systems, Hippocrates studied breathing. He recognized that the inhalation of air was fundamental to life. For this reason, Hippocrates and the Greeks viewed air as something vital and transcendent. They called it pneuma, which literally means air or breath but for the ancient Greeks also meant life force. ... The Greeks and Hippocrates insightfully saw the essence of our existence as a continuum from the atmosphere.”
– Michael J Stephen, MD, Breath Taking

Hippocrates, the father of medicine, studied breathing and saw the “essence of our existence as a continuum from the atmosphere.” How cool is that? So, today’s 1% is simply a wonderful reminder that breath is life—vital and transcendent—connecting our existence with the world around us 🙏

P.S. If you want to connect with “the schedule of your soul” like we did yesterday, you might pause and take a breath or two while reflecting on just how powerful that is...

(#549) Health and Happiness Don't Require This

“Many people live with diseases and even great pain while remaining joyfully connected to their purpose. Others are disease-free and still wake up not wanting to be alive. Health doesn't require us to live in a problem-free body, just as happiness doesn't require us to experience a problem-free life. Health and happiness are about being so connected to our own life force that we feel we fit into the world around us.” – Gladys McGarey, MD, *The Well-Lived Life* (<https://breathlearning.com/book-411s/the-well-lived-life/>)

Here is some timeless wisdom from Dr. Gladys, reminding us that true health and happiness don't come from a problem-free life but from “being so connected to our own life force that we feel we fit into the world around us.” And I may be biased, but a simple way to make this connection is via slow, mindful breathing 🙏

P.S. I recently learned that Dr. Gladys passed away on September 28th at the age of 103. Her book *The Well-Lived Life* (<https://www.amazon.com/Well-Lived-Life-102-Year-Old-Doctors-Happiness/dp/B0BVXZQ3NB/>) was one of (if not the most) life-changing books I've read. In celebration of her, I encourage you to pick it up if you haven't already, or at least check out the Book 411 for a taste of her compassionate and authentic wisdom.

(#550) One Must Dance

“In order to understand the dance, one must be still. And in order to truly understand stillness, one must dance.” – Rumi

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy 🙏

P.P.S. This great quote from Rumi reminded me of this recent one we read in Move: “We need to move to be still, and only from that place of stillness can we move well.”

(#551) Our Only Guide

“We have no one to guide us. Our only guide is our homesickness.” – Herman Hesse

P.S. On weekends, I just share a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(New Science 411) Breath-Heart-Brain Resonance

“Here, we show for the first time, that decelerated breathing at a rate of 6 cycles/minute has a strong influence on the slow cortical potentials (SCPs) of the brain. ... We term this phenomenon the great 10 second synchrony between breath, heart and the brain.” – The Brain’s Resonance of Breathing

Hey folks, we have a new Science 411 available on this 2019 paper on breath-heart-brain resonance.

In short, they found that slow breathing, particularly at 6 breaths a minute, rapidly synchronizes breath, heart, and brain rhythms, which might provide insight into how slow breathing exercises enhance mental and emotional health.

I hope you enjoy the 411!

You can read or listen to it here.

In good breath,
Nick

(#552) A Rarely Discussed Breathing Exercise

“We breathe, most importantly, to bring oxygen from the atmosphere into our bodies and to release carbon dioxide in return. Another crucial aspect of the breath, and one that is rarely discussed, is that it gives us our voice. Breathing generates speech, a fundamental element of our experience as human beings.” – Michael J Stephen, *Breath Taking*

Here’s an obvious yet often overlooked (for me, at least 😊) reminder that speaking is, at its core, a “breathing exercise.” It made me think how, if we become conscious of what we say and how we say it, our speech can become an integral part of our intention to live thoughtfully, providing endless opportunities to practice breathing and mindfulness to support the people we want to be.

(#553) The Practice of the Better

“One of the guiding principles of our Center for Action and Contemplation puts it this way: ‘The best criticism of the bad is the practice of the better.’” – Richard Rohr, *Falling Upward*

This might just be my new favorite life principle, and it’s a perfect practice in mindfulness. Whether at school, work, with friends and family, or even on social media, let’s be mindful to remember: “The best criticism of the bad is the practice of the better” 🙏

(#554) A Million-Star Hotel (and walking 8,000 miles)

Satish Kumar was about to start an 8,000-mile (!?) walk. One of his friends rightfully expressed concern for his well-being. Satish replied with this:

“If I don’t get food some days, I will consider it my opportunity to fast, and if I don’t get shelter some days, I will take it as an opportunity to sleep in a hotel of a million stars. Surely that will be better than a five-star hotel!”

That made me laugh, but it’s also a wonderful reminder that, at any moment, we can use mindfulness to shift our perspective. What seems like hardship—sleeping outside, for example—can become a stay in a “million-star hotel” 😊

So, the question for us is: Are we overlooking any metaphorical million-star hotels because we’re so focused on finding a five-star one?

(#555) Tied into the Universe of Physics

“The lungs are tied into the universe of physics like no other organ, perfectly using the space allotted to maximize flow. And optimizing flow, and movement, is clearly one of the purposes of life from a biological perspective.” – Michael J Stephen, *Breath Taking*

Nothing too practical today, just a reminder of the beautiful design of the lungs, perfectly structured to maximize flow. And since maximizing flow and movement is a primary purpose of life—not just biologically, but mentally and spiritually as well—this can also serve as a prompt for expressing wonder and appreciation for this simple yet amazing process of breathing 🙏

(#556) Finding and Becoming “Generative” People

“Erik Erikson calls someone at this stage a ‘generative’ person, one who is eager and able to generate life from his or her own abundance and for the benefit of following generations. ... They once worshiped their raft; now they love the shore where it has taken them. They once defended signposts; now they have arrived where the signs pointed. They now enjoy the moon itself instead of fighting over whose finger points to it most accurately, quickly, or definitively.” – Richard Rohr, *Falling Upward*

Not only is this an incredible quality to strive for, but it’s also a characteristic we can seek out in teachers, coaches, and authors. So, here’s to finding and becoming “generative” people, so we can “enjoy the moon itself instead of fighting over whose finger points to it most accurately, quickly, or definitively” 🙌

(#557) The Only Cure

“I believe I know the only cure, which is to make one’s center of life inside of one’s self, not selfishly or excludingly, but with a kind of unassailable serenity—to decorate one’s inner house so richly that one is content there, glad to welcome anyone who wants to come and stay, but happy all the same when one is inevitably alone.” - Edith Wharton

P.S. On weekend, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and reflect upon 🙏

(#558) Wrapped in a Blanket of Simplicity

"The solutions to outwardly complex problems...will not arise from complicated analytical theory, but will emerge as an insight, wrapped in a blanket of simplicity." – Sydney Banks

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy 🙏

(#559) Pretending to be Asleep

“You can’t wake a person who is pretending to be asleep.” – Navajo Proverb

I got this quote when I opened Insight Timer one morning, and it felt like getting metaphorically slapped in the face 😊 It’s a humble reminder of the areas of my life where I’m “pretending to be asleep” because I don’t want to change (or admit that change is needed).

At the same time, it’s also a great reminder to focus on our own growth rather than trying to convince others to make changes they may not be ready for.

So, let’s remember: We can’t wake someone pretending to be asleep—including ourselves.

(#560) The Power of Intention

“Intention plays an important role in each moment of consciousness: it determines the objects of subsequent moments of consciousness. The stronger our intention to attend to a particular object, the more moments of attention will subsequently be focused on that object.” – The Mind Illuminated

Just a powerful reminder of the power of intention. And although this was discussing meditation, it applies perfectly to life in general. When we intend to be good people, or intend to live more joyfully, or intend to be more caring and compassionate, then “more moments of attention will subsequently be focused” on cultivating these qualities, and they’ll gradually become part of who we are 🙏

(#561) The 10/15/75 Formula for Thinking

“There is a formula for this: 10 percent of thinking can be concerned with the past, 15 percent with the future, and the remaining 75 percent with the present. When we live mostly in the present, we can move easily, step by step. We can respond to events with an open heart and an open mind.” – Satish Kumar, *Elegant Simplicity*

I loved this formula for thinking. And, of course, we’re not going to actually measure all our thoughts and adhere to it perfectly (at least, I hope none of us do 😊). But it serves as a reminder that we will always spend time thinking back to the past and forward to the future — that’s part of being human. So, our aim is just to do our best to “live mostly in the present” so we can “respond to events with an open heart and an open mind.” 🙏

(#562) Pulling Out the Stakes

“The best advice I ever got was from an elephant trainer in the jungle outside Bangalore. I was doing a hike through the jungle as a tourist. I saw these large elephants tethered to a small stake. I asked him: ‘How can you keep such a large elephant tied to such a small stake’ He said: ‘When the elephants are small, they try to pull out the stake and they fail. When they grow large, they never try to pull out the stake again.’” -Vivek Paul, found in Philosophy for Polar Explorers

Wow. What a vivid metaphor and reminder for all of us to begin looking for any “stakes” we might be tied to that we can now easily pull out. Then, with that awareness, we can mindfully start loosening and pulling them out 🙏

(#563) Flexible Optimism

“Put simply, optimism is the belief that the conditions of things can and will get better. But being optimistic obviously shouldn’t mean being careless. The American psychologist Martin Seligman advocates what he calls “flexible optimism,” which factors in risks rather than blind belief in positive outcomes. When the cost of miscalculating is severe, then it is time to be decidedly pessimistic. But when there’s little to lose by being gung-ho and optimistic, then go for it!” – Erling Kagge, Philosophy for Polar Explorers

As a naturally optimistic and idealistic person (often to my detriment 😅), I love this idea of “flexible optimism.” When the consequences are severe, it’s wise to be pessimistic. But when they’re not, gung-ho optimism it is. Mindfulness comes in by helping us decide which situations are which...

(#564) Few Persons Realize

“Few persons realize that health actually varies according to the amount of laughter.” – James J. Walsh, MD, PhD

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and, in this case, one you can put into practice today 😊

(#565) No Wise Person Ever Wanted This

“No wise person ever wanted to be younger.” – Jonathan Swift

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy 🙏

(#566) Going for an Internal Jog

“Hearty laughter is a good way to jog internally without having to go outdoors.” – Norman Cousins

Ha! That’s a great analogy and reminder to take a daily “internal jog” this week using the most therapeutic breathing exercise of all—laughter. No treadmills required 😊

(#567) Because There is More Light Here

Here is Erling Kagge talking about mullah Nasruddin, a 13th-century Sufi satirist:

“Once, a man found him searching for something on the ground outside his house. When asked, Nasruddin replied that he was looking for his key. The man joined him in the search, but in due course asked the mullah: ‘Where exactly did you drop this key?’

The mullah answered happily: ‘Inside my house.’

‘Then why on earth are you looking here?’ the man asked, quite baffled.

‘Because there is more light here than there is in my house,’ replied the mullah.”

This made me laugh, but it also raises a question for us: Are we looking for any “keys” in the wrong places simply because it’s easier to stay in the light than look in the dark?

(#568) Entire Fields are Dedicated to This

“The brain’s metabolic-energetic coupling to respiration is at odds with how neuroscientists methodologically treat respiration. Respiration-related neural activity is typically considered noise, and entire fields are dedicated to stripping it from brain data.” – Neuroscience Bulletin (2023) (<https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s12264-023-01070-5>)

I just started reading this fascinating paper on Monday, but I had to share this quote immediately 😊. The breath’s influence on the brain is so pervasive that “entire fields are dedicated to stripping it from brain data.” How crazy is that?

It’s a powerful reminder: although we often talk about the breath’s impact on the nervous system, its profound effects on the brain may be the most robust (yet least appreciated) of all...

P.S. The paper is titled “From Lung to Brain: Respiration Modulates Neural and Mental Activity.” The researchers definitely are not treating breathing as noise in this one 😊. I’m excited to get through it and share their findings in our next 411.

New Book 411: The Mind Illuminated

“Repeating simple tasks with a clear intention can reprogram unconscious mental processes. This can completely transform who you are as a person.”

A new Book 411 was just released in the Learning Center on The Mind Illuminated: A Complete Meditation Guide Integrating Buddhist Wisdom and Brain Science.

This book was packed with wisdom on training the mind. If you're into meditation or learning how the mind works, I highly recommend it. The 411 has my five favorite ideas covering mind wandering, mindfulness, and the power of conscious intention.

[Click here to read or listen to the 411.](#)

I hope you enjoy it!

In good breath,
Nick

(#569) Learning to Live

“In the practice of meditation you become sensitive to the actual experience of living, to how things actually feel. You do not sit around developing sublime thoughts about living. You live...meditation, more than anything else, is learning to live.” – Bhante Gunaratana, *Mindfulness in Plain English*

What a wonderful reminder that meditation—and all our other contemplative practices—are not a means of escaping life. Quite the opposite: They are actually a way of learning to live, a way to become more “sensitive to the actual experience of living.”

It brings to mind this insightful quote from Eknath Easwaran: “So try to remember every day that you are participating in meditation even at breakfast, at work, at school, in the garden, everywhere.” 🙏

(#570) Finding Purpose on Life's Different Paths

“When I’ve actively searched for happiness, I’ve never found it. I don’t deny that others can find one single absolute meaning for life, but I haven’t managed it. In my experience, the meaning of life changes from day to day, from year to year, and from person to person. The challenge for me, therefore, is to find purpose on life’s different paths.” – Erling Kagge, Philosophy for Polar Explorers

How good is that? It reminded me of Dr. Gladys’ puzzle pieces: “We’re able to connect with life best when we get juice from multiple places. A puzzle piece doesn’t just click in on one side; it clicks in on two, three, or four.”

So here’s to using our practices to “find purpose on life’s different paths” as we grow and our meaning of life changes day by day, year to year 🙌

(#571) Someone Else's

"If the path before you is clear, you're probably on someone else's." – Joseph Campbell

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#572) One Hundred Percent Honest

“Mindfulness practice is the practice of being 100 percent honest with ourselves.” – Bhante Gunaratana

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#573) A Miniature Model of Life

“When we truly observe the breath, we are automatically placed in the present. We are pulled out of the morass of mental images and into a bare experience of the here and now. In this sense, breath is a living slice of reality. A mindful observation of such a miniature model of life itself leads to insights that are broadly applicable to the rest of our experience.” – Bhante Gunaratana, Mindfulness in Plain English (<https://amzn.to/3NYuQHM>)

That sums it up perfectly: “Breath is a living slice of reality. A mindful observation of such a miniature model of life itself leads to insights that are broadly applicable to the rest of our experience.” I have nothing else to add but several of these 🙏🙏🙏

(#574) Not That Crazy, After All

“Respiration, being so closely coupled to heart activity and oxygen supply, is key in maintaining metabolic activity in all organs including the brain. Given the increased efficiency of aerobic over anaerobic conditions in cellular energy dynamics, one might predict that the brain should be optimized to maximize its direct coupling with the systems that supply its metabolism.” – Neuroscience Bulletin (2023)

As an educator and all-around breath nerd, sometimes it seems ridiculous all the ways breathing influences the body—you start to wonder if you’ve gone crazy 😊

But then I read something like this and remember it’s just basic physiology: Cells prefer aerobic metabolism, which breathing supplies the oxygen for. So, of course the entire body (including the heart and brain) would be intricately connected to the very process fueling its energy.

In fact, it’d be crazier if it wasn’t...

(#575) Life is Far Too Important To Be...

“At some point in your meditation career you will be struck with the seriousness of what you are actually doing. You are tearing down the wall of illusion you have always used to explain life to yourself and to shield yourself from the intense flame of reality. You are about to meet ultimate truth face to face. That is scary. But it has to be dealt with eventually. Go ahead and dive right in.” – Bhante Gunaratana, Mindfulness in Plain English (<https://amzn.to/3NYuQHM>)

That’s pretty intense, but sometimes it’s inspiring to be reminded of the transformative potential of our meditation and breathing practices.

Yet, in true monk-like fashion, it’s also worth balancing that perspective with this equally true viewpoint attributed to Oscar Wilde: “Life is far too important to be taken seriously.” 😊

(#576) The Necessary Path

“The world mythologies all point to places like Hades, Sheol, hell, purgatory, the realm of the dead. Maybe these are not so much the alternative to heaven as the necessary path to heaven.”
– Richard Rohr, *Falling Upward*

That one certainly deserves a “wow.” Are you going through any minor (or major) hells or purgatories right now? (Since you’re human, I’ll bet there’s a 99.9999% chance you are 😊). The timeless wisdom of the world’s mythologies suggests that these are not “the opposite of heaven” but may actually be “the necessary path” to discovering our own version of it...

(#577) It Is a Nexus Point

“That point at the tip of the nostril can be viewed as a sort of a window between the inner and outer worlds. It is a nexus point and energy transfer spot where stuff from the outside world moves in and becomes a part of what we call “me,” and where a part of “me” flows forth to merge with the outside world. There are lessons to be learned here about self-identity and how we form it.” – Bhante Gunaratana, Mindfulness in Plain English (<https://amzn.to/3NYuQHM>)

How good is that? And one of the many lessons to be learned is that we are not separate from the world around us; we are (quite literally) connected to it: “We” absorb pieces of “it,” and it absorbs pieces of us. The breath just reminds us that the boundary between “we” and “it” is somewhat of an illusion 🙏

P.S. That idea brought to mind this equally good quote from James Nestor’s *Breath*: “To breathe is to absorb ourselves in what surrounds us, to take in little bits of life, understand them, and give pieces of ourselves back out. Respiration is, at its core, reciprocation.”

(#578) Nothing in Us Wants to Believe It

“We grow spiritually much more by doing it wrong than by doing it right. That might just be the central message of how spiritual growth happens; yet nothing in us wants to believe it.” – Richard Rohr

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate.

P.P.S. And for this one, I’d say it applies not just to spiritual growth, but to growth in all of life 😊

(#579) Inherent Connectedness

“Breath is a phenomenon common to all living things. A true experiential understanding of the process moves you closer to other living beings. It shows you your inherent connectedness with all of life.” – Bhante Gunaratana

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#580) Helping You Deal with All of Life's Challenges

“I think that working with the breath can be a very powerful technique to center the mind, to help you work more effectively, to help you deal with all of the challenges that life throws in your way every day, and to really turn your direction away from the material world toward the non-physical world.” – Andrew Weil, MD

This is more inspirational than practical, but it's a powerful reminder that the breath can “help you deal with all of the challenges that life throws in your way.” So, whether it's through breath awareness or deliberate breath control, make sure you put it to good use today 😊

(#581) Investigate This Possibility

“Could it be that our encounters with partners, colleagues, and strangers hold the same potential to liberate us as sitting in a solitary room, mindful of breath? I encourage you all to investigate this possibility. As you do, it might help to remember the simple and beautiful words of the Chan master Sheng Yen: ‘Practice should not be separated from living, and living at all times should be one’s practice.’” – Larry Rosenberg, *Three Steps to Awakening*

Here’s something to try today: See if you can use mindfulness to turn “encounters with partners, colleagues, and strangers” into part of your practice. Remember: “Practice should not be separated from living, and living at all times should be one’s practice.” 🙏

P.S. For me, this means deliberately cultivating love and acceptance for whoever I’m encountering. And, of course, it also means intentionally nurturing humor and laughter whenever possible 😊.

From Lung to Brain: New Science 411

“We, therefore, propose that an individual’s respiratory rhythm serves a fundamental, intrinsic role that modulates the topography and dynamics of the whole brain. Going beyond respiration-brain coupling, this opens the door for the application of respiration as a therapeutic technique in mental disorders.”

Our breathing rate might serve “a fundamental, intrinsic role that modulates the topography and dynamics of the whole brain.” How cool is that?

If you’d like to learn more about it, we have a new Science 411 on this paper: From Lung to Brain: Respiration Modulates Neural and Mental Activity.

[Click here to read or listen.](#)

I hope you enjoy it!

In good breath,
Nick

(#582) We Cannot Plan Our Enlightenment

“Any attempt to engineer or plan your own enlightenment is doomed to failure because it will be ego driven. You will see only what you have already decided to look for, and you cannot see what you are not ready or told to look for. So failure and humiliation force you to look where you never would otherwise.” – Richard Rohr, *Falling Upward*

Wow, what a humbling reminder that our failures, misfortunes, and times of humiliation are not obstacles but, indeed, are necessary for our growth. Without them, we might not have found breathing, meditation, yoga, or [insert your favorite practice].

And maybe the most humbling part is remembering that, as much as we’d like to be spared from them, our continued failures and humiliations are necessary for our continued growth, nudging us to keep looking where we would not have otherwise...

(#583) Practice for the “Game”

“We must never forget, however, that seated meditation itself is not the game. It’s the practice. The game in which those basic skills are to be applied is the rest of one’s experiential existence. ... Those periods of seated practice are times set aside for instilling new mental habits. You learn new ways to receive and understand sensation. You develop new methods of dealing with conscious thought and new modes of attending to the incessant rush of your own emotions. These new mental behaviors must be made to carry over into the rest of your life.” – Bhante Gunaratana, Mindfulness in Plain English (<https://amzn.to/3NYuQHM>)

Just a reminder that all our contemplative practices—meditation, breathing, yoga, tai chi, etc.—are just that: practice. The “game” is applying what we learn to the rest of life 😊

(#584) Wholeness and Holiness

“Psychological wholeness and spiritual holiness never exclude the problem from the solution. **If it is wholeness, then it is always paradoxical, and holds both the dark and light sides of things.** Wholeness and holiness will always stretch us beyond our small comfort zone. How could they not?” – Richard Rohr, *Falling Upward*

Ekhnath Easwaran reminds us: “Perhaps the simplest expression of our goal in meditation is that we are trying to make ourselves whole.” I would wager this is the goal of any mind-body practice.

And if we are to truly do that, let’s remember that we will have to hold both the light and dark side of things, the problem and the solution. We must accept all of ourselves—even the parts we want to change—if we are to truly experience wholeness 🙏

(#585) Another Word for Self-Discipline

“There is another word for self-discipline. It is patience.” – Bhante Gunaratana

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#586) Return a Different Person

“It is quite possible to leave your home for a walk in the early morning air and return a different person.” – Mary Ellen Chase

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy.

P.P.S. This idea also applies to sitting and breathing or meditating: Although you don’t physically go anywhere, you return a different person 🙏.

(#587) Returning a “Different Person” (Part II)

“The purpose of meditation is personal transformation. The ‘you’ that goes in one side of the meditation experience is not the same ‘you’ that comes out the other side. Meditation changes your character by a process of sensitization, by making you deeply aware of your own thoughts, words, and deeds. Your arrogance evaporates, and your antagonism dries up. Your mind becomes still and calm.” – Bhante Gunaratana, Mindfulness in Plain English
(<https://amzn.to/3NYuQHM>)

Here’s another great reminder that the person who goes into a meditation/breathing/etc. session is not the same as the one that comes out. However, it’s not that we become “different people”—it’s that we become more of us. With each session, we uncover a new part of our true self while losing (at least temporarily) a part of the disguise we’ve built. So, the “you” that comes out is simply more you 🙏.

(#588) Most Things Are Easy Thereafter

“Getting out of one’s sleeping bag isn’t just the greatest challenge on an expedition, it’s also the most vital. Most things are easy thereafter.” – Erling Kagge, *Philosophy for Polar Explorers*

We might say that breathing and meditation help us get out of our metaphorical sleeping bags—our mental narratives and social masks—that we didn’t even know we were in. And paradoxically, once we leave the comfort and warmth of that predictable space, “most things are easy thereafter.”

(#589) Worry and Frustration

“Worry is the belief that we can control the future.” – Tracy Dennis-Tiwary, Ph.D., *Future Tense: Why Anxiety Is Good for Your (Even Though It Feels Bad)*

How’s that for a succinct (and humbling) reframing of worry?

Here’s a complementary viewpoint on frustration from Buddhist monk Shantideva: “If there is a remedy, then what is the use of frustration? If there is no remedy, then what is the use of frustration?” That’s so good, and it could also be applied to worry.

Now, worry and frustration often motivate us to take action, so they do have some benefits. But these quotes are great reminders that, most of the time, our worry and frustration are unneeded—and unhelpful.

(#590) A Humorous (and insightful) Story on Optimism

Here is Erling Kagge discussing an uneven battle (outnumbered ten to one) that a great warrior named Nobunaga faced—guaranteed to make you smile or laugh, and then perhaps think:

“Nobunaga attacked an enemy force which outnumbered him ten to one. His odds weren’t looking good. But Nobunaga turned to the spiritual world for help. He stopped at a Shinto sanctuary and told the troops that, after praying, ‘I will toss a coin. If heads come up, we will win; if tails, we will lose. Destiny holds us in her hand.’ He prayed silently, then tossed the coin. It came up heads, and his soldiers, inspired by the omen, crushed the enemy. ‘No one can change the hand of destiny,’ remarked his attendant sagaciously after the battle was won. ‘Indeed not,’ said Nobunaga, showing him the coin he had tossed. It was double-headed.”

(#591) Sheath of Breath and Setting Fire to Food

“The second sheath is called the sheath of breath, prānamaya-kośa. The breath oxidizes the food; the breath turns it into life. That’s this thing, this body: food on fire.” – Joseph Campbell, Pathways to Bliss

Our body is, in some ways, “food on fire.” We eat, and our breathing provides oxygen to translate that food into energy (ATP) via cellular respiration. It can be likened to a controlled fire, with oxygen providing the spark for a continuous, life-giving burn. How awesome is that for a visual?

And while there’s absolutely nothing practical about today’s 1% (😂), it is pretty astonishing to imagine our bodies as “food on fire” as a way of cultivating mindfulness around the extraordinary power of the breath.

(#592) All Part of the Universal Rhythm

“The expansion and contraction of the abdomen, lower abdomen, and chest are parts of the universal rhythm. Everything in the universe has the same rhythm of expansion and contraction just like our breath and body. All of them are rising and falling.” – Bhante Gunaratana

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏.

(#593) Don't Ask, Walk

“No one can build you the bridge on which you, and only you, must cross the river of life...There is one path in the world that none can walk but you. Where does it lead? Don't ask, walk!” – Friedrich Nietzsche

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏.

(#594) Our Own Pathway to Bliss

“You enter the forest at the darkest point, where there is no path. Where there’s a way or path, it is someone else’s path; each human being is a unique phenomenon. The idea is to find your own pathway to bliss.” – Joseph Campbell, Pathways to Bliss

How good is that? It applies perfectly to breathing and mindfulness.

Of course, learning from others is essential for safety and effectiveness reasons. But ultimately, we’re each unique, so it’s up to us to find our own individual pathway to bliss—and help those we coach find theirs.

(#595) The “Common Currency” of Breath, Brain, and Mind

“The synchronization between respiration and slow neural activity is likely key to understanding the brain-physiology relationship. Higher degrees of coupling between respiration and brain activity likely manifest as the inverse of symptoms of panic disorder (e.g., relaxation, greater attention, and more measured thoughts). Slow rhythms thus provide a link and shared feature of respiration, neural, and mental activity serving as their ‘common currency’.” – From Lung to Brain (2023)

How neat is this? Speed acts as a “common currency” that the breath, brain, and mind accept. This means when we slow our breathing, the brain and mind accept that as payment and slow down in return. The result is relaxation, better attention, and calmer thoughts.

So, today’s 1% is to remember that the speed of your breath directly influences the speed of your brain and mind, serving as a universal currency you can use as needed 🙌

(#596) The Third Level of Morality

“There is a third level of morality, which might better be termed as “ethics.” This level is a quantum leap up the scale from the first two levels, a complete shift in orientation. At the level of ethics, a person does not follow hard and fast rules dictated by authority. A person chooses to follow a path dictated by mindfulness, wisdom, and compassion. This level requires real intelligence, and an ability to juggle all the factors in every situation to arrive at a unique, creative, and appropriate response each time.” – Bhante Gunaratana, Mindfulness in Plain English (<https://amzn.to/3NYuQHM>)

How powerful is that? I think it's a primary goal of all the mindful arts: To arrive at a place where we naturally choose a path guided by mindfulness, wisdom, and compassion. And luckily, this happens almost naturally when our intentions with our practice and life are clear and aligned with who we want to become 🙏

(#597) Transparent to the Transcendent

Here is Joseph Campbell beautifully describing how the demands of daily life often disconnect us from our Life Force:

“Now, the mind that thinks, the eyes that see, they can become so involved in concepts and local, temporal tasks that we become bound up and don’t let this energy flow through. And then we become sick. The energy is blocked, and we are thrown off center; this idea is very similar to the tenets of traditional Chinese and Indian medicine. So the psychological problem, the way to keep from becoming blocked, is to make yourself—and here is the phrase—transparent to the transcendent. It’s as easy as that.”

“Transparent to the transcendent.” Aside from moral beauty, that’s one of the best word combinations I’ve encountered.

So here’s to using our breath and meditation practices to regularly reconnect to our Life Force so that we may, with time, become transparent to the transcendent 🙏

(#598) Head and Heart

“It’s time to drop the old notions of separation between emotion and science—for ourselves and our future. Just as rivers join on their way to the ocean, to understand Blue Mind we need to draw together separate streams: analysis and affection; elation and experimentation; head and heart.” – Wallace J Nichols, Blue Mind

Nichols was talking about his concept of Blue Mind, but I thought this applied perfectly to the mixed mindful arts. To build a lasting, holistic practice, we need analysis and affection, elation and experimentation, and head and heart. If we balance these two components (rather than treating them as mutually exclusive), we’re bound to better connect with our life force and—to steal a phrase from yesterday—become “transparent to the transcendent.” 🙌

(#599) Full Depths of Human Potential

“The integration of a wide variety of perspectives is necessary for a more complete understanding of the full depths of human potential, as too much focus on a single perspective runs the risk of giving a distorted view of human nature.” - Scott Barry Kaufman, Ph.D.

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy 🙏

(#600) Tunneling Toward this Infinite Reservoir

“A full reservoir of love is lying right inside us. In meditation we are digging deep into our own consciousness, tunneling toward this infinite reservoir that lies waiting to be discovered and manifested in our daily life.” – Eknath Easwaran

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate.

P.P.S. Although I used to be apprehensive about it, I’ve found that loving-kindness mediation (the one on this page is what I do daily <https://breathlearning.com/breath-practices/>) can truly help us tap into this reservoir 🙏

Mindfulness in Plain English (new Book 411)

“Meditation takes gumption. It is certainly a great deal easier just to sit back and watch television. So why bother? Why waste all that time and energy when you could be out enjoying yourself? Why? Simple. Because you are human.”

Hey folks,

We have a new Book 411 available on Mindfulness in Plain English by Bhante Gunaratana. This was an amazing, foundational book on meditation and mindfulness. And hopefully by the end of Thought #1, you'll be convinced that meditation is worth the “gumption” required.

Here's what we cover in the 411:

Why We Meditate: It's a Simpler Reason than You May Think

The Three Activities of Mindfulness

The Nasal Nexus Point and Inherent Connectedness

The Third Level of Morality: What We're After

And the 1 Life-Changing Idea: A Miniature Slice of Life (and all of life)

Click here to read or listen to it. (<https://breathlearning.com/book-411s/mindfulness-in-plain-english>)

I hope you enjoy it, and have a great week ahead!

In good breath,
Nick

(#601) Heroic Failure

“In Britain there’s an expression I haven’t encountered anywhere else: “heroic failure.” There’s something stoic about striving that bit extra, in solving problems as each one arises. The manner in which one fails is decisive too; if it’s done in the way a Brit considers stylish, an amateurish but heroic attempt characterized by courage and backbreaking toil may be greater than achieving the goal itself.” – Erling Kagge, *Philosophy for Polar Explorers*

This made me laugh thinking of all the “heroic failures” I’ve had. But it also reminded me of how awesome humans are: that we love “amateurish, backbreaking toil” simply because we love someone who gives it their all. Just giving such an effort is often more important than achieving the goal itself.

So, here’s to making (and embracing) many of our own heroic failures as we mindfully carve our unique path through life 🙌

(#602) Unity of the Voluntary and Involuntary

“Breath is a curious operation because it can be experienced as both a voluntary doing and an involuntary happening. You could do a breathing exercise and feel that “I am breathing” in just the same way as you can feel “I am walking.” But on the other hand, you breathe all the time when you’re not thinking about it. And in that way, it’s involuntary. You must breathe. And so it is the faculty attending to which we can realize the unity of the voluntary and involuntary systems.” – Alan Watts, *Still the Mind*

Here is another reminder of the power of breathing. We can control it and see that “we are breathing.” At the same time, we can observe it and see that, as Eddie Stern tells us, “We are literally being breathed by the atmosphere all through the day, all through our lives.” The insight and control this brings is why breath awareness and breath exercises have been used for millennia for self-realization 🧘.

(#603) A Gymnasium of the Soul

“I sometimes compare this to a visit to a gymnasium. The trainer looks at us and says, ‘Well, your arms are not bad, but your legs are very flabby.’ So we go on the machines and work out. The reason to work hard on those machines is to become strong...If they are too easy, we find more difficult equipment...There is also the idea that life itself is a gymnasium of the soul...Life is where we have our workout, this is where we train. We shouldn’t avoid challenges or only work out on the easy machines.” – Jetsunma Tenzin Palmo, The Heroic Heart (<https://amzn.to/3ZAXog2>)

Life is a gymnasium of the soul. That’s so good. For physical strength, we head to the regular gym. But to test our breathing and meditation practices and build soul strength, we head to the life’s gymnasium. So here’s to getting off the easy machines and embracing life’s inevitable challenges as part of our soul’s training 🙌.

(#604) Noticing for Real Life

“In meditation, you put your attention on one item. When your mind wanders from this focus, it is mindfulness that reminds you that your mind is wandering and what you are supposed to be doing. It is mindfulness that brings your mind back to the object of meditation.” – Bhante Gunaratana, Mindfulness in Plain English (<https://breathlearning.com/book-411s/mindfulness-in-plain-english/>)

To me, this “noticing” of when your mind has gotten off track is the most critical aspect of mindfulness. And it applies perfectly to life in general: When we’re not being the person we want to be, or not focusing at work, or looking at our phones instead of our kids, mindfulness is that “ah ha” moment when we realize we’ve gotten off track. So, through training it in the morning via breathing or meditation, we’re actually training a powerful skill for living a better life



(#605) “I’ve Been Helping the Wheat Grow”

“Once upon a time in China, there was a farming family, and they were having dinner. The oldest son came in late, and they asked him, “Why are you late for dinner?”

“Oh,” he said, “I’ve been helping the wheat to grow.”

They came out the next morning and all the wheat was dead. It turned out that the son had pulled each stalk up a little bit, to help it grow.” – Alan Watts, Still the Mind

Here is a little humor wrapped around a powerful message. As Watts puts it, “The point is that growth always occurs in a being as it does in a plant, and it is perfect at every step.”

So here’s to enjoying our own unique growth process, knowing that in some way, regardless of how slow it may feel at times, “it is perfect at every step.” 🙌

P.S. At the risk of making this too long, I can’t help but share one of my favorite parables, which we saw back in TB1% #320: “A disciple asks a Zen master: ‘How long does it take to be able to experience Awakening?’ ‘Maybe 20 years,’ answers the master. ‘And if I am in a hurry?’ asks the disciple again. ‘In that case, it is 50 years,’ concludes the master.” – Steven Laureys, MD.

(#606) Where Trouble Comes From

“The trouble comes into the world largely because various beings take themselves seriously, instead of playfully.” – Alan Watts

P.S. On weekends, I just send a short memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏.

(#607) Making Sense of What the Brain Thinks Is True

“Moving in the world and interacting with it are the best way to make sense of what the brain thinks is true.” – Caroline Williams

P.S. On weekends, I just send a succinct yet memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate



(#608) The Universe Exploring Itself

“When you take a scientific point of view, your organism is inseparable from its environment, and so you really are the organism/environment. In other words, you are no less than the universe, and each one of you is the universe expressed in the particular place that you feel is here and now. You are an aperture through which the universe is looking at itself and exploring itself.” – Alan Watts, Still the Mind

We are each an aperture through which the universe explores itself. How insane and mind-blowing is that perspective?

To have some fun with it, we could say that us practicing mindfulness is the equivalent of the universe practicing meta-awareness. And when we practice meta-awareness, then the universe is practicing meta-meta-awareness. I hope your head is officially spinning like mine is now 🤪

(#609) Lasting Happiness and Inner Joy

“I remember one sociologist, who was not a Buddhist, said that it had recently been shown that people have a certain level of basic happiness. That level may vary slightly for different people, but each has a basic level. If, for example, someone wins the lottery, their happiness level goes up for a time and then the next year it returns to that individual’s normal level. Or if someone has a terrible accident and becomes disabled, their happiness goes down, but then after a while it comes back up again.

The sociologist said that the only thing they have ever found that raises the happiness level and keeps it raised is meditation, because it gives one an inner joy that is not dependent on outer things. So provided they carry on practicing, they can sustain this feeling of well-being and joy.” – Jetsunma Tenzin Palmo, *The Heroic Heart* (<https://amzn.to/3ZAXog2>)



P.S. I’d wager that part of this lasting joy comes from how consistent practice (somewhat paradoxically) makes us more humorous, helping us laugh more while taking ourselves less seriously.

(#610) However We Got Here

“No one really knows exactly why our species lucked out and got the skills to deliberately control the muscles that affect the way we breathe...However we got here, we have ended up with a powerful tool. You don’t have to be fit or flexible, strong or even particularly mobile to take advantage of its benefits: it’s surprisingly easy. And, let’s face it, modern life offers many situations where it would be an advantage to take control of your physiological, mental and emotional state.” – Caroline Williams, *Move*

Just our periodic reminder of how lucky we are to have the gift of breath control. And our reminder to occasionally use this tool, remembering that “modern life offers many situations where it would be an advantage to take control of your physiological, mental and emotional state” 🙏

P.S. And let us also remember that breath control isn’t always necessary—our bodies often know exactly what to do. The art is knowing when to go with the flow, and when to deliberately take control.

(#611) Sincere but Never Serious

“You must understand that I am not a serious person. I may be sincere, but never serious, because I don’t think the universe is serious. And the trouble comes into the world largely because various beings take themselves seriously, instead of playfully.” – Alan Watts, *Still the Mind*

“I may be sincere, but never serious.” That might just be my new life motto. It perfectly captures the paradox of giving life every ounce of energy we have while simultaneously laughing at ourselves and approaching it all with humor and playfulness.

So here’s to cultivating a little more sincerity—and a lot less seriousness—today 🙏

(#612) That's It

“If we only practice when all the outer conditions seem nice but not when people are noisy, or when there are problems, or when we are feeling ill, or something adverse comes up, then we don't know how to practice. We have to learn how to use our life—everything in our life—as our practice. That's it.” – Jetsunma Tenzin Palmo, *The Heroic Heart* (<https://amzn.to/3ZAXog2>)

That truly is it 🙏

(#613) What You Absolutely Must Do

“But I do know what bliss is: that deep sense of being present, of doing what you absolutely must do to be yourself.” – Joseph Campbell

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#614) This Is the Whole Art

“In any athletic discipline, the alignment of body and breath is critical. The synchronization of what you are doing with your breathing is the whole art.” – Alan Watts

P.S. On weekends, I just send a short and memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate



(#615) While Nature Cures the Disease

“The art of medicine consists of amusing the patient while nature cures the disease.” - Voltaire

This made me smile and then laugh internally. It also made me wonder if something similar may be said of all our contemplative practices. Perhaps breathing and meditation simply keep the mind occupied so nature can heal our soul...

(#616) The Ego Hates This

“It is also helpful to maintain a sense of humor, as it greatly diffuses anger and humiliation. If we can see the funny side of things then we can laugh. The ego hates to be laughed at; it takes itself very seriously, so it is important to practice not taking ourselves so seriously whenever the opportunity arises.” – Jetsunma Tenzin Palmo, *The Heroic Heart* (<https://amzn.to/3ZAXog2>)

Maybe I’m biased, but it seems like every book I’ve read on mindful living lately emphasizes the importance of humor. So let us remember that the ego hates to be laughed at, and then use that as our reminder to not take ourselves so seriously anytime we have the chance 😊

P.S. It brings to mind this quote we recently enjoyed in TB1% #606: “The trouble comes into the world largely because various beings take themselves seriously, instead of playfully.” – Alan Watts

<https://breathlearning.com/the-breathing-1/number-606/>

A New Study on Mouth Taping

“This is the first comprehensive literature review on nocturnal mouth-taping. It aims to ascertain what research is available that evaluates mouth-taping during sleep and to summarize this research. Additionally, it compares these research findings with the most common claims regarding mouth-taping on TikTok” - Fangmeyer et al. (2024)

A new Science 411 has been added to the Learning Center on a study published earlier this month on mouth-taping.

As a big fan of mouth-taping, I view this study as essential reading. It distinguishes between proven benefits and anecdotal claims, offering the first review that coaches and educators can rely on to provide evidence-based information to the people they work with.

[Click here to read or listen to it.](#)

I hope you enjoy it!

In good breath,
Nick

(#617) Perfection is Handling Imperfection

“If there is such a thing as human perfection, it seems to emerge precisely from how we handle the imperfection that is everywhere, especially our own. ... A ‘perfect’ person ends up being one who can consciously forgive and include imperfection rather than one who thinks he or she is totally above and beyond imperfection. ... In fact, I would say that the demand for the perfect is the greatest enemy of the good. Perfection is a mathematical or divine concept, goodness is a beautiful human concept that includes us all.” – Richard Rohr, *Falling Upward*

How’s that for a perfect reframing of perfection? 😊 It’s a nice reminder that we’ll never be perfect—in life or our contemplative practices. But we can always aim for goodness, which is a human concept, which includes us all.

(#618) Goodwill Can Naturally Radiate Out

“We have to also work on cultivating our heart to become more open and spacious and loving and peaceful, starting from where we are right now, so that gradually goodwill can naturally begin to radiate out. Otherwise, if we are very taut like a drum, everything that touches us makes a loud noise. But if we are relaxed and soft inside like cotton wool, even if something hits us it doesn’t make any noise. Inside ourselves we should feel relaxed and peaceful with a sense of humor, more at home with ourselves, so that whatever happens on the outside will not be so difficult to handle; we can deal with it.” – Jetsunma Tenzin Palmo, The Heroic Heart

<https://amzn.to/3ZAXog2>

I have nothing to add except several of these 🦶🦶🦶

(#619) Tuning the Mind

“To begin with, it is our mental apparatus—our feelings, memories, and desires—that selects what we even perceive. Out of the vast confusion of data that our senses present, it is the mind that decides what registers. Anything that fails to fit our interests or understanding is not introduced to our attention. What we see—and therefore the world we live in, our world as opposed to others’—is a function of our own thinking.” – Eknath Easwaran, Original Goodness

Just a simple (yet often needed) reminder that we only notice what our minds are tuned to see: Everything we experience is a function of our thinking. So, by training our minds each morning via breathing and meditation, we tune them to be more focused and notice more goodness and joy around us 🙏

P.S. This is also precisely why I send these emails each day: to help you (and myself 😊) tune your mind toward more joyful and inspiring ideas, so we’ll notice more of them throughout the day.

(#620) The Entire Works

“Just as the ocean is waving so each one of us is a waving of the whole cosmos, the entire works, all there is.” – Alan Watts

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy 🙏

(#621) Life's Long Lesson

"Life is a long lesson in humility." – James M. Barrie

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable (and in this case, 100% verifiable 😊) quote for you to enjoy and contemplate.

(#622) Which Descends Deep into Our Lungs

“We are all sitting here, breathing in and breathing out the same air. I cannot say, “Excuse me, I don’t want you breathing my air!” Even if we were the bitterest enemies, fighting and shouting at each other, we are actually intimately connected because we are breathing in and breathing out the same air, which descends deep into our lungs.” – Jetsunma Tenzin Palmo, The Heroic Heart (<https://amzn.to/3ZAXog2>)

Just our periodic reminder that breathing not only gives us direct access to our nervous system, brain waves, and emotional state—it also connects us (literally and figuratively) to every living thing on this planet. It’s pretty remarkable to consider when you pause to think about it 🙏

(#623) 25 One-Sentence Breathing Ideas for 2025

This is my 5th year in a row doing these “one-sentence ideas.” I will share these publicly tomorrow on the 1st. But you get them early as a member 🙏.

P.S. Reply here and let me know which are your favorites!

1. Don't take ten breaths; take one breath, ten times.
2. The breath will continue to outgrow any clothing you give it.
3. You will float through life so long as you treat the breath as your ocean.
4. Don't go around air expecting not to breathe.
5. After 8 years of practice, I've never been able to watch my breath without changing it—that's the point; that is the lesson.
6. Laughter is like the Bruce Lee “be like water” of breathing exercises: it flows effortlessly, forms to any situation, and, given enough time, will erode any obstacle in its path.
7. Intention is gravity for your practice.
8. Every breath is life reaching for life.
9. Mindful breathing is a moving museum you can visit anytime.
10. Breath is both a miniature model of life and the whole of life itself.
11. There is a reason laughter is called lightheartedness and not lightheadedness.
12. Breathing is more of an expression of our life force than merely our connection to it.
13. Shining your attention on your breath is like a dimmer switch: even when it's not all the way up, it still helps you see better.
14. Scientific studies of breathing are timely and indispensable; personal experience with the breath is timeless and irreplaceable.
15. All life needs to move, and the airways and lungs are perfectly designed to optimize air movement to support life.
16. Breathing, with awareness, is gratitude.

17. A breath practice is a tool—not a requirement—for a good life.
18. Breathing and meditation keep the mind occupied so nature can heal our souls.
19. Mindfulness is thought meteorology; breath control is weather modification.
20. Slow, mindful breathing helps you feel underwhelmed for a change.
21. The best practice for breath appreciation is getting a stuffy nose.
22. Physiological gratitude occurs 20,000 times a day in the space where an exhale ends and an inhale begins.
23. The most common mistake in breathing is using the nose, lungs, and diaphragm, but not the heart.
24. Sometimes, the most mindful thing you can do is let your mind wander.
25. If you follow your breath, you may actually end up where you're going.

(#624) This Is What Counts

“Before doing anything, we should examine the underlying motivation, because as the Buddha said, “Karma is intention.” It is not so much what we do but why we do it. ... This is why when we are undertaking any action it is important for us to see as honestly as possible the underlying intention behind us performing this action of body or speech. ... It isn’t just the action performed or words that we speak, but how it is said or done and with what intention. That is what counts.”
– Jetsunma Tenzin Palmo, The Heroic Heart (<https://amzn.to/3ZAXog2>)

This is why taking a few moments to recall why you’re practicing—your intention—can deepen any breath or meditation session. And this principle applies to all of life: the more often we recall our intentions, the more fulfilling every moment will be. So here’s to focusing on intentions rather than worrying too much about outcomes because, as Jetsunma reminds us, it’s the intention that counts 🙏

(#625) Leather Shoes for Life

“In a well-known story from the Buddhist scriptures, the question is asked, “If the ground around you was covered with thorns, how would you best protect your feet?” ... The more skillful answer is, “I would make myself a pair of very thick-soled shoes so that no matter where I walk, I will be okay with whatever I encounter.”

Purifying the wind energy is similar to putting on a pair of shoes so we aren’t constantly pricked by thorns when we walk. ... We don’t need to shield ourselves from being hurt. Instead, we work at bringing the mind into balance so that we can deal with whatever life brings us.” – The Tibetan Yoga of Breath

Since wind energy refers to breathing in this context, we can simplify this as: Conscious breathing is a pair of leather shoes for life. Don’t forget to lace up today 😊

(#626) The Easiest Meditation Instructions

“Concentrate for one second. If, at the end of this time, your mind has wandered off, concentrate for another second, and then another. Nobody ever has to concentrate for more than one second—this one.” – Alan Watts, *Become What You Are*

Yep, that’s about as straightforward and low-pressure as it gets. I tried this during my breath “awareness” practice yesterday morning (aka trying to watch my breath while I actually end up slowing it down and deepening it 😊). It was really helpful for staying concentrated on each breath. If it seems right for you, give it a try and see how you feel 🙏

(#627) To Learn Something New

“To learn something new, take the path that you took yesterday.” - John Burroughs

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#628) How Harmony is Restored

“Rituals are the formulas by which harmony is restored.” – Terry Tempest Williams

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#629) The First Step on the Path

“Thus the first step on the Path is to know what you want, not what you *ought* to want. Only in this way can the pilgrim set out...fully prepared.” – Alan Watts, *Become What You Are*

How good is that? It reminded me of our discussion back in October that we don't want to “should on ourselves” all the time. And it's a great reminder that the mindful arts are not about figuring out what we “ought” or “should” do. Rather, as Don Campbell told us back in October, they're about finding “the most ecological way that we vibrate, resonate, empower ourselves with a sound life.” 🙌

(#630) Recharging Our Batteries

“A lot of people also run out of energy because they forget to recharge. We need to recharge our batteries by doing retreats or other things that help us to relax, that give us pleasure and make us laugh, because we don’t want to take ourselves too seriously. We all want to lighten up, don’t we?” – Jetsunma Tenzin Palmo, *The Heroic Heart* (<https://amzn.to/3ZAXog2>)

Here’s a perfect reminder for us to take time to recharge our batteries. Not only in big ways like retreats, but perhaps even more importantly, in tiny ways when we have a few extra minutes to laugh, to breathe, to walk, to read, or to listen. When we care for ourselves this way, we’re better able to serve others 🙏.

(#631) Taking Inspiration from the Environment

“Studies of brainwaves during breathing suggested that the strongest effect of synching up with breathing rate comes on an in-breath. It sounds a bit cheesy, but it’s also true: when we breathe, we are literally taking inspiration from the environment and the subtle clues that it contains.” – Caroline Williams, Move

How neat is that? Inhaling synchronizes our brainwaves because it’s literally our way of receiving and decoding subtle clues from the environment. And this synchronization means that information coming from breathing gets special attention in the brain, which is why deliberately changing how we breathe can profoundly impact our mental and emotional states.

As Williams also puts it: “inhaling brings information about the world and a chance for our brainwaves to beat to a common rhythm, changing the way we feel.” 🧘

(#632) You're Not Good or Bad at It (a way of being in the world)

"The only way you can talk about practice in the context of meditation is to use the word practice in the same way as when somebody says that they practice medicine. That is their way of life, their vocation, and they do it nearly every day." – Alan Watts, *Still the Mind*

When we talk about breathing, meditation, yoga, or any meaningful activity, we must treat our practice as just that: practice. It becomes part of who we are, not something we can be "good" or "bad" at. We just do it. It reminds me of this gem from Rick Rubin, which complements Watts perfectly:

"Living life as an artist is a practice.
You are either engaging in the practice or you're not.

It makes no sense to say you're not good at it.
It's like saying, "I'm not good at being a monk."
You are either living as a monk or you're not.

We tend to think of the artist's work as the output.

The real work of the artist is a way of being in the world."

(#633) Floating on a Raft Off the Coast

“There’s a nice story about some people who were on a raft off the coast of Brazil perishing from thirst. They had no idea that the water they were floating on was fresh water. The river was coming out into the sea with such force that it went out for a couple of miles, so they had fresh water right there where they were. But they had no idea. In the same way, we’re surrounded with joy, with happiness, with love. Most people have no idea of this whatsoever.” – Anthony de Mello, Awareness

One way to wake up to this truth is through awareness, or mindfulness, which allows us to see what’s been there all along. So—at the full risk of sounding like a mindfulness hallmark card—instead of floating above, let’s dive in and do our best to drink deeply from the joy all around us



(#634) Why We Suffer

“For man suffers only because he takes seriously what the gods made for fun.” – Alan Watts

P.S. On weekends, I just send a short, memorable quote for you to enjoy 🙏

(#635) You're Not "Not OK"

"You're not OK. You're not not OK. You're you ... Cut out all the OK stuff and the not-OK stuff; cut out all the judgments and observe. You'll make great discoveries." – Anthony de Mello

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

Still The Mind (New Book 411)

“You are put in the position of feeling that it is absolutely necessary to be different from the way you are, but there is absolutely nothing you can do about it because being the way you are, you can’t be different from your self.” – Alan Watts, Still The Mind

Hey folks, we have a new Book 411 available on Still The Mind by Alan Watts. This was a short book packed with a bunch of wisdom on living, breathing, and meditation. If you are interested in reading it, I highly recommend the audiobook because half the fun is how Watts delivers the lectures.

But if not, that’s what I’m here for 😊. So, I hope you enjoy the short 411 and get lots of practical tools and philosophical perspectives you can use to enjoy life more.

Click here to read or listen. <https://breathlearning.com/book-411s/still-the-mind>

In good breath,
Nick

(#636) Why Slow Breathing Works

“Specifically, as slow and deep breathing is initiated during a contemplative practice, the internal state of being settles into a relaxed state with a slower heart rate. With this slowing of heart rate, a positive feedback loop is initiated: The vagus nerve sends this lowered heart rate information via afferent fibers to the brain, and after it receives these signals that imply safety from the body, the brain then turns off threat arousal activation. Now, parasympathetic activity is dominant over sympathetic activity, initiating a felt sense of peace, safety, and contentment.”
– Crosswell et al. (2024)

Just a terrific “scientific reminder” of why slow breathing works—and why it is a critical part of almost all contemplative practices that elicit deep rest 🙏

P.S. If you haven’t read or listened to our Science 411 on this amazing paper, you can check it out here. <https://breathlearning.com/science-411s/crosswell-et-al-2024/>

(#637) If We Were Perfect, We Would Already Have Arrived

“We have all made mistakes and acted stupidly. So what? We are human beings. If we were perfect, then we wouldn’t need a path—we would already have arrived. It is because we have problems, because we have faults, because we’ve made stupid mistakes that we need a path.” – Jetsunma Tenzin Palmo, *The Heroic Heart* (<https://amzn.to/3ZAXog2>)

That is all 🙏

P.S. Well, one more thing: This doesn’t necessarily mean we need somebody else’s path. It means we must make our own path based on our “stupid mistakes” and personal faults...

(#638) Is Breathing Alone Enough?

“Past work on paced breathing practices have shown benefits on mental and physical health, including down-shifting sympathetic arousal and increasing parasympathetic activity, without any other didactic or psychospiritual components. **It is possible that the didactic aspects of contemplative practice are not necessary to shift physiology.** Perhaps instead, there are unique benefits of the didactic or social aspects of the practice that give meaning to the practice, which allows the person to engage with it for longer periods of time or to exert more intentional effort to perform it more deeply. **Contemplative practices that come with a set of social ethics, prosocial values, and community, may be more likely to be practiced consistently over longer periods of time** compared to types of controlled breathing that do not have a richer psychosocial or cultural context.” – Crosswell et al. (2024)

I love this science wrapped in rationality. Yes, breathing alone is generally good enough. But...if you add in some moral, community, or spiritual components, perhaps it'll make it easier to commit to over the longer term 🙏

What these words underscore is that breath is the great connector. It reminds us that we are all breathing in the same air, even the air of those whom we may disagree with or whose common humanity we may have minimized or diminished. Breath is the beginning, the end, and the tether between us all. It's what keeps us alive. It's what gives us meaning. It's the one thing we can't live without for the shortest amount of time. It's the wiring between all living organisms that proves we're not separated or disconnected, but rather that we are being routed through the same network. It reveals that we are dependent on each other — that with every breath we take in and exhale, we become more firmly enmeshed in a larger system, one that reveals much more about our similarities than about our differences.

Refusing to Hug MLK's Assistant

"So, the first time I went to this country and met Dr. Martin Luther King, an assistant of his, a lovely lady, wanted to hug me, and I refused. I refused because I did not know how to hug. And after I left her, I felt a little bit uneasy...She wanted to hug me to express her sympathy, her concern, not only to me, but to the people of my country who were suffering so much. And I did not allow her to...That's not so good." – Thich Nhat Hanh, *The Art of Mindful Living*

Can you imagine Thich Nhat Hanh, the beacon of compassion and love, refusing a hug? Not because he did not want to, but because he did not know how due to his upbringing.

He decided to learn how to hug (mindfully) so it wouldn't happen like that again when he visited the U.S.

We might ask ourselves if we have any metaphorical hugs we've been refusing, not because we don't want them, but because we don't know how to accept them? Is today the day to start learning?

“Another important point is to remain balanced, not too tight and not too loose. If we're too tight, we'll lose our calmness and relaxation. If we're too loose, we'll stray into distraction. It's like tuning a guitar. For the best sound it should be tuned just right — not too tight and not too loose. This is something we will slowly feel for ourselves over time. We will need to adjust our practice many, many times to find this natural balance.” – Why We Meditate

“Though we travel the world over to find the beautiful, we must carry it with us or we find it not.” - Ralph Waldo Emerson

“Plants give us oxygen for the lungs and for the soul.” - Linda Sologato

“Your mind knows only some things. Your inner voice, your instinct, knows everything.” - Henry Winkler

“Look deep into nature, and then you will understand everything better.” - Albert Einstein

“Regardless of how we get there, either through meditation or more directly by paying attention to novelty and questioning assumptions, to be mindful is to be in the present, noticing all the wonders that we didn't realize were right in front of us.”

— Ellen J. Langer

(#464) No Stopping or Straining

“As usual, I learned this important lesson from an ancient Buddhist text. In the text, someone poetically asks the Buddha how he attained deliverance: ‘How, dear sir, did you cross the flood?’ The Buddha answers, ‘By not stopping, friend, and by not straining I crossed the flood.’ The Buddha further explains that if he had strained, he would have been swept away, and if he had

stopped, he would have sunk. Therefore, he did not stop and did not strain.” – Chade-Meng Tan, Joy On Demand

That sounds like perfect advice for any work or life journey we’re on: Do not stop and do not strain 🙌

Stressful for Challenging?

“Richard Lazarus of the University of California at Berkeley, for example, defines stress as a “relationship between the person and the environment that is appraised by the person as taxing or exceeding his or her resources and endangering his or her well-being.” Put simply, if we interpret an event as threatening, the body responds to what the mind warns is a stressful situation. But if we see the same event as challenging, bodily responses may actually be enhanced.” – Eknath Easwaran, Original Goodness

Here is a great reminder that anytime we’re feeling stressed (over just about anything), viewing it as “challenging” instead of “stressful” can actually enhance our physiological response and performance rather than hindering them.

“It is possible to control your own psychological wellbeing through mental training.” – Steven Laureys, MD

“This may seem incredible, but it means that an exercise as simple as sitting down quietly and focusing on your breathing can contribute to your longevity.” – Steven Laureys, MD

Maybe Death is that Way Too

Here's an incredible perspective shift on dying worth contemplating:

"If you could interview a baby in the womb, a baby that was about to be born, and the baby asked you what is going to happen to it and you said, "You are going to go through a very dark channel. You are going to be pushed out. You are going to arrive into a vacant world of open air and light. The cord that connects you to your mother is going to be cut. You are going to be on your own forevermore, and regardless of how close you come to another, you will never belong in the way you have been able to belong here." The baby would have no choice but to conclude that it was going to die! Maybe death is that way too." – John O'Donohue, *Walking in Wonder*

very well. The self disappears when the mind is concentrated, and there is genuine, if temporary, relief when this happens. In meditation, the feelings of flow that are common in creative pursuits can be accessed, harnessed, and stabilized, sometimes for extended periods of time. But most artists, writers, mathematicians, chess players, actors, musicians, and athletes are no happier, and no more together, than the rest of humanity. If the temporary dissolution of self were all that was needed, problems would not be so tenacious. Even watching television would be therapeutic.

"Life reaches for life. Always. That means that when we feel the most stuck, whether physically, emotionally, situationally, or any other way, we need only to look for where things are still moving. When we put our focus and our energy there, a trickle will form around our dam. Aligning with this trickle will help us realign with life."

"When you develop this marvelous capacity to hold attention steady on the present, like the flame of a candle in a windless place, most anxieties evaporate. There is no reason to worry about what tomorrow may bring." – Eknath Easwaran

(#444) GRATITUDE

“That’s how gratitude works, transforming not reality itself but how reality is seen.” – Matt Fitzgerald, *The Comeback Quotient*

A common theme of essentially any book on meditation, contemplative practice, or just becoming better humans is that it is not reality, but our perception of reality, that matters. We get to choose how we respond in any situation.

And while it’s often challenging, gratitude is the best practice I’ve found for embodying this idea.

The second way to embrace a situation is gratitude. This isn’t some fairyland optimism but rather a cognitive reframe to see your situation in a new light. Fitzgerald says, “That’s how gratitude works, transforming not reality itself but how reality is seen.”

And that’s also how slow breathing works. It doesn’t change your situation, but by changing your nervous system and brain, it transforms how reality is seen.

And if you practice slow breathing enough, it changes the baseline state of these systems, helping you experience more gratitude throughout your day.

So, we might say to embrace your situation, embrace your breath practice, and watch your locus of control and gratitude grow with you.

(#435) The Back (or any) Pain Cycle

“So this is how the chronic back pain cycle works. Our initial pain causes worried thoughts, these thoughts create anxiety, and this anxiety causes muscles to tighten. Tight muscles cause increased pain, and increased pain triggers even more dire worried thoughts. Once the cycle sets in, other emotions, such as frustration and anger, get into the act.” – Ronald Siegel, Psy.D., *The Mindfulness Solution*

Although about back pain, that sounds like just about any physical (or psychological) pain we experience: Pain causes worried thoughts, which causes anxiety, which causes bodily reactions that amplify the pain, which causes more anxious thoughts. It’s quite the dreadful cycle

This is where mindfulness comes in. By helping us accept the pain, we loosen its grip and lessen our worried thoughts. This reduces our resistance, and our suffering goes down.

#247, 414, 317

Similarly, we don’t try to change the puzzle piece; we move it around until it fits.

“We talk of absence and space, and absence and time, but we can never talk about the absence of spirit, because spirit, by nature and definition, can never be absent.” – John O’Donohue

“Possibilities are always more interesting than facts.” – John O’Donohue

“One of the sad things today is that so many people are frightened by the wonder of their own presence.” – John O’Donohue

(#433) The Power of a Slow-Running Mind

“Somehow, in our modern civilization, we have acquired the idea that the mind is working best when it runs at top speed. Yet this is not true even with assembly-line production. A racing mind lacks time even to finish a thought, let alone to check on quality. It just churns out whatever it can, the more the better, and the faster it runs the more likely it is to overheat, jam, and even shut down and have to be restarted. Slowing down the mind means not only achieving better quality but actually getting more done. A smooth-running flow of thought

saves a lot of wear and tear on the nervous system, which means more vitality and resilience in the face of stress.” – Eknath Easwaran, Conquest of Mind

(# 4XX) My Mind Is Always at Peace

“Today I don’t even have to work at this response. It has become second nature to do everything I can to cork up a fermenting asava. My mind no longer goes into turmoil; it is always at peace. But I had to learn this the hard way, just as everyone does: by trying to do it over and over and over, even when it hurt.” – Eknath Easwaran, Conquest of Mind

Sometimes it’s hard for me to believe passages like this—doesn’t everyone’s minds go into turmoil—no one can always be at peace, right? (😂)

But, that last sentence is remarkable.

It made me think of how if an endurance runner said it was easy for them to jog 10 miles, I wouldn’t doubt them. They put in countless hours and miles to make such distances relatively easy.

It’s the same with the mind. We learn by trying over and over and over, even when it hurts.

“By controlling our breath, we can willfully influence the brain and the autonomic nervous system and literally change our mind-body state. By changing the pattern of our breathing, we change the pattern of the information being sent to the brain. In other words, how often, how fast, and how much you inflate your lungs directly affects the brain and how it operates.”

“Receive wisdom skillfully. Try it on for size and see how it fits. Incorporate what’s useful. Let go of the rest. And no matter how credible the source, test and tune in to yourself to discover what works for you.” – Rick Rubin

“Laughter can be more satisfying than honor; more precious than money; more heart cleansing than prayer.” - Harriet Rochlin

(#416)

The function of meditation is twofold: it calms and slows the mind, and by driving the words of an inspirational passage deep into consciousness, it gradually transforms corrosive negative emotions into positive states of mind which release vitality and spread a protective shield against the stress of life.

Easwaran, Eknath. *Original Goodness: 3 (Classics of Christian Inspiration)* (p. 110). Nilgiri Press. Kindle Edition.

Well-Trained versus Out of Control Mind

“A person whose mind is well trained can manage in the midst of a stressful environment. Noise and pollution will take their toll on the body, but vitality and resistance will remain high. By contrast, a person whose mind is out of control can suffer from stress while lying on a quiet beach in Saint-Tropez.” – Eknath Easwaran, *Original Goodness*

How Not to Die

"If you don't want to die, don't be born." — Larry Rosenberg

Why/How the Learning Center Works

"When we meditate on inspired words with profound concentration, they have the capacity to sink into our consciousness, alive with a charge of spiritual awareness. Eventually these ideals become an integral part of our personality, which means they will find constant expression in what we do, what we say, and what we think." – Eknath Easwaran

QUOTE:

"What a man takes in by contemplation, that he pours out in love." - Meister Eckhart

I run a membership called the Breath Learning Center. I share Breath Science & Wisdom Meditations for a Better Life to help people learn to think, speak, and act in alignment with the people they want to be. As part of it, I write a short daily email called The Breathing 1% with timeless wisdom that takes about 30 seconds to read. The goal is for people to read this message attentively and distraction-free, so it serves as a short meditation, calming their minds and shaping a positive outlook for the day. Will you tell me if this email fits that goal?

Will you especially tell me if the last part, "so we can forge the brilliant work of living a well-lived life," makes sense?

Dr. Curt Thompson writes, "By controlling our breath, we can willfully influence the brain and the autonomic nervous system and literally change our mind-body state. By changing the pattern of our breathing, we change the pattern of the information being sent to the brain. In other words, how often, how fast, and how much you inflate your lungs directly affects the brain and how it operates."

"12

Tools We Can't Put Down

"Thinking and planning, wonderful and useful as they are, are at the heart of our daily emotional distress because, unlike other tools, we can't seem to put these down when we don't need them. They keep us worrying about the future, regretting the past, comparing ourselves to one another in thousands of ways, and forever scheming about how to make things better. This makes it very difficult to be truly satisfied for more than a brief time."

THOUGHT:

Contemplative practice is different from typical self-improvement because it is not about becoming someone else. It is about uncovering who you already are.

"Just as our bodies are born to breathe air, we are born to love. That's why although it's good to address our fear, it's even better to focus on our love. Any effort we put toward love—truly, any effort at all—will self-perpetuate, bringing joy, health, and well-being into our lives." – Gladys McGarey, MD (103 years old)

"Without courage we cannot practice any other virtue with consistency. We can't be kind, true, merciful, generous, or honest." – Maya Angelou

"Mindfulness of breathing is your island, where you can be safe and happy, knowing that whatever happens, you are doing your best thing." – Thich Nhat Hanh

"Real difficulties can be overcome; it is only the imaginary ones that are unconquerable." – Theodore N. Vail

"We live not by the breath that flows in
And flows out, but by him who causes the breath
To flow in and flow out." – The Katha Upanishad

Just as Our Bodies are Born to Breathe

“Just as our bodies are born to breathe air, we are born to love. That’s why although it’s good to address our fear, it’s even better to focus on our love. Any effort we put toward love—truly, any effort at all—will self-perpetuate, bringing joy, health, and well-being into our lives.” – Gladys McGarey, MD (103 years old)

“All creatures consume vital energy. In the ancient Hindu tradition, it is said that we come into life with a given supply of this energy, enough to power a certain number of breathing cycles. Our natural human life span, according to this view, is allotted not in calendar years but in the number of breaths we take. The word expire means literally to reach the end of this span of breaths – interestingly enough, at about one hundred and twenty years of age. Anything less is considered a premature death, “death by unnatural causes.”

If this theory is true, it may help to explain why these ancient sages claim a close connection between mental states and longevity. Our breathing rhythm, the measure of how fast our reserves of vital energy are being consumed, is regulated in part by our state of mind. Security, compassion, patience, forgiveness – all these are accompanied, if you observe closely, by a relatively slow breathing rhythm and heart rate. Positive states of mind like these conserve energy and lengthen the life span, leaving a reserve of resilience and resistance for facing challenges. Every time we are able to remain calm under pressure, or merciful while under attack, we are making a big deposit into the vault of vital energy within.”

(#399) Phil Jackson's Proudest Kobe Moment

Phil Jackson said he was most proud of Kobe when, during a TV interview, the host joked about a player who never got to play. This player didn't even get to dress in uniform, but he was always on the bench cheering.

Phil said that Kobe responded: **"Don't make fun of Adam Morrison. He's one of our teammates. He puts in the work. He may not get to dress, but he puts in the work, and he's part of our team."**

It's an excellent reminder that all we can ever do is put in the work. We may not get to play. We may not even get to put on the uniform. But if we're doing the work—whatever work that is meaningful to us—we'll be a critical part of the metaphorical team of people striving toward the same goal as us.

I love this perspective, and it's the perfect inspiration for putting aside time for yourself each morning to put "your activities into a more peaceful perspective that will stay with you all day."

And even if you're not a morning person, let this be a reminder to look for the ebb and flow in your day where your mind naturally grows calm, and use that time to put everything else in perspective.

"Real difficulties can be overcome; it is only the imaginary ones that are unconquerable." – Theodore N. Vail

“Patience is the very heart of love. I don’t think any skill in life is more valuable. Patience is the best insurance I know against all kinds of emotional and physical problems – and it is absolutely essential for learning to slow down.”

For Self-Realization We Need Challenge and Danger

From Original Goodness

Comment on how we often think with contemplative practices that we’re going to be passive and just sit around all day. Quite the contrary. Gandhi worked 15 hours a day, 7 days a week, for decades to overcome the greatest challenges. MLK gave every ounce of him to service. And on and on. It’s not about passivity. It’s about extreme challenges. All meditation does is allow you to face the right challenges, the most important to our being.

(#384) The Soul’s Physiology

“The soul is made of love and must ever strive to return to love. Therefore, it can never find rest nor happiness in other things. It must lose itself in love.” - Mechthild of Magdeburg

P.S. Since we missed our normal Sunday quote with the release of our latest Science 411 yesterday, here’s a short & insightful quote to contemplate on the soul’s physiology.

It’s My Responsibility...

“You will learn, I hope, that happiness is what you make it, where you are. Why in the world would I be unhappy? People here complain all the time, but not me. It’s my responsibility to be as happy as I can, right here, today.” – June Driscoll, Nursing Home Resident

P.S. Since we missed our normal Sunday quote with the release of our latest Science 411, here’s a short & insightful one to contemplate on happiness. I found this in a book I just started on Saturday called 30 Lessons for Living: Tried and True Advice from the Wisest Americans (thanks for the recommendation, Paul!).

(#380) Do What You Love and Love What You Do

“The comedian George Burns appeared on the Disney Channel when he was about ninety years old, talking to a group of kids who looked to be about ten years old. One of the kids asked Burns about the rules to live by that had helped him live so long and well. George Burns didn't have a long list. It's simple, he said. Do what you love or love what you do. I would find it difficult to think of anything better to say to a kid starting out in life.” – Dr. Bob Rotella

OR

“To borrow an analogy from chemistry, enthusiasm acts like a catalyst that makes all the other attributes of a champion's mind work better. Persistence, to take one important example, is so much easier when you're enthused about what you're doing. Sticking with something you love is like biking downhill. Sticking with something you don't love is like biking uphill.” – Dr. Bob Rotella

Eventually Reach this Destination

“How much better to pursue a straight course and eventually reach that destination where the things that are pleasant are the things that are honorable finally become, for you, the same.” — Seneca

“The film director David Lynch formulated it most compellingly when he told me ‘The thing about meditation is, you become more and more you.’ So you should not have the slightest concern about meditating in ways that suit you and are to your liking.” – Steven Laureys, MD

OR

“Saint John of the Cross tells us in Zen-like terms:
In order to enjoy everything,

Desire to get joy from nothing.

OR

OR

Not in a Week or by the Weak

"I am not saying this is easy or quick. Quite the contrary; it can't be done in a week or by the weak. But the task is clearly laid out before us. By removing that which is petty and self-seeking, we bring forth all that is glorious and mindful of the whole."

9 Light-Hearted Quotes to Laugh At

I recently went through a document of quotes I started collecting on Jan 25, 2021. A few made me laugh, and since laughing is always the best breathing exercise, I thought I'd share them here in hopes of providing you a smile to start the week with:

"I was going to buy a copy of The Power of Positive Thinking, and then I thought: What the hell good would that do?" - Ronnie Shakes

"I've been on a diet for two weeks and all I've lost is two weeks." - Totie Fields

"The trouble with facts is that there are so many of them." - Samuel McChord Crothers

"There are three kinds of lies: lies, damned lies, and statistics." - Benjamin Disraeli

"You talk to God, you're religious. God talks to you, you're psychotic." - Doris Egan, House M.D.

"Reality is the leading cause of stress amongst those in touch with it." - Jane Wagner

"Some people never go crazy. What truly horrible lives they must lead." - Charles Bukowski

"A committee can make a decision that is dumber than any of its members." - David Coblitz

(#311) How to Reduce the "Hallmark Adrenal Stress-Hormone"

"Our results expand and reinforce the importance of spontaneous laughter in promoting health by demonstrating a significant and objectively-measured reduction on the hallmark adrenal stress-hormone, cortisol, induced by genuine laughter."

This is just a reminder to laugh a little today. You have my permission to consider it your daily dose of breathing :) And if you really get going, perhaps it can be your core workout, too.

P.S. And don't forget to check out the Science 411 on this one.

QUOTE IDEAS

"Saint John of the Cross tells us in Zen-like terms:

In order to enjoy everything,

Desire to get joy from nothing.

In order to arrive at possessing everything,

Desire to possess nothing.

In order to arrive at being everything, Desire to be nothing...."

"If you live today completely in love—hating no one, hurting no one, serving all—then tomorrow has to be good, whatever comes." – Eknath Easwaran, Original Goodness

"Mindfulness of breathing is your island, where you can be safe and happy, knowing that whatever happens, you are doing your best thing." – Thich Nhat Hanh

"The time to relax is -- when you don't have time for it." - Sidney J. Harris

~~"Interestingly enough, it is just when we forget about the body that it functions at its best."~~
Eknath Easwaran

I always laugh at the altar, be it Christian, Hindu, or Buddhist, because real religion is the transformation of anxiety into laughter.”

— Alan Wilson Watts

“Let yourself be silently drawn by the strange pull of what you really love. It will not lead you astray.” – Rumi

“Like a child depends upon its mother, humans have always depended upon nature for our survival. And just as we intuitively love our mothers, we are linked to nature physically, cognitively, and emotionally.” – Wallace J Nichols

“A flower does not think of competing with the flower next to it. It just blooms.” - Zen Shin

Another one from that paper. I might title it: Better Physiology is Useless without This

“Past work on paced breathing practices have shown benefits on mental and physical health, including down-shifting sympathetic arousal and increasing parasympathetic activity, without any other didactic or psychospiritual components (Blum et al., 2019; Harada et al., 2014; Laborde et al., 2019). It is possible that the didactic aspects of contemplative practice are not necessary to shift physiology. Perhaps instead, there are unique benefits of the didactic or social aspects of the practice that give meaning to the practice, which allows the person to engage with it for longer periods of time or to exert more intentional effort to perform it more deeply. Contemplative practices that come with a set of social ethics, prosocial values, and community, may be more likely to be practiced consistently over longer periods of time compared to types of controlled breathing that do not have a richer psychosocial or cultural context. In addition, the contemplative aspects of the practice may provide other psychological benefits (e.g., insights into self and interdependence, self-compassion, perspective taking, emotion regulation tools, experiences of awe) that increase positive affect and decrease distress, which confers their own health-promoting benefits. These mood-boosting and distress-reducing psychological effects may also motivate the practitioner to come back to the practice day after day, promoting long-term adherence.”

An Excellent Passage on Surrender, Trust, and Breathing

“We are literally being breathed by the atmosphere all through the day, all through our lives. To acknowledge that we are being breathed all through our lives is an interesting prospect, which can actually allow us to practice surrender and trust. It’s reflective of a much larger principle in our lives, and that is the ability or willingness to let go of control, to accept the unknown, and

allow nature to hold us. In that trust, in that acceptance, there can be found great peace and relaxation that we are ok.” – Eddie Stern, *Healing Through Breathing*

“We can do whatever we want on this planet, but the world will always win—so we might as well build as much joy, real joy for all people while we’re here.”

FULL QUOTE:

“Even after the dust storm raged past, the orange sky stuck around for a while. There would be other orange skies that I’d stare up into that year in Iraq but never had I been stuck inside the storm as it scoured past me. We can do whatever we want on this planet, I remember thinking, but the world will always win—so we might as well build as much joy, real joy for all people while we’re here.”

Why We Should Become Mystics

“In these pages I will often refer to the ‘great mystics’ of the world. This word ‘mystic,’ too, is easily misunderstood. Mysticism is the conviction, born of personal experience, that there is a divine core in human personality which each of us can realize directly, and that making this discovery is the real goal of our lives. A mystic is anyone who has achieved this goal.” – Eknath Easwaran, Conquest of Mind

“Mysticism is the conviction that there is a divine core” in each of us and that “making this discovery is the real goal of our lives.”

Although I’ve had an aversion to the word “mystic,” I think that sentence could also serve as a direct replacement for the description of Secret #1.

So here’s to becoming a little more “mystical” in our quest for a well-lived life :)

Like a Shadow that Never Leaves

“Everything depends on mind. Our life is shaped by our mind; we become what we think. Suffering follows an evil thought as the wheels of a cart follow the oxen that draw it. Joy follows a pure thought like a shadow that never leaves.” – The Buddha (translation by Eknath Easwaran)

This is an excellent follow-up to yesterday’s message, reconciling the dilemma nicely.

By inclining our mind toward pure thoughts through reading, breathing, and meditation, we bring joy “like a shadow that never leaves.”

This is probably why inclining our minds toward the 6 secrets and seeing Dr. Gladys’ wisdom everywhere we look makes us feel better and more joyful about life :)

Automatic Yoga

“Automatic yoga comes in many forms. If we begin spinal breathing followed by deep meditation, we may find an increased desire to engage in spiritual studies. Suddenly we will find ourselves reading more books on spiritual matters. We may also notice our conduct becoming more agreeable and kind. Spiritual study and exercising kindness both fall into a category of yoga practice having to do with conduct. Pretty subtle changes, yet noticeable.”

DID EVERYTHING RIGHT, THOUGHT NOTHING WOULD GO WRONG (RONALD SIEGEL)

“I believe our psychology may be the most important determinant of our health.” – Ellen Langer, Ph.D. This explains why TB1% and the short daily wisdom meditations are so powerful. They change our psychology.

I found the below two quotes here: <https://flaxseedsandfairytales.com/12-funny-meditation-quotes-mindfulness/>

"If it weren't for my mind, my meditation would be excellent" – Pema Chodron

"It's like having a charger for your whole body and mind. That's what meditation is!" - Jerry Seinfeld

More Random Quote Ideas:

"Our own physical body possesses a wisdom which we who inhabit the body lack." - Henry Miller (1891 - 1980)

"That is what learning is. You suddenly understand something you've understood all your life, but in a new way." – Doris Lessing

The Real Essentials of Life

"Autotellers, telephones, fax machines, and computers are unquestionably useful, but they are not fundamental. The real essentials of life are compassion, kindness, good will, and forgiveness. It is qualities like these that are fundamental to living as a true human being – and that is where our age lacks a great deal." – Eknath Easwaran

Important Reminder: It's Not Your Fault

"Some people assume after learning about the role that the mind and behavior can play in illness that every malady is somehow 'my fault.' I like to remind my patients what happened to all the great ancient meditation masters. No matter how wise, skillful, or compassionate they were, their bodies all fell apart in the end." – Ronald Siegel, Psy.D., The Mindfulness Solution

(#321) Aristotle on the Middle Path

Here's Aristotle discussing the middle path:

"For both excessive and insufficient exercise destroy one's strength, and both eating and drinking too much or too little destroy health, whereas the right quantity produces, increases and preserves it. So it is the same with temperance, courage and other virtues."

And with breathing, too. There is so much out there on the damages of overbreathing that many of us are tense all day trying to breathe less.

But it's not about breathing less. It's about breathing optimally, the way our bodies were designed. Both excessive and insufficient breathing destroy one's health.

Found this quote on Brian's +1 called: Aristotle's Yoga, #927.

I was describing this mechanism one day to a patient from MIT. He said, as people from MIT often do, "I think there's a mathematical formula for that." I asked him what it might be. He said, "Pain times resistance equals suffering." Here's how this works. When pain sensations are extremely intense (such as when an elephant steps on our foot), we are likely to suffer unless we can manage to have virtually no resistance (which is very improbable). When pain is mild or moderate, if our resistance to it is low, suffering will also be limited—but if our resistance to the same pain is high, we will still suffer a lot. Put differently, to the extent that we can accept our pain, we won't suffer. This is the Buddha's story of the two arrows expressed mathematically. We see it vividly with

It's Not a Method or System, It's an Outlook

"In meditation we should not look for a 'method' or 'system,' but cultivate an 'attitude,' an 'outlook': faith, openness, attention, reverence, expectation, supplication, trust, joy." – Thomas Merton

Merton was a Christian Monk, so he uses the word meditation differently than we do when we discuss breathing and mindfulness practices.

But I thought this still fit perfectly with the theme of what we do. We rely on systems and methods to get going, but one overarching hope is that we ultimately change our outlook toward more joy, openness, and trust.

What Separates a True Savage

"Everything in life comes down to how we handle those crucial seconds. When psychological, physical, or emotional pressure redlines, your adrenal glands go haywire, and you are no longer in control. **What separates a true savage from everybody else is the ability to regain control of their mind in that split second**, despite the fact that all is still fu****!" – David Goggins, Never Finished

As we read and study great people, we might realize that they all share common threads on how they think (though they may articulate it in different ways 😊).

And whether it's Goggins or Gandhi, Michael Jordan or Mother Teresa, they all agree that we must learn to control our minds in the most challenging situations.

And that's precisely what breathing and mindfulness practices teach us. This is perhaps why all great athletes and spiritual leaders practice it in some capacity 🙏

Holistic (Where Our Soul Needs Work)

"The term holistic medicine refers not to the strategy but to the approach. It's about treating the whole patient, not just the disease. ... The word holistic combines whole and holy, not in a specifically religious sense but in a way that deeply respects the perfection of each human soul and sees the body as an instrument that assists the soul in its tasks. Diseases and symptoms—from simple aches and pains to metastatic cancer—are also part of that perfect design. By showing us where the body is hurt, they show us precisely where the soul needs to work next."

"Diseases and symptoms...are also part of that perfect design. By showing us where the body is hurt, they show us precisely where the soul needs to work next."

That blew my mind.

I hope it resonates with you, too.

Breathing is Philosophy in Action

"...but there was an important bifurcation between what philosophy became in the West and its original purpose, which was to understand something about the nature of being in the world, such that it transforms your capacities as a person. Philosophy should transform the moment-to-moment quality of your life. ... We have largely lost that." – Steven Laureys, MD, The No-Nonsense Meditation Book

Like ancient philosophy, the point of contemplative practice is to transform "your capacities as a person."

And that's why they all start with the breath.

Breathing helps us understand the nature of being in the world. And because we're always doing it, it gives us a way to quickly "transform the moment-to-moment quality" of our lives.

We might say: Breathing is philosophy in action.

“A lot of things in daily life boil down to wonder. It is one of the purest forms of joy I can imagine.” – Erling Kagge

Silence is more of an idea. A notion. The silence around us may contain a lot, but the most interesting kind of silence is the one that lies within. A silence which each of us must create.

“For thousands of years, individuals who lived in close quarters with no one but themselves around—monks on mountaintops, hermits, sailors, shepherds and explorers on their voyage home—have been convinced that the answer to life's mysteries can be found in silence. That is the point. You sail out across the sea, but it's when you make your return that you may discover what you have been seeking is in fact inside yourself.”

“Our results expand and reinforce the importance of spontaneous laughter in promoting health by demonstrating a significant and objectively-measured reduction on the hallmark adrenal stress-hormone, cortisol, induced by genuine laughter.”

“In conclusion, our results support the ancient knowledge that spontaneous laughter is in fact good medicine (preventive or therapeutic) being associated with greater reduction in cortisol levels as compared with usual activities.”

Here's a lesson that has recently revealed itself to me:

With consistent practice, the breath creates its own gravity, naturally pulling your attention toward it in every situation.

“What we get from this adventure is just sheer joy. And joy is, after all, the end of life.” – George Mallory

(#292) Are We There Yet?

“It's a mistake to think too much about the goal and to ask too often about it. I was happy on those hikes with my parents. ... Happy until the moment when I started asking how much farther it was.” – Erling Kagge, Walking

(#) The Body Can Be Completely Transformed

“If we look at physiology from this point of view, we begin to realize that the material body, which we have tended up to this time to regard as primary, is in fact secondary to an inner field of energy even more fundamental than itself. The flow of energy creates and sustains the tissues of the body, and if the energy pattern changes sufficiently, the physical body changes also. If the energy pattern is altered drastically enough, the body can be completely transformed, for better or worse.”

“Given this insight, we can effectively invite joy just by smiling a genuine smile. Smile as if you are really happy. When you do this, you may create changes in the autonomic nervous system relating to happiness, and from these changes, you may experience joy. This works for me almost every time. It doesn’t even need to be a full smile—a half smile works as well.”

How I View Breath as Medicine

Breathing is air medicine.

I wrote that quote to sound cool. But I also 100% believe it. Here’s how I look at it.

Breath awareness or mindful breathing is the baseline. We can do that as much as we want, no matter how we’re feeling.

Then, more deliberate breathing exercises should be dosed according to the person.

(#281)

If I asked you today what your favorite breathing exercise is. Or what your morning routine looks like. Would it be different from one year ago? Or four years ago?

Remember this when you hear an author or expert tell you their morning routine or their favorite thing they do for their health.

It’s a snapshot of their current level of understanding and their current influences. In a year, it will be different.

If You Belong to This Population, You Are So Lucky

“Sometimes, you get lucky in life, when the most important thing you need to do turns out to also be the simplest. One example is breathing. Breathing is the most important thing we need to do in our lives, and for most of us, it is also the easiest thing we ever do. If you belong to the population of people who can breathe effortlessly, you are so lucky!” - Chade-Meng Tan, Joy On Demand <https://www.amazon.com/Joy-on-Demand-Chade-Meng-Tan-audiobook/dp/B01COR0MV8/>

Just an excellent quote to help us cultivate a little gratitude for how lucky we are to be breathing, especially since it's likely pretty easy for us most of the time.

“The closest parallel to okayness in psychology may be the new field of well-being, and the realization—and scientific verification—that this positive inner state can be cultivated: well-being is a skill.” – Daniel Goleman, Ph.D.

(#267) The Breath versus Breathing

We don't notice the breath. We notice the sensations of breathing.

We don't change the breath. We change how we are breathing.

The breath is an idea. Breathing is a process.

“There is, I assure you, a medical art for the soul. It is philosophy, whose aid need not be sought, as in bodily diseases, from outside ourselves. We must endeavor with all our resources and strength to become capable of doctoring ourselves.” – Marcus Tullius Cicero

“It is easy in the world to live after the world's opinion; it is easy in solitude to live after our own; but the great man is he who in the midst of the crowd keeps with perfect sweetness the independence of solitude.”
— Ralph Waldo Emerson

BEFORE HE DIED in 1996 at 100 years of age, comedian George Burns said, “If you ask me what is the most important key to longevity, I would have to say it is avoiding worry, stress, and tension. And if you didn’t ask me, I’d still have to say it.”

Science suggests Burns knew what he was talking about. Aging and longevity are influenced by a variety of factors, including genes and lifestyle, but research has proven that psychology has the greatest influence. Specifically, people who have a positive attitude and who don't sweat the small stuff tend to age slower and live longer.

Fitzgerald, Matt . How Bad Do You Want It? (p. 267). VeloPress. Kindle Edition.

"There is no single more powerful – or more simple – daily practice to further your health and wellbeing than breathwork." – Andrew Weil, MD

"By changing patterns of breathing we can change our emotional states, how we think, and how we interact with the world." – Dr. Patricia Gerbarg

(#240) Two Reasons to Obey the Law

“It is one thing to obey the law because you know the penalties and fear the consequences; it is something else entirely to obey the law because you have cleansed yourself from the greed that would make you steal and the hatred that would make you kill.” - Henepola Gunaratana, *Mindfulness in Plain English*

For us, this concept applies beyond laws and more so to our general morals and character.

We may periodically ask:

Are we doing good things because it's what we think we “should” be doing? Or maybe because we want to post them on social media?

Or are we doing good things because we have genuinely transformed ourselves through practice?

(#240) Inhales Aren't Sympathetic (and exhales aren't parasympathetic)?

Here's what I'm discovering as of late:

Low Lung Volume = Sympathetic (fight-or-flight)

High Lung Volume = Parasympathetic (calming)

Upon reflection, this makes common sense to me.

But it means:

The first part of an inhale is sympathetic. The last part is more parasympathetic.

The first part of an exhale is parasympathetic. The last part is more sympathetic.

And explains why:

Inhale-holds are parasympathetic - - > the lungs are relatively full

Exhale-holds are sympathetic - - > the lungs are relatively empty

So, we might say:

An inhale stretches the lungs, causing a parasympathetic response (which then causes an exhale).

An exhale collapses the lungs, causing a sympathetic response (which then causes an inhale).

Reply here if you have any thoughts or insights on this 🙏

P.S. Here are some of the papers I've found so far:

<https://www.ahajournals.org/doi/abs/10.1161/01.res.67.1.130>

<https://www.ahajournals.org/doi/epdf/10.1161/01.RES.72.2.440> (top row of Figure 1 shows it nicely)

<https://www.ahajournals.org/doi/full/10.1161/01.RES.85.5.457> (the third row of Figure 3A also shows it clearly).

<https://journals.physiology.org/doi/full/10.1152/ajpheart.00112.2013>

<https://journals.physiology.org/doi/full/10.1152/ajpheart.00296.2020> (more recent 2020 paper that also looks at baroreflex sensitivity)

(#2--)

“Mindfulness is evolution’s joy reflex to suffering.”

That was a thought I had the other day while pushing my daughter on the swing at the park.

If you’ve ever experienced physical, mental, or emotional suffering (which, since you’re human, I know you have, lol), then you’ll understand the truth behind that statement.

“Earth brings us to life
and nourishes us.

Earth takes us back again.

We are born and we die with every breath.” - Thich Nhat Hanh

(#233) 10 Thoughts on Mindful Breathing

Mindful breathing simultaneously reveals unshakeable confidence and very-shakable vulnerability.

Mindful breathing simultaneously reveals poetic words and a 12-year-old’s sense of humor.

Mindful breathing simultaneously reveals scientific insights and spiritual yearning.

Mindful breathing simultaneously reveals immaculate health and inescapable suffering.

Mindful breathing simultaneously reveals irrational goals and rational steps for reaching them.

Mindful breathing simultaneously reveals who you think you should be and who you are (and that the two are the same, whether you know it or not).

Mindful breathing simultaneously reveals the seriousness of living and that it shouldn't be taken seriously at all.

Mindful breathing simultaneously reveals compassion in our hearts and intolerance in our brains.

Mindful breathing simultaneously reveals profound-sounding thoughts and laughter at oneself.

And sometimes, if we're lucky, mindful breathing simultaneously reveals nothing at all and everything we need.

(#2--) The Best Definition of Mindfulness

I've come across many definitions of mindfulness, but this may be my new favorite:

"Doing things with mindfulness means you perform each action with clear awareness of what's happening and of what you're doing in the present moment, and you feel happy as you do it. Mindfulness is the capacity to shine the light of awareness onto what's going on here and now." – Thich Nhat Hanh, Peace is Every Breath

Mindfulness is the most logical evolutionary adaptation to suffering.

When you're suffering, the only way to get through is to be mindful. To live moment-to-moment, not in the past or future (any ultrarunner will tell you this).

Our entire existence is suffering. Whether it's today's world, 100 years ago, or 10,000 years ago.

Mindfulness may have been an adaptation to a constant state of uncertainty

(#222) Sometimes It's Easy, Sometimes It's Hard

"Sometimes breathing is hard, sometimes it comes easily." – Lao Tzu

P.S. This quote goes nicely with Thought #3 in our new Book 411 on *Spinal Breathing Pranayama*.

"Practicing a regular, mindful breathing exercise can be calming and energizing and can even help with stress-related health problems ranging from panic attacks to digestive disorders." – Dr. Andrew Weil

“The body says what words cannot.” - Martha Graham
(<https://www.dailygood.org/2022/11/11/dancing-in-a-yard/>)

#223 TBD

(#224) Automatic Yoga

“Automatic yoga comes in many forms. If we begin spinal breathing followed by deep meditation, we may find an increased desire to engage in spiritual studies. Suddenly we will find ourselves reading more books on spiritual matters. We may also notice our conduct becoming more agreeable and kind. Spiritual study and exercising kindness both fall into a category of yoga practice having to do with conduct. Pretty subtle changes, yet noticeable.”

“If your knowledge of fire has been turned to certainty by words alone, then seek to be cooked by the fire itself. Don’t abide in borrowed certainty. There is no real certainty until you burn; if you wish for this, sit down in the fire.” – Rumi

“[W]e must seek awareness, and that can begin with the awareness of your breath, the foundation of your totality as a human being.” - Al Lee and Don Campbell

(#212) The Mind is the Root of Everything

“To know that the mind is the root of everything is to realize that we are ultimately responsible for both our own happiness and our own suffering. It is in our hands.” – Sogyal Rinpoche

We cannot control anything outside of us. Thus, our greatest hope for achieving the slightest bit of happiness in life is to gain some control over our mind. It is in our hands.

P.S. And given the powerful breath-mind relationship, instead of saying “It is in our hands” we might say, “It is in our lungs.”

Given the relationship between breath & mind, we might say: We are ultimately responsible for both our own happiness and our own suffering. It is in our breath.

(#203)

(#202) The Rest of Your Body Falls in Line

“As you slow down your breathing, the rest of your body falls in line: Slower heart rate. Increased brain alpha waves. General feelings of well-being and relaxation. And higher heart rate variability.”

(#201) Shift Your Physical Environment

“It’s simple: By shifting our physical environment, we can shift our mental state. We can change both the content of our thoughts and our thought processes.” – Elissa Epel, Ph.D.

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy & contemplate.

(#199) The Power of Water

“Many people also resonate with the soothing sound of rhythmic ocean waves—it affects our breathing, slowing it down and encouraging deeper breaths.” – Elissa Epel, Ph.D., The Stress Prescription

Epel also says that basically any exposure to nature does something similar, with the net result being less stress and more positive emotions.

It's easy to assume that the brain generates the mind.

But the heart influences the brain. So heart is mind.

But the breath influences the brain. So breath is mind.

But the whole body influences the brain. So body is mind.

"For example, when Varela put on an EEG cap, which uses electrodes to measure electrical activity in the brain, monks from the Institute of Buddhist Dialectics in Dharamsala laughed and said, "How could we be measuring anything to do with the mind by putting a cap on the head? The mind is here!"—pointing to their hearts."

Isn't fun to consider how we assume the mind is in the brain, but that's just how we? Maybe it is in the heart? Maybe it's in the lungs? Maybe it's our whole body?

(#181) Two Major Benefits of Contemplative Effort

"When these strands of change are twined together, there are two major ways anyone benefits from contemplative effort: having a healthy body and a healthy mind." - Daniel Goleman, Ph.D. & Richard Davidson, Ph.D.

"Joy lies in the fight, in the attempt, in the suffering involved, not in the victory itself." – Gandhi (found in Gandhi The Man pg. 95)

"Gandhi used to walk for miles every day repeating it to himself until the rhythm of the mantram and his footsteps began to stabilize the rhythm of his breathing, which is closely connected with the rhythm of the mind."

– Eknath Easwaran, [*Gandhi The Man*](#)

"On a daily basis, it can bring us greater peace of mind because we carry the breath with us wherever we go. No matter what is happening in the moment, we need not disengage from life for a second to 'practice.'"

"You might think you need to meditate for many years to access joy, but as you will see in Chapter 2, you can begin to experience benefits in one breath."

I just started this book, so I haven't made it to Chapter 2, but I know a simple way to access joy in one breath.

Say to yourself, "isn't this great, I have an abundance of the most valuable resource on the planet, and I don't even have

Conscious slow breathing is chicken soup for the soul.

P.S. Vegan options are available, but you get the analogy :)

(#169) Patrick McKeown

In 2018, when I got certified under Patrick, I raised my hand and said something like, “I really like slow breathing with an app. Could it be ok to do that if I reduced my breathing volume?”

(Back then, part of Patrick’s “stance” was that breathing pace didn’t matter, it was the volume that was most crucial.)

To my surprise, he stopped, contemplated it, and then said something like “sure, I don’t see what would be bad about that as long as you reduce your volume too.”

A year or two later, after tons of research came out, he star

This morning (Sunday, 7 May 2023) as I was doing my breathing practice, I had an amazing sense of gratitude wash over me. I thought, How wonderful that the same process that sustains life is also able to give us the most relaxed and focused states. It’s just crazy, you know?

(#164) The Breathing Exercise to Do in the Morning

The best breathing exercise to do in the morning is a good night's sleep.

P.S. Although sleep is foundational to health, I rarely talk about it because I think a lot of people worry too much about it, which causes more harm than good. However, I've had a few nights of poorer-than-normal sleep and noticed that my morning breathing is nowhere near as enjoyable or effective. Which made me think of this purposefully playful sentence :)

"The yogi's life is not measured by his days, but by the number of his breaths." - B.K.S. Iyengar

If breaths measure time,

(#150) Breathing versus Meditation

I've come to believe this is a trick comparison.

I think all breathing exercises (or "breathwork") are a subcategory of meditation.

Paradoxically, I equally believe that all of meditation is a subcategory of breathing.

Tomatoes, tomatoes.

The most important aspect is what outcome you're trying to achieve.

And just like you can't compare vipassana to loving-kindness meditation, I don't think there's any real way to compare breathing exercises to other forms of meditation because they have different purposes.

(#150) A Small Investment, An Enormous Reward

“We’re busy. We’re time-pressured. We are always under the gun. But twelve more minutes of work is simply not going to catch you up as much as sitting quietly, and on purpose, with your breath. For only a little effort and a small investment of time, you can reap an enormous reward.” – Amishi P. Jha, Ph.D., [*Peak Mind*](#)

Got a lot to do? Doing more work will not catch you up as much as 12 minutes with your breath will.

Reminds me of Gandhi, yet again,

(#142) It Is a Superpower But...

“I said in the introduction that the present moment is the only place you can use your attention. It can't be saved up for later. It is a superpower, but it has to be used now. It can only be used now.”* – Amishi P. Jha, Ph.D., [*Peak Mind*](#)

Likewise, breathing is also a superpower. But it can only be used now. It can't be saved up for later.

* I'm listening to this book and haven't gotten the print or Kindle versions yet, so this is my best attempt at transcription.

(#140) Imagine

Imagine if we checked in with our breath as much as we checked our phones.

Imagine if, when we checked to see what our fitness devices said, we first checked into our bodies to see how we felt before letting the number decide that for us.

It's fun to imagine...

(#129) Olaf, You, and Your Breathing

My daughter loves Frozen. I was reading her the story and learned that Olaf—the snowman—always dreams of summer. It's all this snowman talks about.

It's funny, of course, but it made me think how funny it is that we're all Olaf. We're all desperate to have whatever we don't have. Not knowing that if we did actually get it, we might melt away...

“For example, like the channels, the nervous system carries the body's energy and impulses to the tissues and organs in different parts of the body. And as we have seen, working with the breath can regulate the sympathetic nervous system to reduce agitation and stimulate the parasympathetic nervous system to invite relaxation. The breath brings the energy of our entire system into balance.”

(#93) The Shape of the Lungs

Yesterday, we learned we should breathe nasally and abdominally because it helps us relax and get more oxygen.

Another reason—which I always forget because I like to complicate things—is simply the shape of the lungs:

“Abdominal breathing is more efficient simply because of the shape of the lungs. Since they are narrow at the top and wider at the bottom, the amount of blood flow in the lower lobes of the lungs is greater than in the upper lobes.” – Patrick McKeown, *The Oxygen Advantage*

Anatomy and physiology have a way of complementing each other 😊

(#92) Becoming Breathing Coddiwomples

Coddiwomple: To travel purposefully toward an as-yet-unknown destination.

I think that describes what we’re doing in the Learning Center perfectly: Becoming breathing coddiwomples.

P.S. Thanks to Robert Moses for sharing this funny word with me. I love being a breathing coddiwomple.

A Paradox of Breathing Studies

“Mingyur had run smack into a paradox of today’s research on consciousness, the mind, and meditative training: those who do the research on meditation are too often in the dark about what they are actually studying.”

- Daniel Goleman & Richard Davidson, *Altered Traits*

Of course, it’s good to have scientists blinded when analyzing results. But when designing the experiments, expertise is better.

Unfortunately for breathing studies, this is not always the case. So we just have to do the best we can to analyze the results in great detail to discover which ones make sense and which ones are truly breakthroughs.

P.S. This is why I love doing the Science 411s, and why I hope you find them valuable :)

#13: Resonance Breathing for Sleep: A World-Renowned Yoga Instructor

Yesterday, we discussed a study showing that slow breathing before sleep improves sleep quality and vagal tone.

But better than any study, here's a real-world example from a world-renowned yoga instructor (and just genuinely good human being), Eddie Stern.

"I have found that just a few minutes of resonance breathing each day has improved my sleep, and my ability to fall asleep much more quickly. ... Resonance breathing has helped me to get in touch with the parasympathetic branch of the nervous system that rules rest. When I lie down to sleep at night, I can sense sleep much more readily, and I can give into it."

- Eddie Stern, One Simple Thing

In fact, it was so powerful for Eddie that he went and created a resonance breathing app.

Use it tonight for better sleep. (https://apps.apple.com/us/app/the-breathing-app/id1285982210?utm_source=TheBreathingDiabetic)

#15: Why Slow Breathing Helps Reduce Blood Pressure

“The connection between stress and blood pressure is the autonomic nervous system, which regulates the tone of the smooth (involuntary) muscle that lines the walls of arteries. The sympathetic branch of that system constricts arteries, increasing blood pressure, while the parasympathetic branch relaxes them, lowering pressure.”

- Andrew Weil, MD, Mind Over Meds

Slow breathing activates the parasympathetic branch of our nervous system. As we learn here, this relaxes our arteries and lowers blood pressure.

And with regular practice, we increase the tone of the parasympathetic nervous system, leading to [long-term reductions in blood pressure](#).

This is why the [American Heart Association says](#), “*The overall evidence from clinical trials and meta-analyses suggests that device-guided slow breathing can significantly lower BP [blood pressure].*”

Sounds good to me 🙏

#20: Going on a Never-Ending Cleanse

"The waste that is collected by the blood and delivered to the lungs is expelled with the next inhale, but few people realize that 70 percent of the waste that our bodies generate is removed by the breath. Only 30 percent is removed via sweat and elimination."

- Al Lee and Don Campbell, Perfect Breathing

I've actually never been able to find a study explaining this statistic (which I hear everywhere). And at first glance, it seems a bit crazy.

But it actually makes a lot of sense.

The other ways of removing toxins (sweating, restroom breaks) only occur several times a day (or maybe not at all for sweating). But we typically breathe 20,000+ times a day, and upwards of 3000 gallons of air.

So, perhaps it is not surprising that our bodies use the breath to eliminate toxins. And maybe what's more surprising is that optimizing breathing isn't the first step of any "cleanse."

#21: The Best Way to Make Your Breathing Practice (or any habit) Stick

“Celebration will one day be ranked alongside mindfulness and gratitude as daily practices that contribute most to our overall happiness and well-being.” - BJ Fogg, Tiny Habits

That’s a crazy powerful statement when we think about how much research has been done on mindfulness and gratitude. And a great reason to add celebration into your routine.

If you spend 1 minute focused on your breath, celebrate it. If you already have a solid practice, try adding some celebration to the end. Say, “that’s like me!” or give yourself a high five.

Is it cheesy? Certainly.

Is it rooted in science from the leader in habit development at Stanford? Yes.

Will anyone know? Nope.

Give it a shot.

#23: Two Tiny (but hopefully useful) Thoughts on Methods

1. If you know only one breathing method, then you really know none; if you understand one breathing method, then you really know them all.

2. Every method works when used correctly, but no method works for everybody.

Apply these to your breathing, as well as all aspects of life (especially #2).

#25: Mindful Low-and-Slow Breathing is “Almost Always Helpful”

“Mindful low-and-slow breathing (Chapter 2) activates the parasympathetic (relaxation) nervous system and is therefore almost always helpful in reducing physiological arousal, including bringing down skin conductance. Reducing skin conductance with low-and-slow breathing is particularly helpful for a quick recovery break, between meetings, or as a break from challenging activities of the day.”

- Inna Khazan, PhD, Biofeedback and Mindfulness in Everyday Life

Mindful low-and-slow breathing is “almost always helpful in reducing physiological arousal.”
<— sounds good to me.

And the best part is that we can use it anytime, anywhere, for a quick reset and recovery.

Be sure to take advantage of it, today.

P.S. Skin conductance is important here because, according to Dr. Khazan, “*Higher skin conductance indicates increased stress activation.*” Breathe deeply, lower your skin conductance, and reduce your stress activation.

#26: How to (actually) Accomplish More than You Ever Thought Possible

“By tapping into your natural resilience through breathing and other calming exercises that activate the rest and digest part of your nervous system, you can learn to reduce stress and accomplish more than you ever thought possible.”

- Emma Seppälä, Ph.D., The Happiness Track

When we practice breathing exercises regularly, we learn to “reduce stress and accomplish more than you ever thought possible.”

Personally, I never imagined I could have written a newsletter every week for 4 years. Or walked 100 miles wearing a 20 lbs. rucksack. Or started a learning center.

It all started with the power of the breath.

What about you? What has a consistent practice helped you accomplish? Or what might it help you achieve in the future?

Here's to exceeding our potential, today.

#30: How to Enter Mystical Traditions without Caves

“Do you want to enter into the most mystical of traditions and gather their fruits? Forget studying difficult languages and going into a cave for twenty years. Just breathe on the sofa in the morning before breakfast.”

- Wim Hof, The Wim Hof Method

This made me laugh, but it's also quite accurate. And not just for Wim's method. It also applies to slow breathing; to alternate nostril breathing; to basically every method.

Breathing is a shortcut into mystical traditions. All you have to do is *“breathe on the sofa in the morning before breakfast.”*

Give it a try tomorrow morning 🏠

#35: Breathing Residue: Turning Setbacks into Assets

“The problem this research identifies with this work strategy is that when you switch from some Task A to another Task B, your attention doesn’t immediately follow—a residue of your attention remains stuck thinking about the original task.”

- Cal Newport, Deep Work

Attention residue. It’s a major setback to productivity.

However, let’s turn that concept into something positive with a new term:

Breathing Residue: The calm yet mentally alert feeling that persists several minutes (sometimes hours) after performing a slow breathing practice.

Let’s try to reduce our attention residue, and increase our breathing residue, a little more today :)

P.S. The true science nerds among you might prefer to call “breathing residue” by its more scientific name, vagal tone. But that’s not as fun 😊

#36: What is Slow Breathing?

We talk a lot about slow breathing because it's the most studied and proven method for better overall health and wellness. But we haven't formally defined it. So, let's do that.

Scientifically, it's slow breathing is breathing at a rate less than 10 breaths per minute.

But, when I refer to it, I usually mean breathing at a rate less than 7 breaths per minute (usually somewhere between 3 and 7 breaths/min).

And the simplest way to start is to breathe at 6 breaths per minute using a 4-second inhale and a 6-second exhale.

Give it a try, for at least 2 minutes, and see how you feel.

#38: The 3 Best Ways to be Consistent with Your Breathing (or any) Practice

“A small daily task, if it be really daily, will beat the labours of a spasmodic Hercules.”

– Anthony Trollope

1. Start very tiny. Even if it's 1 breath or 30 seconds. Just pick something so small you can't fail.
2. Do it at the same time every day. Pick a consistent cue (e.g., brushing your teeth, etc.) that will trigger your tiny practice.
3. Celebrate. This is most important. Do something silly that you find rewarding (fist bump, etc.). Celebration releases dopamine, which will trick your brain into looking forward to your practice.

P.S. Here's my celebration: “That's like me to do another breathing session!”

P.P.S. These concepts come from the excellent book Tiny Habits.

#39:

#41: The Best Breathing (and life) Advice I've Ever Read

After reviewing tons of scientific papers, reading books, taking classes, and on & on, here's the best breathing advice I've ever read:

"All this is literary, over-simplified, but we breathe as best we can." - Samuel Beckett

Try as we might, we'll never fully understand it. They'll be inconsistent results. New discoveries. Revised approaches. But it's all "literary, over-simplified."

So, we just "breathe as best we can" with what we know.

P.S. Want the best life advice? Replace "breathe" with "live": All this is literary, over-simplified, but we live as best we can. Let's try to do that, today.

#42: Breathing to Boost Creativity: Quieting the Amygdala, Pessimism, and 80%

“Unfortunately, to keep us safe, the amygdala is strongly biased toward negative information. ...This crushes optimism and squelches creativity. When tuned toward the negative, we miss the novel.”

- Steven Kotler, The Art of Impossible

When we meditate or practice slow breathing (~4-6 breaths/minute), activity in our amygdala is reduced.

This turns down negative thinking and turns up creativity.

Perhaps this is why, after interviewing the most creative people on the planet, Tim Ferriss discovered that *“More than 80% of the interviewees have some form of daily mindfulness or meditation practice.”*

These practices naturally lead to cardiorespiratory coherence, quieting the pessimistic amygdala, allowing us to see the novelty all around us.

So how about we slow down our breath, quiet our amygdala, and cultivate a little more creativity, today.

#44: Slow Breathing for Diabetes and High Blood Pressure

“If consistently used, guided breathing enhances restoration of physiological autonomic balance in patients with diabetes and hypertension.”

- Effects of Guided Breathing on Blood Pressure and Heart Rate Variability in Hypertensive Diabetic Patients

This study found that just 12 minutes a day of slow breathing (with no changes to medication) led to significantly lower blood pressure, increased heart rate variability, and a reduced spontaneous breathing rate.

All these results indicate reduced sympathetic arousal—that is, higher vagal tone.

And even if you don’t have hypertension or diabetes, these benefits will be useful, nonetheless.

So here’s to controlling our breath, reducing our blood pressure, and reducing the amount of time we spend in a fight-or-flight mode, today.

#45: Longer Exhalations are Naturally Relaxing

“It's helpful to extend your exhalations because the ‘rest and digest’ parasympathetic nervous system handles exhaling while also slowing your heart rate. So, longer exhalations are naturally relaxing.”

- Rick Hanson, Ph.D., Neurodharma

Just a friendly reminder that extending the exhalation is one of the fastest ways to naturally relax. That is all for today.

Well, except for a friendly reminder that we have to actually practice this stuff to get the benefits. So why don't we all take a few minutes and focus on extending our exhales so we can actually feel it for ourselves :)

Why We Breathe: Chemically and Spiritually

“Our drive to breathe is regulated by the medulla oblongata ... When pH decreases (becomes more acidic due to the increase in CO₂), chemoreceptors in the medulla send out a signal for the body to breathe. This means that our carbon dioxide levels have to rise to a sufficiently high level for our brain and body to know that it is time to take the next breath.”

- Inna Khazan, Ph.D.

It's the perfect day to review why we breathe. So there's the technical reason.

But breathing is a lot more than just gases. As Michael J Stephen, MD, tells us,

“That oxygen, life, and lungs all came into our world in relatively close succession is no coincidence. Only with oxygen and some means of extracting it are all things possible—thinking, moving, eating, speaking, and loving. Life and the breath are synonymous.”

So beyond chemistry, we ultimately breathe to live—to think, to move, to love. Breathing is, after all, what makes “all things possible.”

#6: What Do 5,649 and 28,800 Have in Common?

“The average daily step count required to induce feelings of anxiety and depression and decrease satisfaction with life is 5,649. The typical American takes 4,774 steps per day. Across the globe, the average is 4,961.” – Kelly McGonigal, The Joy of Movement

People become anxious and lose life satisfaction when their step count drops to 5,649 or less. That’s crazy, given that the U.S. and global average step counts are below that.

With breathing, however, the opposite relationship is true: The more breaths you take, the more taxing it is on your mental and physical health:

“Recent evidence suggests that an adult with a respiratory rate of over 20 breaths/minute is probably unwell, and an adult with a respiratory rate of over 24 breaths/minute is likely to be critically ill.” – Respiratory Rate: The Neglected Vital Sign

(<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/18513176/>)

If your spontaneous breathing rate is over 20 breaths per minute, you are “probably unwell.” That comes out to about 28,800 breaths per day.

So, do you want to feel unwell and anxious?

Take less than 5,649 steps and breathe more than 28,800 breaths per day.

Want to be happy and healthy?

Walk more, breathe less.

P.S. That 28,800 number is likely way too high. James Nestor shares some great ancient wisdom on this:

“Chinese doctors two thousand years ago advised 13,500 breaths per day, which works out to nine and a half breaths per minute. “

- Breath

P.P.S. Deeper, slower, quieter, and more regular

#6 Is There a Perfect Breath?

“What is the perfect breath? Far from being some noble yet unreachable goal that takes years of rigorous practice to master, a perfect breath is any breath you take for which you are completely and mindfully aware.” – Al Lee & Don Campbell

That definition is, well, perfect. But let’s not forget about James Nestor’s perfect breath, which has slightly deeper roots in physiology:

“They discovered that the optimum amount of air we should take in at rest per minute is 5.5 liters. The optimum breathing rate is about 5.5 breaths per minute. That’s 5.5-second inhales and 5.5-second exhales. This is the perfect breath.”

#7 The Best (and Second-Best) Time to Start a Breathing Practice

“Build before you have to.

- Build knowledge before you have to.
- Build strength before you have to.
- Build an emergency fund before you have to.

Let internal pressure drive you today, so you can handle external pressure tomorrow.”

James Clear, 3-2-1 Newsletter (3 Sep 2020)

This reminded me of the famous Chinese proverb that begins: The best time to plant a tree was 20 years ago. That is, if you want a tree now, you need to have planted it 20 years ago. If you need strength now, you need to have been building it previously.

The Chinese proverb, however, ends like this: The second-best time is now. Let’s remember that with our breathing practice as well.

The best time to start a breathing practice was 12 months ago.
The second-best time is now.

Like we said last time, action is the cornerstone of all improvement.

Here’s to acting (and starting) today.

#8 Breath Practice versus Breath Training

Breath Practice: Time you spend every day performing breathing exercises that are comfortable and beneficial to you. Think of it as self-care. For me, this would include my 20 minutes of slow breathing first thing in the morning.

Breath Training: Time you spend deliberately pushing yourself to improve your breathing. For example, if you can comfortably box breathe with a 4-4-4-4 rate, you might spend some time at 5-5-5-5 rate as training.

Breath Training is always Breath Practice, but Breath Practice is not always Breath Training.

(This thought was inspired by pages 51-53 of Breathe to Perform.)

#9 The Most Important Part of Your Breathing Practice

Regardless of which method you use, here is the most important part of the practice: to practice.

How can you practice (and enjoy the practice) more today?

#10 Why Are You “Breathing”?

“Don’t mistake the finger pointing to the moon for the moon itself.” – Buddhist Saying

Let us not forget that “breathing” is only the finger.

#11 The Positive Breathing-Relaxation Feedback Loop

“Slow breathing techniques with long exhalation will signal a state of relaxation by VN, resulting in more VN activity and further relaxation.”

- Frontiers in Human Neuroscience, 2018

Here's a positive feedback loop we can celebrate: Slow breathing sends a message of relaxation via the vagus nerve, which increases vagal activity, further enhancing relaxation. Thank you, complicated physiology.

Practically, this is why when you start your slow breathing practice, you don't feel much at first, but after a few minutes, you feel like a different person. You're experiencing this positive breathing-relaxation feedback loop in action.

Complex science. Simple to experience.

Give it a shot today.

#12 Slow breathing is reverse Arambhashura. It makes you a hero at the end.

#13 Are Lucid Breathers The Future Of Evolution?

“It seems to be only around 20 to 30% of the population are actually natural lucid dreamers...Maybe those 20 to 30% of people who do lucid dream are at the forefront of hominid evolution, and they are going to be the next species of preference. We just don’t know.”

- Matthew Walker, Ph.D.

Maybe the same is true of lucid breathers? Interestingly, Nature made it difficult to control our dreams. It made it simple to control our breath—though most of us sleep right through it.

But control over our breath was not an accident. As Belisa Vranich and Brian Sabin tell us in *Breathing for Warriors*, “It’s an invitation, an opportunity to take part in our own nature and evolution.”

So wake up in your breath. Use it to control this dream we call living.

#14 Breathing is Practical Idealism

“Mahatma Gandhi called this “practical idealism,” which means that it can be practiced in every aspect of life. It doesn’t call so much for great acts of heroism as for a continuing, persistent effort to transform ill will into good will, self-interest into compassion.” – Your Life is Your Message

Breathing is a form of “practical idealism.” It’s idyllic in that we can talk about how “breath is life,” or how it’s our body’s most important function.

But it’s practical in that it can be used by anyone, anytime, anywhere. It doesn’t call for huge acts, just simple changes like using your nose, slowing down your breath, and extending your exhales.

And, quite literally, it can transform “ill will into good will, self-interest into compassion.” Not in some woo-woo way, but in a concrete way, by stimulating the vagus nerve and shifting dominance to your parasympathetic (calming) system.

But, it’s only practical idealism if you practice it. So here’s to bringing more slow breathing and good will into your life today.

#15 Use Your Breath Instead of Your Brain

“Social psychologists now know that the truth lies in the opposite direction. People need to change their actions and their minds will follow.” – Sean D Young, *Stick With It*

Experts tell us it's hard to think our way out of thinking. We need to act and let the mind follow. I believe this is what makes breathing so powerful. It gives you an action you can perform anytime to trick your mind into following.

If you're anxious, you can breathe slowly, which will calm your nervous system and lead to calmer thoughts. If you're tired, you can breathe rapidly and stimulate your nervous system, increasing your heart rate and alertness.

There are many ways to use actions to control your emotions and thoughts. But breathing is free and easy.

How can you stop thinking and start breathing more today?

#16 The Best Advice You Can Give Someone Interested in Breathing

If you ever mention that you're into "breathing," maybe to a coworker, friend, or family member, you might be asked where the best place to start is. I think James Clear's quote below is the perfect approach:

"Start now. Optimize later. Imperfect starts can always be improved." – James Clear

Whether you recommend the Oxygen Advantage, Wim Hof, The Art of Breath, Buteyko, Breatheology, SKY, ujjayi, or just sitting with an app and slow breathing, the most important thing is that they just try it. Ask them to choose one that sounds fun and start—experience for themselves how simple and powerful these practices are. They can optimize later.

Direct vs. Indirect Slow Relaxed Breathing: Pick Which Suits You Best

Thoughts 2 & 3 bring up two important concepts:

Direct Slow Breathing: Using an app (or counting) to deliberately breathe slowly at a set pace (like five breaths a minute).

Indirect Slow Breathing: Using mindfulness or a relaxation technique (like yoga nidra) to inadvertently slow your breathing.

Of course, they have slightly different benefits, but either will be an effective way to improve your health & wellness, so pick the one that suits you best 🙏

(#639) Being Breathed

“One day I noticed that I wasn’t breathing—I was being breathed.” —Byron Katie

I think about this quote often—not in a “woo-woo” kind of way, but in a way that sparks gratitude.

Because no matter what we call it—God, prana, life force, or simply the autonomic nervous system—it’s pretty remarkable to remember that there is something within us that ensures we’re always breathing, always living.

It brings to mind this gem from Yogani:

“The fact that we are breathing is an affirmation of life. It means we want to be here. It means we want to be doing something here.” 🙏🙏🙏

(#640) Do Them Enjoyably, Not Well

“Why do you have to do things well? Do them enjoyably, not well.” – Anthony de Mello, Awareness

This quote comes from a story about a small group of friends that loved playing music together—not because they were good, but because they enjoyed it. I thought it was a wonderful reminder that we don’t always have to optimize and be amazing at everything we do (including our contemplative practices). We can just enjoy it—that’s what matters most. That’s the art of mindful living 🙏

(#641) Making Goodness Thrive

“I will laugh at evil and it will die untasted; I will laugh at goodness and it will thrive and abound.”
— Og Mandino

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate—and in this case, one you can immediately put into action 🙏

(#642) Eternity Is Not a Long Time

“Eternity is not a long time. Eternity is not future or past. Eternity is a dimension of now. It is a dimension of the human spirit—which is eternal.” – Joseph Campbell

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#643) The Concept Might Be Holding Us Back

“A second quality of a concept is that it is static whereas reality is in flux. Let’s suppose...I want you to get the feel of what the flow of a river is like and I bring it to you in a bucket. The moment I put it into a bucket, it has stopped flowing. The moment you put things into a concept, they stop flowing; they become static, dead. ... Concepts are always frozen. Reality flows.” – Anthony de Mello, *Awareness*

This applies perfectly to our contemplative practices. The moment we (or the people we help) put them into a bucket, they stop flowing. We might want them to “feel like they did when we first started” or match some static idea of what meditation “should” be. But we’d be wise to remember that reality is always flowing: Our concepts are just buckets trying to convey the river’s power. It’s better to simply jump in.

(#644) Three Excellent Quotes

I was revisiting our Book 411 on The Healing Power of the Breath and decided to switch up this TB1% and simply share three great quotes from it. Enjoy!

“The daily use of breath practices can turn back the tide of stress, counteract disease progression, and improve overall quality of life.”

“Once you establish an inner calm, you will transmit it naturally to others.”

“In learning breath practices the most important thing to remember is to relax. ... Self-judgment adds another layer of stress. The less you judge yourself, the easier it will be to relax and experience the benefits.”

(#645) Take It on the Path with Us

“The important thing is not to worry about what is going to happen to us but to create inner strength to deal with whatever does happen. We will be able to take it on the path with us. Something that outwardly looks negative can inwardly be exactly what we need as a real help and aid to our practice. This is so important.” – Jetsunma Tenzin Palmo, *The Heroic Heart*

This perfectly captures everything we do in the Learning Center. It’s not about never having challenges or “making life perfect.” It’s about using our practices to build resilience so we can deal with the stressors that will inevitably come our way. As Sheng Yen says, “Practice should not be separated from living, and living at all times should be one’s practice.” 🙏

(#646) Mindfulness Lowers Inflammation

“Mindfulness practice, it seems, lessens inflammation day to day, not just during meditation itself. The benefits seem to show up even with just four weeks of mindfulness practice (around thirty hours total), as well as with loving-kindness meditation. While those new to MBSR had a mild trend toward lower cortisol, a large drop in cortisol under stress seems to kick in at some point with continued practice. Looks like there’s biological confirmation of what meditators say: it gets easier to handle life’s upsets.” – Daniel Goleman, Ph.D. & Richard Davidson, Ph.D., *Altered Traits*

Given that excess inflammation negatively impacts nearly every aspect of health, this highlights just how powerful a consistent mindfulness practice can be for overall well-being 🙏

(#647) Easy to Absorb and Apply

“Consider the tale of a yogi who had spent years in a Himalayan cave on retreat. One day a traveler happened by and, seeing the yogi, asked him what he was doing.

“I’m meditating on patience,” the yogi said.

“In that case,” replied the traveler, “you can go to hell!”

To which the yogi angrily retorted, “You go to hell!”

That tale...has served for centuries as a cautionary tale to serious practitioners, **reminding them that the test of their practice is life itself, not isolated hours in meditation.** A trait like patience should leave us unflappable no matter what life brings our way.” - Daniel Goleman, Ph.D. & Richard Davidson, Ph.D., *Altered Traits*

That’s my favorite kind of medicine: a powerful insight wrapped in humor to make it easy to absorb and apply 😊.

(#648) Interrupting a Song After Every Note

“Self-consciousness is a stoppage because it is like interrupting a song after every note so as to listen to the echo, and then feeling irritated because of the loss of rhythm.” – Alan Watts

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#649) Living from Your Innate Goodness

“Virtue sounds lofty, but it’s actually down to earth. It simply means living from your innate goodness, guided by principle.” – Rick Hanson, Ph.D.

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy 🙏

(#650) It Was the Stop that Hurt

“There’s the story of Paddy, who fell off the scaffolding and got a good bump. They asked, ‘Did the fall hurt you, Paddy?’ And he said, ‘No, it was the stop that hurt, not the fall.’” – Anthony de Mello, Awareness

How funny is that? It’s a great reminder that when things hurt, it’s usually a good sign—it likely means we’ve finally stopped falling.

(#651) Complex Problems, Simple Solutions

“Many fall into the trap of thinking that if they have a complex or debilitating problem, then they need a complex or difficult solution, one that takes time and energy to apply. Since they expect the solution to take effort, they overlook the easy suggestions and focus only on the difficult techniques, or those they haven't heard or used before.

The truth is, if you have a big or complex problem, then more than likely you need a simple and easy solution—one that is easy to apply and that you are encouraged to apply.” – Kam Knight, Concentration

A wonderful reminder that just because a problem is complex doesn't mean the solution has to be. Most times, it's the simple things—breathing, meditating, walking, laughing—that help the most 🙏

(#652) The Overlooked Way to Stress Resilience

“But the research shows us that when it comes to building stress resilience, one of the most powerful interventions is focusing on joy—specifically, the positive things that exist in our lives now, and on creating a positive future.” – Elissa Epel, Ph.D., The Stress Prescription (<https://breathlearning.com/book-411s/the-stress-prescription/>)

Here’s an excellent reminder of a straightforward yet often overlooked truth: a robust way to build stress resilience is to simply focus on joy. This includes finding joy in what you already have, and in doing things that bring you joy (not things that “ought” or “should” bring you joy, but things that actually bring you joy).

So, that’s our “stress prescription” for the day: find joy in what we have and find ways to do things we enjoy 🙌

(#653) Rain, Windshield Wipers, and Your Mind

“Like driving in a heavy storm, rain is falling on the windshield, but the wipers clear it away. There is never a moment when the rain stops; however, because the wipers constantly wipe away the falling water, the view remains clear.

...Like a heavy storm, thoughts pour relentlessly into awareness, blurring the view of what’s important. Removing the thoughts keeps awareness clear, despite the endless downpour. You are not pulled away or distracted by any drop.” – Kam Knight, Concentration

This is a great analogy for concentration and meditation we can use and share with others. Thoughts will always pour in like rain during a storm. Our job is to simply run the windshield wipers: observe the thoughts, let go of them, and then return to our object of focus. Just like driving in a storm, it’s the constant repetition that keeps our view clear 🧘

(#654) It's Okay to Have Fun with It

"It's good to bring playfulness, even delight, to your practices. See if you can be amused sometimes by your own mind, its zigging and zagging, the tricks it can play, the surprising sudden openings. I've gotten way too serious about my own practice in the past. Practice is less effective if it's heavy and somber most of the time. It's okay to have fun with it!" – Rick Hanson, Ph.D., Neurodharma <https://breathlearning.com/book-411s/neurodharma/>

That is some excellent advice for our contemplative practices...and all of life: "It's okay to have fun with it!"

(#655) Stop to Think?

“Someone once said, ‘I dare not stop to think, because if I did, I wouldn’t know how to get started again.’” – Anthony de Mello

P.S. On weekends, I just share a memorable (and in this case, lighthearted) quote for you to enjoy 🙏

(#656) A Better Definition of Happiness

“Perhaps we can define happiness as experiencing real emotions over real problems and real tasks.” – Abraham Maslow

P.S. On weekends, I just share a memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

(#657) Freezing on Words

“Mark Twain put it very nicely when he said, ‘It was so cold that if the thermometer had been an inch longer, we would have frozen to death’. We do freeze to death on words. It’s not the cold outside that matters, but the thermometer. It’s not reality that matters, but what you’re saying to yourself about it.” – Anthony de Mello, Awareness

How good is that? We often put more meaning into the words we use to describe reality than into reality itself. But this is where mindfulness comes in. With practice, it allows us to see things for what they are and let go of the concepts that may be holding us back. Instead of trying to “trap the river in a bucket,” we simply jump in and experience it for ourselves.

P.S. This brings to mind a similar gem from Alan Watts: “Most of us would rather have money than tangible wealth, and a great occasion is somehow spoiled for us unless photographed. To read about it the next day in the newspaper is oddly more fun for us than the original event.”

(#658) Three Quotes: Moving for Stillness

Here are three great reminders that, somewhat counterintuitively, movement is a key ingredient of any stillness practice:

“We need to move to be still, and only from that place of stillness can we move well.” – Caroline Williams

“Without a balance between physical activity and meditation, for instance, we may become irritable or restless. Exercise...can help to solve some of the problems that come as you descend in consciousness.” – Eknath Easwaran

“In order to understand the dance, one must be still. And in order to truly understand stillness, one must dance.” – Attributed to Rumi

(#659) The Key to Mind Control

“Additionally, a growing body of literature reveals that developing control over physical movements is necessary for improving attention and concentration. A 2015 study of mindful movement and skilled attention by Dav Clark, Frank Schumann, and Stewart Mostofsky stated that the process of controlling attentional movement cannot be cleanly separated from the selection of physical movements. In other words, motor control is the key to mind control.” – Kam Knight, Concentration

Yesterday, we saw three great quotes on how movement and stillness are interdependent. Today, we go even further, learning that movement isn’t just important for stillness—it’s necessary for improving attention itself. So, let’s do our best to remember and apply these practical words: “Motor control is the key to mind control.”

(#660) On Results Guiding Truth

“Investigate yourself. Question everything. Take nothing for granted. Don’t believe anything because it sounds wise and pious and some holy man said it. See for yourself. That does not mean that you should be cynical, impudent, or irreverent. It means you should be empirical. Subject all statements to the actual test of your own experience, and let the results be your guide to truth.” – Bhante Gunaratana, Mindfulness in Plain English
(<https://breathlearning.com/book-411s/mindfulness-in-plain-english/>)

Amen to that 🙏

P.S. Here’s another gem from Rick Rubin on this same concept: “Receive wisdom skillfully. Try it on for size and see how it fits. Incorporate what’s useful. Let go of the rest. And no matter how credible the source, test and tune in to yourself to discover what works for you.”

(#661) Flow and “Putting Out Fingers”

“Watch the flow of water when it floods an area of land and you will see that it puts out fingers, and some of them stop because they come to blind alleys. But the water doesn’t pursue that course; it simply finds its way around. The water never uses any effort, however, only its weight and gravity, and by following its level it finds the path of least resistance.” – Alan Watts, *Still the Mind*

Water doesn’t force its way through obstacles. It lets gravity do the work and simply finds its way around. This is a great analogy for mindful living. While we still put effort into tasks and goals, mindful living teaches us to stop forcing rigid outcomes and instead go with the flow of life.

So, today’s 1% is to make sure you’re “putting out enough fingers” to find your way around any challenge you may be facing 🙌

New Science 411: The Benefits of Bhramari Pranayama

“Bhramari pranayama practice is found to be associated with higher levels of attention, quality of sleep, parasympathetic activity and pulmonary functioning and lower levels of stress, anxiety, depression, sympathetic activity and blood pressure across the included studies.” – Chetry et al. (2024)

We have a new Science 411 available all about bhramari pranayama (or humming bee breathing), and that excerpt from the abstract sums it up nicely.

While humming is often claimed to have many health benefits, this paper provides a well-rounded look at the actual evidence supporting bhramari as a formal breath practice. (Interestingly, nitric oxide wasn't even mentioned in this review, yet the findings still showed a wide range of notable health improvements.)

I hope you enjoy reading (or listening) to the 411!

In good breath,
Nick

(#662) Evolutionary Balance and Beauty

“It is quite a striking example of evolutionary balance and beauty that the trees around us that give off oxygen and the trees in our lungs that absorb it share a similar structure.” – Patrick McKeown

P.S. On weekends, I just send a short and memorable quote for you to enjoy 🙏

(#663) To Be Soothed and Healed

“I go to nature to be soothed and healed, and to have my senses put in order.” – John Burroughs

P.S. On weekends, I just send a short and memorable quote for you to enjoy 🙏

P.P.S. I found this one in Blue Mind. If you haven't checked out the 411 on that book, it's worth a look.

(#664) A Lens that Focuses Scattered Energy

“One way to think of this process of transformation is **to think of mindfulness as a lens, taking the scattered and reactive energies of your mind and focusing them** into a coherent source of energy for living, for problem solving, and for healing.” – Jon Kabat-Zinn, Full Catastrophe Living

What a great analogy for why something as simple as “paying attention” can be so powerful. It’s not that mindfulness is some magical force. It simply helps us gather all the energy of the mind that’s already there—energy typically wasted on things like reacting, worrying, and stress—and focus it on good.

So, here’s to using our “lens” to put our energy toward living, problem-solving, and healing a little more today 🙏

(#665) Intelligent Control of Breathing

“An intelligent control of our breathing power will lengthen our days upon earth by giving us increased vitality and powers of resistance, and, on the other hand, unintelligent and careless breathing will tend to shorten our days, by decreasing our vitality and laying us open to disease.”
— Science of Breath, Yogi Ramacharaka

Just a simple (but always welcomed) reminder of the power of our breath. By using it wisely—which usually means nasal, slower, deeper, and quieter—it can help us lengthen our days and support our vitality and resilience 🙌

P.S. And let’s also remember that the simple practice of mindful breathing can literally lengthen our days (insert hyperlink <https://breathlearning.com/the-breathing-1/number-154/>) by helping us actually be present for more of them.

(#666) Spirituality Means to Breathe

“Richard Dawkins, the scientist, once said to me, “Mr. Kumar, I don’t believe in spirituality.”

I answered, “Professor Dawkins, Don’t you believe in breathing?”

He said, “What do you mean?”

I said, “Spirituality means to breathe. You and I breathe together, that’s spirituality.” – Satish Kumar, Elegant Simplicity

Just a lighthearted reminder that spirituality doesn’t have to be complicated or tied to a specific system. It can simply mean to breathe together. Nothing is more natural than that 😊

P.S. Speaking of lighthearted, I chose this quote about spirituality and breathing because today is TB1% number 666...figured I’d err on the safe side 😄

(#667) Nature's Plan is Proper Breathing

“The internal organs also need exercise, and Nature’s plan for this exercise is proper breathing. The diaphragm is Nature’s principal instrument for this internal exercise. Its motion vibrates the important organs of nutrition and elimination, and massages and kneads them at each inhalation and exhalation, forcing blood into them, and then squeezing it out, and imparting a general tone to the organs.” – Yogi Ramacharaka, Science of Breath

Here’s a great reminder that, aside from its life-giving properties and direct influence on the brain and nervous system, the breath also gives the abdominal organs their daily exercise via the diaphragm.

So, here’s to getting our inner workout—many thousands of times—today 🙏

(#668) Breath-Heart Connection

Here are three great reminders of the breath-heart connection to enjoy today:

1. "You know that our breathing is the inhaling and exhaling of air. The organ which serves for this is the lungs which lie round the heart. Thus breathing is a natural way to the heart." - Nicephorus the Solitary
2. "If you would foster a calm spirit, first regulate your breathing; for when that is under control, the heart will be at peace." - Kariba Ekken
3. "Thank you from the bottom of my heart, which is, of course, my diaphragm." - Jill Miller

(#669) Your Only Hope

“It is impossible to become like somebody else. Your only hope is to become more fully yourself.” – Jon Kabat-Zinn, Ph.D.

P.S. On weekends, I just send a short memorable quote for you to enjoy 🙏

(#670) Artistry in Living

“Artistry in living begins with learning to be flexible for the sake of those around us.” – Eknath Easwaran

P.S. On weekends, I just send a short memorable quote for you to enjoy and contemplate 🙏

P.P.S. If you’re interested in more context, Easwaran had an important clarification to this idea that is quite insightful:

“I always try to make clear that this does not mean making yourself a doormat, saying yes to anything people say or do. Putting the welfare of other people first is not the same as doing whatever they want. If someone close to you wants something that is in no one's best interests, or something which you feel is wrong, it is necessary to say no, respectfully but firmly. The point of this exercise is not to weaken good judgment but to reduce self-will: to become more sensitive to others' needs and less insistent about our own”

(#671) The Brain Will Respond in Kind

“When we breathe slow and steady, with the abdomen rising and falling with the breath, the messages that get sent to the brain through the vagus nerve are messages of steadiness, evenness, rhythmicity, safety, and control. **The brain will receive these messages, and then respond in kind**, sending messages back down to the body and releasing hormones and neurotransmitters that are a response to safety.” – Eddie Stern, Healing Through Breathing

Just a great reminder of the power of slow, gentle, deep breathing. By sending messages of calm and safety to the brain, it sets off a cascade of positive events that benefit the whole body. Make sure you take advantage of this healing feedback loop today 🙏

(#672) Enjoying the Symphony

“Do you want to enjoy a melody? Do you want to enjoy a symphony? Don’t hold on to a few bars of the music. Don’t hold on to a couple of notes. Let them pass, let them flow. The whole enjoyment of a symphony lies in your readiness to allow the notes to pass.” – Anthony de Mello, Awareness

What a perfect analogy for life. We all want to hold onto things we enjoy: How we feel after our breath practice, the excitement of a new project, that first-cup-of-coffee motivation, and so on. But mindfulness teaches us that the true enjoyment of these feelings actually lies in our readiness to let them pass. By letting them flow, we know they’ll return in due time. So, here’s to enjoying all the notes of life’s symphony a little more, today 🎵

(#673) Private Satisfaction and Personal Fulfilment

“Well, here is the thing: the most generous act we can make is to take time to focus on our own wellbeing as soon as we wake up (in most cases, that is the morning). There is something about a morning ritual that creates a sense of comfort, of certainty, of hope, or contentment.” – Libby DeLana, Do Walk

As many of you know, I’m a huge fan of starting the day with breathing, meditation, or [insert your favorite practice]. And while this passage is about walking, it perfectly captures why morning practice is so powerful: It creates “a sense of comfort, of certainty, of hope or contentment.”

Or, as she more plainly puts it:

“But why the morning? To kick off your day on the right foot. Once you commit that time to yourself there is a certain private satisfaction and personal fulfilment that comes from starting the day with a focus on your wellbeing.” 🙌

(#674) How Old Should the Horse Be?

“You frequently interpret everything that’s being said in terms of your hypnotic state or your conditioning or your programming. Like this girl who’s listening to a lecture on agriculture and says, ‘Excuse me, sir, you know I agree with you completely that the best manure is aged horse manure. Would you tell us how old the horse should be?’” – Anthony de Mello, Awareness

If you’re a coach or instructor of any kind, here’s a funny reminder that we can’t control how people interpret what we say. Even when someone agrees with our ideas, it may be for reasons we never intended.

And when they don’t—or when they simply miss the point—we’d be wise to smile inside, remembering that they are simply interpreting and filtering it from their own conditioning.

(#675) It's about Pace, Not Speed

"It is a gentle, slow practice...and pace (not speed) matters. There is no rushing, no urgency embedded into a step. It isn't a task to 'get over' so I can move on to the next thing on the list. Instead it is an opportunity to be aligned with the pace of the natural world." – Libby DeLana, Do Walk

This was about walking, but how perfectly does it apply to any contemplative practice we might do? It's about pace, not speed—about aligning with the flow of the natural world (if only for a few minutes) before getting carried away with the day's tasks.

A slight modification of DeLana's wording generalizes it perfectly for walking or any mindful practice we do: There is no rushing, no urgency embedded into a breath. 🙏

(#676) The Great Opportunity

“The lure of the distant and the difficult is deceptive. The great opportunity is where you are.” –
John Burroughs

P.S. On weekends, I just send a short, memorable quote for you to enjoy 🙏

(#677) Doing Something You Love

“Doing something you love, even physical activity, generates more energy rather than depleting it.” – Libby DeLana

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy 🙏

(#677) This Is Nothing More Generous than This

“Commitment is intoxicating. There is nothing more generous than sticking to a promise you have made to yourself.” – Libby DeLana

... Walking was a way back to a pace that was natural and recognisable, and also a way to truly be open, to see what each day was going to bring.

(#673) Same as With a Breath Practice

The way the natural world operates walking is rather narrowly understood, but it has the potential of being life changing. To understand it as life changing requires a clarity of intention, surrender of destination, dedication to the moment and commitment to a practice. For morning walk may not look like my morning walk, and that's wonderful. It may be in an urban neighborhood or rural community. It may include wheels. It may include a furry companion or not. No matter where or how you go there, you are committed to a practice open to the moment and embracing the ever changing circumstances come.

(#671)

Either: Diligence Thought from The Heroic Heart

Or

Have to breathe in and breathe out from Heroic Heart

But the point is that we should really dedicate our lives not only to benefiting ourselves, but also to benefiting others. However, this doesn't mean that we only benefit others and ignore ourselves. There has to be a balance between the two. We have to breathe in as well as breathing out. If we are only breathing out and hardly breathing in, we are going to be asphyxiated and exhausted quickly. this often happens

"If in doubt, just walk until your day becomes interesting." - Rolf Potts (Found this in Arnold's newsletter on 7 February 2025)

(#669) It Is Not Virtuous

"It is not virtuous to pretend to be who we are not." – Jetsunma Tenzin Palmo

"Whatever our past, whatever our present, all of us have the capacity to change ourselves completely through the practice of meditation." – Eknath Easwaran

"Artistry in living begins with learning to be flexible for the sake of those around us." – Eknath Easwaran

(#670)

Cultivating mindfulness means learning to tap into and focus our own wasted energies." – Jon Kabat-Zinn, Full Catastrophe Living

"An intelligent control of our breathing power will lengthen our days upon earth by giving us increased vitality and powers of resistance, and, on the other hand, unintelligent and careless breathing will tend to shorten our days, by decreasing our vitality and laying us open to disease."
– Science of Breath, Yogi Ramacharaka

“It is impossible to become like somebody else. Your only hope is to become more fully yourself.” – Jon Kabat-Zinn, Ph.D.

That is the reason for practicing meditation in the first place.”

“If in doubt, just walk until your day becomes interesting.” - Rolf Potts (Found this in Arnold’s newsletter on 7 February 2025)

“The lure of the distant and the difficult is deceptive. The great opportunity is where you are.” – John Burroughs

“The secret of happiness is something to do.” – John Burroughs

Water doesn’t force its way through obstacles—it simply moves around them, letting gravity do the work. This is a great analogy for mindful living. While we still put effort into our tasks and goals, mindful living teaches us to stop forcing rigid outcomes and instead work with the natural flow of life. Some paths open, some close—but if we keep exploring, we’ll always find a way forward.

So today’s 1%: Make sure you’re putting out enough fingers—trying enough approaches—to let the flow of life guide you around any obstacles you may be facing. 🙌

Of course, as humans, we still put effort into tasks and goals. But with mindful living, we focus more on going with the flow. We know we ultimately can’t control the outcomes, so we put out fingers—some stop, some keep going. But no matter what, we simply find a way around 🙌

This is a great analogy for mindful living. Water doesn’t force its way through obstacles—it simply moves around them, always adapting. In the same way, we put effort into our tasks and goals, but we don’t force rigid outcomes. Instead, mindful living teaches us to follow the natural flow of life. Some paths open, some close—but we don’t need to fight against the current. We simply adjust, knowing that there is always a way forward. 🙌

is inevitable, we still ultimately realize that we don't necessarily rely on effort but more on going with the flow

Thus, if we follow the advice of Watts, the Buddha, Easwaran, Dr. Gladys, and all the other teachers we learn from, our whole life becomes "flow." We put our fingers; some stop, some keep going. But no matter what, we simply find a way around 🙏

Have Faith in Your Practice?

"Faith and morality, by the way, have a special meaning in this context. Buddhism does not advocate faith in the sense of believing something because it is written in a book, attributed to a prophet, or taught to you by some authority figure. The meaning of faith here is closer to confidence. It is knowing that something is true because you have seen it work, because you have observed that very thing within yourself." – Bhante Gunaratana, Mindfulness in Plain English (<https://breathlearning.com/book-411s/mindfulness-in-plain-english/>)

Similar to today's TB1%, this one simply gets an amen 🙏

"To an extent, we are always aware of everything going on around us—except that we are not. Somewhere in the brain, a decision is made about what to focus on and what to ignore." – Kam Knight

What a fantastic analogy for concentration and meditation! Thoughts will always pour in—just like rain in a storm (we can't stop the rain). Our job is simple: keep the windshield wipers running. Observe the thoughts as they arise, let them go, and gently return to our object of focus.

This is such a helpful way to share the practice with students. It reminds us that the goal isn't to stop the thoughts entirely but to maintain clarity by consistently wiping them away. Just like driving in a storm, the key is in the repetition 🙏

Therefore, don't underestimate the simplicity of some of the suggestions in this book, and don't focus only on the ones that are new, popular, or demanding. If a suggestion works, use it. If not, move on and try another. Each person is different, so what works for one person may not work for you, and what works for you may only require something simple.

Unfortunately, many fall into the trap of thinking that if they have a complex or debilitating problem, then they need a complex or difficult solution, one that takes time and energy to apply. Since they expect the solution to take effort, they overlook the easy suggestions. And focus only on the difficult ones or those they haven't heard or used before. The truth is, if you have a big or complex problem, then more than likely you need a simple and easy solution, one that is easy to apply and that you are encouraged to apply. Applying a technique is what brings results, not procrastinating on it because it's too difficult or time consuming. Therefore, don't underestimate the simplicity of some of the suggestions in this book, and don't focus only on the ones that are new, popular or demanding. If a suggestion works, use it. If not, move on and try another. Each person is different, So what works for?

(#649) We Have Good Imaginations

“In truth we are always present. We only imagine ourselves to be in one place or another.” – Howard Cohn

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable and fun quote for you to enjoy 🙏

“Perhaps we can define happiness as experiencing real emotions over real problems and real tasks.” – Abraham Maslow

“Virtue sounds lofty, but it’s actually down to earth. It simply means living from your innate goodness, guided by principle.” – Rick Hanson, Ph.D.

Whether you believe that this is evidence of a greater spiritual power or a global consciousness that we can connect with, given enough dedication, or whether you think of it as a biological phenomenon that makes you feel good, the important thing here is that, thanks to the way that your brainwaves synchronize with the rate at which you breathe, anyone can access this feeling for free. All you have to do is take control of your diaphragm and the intercostal muscles between your ribs, and practice slowing it down to three breaths per minute.

“It is not virtuous to pretend to be who we are not.” – Jetsunma Tenzin Palmo

Is There a Life After Death?

“Is there a life after death?”

...

Nobody seems to be grappling with the problem of: Is there a life before death? Yet my experience is that it's precisely the ones who don't know what to do with this life who are all hot and bothered about what they are going to do with another life. One sign that you're awakened is that you don't give a damn about what's going to happen in the next life. You're not bothered about it; you don't care. You are not interested, period.” – Anthony de Mello, Awareness

Just a little bit of humor wrapped around some profound wisdom. I think we'd all be wise to grapple with the problem of “Is there a life before death?” rather than is there one after it...

With breathing, it's easy to want to tell everyone how they're not doing it right. But here's a funny story about recognizing when people aren't ready for our guidance, even when the problem seems obvious. (It's a little longer than normal, but since it's funny, it gets a pass.)

Like the businessman who goes into a bar, sits down, and sees this fellow with a banana in his ear—a banana in his ear! And he thinks, "I wonder if I should mention that to him. No, it's none of my business". But the thought nags at him. So after having a drink or two, he says to the fellow, "Excuse me, ah, you've got a banana in your ear". The fellow says, "What"? The businessman repeats, "You've got a banana in your ear." Again the fellow says, "What was that"? "You've got a banana in your ear!" the businessman shouts. "Talk louder", the fellow says, "I've got a banana in my ear!" So it's useless. "Give up, give up, give up", I say to myself. Say your thing and get out of here. And if they profit, that's fine, and if they don't, too bad!

"answers usual life is the very down. How does one bring oneself into a chord with it? If you try to accord with it. You will get away from it. For to imagine that there is a you separate from life, which somehow has to accord with life is to fall straight into the trap.

"Everything is in a mess, and all is well. Strange paradox." – Anthony De Mello

Just a quick reminder that, although everything is in a mess, all is well. A strange but wonderful paradox, indeed.

But, tragically, most people never get to see that, they never get to see that all is well because they are asleep."

While there's nothing too practical about today's message, it's a fun reminder of the power of our breath for influencing our brain and emotions 🙌

Research where people consciously change their breathing rates has shown that different ways of breathing can encourage particular frequencies to dominate across the brain, which can take us to a more alert and focused state or to a more relaxed and drowsy one.

“We are really stuck with ourselves, and our attempts to reject or to accept are equally fruitless, for they fail to reach that inaccessible center of our selfhood which is trying to do the accepting or the rejecting. The part of our self that wants to change our self is the very one that needs to be changed; but it is as inaccessible as a needle to the prick of its own point.” – Alan Watts

This is why it is quite literally off the point to time yourself, to compete with yourself, and to bother about your progress and success in the art. It’s simply the old story of making a difficult job easy by taking it one step at a time.” – Alan Watts, *Become What You Are*

“There’s only one corner of the universe you can be certain of improving, and that is your own self.” – Aldous Huxley

“Rituals are the formulas by which harmony is restored.” - Terry Tempest Williams

Only in quietness do we possess our own minds and discover the resources of the Inner Life.

- Helen Keller

Subject Line: Mindfulness “To learn something new, take the path that you took yesterday.” - John Burroughs

“Life is a long lesson in humility.” – James M. Barrie

The True Gospel

“The true Gospel is always fresh air and spacious breathing room.” – Richard Rohr

What You Absolutely Must Do

“Now, as I’ve gotten older, I’ve been thinking about these things. And I don’t know what being is. And I don’t know what consciousness is. But I do know what bliss is: that deep sense of being present, of doing what you absolutely must do to be yourself. If you can hang on to that, you are on the edge of the transcendent already.” – Joseph Campbell, Pathways to Bliss

That sounds just like juice :) And it’s an amazing North Star to aim toward: doing what you absolutely must do to be yourself. It is so simply worded, yet so incredibly powerful to read.

The Breathing 411 is mindfully created each week to support your journey. If you find it valuable, consider joining the Breath Learning Center. Members gain access to an ever-growing collection of book summaries, science paper reviews, and insights from the greatest teachers and thinkers, designed to help you find your unique path, connect ideas, and grow as a Mixed Mindful Artist. Membership also includes ad-free daily emails, guided practices, and more. Unlock your potential and see what you’re missing.

(#609) Outside Adversity, Inside Growth

“The important thing is not to worry about what is going to happen to us but to create inner strength to deal with whatever does happen. We will be able to take it on the path with us. Something that outwardly looks negative can inwardly be exactly what we need as a real help and aid to our practice.” – Jetsunma Tenzin Palmo, The Heroic Heart (<https://amzn.to/3ZAXog2>)

That sums up the whole point of contemplative practice. It's not about nothing bad every happening. It's about developing resilience to deal with the inevitable challenges that do come, so that outwardly negative events can "inwardly be exactly what we need as a real help and aid to our practice." 🙏🙏🙏

"Because eternity is not a long time. Eternity is not future or past. Eternity is a dimension of now. It is a dimension of the human spirit—which is eternal. Find that eternal dimension in yourself, and you will ride through time and throughout the whole length of your days." – Joseph Campbell

"The trouble comes into the world largely because various beings take themselves seriously, instead of playfully." – Alan Watts

(#600) Spirituality Means to Breathe

"Richard Dawkins, the scientist, once said to me, "Mr. Kumar, I don't believe in spirituality."

I answered, "Professor Dawkins, Don't you believe in breathing?"

He said, "What do you mean?"

I said, "Spirituality means to breathe. You and I breathe together, that's spirituality."

P.S. On weekends, I just send a memorable quote for you to enjoy 🙏

P.P.S. This one is much better when you hear Kumar speak it in the audiobook, as you can hear his lightheartedness and slight humor in it :)

“I don’t need to push the river as much now, or own the river, or get everybody in my precise river; nor do others have to name the river the same way I do in order for me to trust them or their goodwill. It takes lots of drowning in your own too tiny river to get to this big and good place.” – Richard Rohr

“When you do things from your soul, you feel a river moving in you, a joy.” – Rumi

“Why take someone else’s word for it? Enter the laboratory of your mind and perform the experiment. Then you will be in a position to judge for yourself, and nothing can be as persuasive as that.” – Eknath Easwaran

Anxiety Spurs Creativity

“Our lives are littered with anxious moments, big and small, that make us more creative because they help us see the possibilities so that we can bring something worthwhile into being that has never existed before. Creativity is seeing possibilities, and anxiety helps us see the possibility that there are possibilities.” – Tracy Dennis-Tiwary, Ph.D., *Future Tense: Why Anxiety Is Good For Your (Even Though It Feels Bad)*

Universal Process

“Breathing is a universal process. All vertebrates breathe in essentially the same manner. All living things exchange gases with their environment in some way or other. This is one of the reasons that breathing has been chosen as a focus of meditation. The meditator is advised to explore the process of his or her own breathing as a vehicle for realizing our inherent connectedness with the rest of life. This does not mean that we shut our eyes to all the

differences around us. Differences do exist. It means simply that we de-emphasize contrasts and emphasize the universal factors that we have in common”

Came across this quote from David Chapman on why learning mental models is a good idea:

“Learn from fields very different from your own. They each have ways of thinking that can be useful at surprising times. Just learning to think like an anthropologist, a psychologist, and a philosopher will beneficially stretch your mind.”

“Mindfulness is mirror-thought. It reflects only what is presently happening and in exactly the way it is happening. There are no biases.”

That is the final step of mindfulness. But I think there is a critical first step before, which is realizing that your mind is kind of like one of those circus mirrors. Mindfulness first helps you see how distorted your view of life actually is—completely biased, reflecting not what is happening but what we wish to be happening.

“Awakening is an accident, but continued practice will make you accident-prone.” – The Mind Illuminated

“When you do things from your soul, you feel a river moving in you, a joy.” – Rumi

“First secure an independent income, then practice virtue.” – Greek Proverb

Any Fool

"Any fool can make something complicated. It takes a genius to make it simple," is attributed to the American folk singer Woody Guthrie.

“Whole people see and create wholeness wherever they go. Split people see and create splits in everything and everybody.” – Richard Rohr

(#5XX) All Life is Yoga

“Yoga practice is a balancing act between doing and not-doing: we must somehow exhibit all the prowess of the charioteer in mastering his horses and yet remain the same whether in success or failure.” – Richard Rosen, The Yoga of Breath

Although I don’t do yoga anymore, this perfectly captures the essence of how we’re trying to live. We practice, read, and give it our all, exhibiting the “prowess of the charioteer.” At the same time, we realize that, ultimately, we have no control over whether we will succeed or fail in any endeavor.

Instead, we just keep last week's quote from Eknath Easwaran in mind: 'It doesn't matter what you bring today. If you bring something pleasant, I will flourish; if you bring something unpleasant, I will still flourish.'

I guess this quote (accredited to Sri Aurobindo) pans out: "All life is yoga." 😊

A Different Weight on Our Shoulders

"When sitting for pranayama, some students have a tendency to lift the shoulders during inhalation. Imagine that there's a weight hanging from each of the scapulas. Slide these bones down toward the tail on the inhalation." – Richard Rosen, *The Yoga of Breath*

On Friday, we got some wisdom from Eknath's Easwaran's grandmother about the weight we carry on our shoulders. Although not conceptually related, it reminded me of this quote I read many years ago from Richard Rosen.

He advises imagining you have a small weight hanging from each shoulder blade to prevent them from lifting during inhalation. This helps guide the shoulders down, supporting better breathing. It's a picture that's stuck with me—maybe it will help you too 🙏

Here is a great story from Mark Epstein, MD, after finishing a meditation retreat and going out to eat with the teachers:

“Much to my surprise, Jack Kornfield ordered a hamburger. I did a double take. A hamburger? After a retreat? A Buddhist teacher? I felt suddenly lighter. I was ready to superimpose a set of expectations on myself that went all the way down to what I could have for lunch. Right View, Right Speech, Right Livelihood, Right Action, and Right Lunch.

I did not even want a hamburger. But if I did, I could decide for myself. I have always been grateful to Kornfield for this moment—one I am sure he has long forgotten, one that solidified my sense of Right View. The lesson I took from it was that my Buddhist leanings did not mean I had to cloak myself in a false identity. Even as I was pursuing Buddhism, I could be myself.”

“And when they played they really played. And when they worked they really worked.” – Dr. Seuss

“We've just described how conscious intention influences the unconscious mechanisms that sustain attention, but that's only the beginning. Throughout the Stages, you use conscious intention to train the unconscious mind in a variety of ways. The correct use of intention can also transform bad habits, undo incorrect views, and cultivate healthier perspectives. In short, skillfully applying conscious intention can completely restructure the mind and transform who we are. This is the very essence of meditation: we reprogram unconscious mental processes by repeating basic tasks over and over with a clear intention. We'll talk more about how this simple activity changes unconscious processes when we introduce the Mind-System model in the Fifth Interlude.

“Body movements can serve as a short-cut to changing the ways we think and feel.” – Caroline Williams

Here for a Reason

“Each of us is here for a reason, to learn and grow and to give our gifts. When we are able to do so, we're filled with the creative life energy that I call the “juice.” The juice is our reason for living. It's our fulfillment, our joy. It's what happens when life is activated by love. It's the energy we get from the things that matter and mean something to us.” – Dr. Gladys

I went back and reread this after our conversation, and wow, how good is that? The part that really stood out this time around: “It’s what happens when life is activated by love.” So, we find our juice when our lives are activated by love. Even if we never fully reach that state, it feels like the perfect goal to strive for 🙏

“Diligence helps start you on your way, but the real solution to these obstacles is learning to enjoy your practice. One simple, powerful way to do that is to intentionally savor all feelings of physical comfort and deliberately cultivate the pleasure that can be found in quietness. Take satisfaction in the fact that you have actually sat down to meditate. That is an accomplishment in itself! Too often, people approach meditation as though they were taking medicine—it tastes bad, but they grin and bear it because it's supposed to be good for them. Instead, make meditation into a pleasurable activity. If you're at ease and happy, you will be more successful than if you're tense and straining. The more you succeed in seeking out the pleasant aspects of meditation, the more motivated you'll be and the more you will look forward to practicing. Everything else will fall into place. Doubt will disappear. You'll be inspired to meditate and can find plenty of time for it. Once you taste the joy and pleasure of practice, procrastination and resistance vanish. You'll look forward to your time on the cushion and guard it as something precious. As you progress to the higher Stages, you won't just deliberately cultivate joy. It will eventually become your default state of mind.”

https://shwin.co/blog/hacking-sales-as-an-introvert?utm_source=tldrnewsletter

Paced breathing’s impact on arousal and memory: Examining the effects of slow and fast paced breathing on heart rate variability, skin conductance, and long-term memory
<https://essopenarchive.org/doi/full/10.22541/au.172494855.58334655>

Effectiveness of Alternative Nostril Breathing on Blood Pressure: A Systematic Review and Meta-Analysis of Randomized Controlled Trials
<https://karger.com/cmr/article-abstract/doi/10.1159/000539707/910373/Effectiveness-of-Alternative-Nostril-Breathing-on?redirectedFrom=PDF>

“We have a common tendency to separate meditation practice from the rest of our life. If the skills and insights we learn on the cushion don’t infuse our daily life, progress will be quite slow.”

there is also an ever-increasing pile of scientific research that demonstrates that, when you control your breath, what you are actually doing is taking your brainwaves in hand and tethering the rate of their fluctuations to your breathing rate.

Williams, Caroline. *Move* (p. 150). Hanover Square Press. Kindle Edition.

“They found that, when the volunteers passively observed their breath but didn’t change its rate or rhythm, brainwaves in areas involved in interoception—the sense of the internal state of the body—became more strongly locked to the respiration rate. This could be important:...tuning in to how your body is feeling can be a powerful tool to understand and manage your emotions. The study volunteers only counted their breath for a couple of minutes at a time, which suggests that taking just a short break to do the same...could be a great way to get out of your head and calmly reconnect with the rest of your body.” – Caroline Williams, *Move*

Over time a regular check-in using breath as a shortcut to the body could add up to a significant boost to mental health.” – Caroline Williams, *Move*

“They found that, when the volunteers passively observed their breath but didn’t change its rate or rhythm, brainwaves in areas involved in interoception—the sense of the internal state of the body—became more strongly locked to the respiration rate. This could be important: as

we've seen with dance and stretching, tuning in to how your body is feeling can be a powerful tool to understand and manage your emotions. The study volunteers only counted their breath for a couple of minutes at a time, which suggests that taking just a short break to do the same—no cushion or chanting necessary, you don't even need to close your eyes or let on that you're doing it—could be a great way to get out of your head and calmly reconnect with the rest of your body. Over time a regular check-in using breath as a shortcut to the body could add up to a significant boost to mental health.” – Caroline Williams, *Move*

And this is where breath–brain synchronization becomes a useful tool to change your mental state. Research where people consciously change their breathing rates has shown that different ways of breathing can encourage particular frequencies to dominate across the brain, which can take us to a more alert and focused state or to a more relaxed and drowsy one.

There's only one catch, and it's something else that yogis have been banging on about for centuries: breath-linked mind control only works if you breathe through your nose.

Williams, Caroline. *Move* (p. 153). Hanover Square Press. Kindle Edition.

Simplest Expression of Our Goal

“Perhaps the simplest expression of our goal in meditation is that we are trying to make ourselves whole.” – Eknath Easwaran

What We're Actually Controlling

“...there is also an ever-increasing pile of scientific research that demonstrates that, when you control your breath, what you are actually doing is taking your brainwaves in hand and tethering the rate of their fluctuations to your breathing rate.”

(#495) Simplest and Most Unobtrusive Body Movement

“Despite centuries of reports from followers of Eastern traditions that slow breathing can improve focus, bring a sense of calm when we might otherwise lose it and even whisk us away to an altered state of consciousness, most of us still don’t take time out from our busy lives to prioritize this simplest and most unobtrusive of body movements.” – Caroline Williams, *Move*

“You can’t wake a person who is pretending to be asleep.” – Navajo Proverb

“Why take someone else’s word for it? Enter the laboratory of your mind and perform the experiment. Then you will be in a position to judge for yourself, and nothing can be as persuasive as that.” – Eknath Easwaran

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“Most people use the tools to address a particular problem, and when the problem is solved they forget about the tool. They’ve used the tool to climb out of whatever hole they’re in, they experience the relief of being free from what’s been bothering them, and then they go on with their life.

They’re missing something. Abandoning the use of tools once your problem is solved is like leaving the theater before the final act. The tools don’t just help you climb out of a particular hole...If you keep using them, you ascend to another state—another world, filled with limitless potential.” – Barry Michels and Phil Stutz, *Coming Alive*

Just a reminder that the

“Happiness, it has been said, is a mosaic composed of very little stones. Each taken singly is of little value; but when all are grouped together, combined and set, they form a pleasing and graceful whole—a costly jewel.”

Found this one in Tim Ferriss’ 5-bullet Friday on 16 August 2024:

“If you forget your feelings
about things of the world,
they become enlightening teachings.
If you get emotional
about enlightening teaching,
it becomes a worldly thing.”
— Musō Soseki

“One way to help stop the rot, then, is for anyone who is able to do so to get on their feet whenever possible and move forwards at whatever speed feels easy to them. If physically walking isn't possible, or if cycling or canoeing is more your thing, then moving forwards in other ways will have at least some of the benefits as long as you do it at a level that is easy enough for you to be able to forget that you are moving and let your mind wander. Ideally this would be done alone somewhere familiar, so that your thinking mind can switch off, drift away and come back with a shiny new idea. It really is that simple.”